She-Ra: Masters of the Universe

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/26713198.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Categories:
F/F, F/M, M/M, Multi, Other

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Castaspella/Juliet (She-Ra), Netossa/Spinnerella (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Kyle/Lonnie/Rogelio (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra), Emily (She-Ra), Razz (She-Ra), Swift Wind | Spirit, Kyle (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra), Darla | Mara's Ship (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Shen (She-Ra: Masters of the Universe), Panga (She-Ra: Masters of the Universe), Zzar (She-Ra: Masters of the Universe), Shen'Aan-war (She-Ra: Masters of the Universe), Octavia (She-Ra), Tung Lashor, Huntara (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra), Juliet (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Unofficial Sequel, Epic Battles, Outer Space, Plot Twists, Love, Drama & Romance, Original Character(s), Bad Jokes, Singing, Weddings, Personal Growth, Origin Story, Visions, Yoga, Catra Kai

Language:
English

Series:
Part 1 of She Ra: Masters of the Universe

Stats:
Published: 2020-09-29 Completed: 2021-03-20 Words: 148,201 Chapters: 28/28

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She-Ra: Masters of the Universe

by Largemovingtorb

Summary

A year after the Battle of Etheria, much has change while much as stayed the same. Our heros take their first steps into the wider galaxy to "bring magic to the universe." Their journey takes them to a strange First One's temple, there they unknowingly reveal themselves to an ancient evil enemy. They soon face The Outcast, a demon-possessed assassin sent to eradicate the only woman strong enough to stand in the way of a galactic conquest. Adora, Catra, Glimmer and Bow again find themselves fighting against an implacable enemy, their fight taking them taking them from Etheria, to the very stars, and even farther…

Notes

This work contains commissioned art by a plethora of talented She-Ra artists

Authors Note (01/28/23): When I was writing this, I imagined my story as the movie we never got. Every good movie needs a soundtrack, right? Well, seeded throughout my fanfic are links to songs that fit the scene you are currently reading. It is not mandatory for you to listen to them, and I'm sure you may not like my taste in music, but they are songs that were close to the heart of my emotions at the time I wrote this story. They will be in bold caps with two * on either side and will transport you to the song on Soundcloud or Youtube. I hope you enjoy!

Prologue

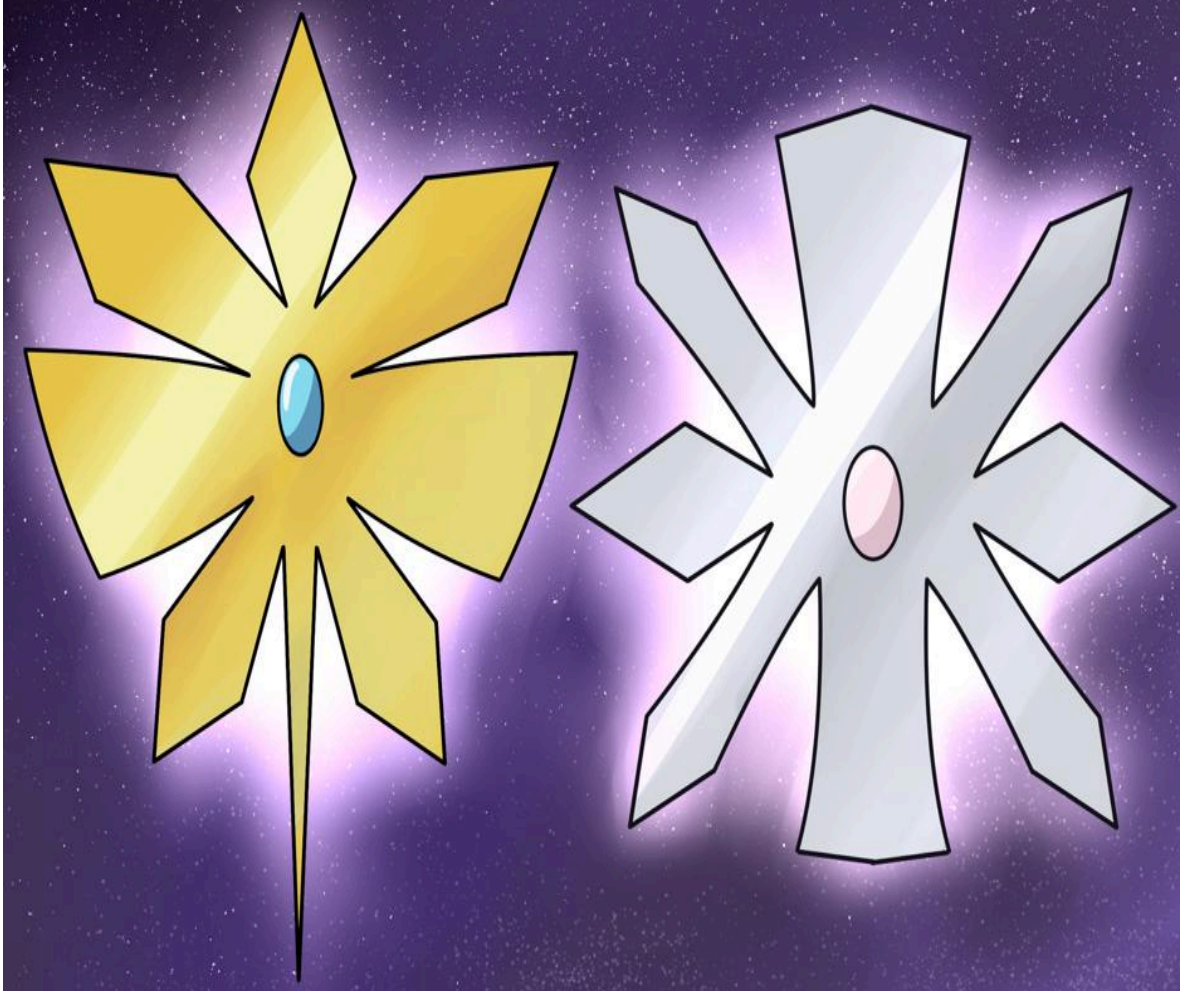
Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She-Ra

Masters of the Universe

Written by Largemovingtorb





She-Ra:

Masters of the Universe

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* OPENING CREDITS *

It's been one year since the battle of Etheria, and the end of Horde Prime's oppressive reign over the universe.

Etheria has become wilder and more beautiful with the release of a thousand years' worth of magical energy. It has also become a little more dangerous since the magical energy cannot, and will not, be controlled, as if being contained for so long has made it resistant to the possibility of being yoked again. Some of the new phenomena that have appeared are beautiful, and strange aurora-borealis appear one moment, only to be replaced by balls of fire-lighting. Amazing, new animal forms have also appeared, although many suspect that they have always been on Etheria, hibernating and waiting for the magic to be released.

Adora, Catra, Bow and Glimmer did not immediately leave on their road-trip around the universe, as there were too many problems on their own planet to focus on before taking such a journey. Even before the dust had settled, there were cries for justice, justice for the level of destruction caused and for the members of the Horde to be punished. Since Horde Prime was gone, there was only Etheria's Horde to take the brunt, plus whatever clones managed to survive.

As Queen of Etheria, Glimmer had to listen to her people and a tribunal was put together. Hordak, Catra, Entrapta and the Force Captains, including Scorpia— for she was a Force Captain for many years before defecting— were held at Bright Moon while the trial proceeded.

Since they all could not be held in the spare bedroom, an extension was added to Bright Moon, close to the guard quarters. Even with the added room, many of the prisoners still had to share rooms, leading to Entrapta, Scorpia and Catra bunking together. This worked out in the end, for it gave the woman a chance to catch up and heal old wounds; the last time they were together was under the banner of the Horde. Many hours of "quality time" were spent hanging out and playing board-games, much to Scorpia's delight.

Catra even had a chance to talk to Hordak, apologizing for deceiving him into thinking Entrapta betrayed them. Hordak, true to his nature, grunted something back, including a barely distinguishable apology, then clearly stated to Catra that she was the most effective second he ever had.

The trial took a month, where much evidence was presented and extenuating circumstances were considered. For many of the ex-Horde leaders, this was the first time they were really made to face what they had done, which was a sobering experience for them.

Adora, Bow and Queen Glimmer herself spoke up on Catra, Scorpia and Entrapta's behalf, but in the end, they were all found guilty of their crimes. Since the concept of capital punishment and long-term imprisonment did not exist on Etheria, another sentence was doled out. In the grand hall of Bright Moon, the convicted were made to swear a mighty oath, one that bound them to forever work toward the betterment of the people of Etheria, to fight for good wherever it may exist, and to forever work on their personal improvement, for to be there for others they must first be there for themselves. This they did gladly with the Royal Advisor and father to the Queen, Micah, using a truth spell; their oaths were shown to be true and sound. Adora was at Catra's side the whole time, holding her hand while she recited the Oath. Perfuma was there for Scorpia as well, while Hordak and Entrapta had each other.

As the leader of the Horde, it was decided that Hordak needed his own special punishment on top of swearing the Oath. He was to remain in the Kingdom of Dryle, swearing never to leave its borders and to use his knowledge and skill to develop technology for the betterment of Etherian-kind. Hordak had no issue with this and relished his new role in life. The fact that it was to stay in Entrapta's home was an extra special bonus for the old villain. He always was more comfortable in his laboratory working on projects; his drive to conquer was only a manifestation of his need to prove his worthiness to his brother. When Catra heard this, she quipped that it was perfect for ol' shut-in Hordak.

The Horde soldiers as a whole did not participate in the trial, but instead, in re-education and re-building projects around Etheria. After their period of service was over, many of them joined the royal guards of the different Princess realms or the burgeoning Etherian Star Force. Many of Horde Prime's ships were salvaged and put to use for good, and crews were needed to fill them. With their life-long experience in the regiment, Horde soldiers made good Naval candidates— it was a perfect match. Much was the same for the clones. Many of them did not know anything else other than service, so the transition was an easy one. With the question of justice resolved, the true healing could begin.

Adora's powers as She-Ra have increased after the destruction of the heart of Etheria. Her strength and physical prowess have stayed much the same but her magical abilities have strengthened. This was fortuitous since Etheria and its people needed She-Ra's healing energy. Along with "The Best Friend's Squad" and the Princess Alliance, Adora spent the rest of her time after the Trial traveling Etheria to help re-establish harmony.

Adora's appearance hadn't changed much. Since Queen Glimmer had named her "Protector of the Realm," Adora replaced her old red Force Captains jacket with a light blue jacket with purple shoulder trim. Along with her white shirt, it was a color scheme that mimicked the bright moon guards. Much to the chagrin of Catra and the others, she still kept her hair in a high ponytail with

her bangs swept back in a distinctive poof, but when not on duty she was known to let her hair down.


ANSDRELA

Her She-Ra form is much the same as it was a year ago, but somehow more potent with the infusion of more magical energy. It was the same white pants sleeveless tunic with gold shoulder armor and trim. Her new She-Ra form had incorporated elements of the people closest to her; there were the wing emblems on her upper thighs representing Glimmer, her gold shoulder pads formed a heart just above her chest representing Bow, and her golden tiara now wrapped around her face, much like Catra's mask did before it.

The heart rune on her breast has remained, appearing when touched and fading away when the touch was gone. It does not serve any purpose other than as a reminder of her greatest strength, love; love for herself, for her friends, her world, and not least of all, love for Catra. Adora's past insecurities concerning her role and destiny as She-Ra have disappeared. In their place, she has been filled with confidence about her place in the universe as a protector and healer.

Catra still had a long way to go since her defection from the Horde. With her breakdown, then being mind-controlled by Horde Prime, Catra was left broken and unsure of herself, and had lost much of her confidence. If not for her love for Adora and the fact it was reciprocated at the end of the Battle for Etheria, Catra's future would have been very grim. In her fragile state, there were many paths Catra could have taken, most of them ending in disappointment.

After the Trial and the Taking of the Oath, Catra travelled Etheria with Adora and the rest of the gang, helping to rebuild wherever they could. This experience gave Catra an up-close view of the destruction the Horde caused— not just Prime's Horde, but Catra's Horde as well. Seeing the oppression and pain she caused almost drove Catra back into herself, but Adora and her new friends kept her from unravelling.

After a while, the act of helping others acted as a much-needed catharsis for Catra, who started to forgive herself, coming to terms with her guilt. After almost a year of this, much of Catra's

confidence had returned. The bold, strong woman who clawed her way to the top of Etheria's Horde by will and strength returned, tempered by compassion, love, and a touch of humility.

She still had issues with anger and sadness, issues that she agreed to work on, going as far as to participate in Perfuma's "group therapy" sessions. More often than not, Catra made it through these sessions but was known to blow up and storm out. Those outbursts were decreasing with time and a lot of patience on Perfuma's part.

Catra has grown her hair out, even allowing the brown tufts under her ears to come back, the same tufts she cut off after Shadow Weaver caressed them, believing them to be a tool for others to manipulate her. By letting them grow back, Catra, in her own way, showed that she is ready to open her heart and trust others again, something she would never admit, even to herself, for now.

Catra continued to wear her usual outfit of a maroon leotard, black collar around her neck and shoulders, and black and burgundy leggings. When she is expected in battle, she wears a new gold headpiece. It is almost an exact replica of the one She-Ra now wears, except the portion that encompasses her face is rounder, not as sharply angled as her old headpiece. The back is open to allow her wild mane to flow behind her, the feel of it whipping behind her as she struck down her enemies as exciting as it was when she fought for the Horde. Except now, these enemies were the enemies of She-Ra, Bright Moon, Etheria and everything good in the universe.

The bond between Catra and the magical being Melog still exists, for it is a lifelong bond. Melog continued to accompany Catra on missions, to add their magical abilities to the cause. When they are separated over great distances, Catra is able to call Melog through their bond and ask for her friend's assistance. It is not a command, but Melog always responds. Their bond aside, Melog is not Catra's pet. They are a conscious, intelligent being with a will of their own. When not needed, they spend a great deal of their time deep in the Whispering Woods, where the magic is strongest.

Melog does not speak of what they do there, and Catra never asks, respecting her friend's privacy. There are tales told among denizens of the Whispering Woods, tales of strange and ethereal humanoid beings spotted deep in the Whispering Woods. The love between the friends was great, and at least once a week, the two met to run through the Whispering Woods together, both on all fours.


@miledibuja

In a short timespan, Glimmer had become Queen of Bright Moon, and after a unanimous vote by the rest of the Princesses, Queen of Etheria. A great burden was thrown on Glimmer's small shoulders, having to decide what to do with the Horde prisoners, and rebuilding was very taxing for her. Glimmer's shoulders were strong though, and with her friends and newfound father-turned Chief Court advisor, she overcame these obstacles. Glimmer took to the re-building of Etheria with zeal, leading from the front and out in the field, just as she did in battle. The people of Etheria were able to see their beautiful and strong Queen up close, and their love for her grew immensely.

The return of her father Micah was an unexpected surprise for Glimmer. She was eager to get to know the man she only knew from old stories and whose face she only knew from the mural in the council room. During the Trial and Re-building, Micah was at his daughter's side and the bonds they formed were strong. Micah, with his immense magical power and arcane knowledge, also began to further instruct and tutor his daughter in more advanced magic. Glimmer's magical powers grew, although they were at their strongest on Etheria, close to the Moonstone. Only when magic had been brought back to the universe could she truly bring her powers to distant worlds. This was the task she focused her talent on next.

Glimmer looked much the same as when Horde Prime was defeated, for she had no time to think about any kind of make-over, too busy with her role as Queen as Etheria. The only addition was the crown of office she wore when holding court.



Bow continued to be the glue that holds the Friendship Squad together, always quick to add levity and to act as counselor when his friends squabbled. His role was in great demand during the Trial and Re-building, and he was constantly on call when the weight seemed too great, tears started flowing, or yelling matches began.

Bow honed his skill with his weapon of choice— the bow, the string Netossa so carelessly added actually making his shots more powerful. Bow even started working more on his close-quartered combat skills, skills that come in handy when enemies are too close for an archer. Bow had approached Catra and asked her to

try and teach him some of her martial arts, a skill that came so naturally to her. On numerous occasions when they fought on opposing sides, Bow found himself at Catra’s mercy, narrowly escaping with many bruises and scratches; she was the perfect teacher. Catra reluctantly agreed and started off extremely skeptical of her student.

Bow took to the lessons well, having many good sessions and a few bad ones when Catra was feeling particularly merciless. Glimmer was always there at the end of the day to mend cuts, help ice the bruises and add some much-needed care. After a while, Bow was able to mimic Catra’s open-handed claw strikes, and roundhouse kicks well enough to use them in battle. He had even started telling people he knew “Cat-Fu”, however, this stopped when Catra found out and told him she would disown him as a student if he ever referred to her fighting style as “Cat-Fu" again. Bow even earned the new nickname, “Punchy", from Catra; an inside joke that was shared with the rest of the Best Friends Squad.

Bow started to grow his hair out longer and experiment with facial hair, growing a fuzzy patch on his chin. His outfit remained the same with one exception— the red heart on his chest was now a heart-shaped gold chest piece in honor of She-Ra.



A year had passed, a year of struggles, learning, and growth. The issues they faced immediately after the destruction of Horde Prime had been laid to rest, and now it was time for the next chapter. It was time for their road-trip, although they were coming to understand that this challenge did not match such a flippant label. Adora, Catra, Glimmer, Bow, Entrapta, Emily and Melog boarded Darla— Adora's spaceship she inherited from the previous She-Ra— and started their exploration of the greater universe, trying to understand what their place in it would look like and how they would bring magic to it. After coming across rumors of a First Ones temple on the planet Twilight, they decided to investigate.

After all, the First Ones were experts on finding and exploiting magical fonts in the Universe, so it was a good place to start.

Chapter End Notes

Cover #1 by @Yoritomito
Cover #2 by awesomerebelkitty_art
Illustrations of Adora, Glimmer and Bow done by @Ansdrela_Art
Illustration of Catra done by Miledibuja

Tentative Steps

Chapter Summary

Our hero's take their first steps into a greater universe, their search brings them to the planet Twilight where they explore a strange First One's temple. In their explorations they unknowing bring themselves to the attention of an evil greater than Horde Prime.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

PART 1:

I was lost, so very lost, until I met you…

The planet Twilight was true to its name; bathed in the light of its system's weak sun, the world's day cycle was in perpetual twilight. Not much was known about this planet other than it was old and barren, sapped of every resource and all life. It used to be a place of strong magic, but that too was sucked almost dry by greed. It was a haunted place, offering nothing except a trading post and boundless emptiness. It was easy to find the temple when there was nothing to hide it.

"Adora, look out!!" Bow shouted.

Adora, in She-Ra form, turned and narrowly ducked as one of the temple robot elementals sliced down at her with a wicked arm blade. She parried and easily sliced the elemental neatly in two, while the second behind it was taken down by an arrow to the head.

"Thanks, Bow! Behind you!" She-Ra/Adora yelled.

Bow turned. The elemental was almost upon him, too close for him to notch an arrow and fire. Through muscle memory, he spun around, delivering a roundhouse kick that tripped the elemental. Using the downward momentum of his falling opponent, he delivered an open-clawed chop to its neck, almost severing its head. Catra's lessons had come in pretty handy.

"Nice, Bow! I need you to hold off these guys while I focus on the group massing near the temple entrance. You got this?" She-Ra/Adora asked.

"I got your back, Adora!" Bow shouted as he delivered more arrows into a group of enemies.

She-Ra/Adora bounded off in the direction of the greatest threat. Her stride was confident as she drove into the elementals. Although She-Ra/Adora did not fight with the acrobatics and speed of Catra, her strikes were implacable and true, her skill with the sword expert level. Her fighting style might be slower but it was relentless, and the elementals were driven back before her. She disappeared from view into the mass of them; the only evidence of her presence was the occasional elemental being tossed in the air in ruins.

Bow managed to fire an arrow into a charging elemental while delivering a backwards kick into one approaching on his blind side.

"You know, I'm getting pretty good at this!" Bow exclaimed, truly proud of his handiwork.

"I'm coming in, Punchy!" Catra yelled with glee.

Bow stared as Catra soared in an upright spin, her body straight and arms held close to her front and back to increase the speed of her rotation. As she descended upon her quarry, her arms flashed out, fingers and claws extended. The centrifugal motion of her spin added power to her attack and the two robot elementals approaching Bow were sliced neatly in two. Catra landed

crouched, one leg extended behind her in an extravagant bow. Dropping into a one-armed handstand, she simultaneously kicked two elementals who crumpled to the ground, their heads colliding... Catra flipped forwards, and both of her clawed feet crushed their heads into ruin.

"That's good form, Punchy, but let Sensei Catra show you how it's done!" Catra cried. She was feeling good and the close-quarters destruction made the primal essence in her blood sing.

"Show off!" Bow retorted, smirking.

"Am I going to have to separate you two again?" Glimmer shouted to them.

More elementals had surrounded Bow and Catra. Glimmer teleported in and out, extracting them from their encircling enemies. With her friends out of the way, Glimmer extended both arms, delivering dual beams of sparkling purple power at maximum intensity. The group of elementals close to each other made perfect targets and were instantly vaporized.

"Whoa, Sparkles! I guess there's some magic here for you to harness!" Catra stated, impressed.

Glimmer blew on her hands one at a time as if they were smoking guns.

"Amazing and beautiful as always!" Bow exclaimed.

Glimmer winked and blew a kiss to him.

"Ugh, get a room you two!" Catra groaned, feigning looking sick.

"AAACCCCKKK!!!" came a scream from nearby. Not too far away, the elementals were moving in on a seemingly weak Entrapta, who backed away from her attackers.

"Emileeeeee!! Help! Gahh!" Entrapta pleaded.

Entrapta's faithful robot friend Emily charged in on four legs, emitting the equivalent of a robot war cry in the form of beeps. She extended the dual cannons she had been upgraded with and blasted the two threats closest to Entrapta into pieces. Four more elementals turned to confront the new enemy, encircling Emily. They were moving in too fast for Emily to effectively target and eliminate them before taking critical damage.

Fortunately, Emily had a new trick for them. Emily had not only been upgraded with new cannons but also with an EMP pulse specific to disabling First Ones technology. This was a recent invention and considering where their journeys would take them, a fortuitous one. She emitted the EMP blast in a wide radius, disabling the encircling robots. Unfortunately, there was a down-side of the EMP blast, and Emily shut down for a reboot period. Emily and Entrapta were now defenseless.

"Oh, my poor girl. I promise momma is gonna fix that pesky shut-down problem," cried Entrapta, kneeling and hugging her mechanical friend, her arms and ponytails encircling Emily's round body. Sensing weakness, more elementals moved in for the kill.

"Roooawwww!!"

Melog bounded in, quickly cloaking Entrapta and Emily with their magic. Due to the magical nature of the alien creature, Entrapta and Emily were invisible and impervious to any kind of electronic surveillance. The elementals, no longer sensing their victims, wandered off to find another quarry.

Melog had been instructed by Catra to keep a close eye on the diminutive princess and keep her out of trouble. The act of basically throwing Entrapta away for her own rise to power had almost torn Catra's soul apart. She had since received Entrapta's forgiveness and learned to forgive herself, and the guilt had turned into a form of overprotectiveness of Entrapta. Catra now watched over Entrapta, keeping her from outside danger, inadvertently causing harm to herself, or from blowing them all up. Catra would never admit any of this, of course.

Entrapta, easily distracted by anything out of the ordinary, took an interest in the alien's powers, suddenly unbothered by the battle around them.

"Your cloak ability is FASCINATING! When this is over, may I have a sample to study? I promise, just a small sample." Entrapta emphasized her words by forming a small hand with her ponytails. Then, using her prehensile ponytails, Entrapta pulled out a pair of large shears and saw.

Melog, suddenly unsure and uneasy of the charge they were tasked to protect, simply tilted their head and whined.

As the elementals moved away from Entrapa, Melog and Emily and joined the others, forming a larger group that moved toward Bow, Glimmer and Catra. The friends moved toward each other, back to back; they were outnumbered now.

"Glimmer, this would be a good time for you to get us out of here!" Bow shouted over his shoulder.

"Bow, this isn't Etheria! I have no direct connection with the Moonstone to draw on! All I have is residual magic and I used that up!" Glimmer yelled, panic in her voice.

"So, Sparkles ran out of sparkles, no big deal," Catra stated matter-of-factly, "Time for us to do this the old-fashioned way. Punchy, remember that back-to-back defensive technique I taught you? We can keep Sparkles here between us and slowly wear these guys down. It's our only option."

"Catra! I am not a defenseless baby who needs protection. I can fight too!" Glimmer said petulantly, her fists clenched in anger.

Catra rolled her eyes, expecting Glimmer to stomp her foot too.

"I see I'm just in time!" a familiar, cocky voice shouted.

She-Ra/Adora strode through the mass of enemies, effortlessly slicing countless elementals apart. The mass of enemies sensed

the greater threat and moved in to overwhelm her. She-Ra/Adora, using a radial blast emitted from her core, knocked the first line of attackers on their backs. Then, extending a line of energy from the point of her sword like a whip, she destroyed the next group in line. The elementals downed by her radial blast began to rise and move toward their prime enemy.

“What are we waiting for?” Catra yelled to Bow and Glimmer, “Let’s get in there! For She-Ra!”

Bow and Glimmer joined Catra in her charge, emitting their own war-cries.

“For Etheria!”

“For Bright Moon!”

The friendship squad fought as one, the elementals succumbing to their unified front. The friends fought together effortlessly, not through years of training, but their bonds of love. Driven by simple commands and programming, the elementals were no match for this. They did no love, care or even like each other, and therefore were not concerned for each other’s safety. Even though our heroes were heavily outmatched, they had an overwhelming advantage.

The last elemental was smashed to the ground by She-Ra’s sword.... but not before knocking Catra on her backside.

“Ye-OW!! Ooof, that hurt. I wish you did that sooner Adora!” whined Catra.

She-Ra/Adora extended a hand to Catra, who gratefully took it. As she rose, she grimaced and rubbed at her abused hindquarters with her other hand.

“If it’s really serious, we are going to have to take a look at it later.” She-Ra/Adora teased, grinning wickedly.

Catra returned the grin with one equally, if not more wicked. “Oh yeah, I think it’s broken. It’s going to need some *serious* attention.”

“Get a room you two!” Glimmer groaned, almost exactly imitating the sick face Catra had made earlier.

“Is it just me, or do these elementals look a lot different than the ones we’re used to on Etheria?” Bow asked, tapping one of the downed robots with his foot.

Bow was right. The elementals on Etheria took the form of the native life present on their planet. Unlike those elementals, these ones were uniform and shared a humanoid form, much like Horde Prime’s robot soldiers. They were also darker and more sinister than Prime’s soldiers, though instead of arm cannons, they sported arm-blades made not for cutting, but for also inflicting maximum pain.

The differences didn’t just extend to the elementals, but to the First One’s temple as well. Where on Etheria the temple was made of neat geometric shapes, this one had a more chaotic, twisted look, like a large overgrown thorn bush. The Etherian temple also projected an inner light that was pleasant to look upon, while this one glowed with a ghostly energy.

“Yeah, I see it Bow. Strange...” She-Ra/Adora said, staring quizzically at the elementals and temple.

“Who cares? Elementals on this planet, that planet, or on Etheria... they don’t stand a chance.” Catra said, nonchalant as always.

“Well, Entrapta,” Glimmer began, “It looks like your little scheme worked. Your device drew the elementals out and allowed us to destroy them while leaving the temple intact. Knowing She-Ra and Catra, the place would have been wrecked if we had to fight them inside.”

“Hey! I’m getting better at controlling some of my powers! It’s totally unfair.” She-Ra/Adora pouted, hands on her hips.

Catra shrugged. “Yeah... for me, that’s a fair assessment.”

“Yes! Thank you!” Entrapta exclaimed, her ponytails formed arms and she bowed. “It also appears Emily’s new EMP upgrade worked perfectly!”

Emily, who had since rebooted and come back on-line beeped in appreciation. Entrapta patted her affectionately with her flesh and hair hands simultaneously.

“If ‘work perfectly’ means working once then shutting down and leaving you defenseless, then yes, that hunk of junk is really earning its keep,” Catra interjected sarcastically. “If it wasn’t for Melog, you guys would have been toast.”

Emily beeped in protest.

“There, there girl, don’t listen to her. We both know Catra likes you.” Entrapta cooed, rubbing Emily in the spot where there once were deep claw marks; now, there was only a smooth surface. “Why else would Catra have buffed her old claw marks out of your lovely metallic hide?”

“Ha! Yeah right, never happened. You’re dreaming, Entrapta.” Catra responded, crossing her arms over her chest.

“Oh yeah, that’s right!” She-Ra/Adora said brightly. “I was wondering why that old Horde vehicle buff was in your drawer, Catra.”

“Guys, don’t listen to Adora. She gets hit in the head a lot. It makes her delusional.” Catra instantly replied.

She-Ra/Adora, Glimmer and Bow shared a knowing look. They knew their tough-as-nails friend had a tender heart. It was pointless to get the truth out of Catra though, as she would

deflect and deny until the sun went down, and they had a mission to complete.

She-Ra/Adora turned to the temple, ready to begin the next phase of the mission.

“Alright, let’s see what we can learn from this temple. According to the rumors and legends we dug up, this is the last sighting of the First Ones anywhere in this universe.”

“Yaaaaaaaahhhhh! I will pry its secrets out and make them mine! ALL MINE! YA-HAHAHAHAHAHAHA!” Entrapta yelled, bordering on euphoria.

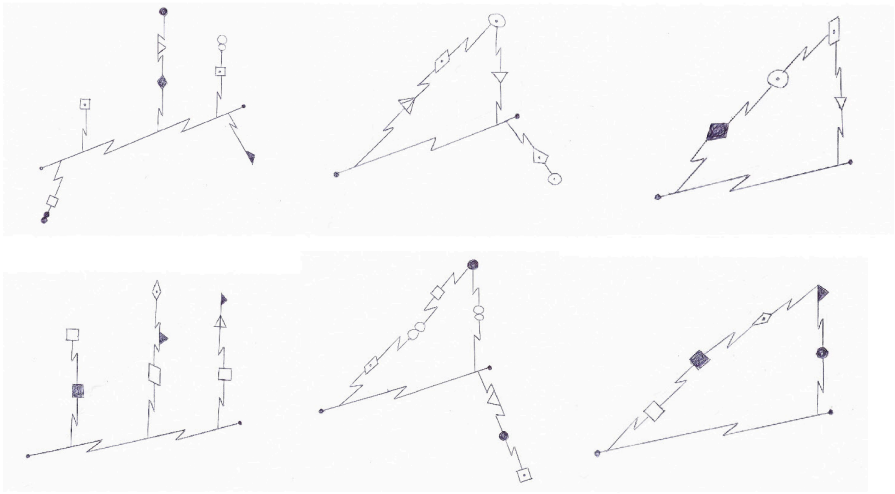
Everyone else besides Entrapta looked at each other, a little worried. Entrapta snapped back into herself, suddenly realizing everyone else was quiet.

“Oh, well, uh... what I mean to say was I will use my scientific and deductive skills to learn everything I can from this temple, to find out where the First Ones went and possibly, maybe, find them and learn what they knew of magic and its relationship to the universe, thereby, fulfilling my role as the ‘technical wizard genius’ of the group,” Entrapta said, taking a deep breath after her statement.

She-Ra/Adora looked down and smiled kindly at Entrapta.

“That’s correct, Entrapta, and we are very fortunate to have you with us.” She-Ra/Adora placed her hand on Entrapta’s shoulder as she blushed.

The group cautiously approached the temple. It seemed to become more oppressive as they got closer. Its ghostly glow did not seem to cast any shadows behind them, even in the twilight of the planet’s weak sun. They stopped at what appeared to be the entrance, and She-Ra/Adora placed her hand on the runes etched in the door, studying them intently.



"These runes are strange, not like ones I've ever seen before." She said thoughtfully.

The runes glowed with the same ghostly light as the rest of the temple. They appeared much like the runes on Etheria, but meaner, more corrupted.

"Can you read them, Adora?" Bow asked standing by her side, also peering at the writing.

"Maybe... give me a moment." She-Ra/Adora squinted, staring intently. "Hmm. I think it says, 'I wish to go forth from Twilight and enter Night, to move forth from weakness to strength'?"

Nothing happened.

"No, I've got it." She snapped her fingers. "I *demand* to go forth from Twilight and enter Night, to *cast aside* weakness and *gain power.*" She stated.

The door slowly rumbled open, revealing a dark, chasm-like entrance.

"Oh boy, nice, it looks really inviting." Glimmer timidly joked. "I can't wait!"

The group entered and Emily engaged her third upgrade, 360-degree floodlights. Even with the comfort of lights, the dark and

oppressive nature seemed to bear down on the group.

"Yearow-rowr!"

The group turned, seeing that Melog was still at the entrance, refusing to come in. Catra walked back and waved to her friend, indicating that they should follow.

"What's wrong, Melog? Come on!" Catra called.

Melog began a dialogue with Catra in their unique language; the rest of the group only heard meows and yowls that were feline in nature. Catra squinted as they spoke, seeming to be listening to Melog from far away and straining to understand them.

"They say that the magic is sick here, that it acts as a repulsive force to their magical nature. They cannot come with us and suggested we turn back." Catra translated for the rest of the group.

"Oh, that's great, a REALLY good sign when the magic is 'sick'." Glimmer deadpanned. "Maybe we should listen to Melog?"

Entrapta leapt up, her arm straight, index finger pointing in the air with one of her ponytails forming into the exact same stance. "NO! We must continue! FOR SCIENCE!"

"I agree with Entrapta— we came this far and handled everything that was thrown at us," She-Ra/Adora assured the group. "A dark hallway and some 'sick magic' shouldn't stop us from the answers we need. Let's continue."

Catra approached her friend and stroked their head reassuringly. "It's okay, Melog. Can you stand guard at the entrance and make sure nothing follows us?"

Melog yowled plaintively but sat and did as Catra requested. The group turned and continued down into the depths of the temple.

Bow looked around nervously as they walked deeper, trying to think of something to brighten the mood.

"So, Catra... is that really all you had for me? 'Good form, Punchy'?" He asked as he walked alongside her.

Catra looked over at Bow and delivered a half-hearted swat at him, which he deftly blocked.

"Ah-ha, denied!" Bow exclaimed, then continued in a deep voice: "When I left you, I was but the learner, now I am the master."

"Don't get cocky, kid." Catra retorted.

"Did you just call me kid? I'm the same age as you." Bow replied, confused.

Catra shrugged. "Yeah... I don't know where that just came from, must be from some line I heard from one of Double Trouble's stupid musicals. Anyway, in all seriousness, you should be addressing me with the correct title."

Bow rolled his eyes. "Oh, not this again."

"Yes, that's right, Punchy. You should address me as Sensei or Sensei Catra. It is the correct form of respect for your teacher." Catra said seriously.

"Yeah, I respect you but... not gonna do that. Also, why would I give you a respectful title when all I ever get is 'Punchy' as a name and title from you?" Bow retorted.

Before Catra had a chance to respond, Entrapta interjected.

"Query: So, I understand the concept of nicknames as a substitute for the proper name of a familiar person. Commonly used to express affection, it is a form of endearment and amusement. I also understand why Glimmer would be referred to as 'Sparkles', which is due to her appearance and the sparkly nature of her powers. What I don't understand is why Bow is

referred to as ‘Punchy’, as he is not known for his punching abilities, but his abilities with a Bow. His name is already ‘Bow’ so why the different nickname?”

Catra groaned covering her face with her hand, exasperated with Entrapta’s obtuseness. Glimmer and She-Ra/Adora chuckled.

“Oh, let me tell this one, this is *such* a great story!” Bow said with mock enthusiasm. “As you know, Catra took me under her wing, or paw, and started teaching me her special brand martial arts. After a particularly rough session – “

“Oh man, you took a beating that day!” Catra interrupted, chucking.

Bow glared at Catra and continued.

“Anyway, after a rough session, where Catra fought dirtier fighting than usual – “

“Me, fighting dirty? Never!” Catra exclaimed.

“She totally fights dirty.” She-Ra/Adora added.

“Please stop interrupting me! After this session, Glimmer asked me if Catra just used me as a punching bag instead of teaching me, and that I looked a little ‘punch drunk’. Catra overheard this and came up with the *wonderful* nickname of ‘Punchy.’ It’s been *so* much fun ever since.” Bow finished, oozing with sarcasm.

Entrapta thought about this and used one of her hair hands to rub her chin.

“Okay, that makes sense,” Entrapta said thoughtfully. “Next question— I understand that sometimes the act of giving a nickname is reciprocal. What is Bow’s nickname for Catra?”

“He doesn’t have one, which is a smart move on his part,” Catra said lowly, menace in her voice.

She-Ra/Adora suddenly looked back brightly at Catra. "Oh, I have one for her! Remember, Catra? You liked it too."

Catra whirled around, eyes wide and imploring. She mouthed *"No! No! No!"* to Adora.

"Oh yeah, her nickname is 'Fuzzy-Bum'." She-Ra/Adora snapped her fingers.

"ADORA! That was PRIVATE!" Catra screeched.

The desperation in Catra's voice brought a smile to everyone's face. It also acted as blood in the water to circling sharks.

"No way! So ca-yuute!" Bow gasped, hands on his cheeks.

"Logically, that is a good nick-name," Added Entrapta, "If by 'fuzzy' you mean fur and by 'bum' you mean the Gluteus Maximus, then yes, fur does encompass that part Catra's body. She does, in fact, have a 'fuzzy-bum'."

"Entrapta! What? How would you know?!" Catra looked a little worried. *How far had Entrapta's quest for data taken her?*

"Theory! Science runs on theory!" Entrapta answered simply, both her flesh and hair hand extended to a point in the air.

Glimmer's face was red with laughter. "'Fuzzy Bum'! And her full name is 'Princess fuzzy-wuzzy-was-her-bum'!" She cackled.

Bow gasped even deeper. "The cuteness intensifies!" His hands pressed so hard on the sides of his head, it seemed it would burst.

Catra looked at them with horror on her face, trying to think of a way to keep this from getting worse. She was so flustered, it made it hard for her to come up with a proper comeback.

"There is no way you guys are calling me 'Fuzzy-Bum', I won't allow – "

“How about I meet you halfway, Catra?” Bow interrupted placatingly. “You want to be called Sensei? How about Sensei Fuzzy Bum?” Bow laughed.

Catra whirled around, her fists clenched.

“Bow,” Catra was so flustered she dropped the nickname. “You call me that during our next sparring session, and Glimmer won’t think I used you as a punching bag, but as a scratching post.” She threatened.

“Ha ha, Catra, good one.” She-Ra/Adora said sarcastically, all the while making a stupid face that Catra hated.

Catra was flustered beyond all reckoning now and turned to She-Ra/Adora. “Well... how about I call you stupid…stupid-face hair-poof?” She retorted.

“Oh wow, that’s a good zinger, Catra! You know, I really love it when you’re too flustered to think straight!” She-Ra/Adora teased.

Everyone laughed and Catra tensed up. Her old anger flared up, but only for a moment. Catra breathed deeply and looked at her friends smiling back at her. Smiling not with harmful intent but affection, she fell into their old trap again. Catra breathed out and the anger, embarrassment and fluster flowed out of her as she realized her friends were once again trying to bring her down a peg and teach her humility. She let out a weak laugh.

“Oh well, everyone’s ganging up on Catra again. Whatever, jerks.” Catra said, indifferently.

She-Ra/Adora, Glimmer, Bow and Catra shared a laugh; the Best Friends Squad’s bonds were strong. Their affection and love for each other seemed to physically push the dread, darkness and oppressiveness of the temple far away.

Just then, Emily beeped and Entrapta looked down at her pad.

“I hate to interrupt this FASCINATING social exchange, but Emily’s sensors are picking up a strong First Ones energy source ahead. This is it! This is what we came looking for!” Her hair hands rubbed together over her head while she licked her lips hungrily.

Glimmer reached out to Entrapta, already knowing what came next. “Easy, Entrapta, let’s not be hasty. We need to take this slow _"

Entrapta was already bounding ahead in her excitement. “AH HA! SCIENCE! HAHAHAHAHA!”

Catra tried to grab Entrapta by her pigtails, but even Catra’s lightning-quick reflexes were no match for Entrapta’s enthusiasm. The group chased Entrapta down into the dark depths until they reached a large chamber. The oppressiveness and dread there seemed to swallow them and the darkness absorbed Emily’s light. A line of side by side pillars ran from the room’s entrance to the back in a line. In combination with the gloom, this effect added to the group’s uneasiness. At the back was what appeared to be an altar, with an arch behind it. The arch was much like the rest of the appearance of the temple, twisted and evil looking. Entrapta suddenly stopped and the group crashed into her back, ending up in a pile on the floor. Glimmer tackled Entrapta and pinned her to the ground.

Glimmer was panting hard. “Like I said, we need to take this next part SLOW.” She whispered.

The group helped each other off the ground and slowly approached the altar. On the face of the altar, there appeared to be a slot for a data crystal. On the floor, they saw its intended recipient, a black crystal. Unlike the usual crystals they found affixed in First Ones temples, this one was not diamond-shaped. It looked more like a 6-pointed star, much like the 3-pointed star that corrupted She-Ra with the rage-virus.

“Fascinating! According to Emily's sensors, the strongest readings are coming from this data-port and the structure behind it. The

structure appears to be a portal! This is it! Going by our usual experience with these things, by placing the crystal in the data-slot and speaking the command, we can activate the portal."

She-Ra/Adora stepped forward. "It should be me who activates it. If anything negative happens, I'm best suited to handle it as She-Ra."

Glimmer reached out and gently grasped her hand. "Do you really think that's a good idea? That crystal looks a lot like the one that infected you with the data virus. We really don't need to deal with 'Rage She-Ra' or 'Silly Adora' right now." Glimmer asked.

"Glimmer, I was only infected because She-Ra was shackled by the First One's sword at that time. The sword is gone and She-Ra is in her purest form. It can't happen again, trust me."

She-Ra/Adora placed her hand on Glimmer's shoulder and smiled down at her. Looking up at her smiling face, Glimmer was struck by how utterly pure and beautiful her friend was. She-Ra/Adora's light shone down on her, instilling a feeling of good and peace. Glimmer was convinced and gently nodded toward She-Ra/Adora.

She-Ra/Adora picked up the crystal and studied it. It was smooth and so cold. Its surface was black, but not solid, almost opaque. It was as if she was looking down into a very dark, deep hole with a faint light glowing at its bottom. She gasped as a distant voice seemed to whisper in her head, indistinguishable at first, but becoming more intelligible the more she listened.

"Speeeak… speeeeeak... speak the commaaaand, mmmmasssSSSTERSSS of the UNIVERSSSSSSE."

She-Ra/Adora placed the black crystal in the port, which made a sharp sound as it clicked into place.



“Masters of the Universe.” She-Ra/Adora tentatively spoke.

She-Ra/Adora’s body instantly went rigid. Her mouth opened in a soundless scream and her hand locked onto the crystal as if it was holding her. In her mind, she experienced a vision: *A dauntless*

implacable enemy, a losing war, a plan and then a weapon – hope. Betrayal, the weapon destroyed, hope lost, the enemy closes in. A last-ditch effort, an unthinkable choice chosen. Falling, darkness closing, hope turning to despair, then anger and ultimately, pure hate. A galaxy of infinite darkness, a faint light, near the light, a dark planet. On this planet, a presence, familiar like an old friend, but a friend that has not been seen in a very, very long time. A friend you are unsure of whether or not they are still your friend, their face has darkened. The presence stirs, sensing her, recognition, surprise, reaching out, grabbing hold, pulling in…

"Adora!" Catra screamed, all composure gone.

"What's happening? Is it electrocuting her?" asked Entrapta. "I know the signs because it happens to me all the time. We need an object to act as an insulator! We can use it to directly force her away from the data-port and break the circuit. Hurry!"

Bow rushed forward, holding out his bow. "Use this!"

Holding the bow between them, Bow and Catra ran directly at She-Ra/Adora, clothes-lining her back and away from the altar. She dropped limply to the ground and transformed into Adora, unconscious.

Catra was instantly by her side cradling her head. She placed her hand on Adora's chest and the heart rune appeared, still strong.

"Please wake up... please be okay!" Catra pleaded, stroking Adora's face.

"Okay, mission failed. We need to get out of here— now! This place is too weird and dark for it to be any good." Glimmer stated, taking charge.

"Glimmer, is there any residual magic here for a teleport?" Bow asked.

Glimmer closed her eyes and concentrated, but harnessing the magic here was not second nature for her. It was different and not as easily accessible. She allowed it to flow into her…

“Ahhh!” Glimmer screamed as she collapsed, vomited and began shaking.

Bow rushed to her, placing his hands on her shoulders.

“Glimmer! Are you okay? What happened?” he asked worriedly.

“I see what Melog was talking about… the magic here is bad. The description of being sick is spot on. I’m not trying that again.” Glimmer’s voice shook as she wiped some vomit from her mouth.

The group heard howling in the distance; it was Melog sensing their danger and unable to come to their aid. The sadness in its voice was heartbreaking. The room became even more sinister as the shadows and darkness seemed to move, questing tendril-like fingers moving in their direction.

Catra watched, eyes wide and ears lowered. “Oh boy... that’s not good. We need to get out of here— and fast! Can someone please help me with Adora?”

“Allow me! Emily, carry Adora!” Entrapta stepped forward. Emily displayed her fourth new upgrade as four delicate arms appeared, each ending in a hand. Emily delicately scooped Adora in its arms and cradled her against her hull.

“I upgraded Emily with these arms to assist me in my experiments. Between Hordak, Wrong-Hordak and Emily, I have a whole team of assistants.” Entrapta said proudly.

“That’s great Entrapta, but now is not the time. We need to get out of here, especially Adora and Glimmer.” Bow said angrily. His seemingly infinite patience had worn thin.

“Right! Just let me just get the black crystal for experimentation.” Entrapta said, turning away.

Catra grabbed Entrapta and spun her around. Holding her shoulders firmly, Catra looked into Entrapta's violet irises, trying to catch and hold the other's shifting gaze. There was no anger in Catra's face, only firm resolve.

"Entrapta, please," Catra began, surprisingly calm, "Adora is hurt and Glimmer is sick. This place is not right and we should have nothing to do with it. We definitely shouldn't take anything with us. We need to get out of here *right now*." Catra emphasised.

Entrapta's eyes briefly met Catra's heterochromatic yellow and blue ones. As their gazes locked, Entrapta saw the sincerity in the other woman's eyes. Entrapta looked away, realization dawning on her that this was one of those moments she needed to focus on her friends more than technology.

"Okay..." Entrapta agreed sadly. Catra smiled at Entrapta and squeezed her shoulders.

The group moved out, with Bow guiding Glimmer, Emily carrying Adora with Catra close at hand, and Entrapta in the lead holding a pad and pressing in a series of commands.

"I've just sent instructions for Darla to meet us at the entrance and pre-set coordinates for a return trip to Etheria at top speed!"

"Excellent work, Entrapta!" Bow responded.

The group made their way through the temple, their concern for Glimmer and Adora at the forefront of their minds. As they tentatively walked through the halls, more tendrils appeared, searching for them. They began to hear whispers, beseeching them to remain in the dark. As they approached the entrance, they saw Melog, who howled with pleasure at the sight of them, bouncing back and forth. Their ears perked up when they saw Adora held aloft by Emily and Melog queried Catra, tilting their head.

Catra patted her friend on the head. "I don't know what happened in there, Melog, but Adora is hurt and Glimmer is sick. We should

have listened to you. I'm sorry."

Melog rubbed up against Catra; they did not care about sorry or being right, only that their friends were okay. Catra affectionately rubbed their ears, watching as Emily brought Adora up Darla's ramp, Bow and Glimmer not far behind. She walked toward the ship, stopped and glanced back at the hateful temple, silently cursing it.

Entrapta studied data appearing on her pad. "Good news! Now that Adora is on board and in range of Darla's medical sensors, I can report that Adora has not suffered any physical harm. Her body has temporarily entered a coma-like state as defense against some form of psychic attack. Glimmer has been examined as well and has been administered something to help with the nausea."

Catra's calm demeanour was quickly replaced with anger. "Psychic attack? Temporary coma? How is that good news? How long is temporary?"

Entrapta checked her pad. "Temporary as is a day, week or month. As for the nature of the attack, I have no clue. I had no idea Darla's sensors were advanced enough to sense something like that, it's quite fascinating! Anyway, since Adora and Glimmer are safe, is there any chance…?" Both of her ponytails formed fingers pointing toward the temple.

The look on Catra's face was enough to make Entrapta snap back into herself and she immediately came to attention, flesh and hair hands forming a perfect salute over her brow.

"RIGHT! Back to Etheria!" Entrapta did an about-face and strode up Darla's ramp, Catra following right behind her.

* * *

Elsewhere...beyond space, beyond time, beyond the stars. In another dimension, a dark place, Night.

In a cell, deep within a mighty castle, a prisoner awoke from tormented dreams. He was not alone in his cell. His tormenter was there with him, the Lord of this realm, the Shen'Aan-war.

"Are you awake, Outcast? I have need of you."

The Outcast raised his head, greasy black hair plastered his face. There was light in his cell now, light that had been absent for a long time, so he squinted when he looked upon his Lord.

"Yes, I hear you. What do you need? Must I end more of your enemies? More rebels?"

His Lord did not like to be addressed this way, for he was master of this realm and demanded nothing but fear from his subjects. To be addressed so boldly by an underling would usually end in their death. This would not be the case here, for what he had done to the Outcast was already worse than death. The Outcast was beyond death— death would be the Outcast's ultimate reward. He swallowed his anger and silently promised exquisite torment for the Outcast once he was done with this mission.

"Yes, something like that. I have sensed a…disturbance. This disturbance reaches me through the void of space and time from the Greater Universe."

The Outcast sat up, interested now. *The Greater Universe?* Up until now, this had been an unattainable goal since The Fall.

"You have never heard me speak of the *Greater Universe* before, have you? It was before your time. I remember it well. We had temples and outposts all over in my day. I sensed a powerful presence meddling in the one we used to enter this realm, long ago. You see, this particular temple is saturated with the power we have sided with, power which allowed me to draw energy from this special individual. Our Death-Binders were able to use this energy to open a tenuous passage from our realm to theirs," The Shen'Aan-war explained.

“So, you need me to scout ahead and explore this realm?” The Outcast asked.

The Shen’Aan-war shook his head. “No, I have a task with which you should be familiar with. You see, I recognized this individual, an old acquaintance. In my time, this presence was associated with an individual named Mara. She was the bearer of the She-Ra.”

The Outcast looked confused, “Mara the Betrayer?”

“Yes and no, it is the She-Ra but not Mara, it is someone new. As I entered her psyche, I was able to see her more recent memories. They are most promising. Somehow, this new She-Ra was able to destroy our old enemy, that piece of genetic filth who called himself ‘Horde Prime’. This new She-Ra must be powerful indeed to have defeated a foe who almost destroyed us. Your task is a great one. I need you to enter the greater universe, find She-Ra’s new vessel and kill her. She must be out of the way for us to gain a foothold there and take our rightful place as Lords and Masters of that realm.”

The Outcast thought on this. He no longer cared about the history or future plans of his people. Mara the Betrayer, Horde-Prime and She-Ra were meaningless old stories. What bothered him was that he was being told to destroy again, to travel a great distance to kill someone he did not know.

His Lord became stern. “I sense resistance in you... should I have the Death-Binders send the Other?”

The Outcast cowered in terror at the change in his Lord’s voice. “NO! PLEASE NO! I BEG OF YOU, DON’T!”

The Outcast crouched face down before his tormentor, beseeching, daring to touch his hand.

“F-F-F-Father, please…”

A backhanded blow threw the Outcast back while his Lord, his Father stood over him, the embodiment of rage.

The Shen'Aan-war was furious. "You have long lost the privilege of addressing me as that title, Outcast! Now, will you do as I say, or shall we send the Other in your place?" He sneered.

"Yes. Yes, I will. I will do as you ask." The Outcast's head was down, as he held back sobs.

"Wise choice, for I would be loath to send that level of destruction so soon and tip our hand to our enemies. I will alert the Death-Binders; they will prepare you for your journey. Do not fail me."

The Outcast did not answer as his Lord left. With him went the light. In the darkness, he felt the Other presence within him wake. It spoke to him in a faint sibilant whisper, almost cooing.

"Your father wanted to send me. You should have let him. It would be so easy to let me do the job for you. I know it taxes you so, the thought of taking a life. ***Release me****."* The voice was soothing, the Outcast shivered when it spoke.

The Outcast hugged himself, as if by doing so, he could contain the evil within.

"No, never! Never again! I won't let you." the Outcast said weakly.

"Never is a really long time and you can no longer die, don't you remember? It's very unlikely you could hold out for that long. ***Give in****."* The Other chuckled maliciously.

The Outcast began to sing to himself to drown out the Other's taunts and provide a small amount of comfort for himself. It was an old song, one his mother used to sing to him when she was still alive. His singing had a melancholy beauty to it, fueled by the pain that filled his life. However, it was to no avail. Comfort had long left him.

The Other was exasperated. *"Really? Trying to drown me out with this old song again?"* They sighed. *"I don't understand why you treat me this way, after all, am I not your friend? Actually, I am your only friend since you –"*

"NOOOOOOOOOOOOOOO!!!! SHUT UP! SHUT UP! SHUT UP! SHUT UP! SHUT UP! AHHHHHHHHHH!" The Outcast stopped his singing and continued to hug himself, crying while rocking back and forth. He stayed this way in the dark while the demon in his heart laughed at him.

Chapter End Notes

Illustration of corrupted First One's Runes by the Author.

Illustration of Adora and Catra by @Yoritomito.

Interloper

Chapter Summary

The Outcast enters "the Greater Universe", intent on his mission to kill the bearer of She-Ra

Adora wakes from a horrible nightmare.

On the planet Twilight, a small portal opened under the gate in the main chamber that Adora was psychically attacked in. It was a swirling vortex of chaos, gaping like a demon maw to deposit a black-clothed body roughly on the floor, then closing back up with a primal scream. White corposant drifted off his body like fumes as he curled up in a ball, shuddering in pain. The Outcast groaned, unable to focus on anything but the pain of his interdimensional travel. The path to this reality was tenuous at this point, which made the journey painful.

* THE OUTCAST *

Unexpectedly, he felt it, a wicked wild glee within himself, unravelling and breaking its bonds. A faint reddish glow started to emanate from his chest.

"*Yeesssssss!*" the Other cried. "*You cannot hold me any longer!*"

The agony and pain of his travel had interrupted his focus, giving the Other its chance to be released, one it took with no regard to the secrecy of the mission.

"NO!" the Outcast cried, hugging himself again, useless against what was happening. The reddish glow intensified. His rib cage

and internal organs began to show through his skin, the pulsing light coming from his core, where his heart should be. "I won't let you!"

The Outcast concentrated, beginning an intuitive process to regain control of his body and subdue the Other within. He began by focusing on the scattered fragments of happiness that had dotted his life. These always began with his mother's face, a kind, sad face, gazing down upon him. He focused on her singing, the way it always seemed to calm his terrors and soothe his tears. He began to repeat the same song aloud now, though not as melodious as before, his strain and concentration taxing the song's beauty.

He then moved to another memory, one of his father finally taking him hunting in the huge dark forests of the Shadow Mountains. At the time, it seemed as if his distant father was finally accepting his son, a son he mentioned in the past as being too weak. There were other memories, few and far between, but they served as a kind of rope, loosely encircling the escaping prisoner inside him. He conjured up the final memory, which tightened the rope and finally tied the knot that secured the Other.

He remembered another face, a beautiful masculine face, his face. He remembered their first meeting, the other laughing and cajoling him for being so serious.

"*You know, My Prince,"* he had teased, *"you really need to lighten up! Open your heart, smile! We live on a dark world but it doesn't mean we have to live dark lives!"*

Later, when he had joined the rebellion and they were both on their first mission together, along with the others, his new friends. The mission at the time looked dire, and he was unsure of his new allies.

"My Prince, you have faith in us, open your heart and trust in your friends, we can do this!"

After, when they fell in love.

"After all this time, My Prince, you finally decided to listen to me... you have opened your heart to me."

The Outcast then spoke the name that belonged to the beautiful face that only resided in his memories.

"Shen'Dara."

"NO!" screamed the Other, feeling its escape halted and its prison walls reforming. It said no more after that, only struggling madly at its bounds, too furious to speak.

The Outcast felt the struggles slowly weaken until finally, he felt the Other within sag with defeat. It was sullen, sulking and withdrawn.

That should keep them quiet for a while, the Outcast thought to himself, *At least long enough for me to think.*

He could see nothing; his surroundings were pitch black.

Curses, he thought, *I was hoping for more time before I had to ask them for a favor.*

Focusing within, he spoke a command.

"Grant me the power of Dark-Sight."

The Other stirred, still angry and resistant, but bound by magic to obey commands. The Other usually had some quip during these exchanges, but only responded with a grunt.

Instantly, the Outcast's surroundings came into view, the Dark-Sight granting complete and total vision in the gloom. Dark-Sight did not rely on light of any kind to grant him the ability to see, but on the absence of it; the more complete the darkness, the more effective the spell was. Dark-Sight worked by using the dark to see shapes instead of light, the dark somehow reflecting shapes

and textures to the Outcast's eyes. It was not perfect though, as there was no color and no real clear details in the objects being reflected.

The Outcast looked around the chamber; he was alone. If the Death-Binder's spells were true, he should be here mere moments after the intruders left, the nature of his realm being outside this universe's timeline, making this possible.

He heard distant voices and other sounds, like an animal's joyous cries at a friend's return. *He must hurry!* The Death-Binders had imprinted a small portion of the She-Ra's stolen energy into an energy spore on the Other within him, allowing the Outcast, by proxy, to follow the scent. Rushing through the dark corridors, he used the energy spore of his quarry to determine the right path.

As he came closer and closer to his prey, his Dark-Sight became less and less effective as the ambient light from outside became stronger.

"I rescind the power of Dark-Sight." He commanded.

The Dark-Sight left him and was replaced by a glow ahead; it was the temple entrance and it was still open. The Outcast rushed out and was instantly brought to his knees, then fell flat on his face. *Light! So much light!* It was intense and the new sensation filled him with overwhelming feelings; agoraphobia mixed with a kind of warmth, almost happiness. The light also hurt his eyes and he had to press his face into the dirt. Slowly, he began to turn his head and then, just as slowly, he opened his eyes. It took him some time to focus, but what he saw in the distance made him despair. It was a ship blasting off into the sky, and he sensed his quarry was upon it.

"Wow, my Prince, you really managed to screw that up." the Other said drolly.

The Other seemed to be back to its old self and was feeling particularly malicious, using Shen'Dara's old nickname for him as a

vicious barb. The Other took great pleasure in using the Outcast's own weapons against him.

It was no matter. The spore-scent imprinted into the Other was absolute and he could follow it, no matter how far away his quarry was. What he needed was transportation off this world and to wherever the bearer of She-Ra escaped to.

He suddenly realized how amazing the idea of another world was to him. There was only one planet in his realm and he had no reason to ever leave it. The knowledge of space travel, planets and stars was imprinted on him by the Death-Binders before his departure. He did not have time to learn all of these concepts the hard way as it was easier to magically cram them into his mind.

The Outcast forced himself to concentrate back on the task at hand. He needed a ship. Looking around, he saw nothing but the temple surrounded by flat desert, a wasteland.

There must be some form of settlement nearby, he thought to himself, *If there is a settlement, then perhaps there is a ship.*

The Outcast reflected on this and seeing how lifeless his surroundings were, an idea formed in his mind. He could use the scarcity of life on this planet to find any nearby settlements. He had the perfect request for this.

"Grant me the power of Life-Sense," the Outcast directed within.

"Granted," the Other stated in a bored tone. Though this was unnecessary, the Other took every opportunity to communicate with him, usually with taunts.

An overwhelming feeling washed over him, pulling in one direction. The Outcast allowed it to pull him along and slowly made his way to what he hoped was his intended destination.

* * *

Adora opened her eyes. She was on her back looking up, naked and floating in warm water, like a bath. She quickly realized that this was no bath, as no sides were enclosing her and she was not inside; a dark, star-less sky hovered above her. She saw a bright moon shining down on her, projecting a hard and cold light, not like the gentle comforting glow of Etheria's moon.

Strange she thinks, *how can a moon project much heat, let alone cold?*



As she stared at the bright orb, she had a creeping sensation that it was staring back, that a dark intensity was inspecting her. Adora squinted, taking a better look at the moon, not seeing the usual craters and cosmic marks that covered the Etherian moons. This moon seemed to have no discerning marks, just flat, dead light. She sensed that whatever was far above her in space was no moon.

Adora shifted from her back to a vertical position, treading water, not wanting to look at the hateful orb. Shifting gave her a clear

view of her surroundings. She saw only flat water as far as the eye can see, perfectly calm except for small ripples caused by her treading. She spun around being surrounded by the same on all sides, endless water eerily lit by the orb above. She started to panic but quickly shut it down, old Horde training kicking in.

Okay, Adora, you got this she thought to herself. *Remember what Force Captain Octavia taught you during water survival school*. She pictured the other woman clearly in her mind, instructing them by a large pool in a husky voice.

"Cadets, when you find yourself in an overboard situation, the first thing must do is STAY CALM. Second, you must stay in one place — it makes it easier for your vessel to locate you, that is... if they decide you're worth turning around for."

Adora smirked at this memory, remembering after that statement, Lonnie elbowed Kyle in the ribs and whispered that they wouldn't turn around for him.

She recalled more of the memory. "*Third, try switching between treading water and floating on your back to rest. Treading water helps to keep you warm and stave off hypothermia while lying on your back lets you rest so you don't overtire yourself. With the Horde fitness regime, you should be able to maintain this rotation for a very long time until your ship finds you or you tire out, drown and die."*

Her smirk turned into a warm smile as this memory made her think of how Catra never participated in the water survival school due to her hatred of water. Her absence from these classes was what created so much turmoil between her and Octavia, turmoil that resulted in Catra scratching out one of the woman's eyes.

Adora continued to tread water, continuing even when she began to tire out, reluctant to lay on her back and face the evil orb in the sky.

She became conscious of how far her feet kicked down and started to restrict the distance they traveled down from her body as if by extending too far, she could kick something that might turn around and grab her.

She began to feel frightened and too vulnerable in her nudity, the panic she previously suppressed returning.

Come on Adora she chides herself, *you've been in the ocean before. Remember the first time you were on Seahawk's ship? When you leaped off like a maniac as She-Ra and attacked that sea monster?*

Remembering her She-Ra form, she concentrated on transforming, hoping that by becoming She-Ra, her sense of comfort and safety would return... and because being She-Ra always came with clothes.

She held her hand up out of the water and attempted to summon the sword, then She-Ra.

"For the honor of Grayskull!" she shouted up at the dark sky, nothing happened. No matter how hard she concentrated, she couldn't transform. Adora became even more fearful at this.

"What is happening?" she cried aloud. "Somebody help me!".

She slowly realized that the water she was treading in was very deep, perhaps having no bottom. It was not empty though, and something stirred, responding to her cries. Something huge, ancient and malevolent moved up toward her, and Adora senses its approach and animalistic hunger.

"NO!" she screamed, the fear becoming complete and absolute panic.

She began to kick harder, pushing down with her arms, as if by doing so, she could leap out of the water and out of danger. She looked up, once again seeing the orb gazing mercilessly down on her; it seemed to be enjoying her torment. Her focus returned to

the presence below her, now almost upon her, a vast gaping mouth rising to engulf her…

* * *

"NOOOOOOO!!" Adora shrieked as she woke up, still kicking and clawing out with her arms. She quieted, realizing that she was safe and her breathing began to even out, feeling bright warm light on her skin, light that was coming in through the room's open windows. The light was soft and diffused, a morning light. She sat up and it dawned on her that she recognized this room. She was in her bedroom, hers and Catra's.

"Bright Moon!" Adora exclaimed happily. "I'm home!"

The door burst open and Catra entered. "Adora? Adora!" she cried as she rushed over and leaped on the bed, wrapping her arms around Adora and kissing her face. Adora returned the embrace, overwhelmingly thankful to have Catra comforting her after such an awful experience. They parted, and Catra held Adora's face and gazed into her eyes, her heterochromatic eyes searching for signs of hurt.

"I heard you yelling, are you okay? Oh, Adora, we were so worried!" Catra was almost gushing with happiness and concern, acting most unlike herself. Adora placed her hand over Catra's.

"Yes…Yes I am. I just had the most horrible dream, although I think it would have been worse for you. I was floating in some kind of large sea –" Catra groaned at this; Adora knew she would hate that part. "I was floating in this sea, under some kind of weird moon that wasn't a moon, and something was rising to eat me, well, at least I think it was going to eat me." Adora gazed was unfocused, fear reappearing.

Catra's eyes softened and she started purring. "Well, you're safe now." She said, going in for a kiss.

"Hey, I heard yelling, is Adora awa—" Bow suddenly stopped, then gasped and blushed, turning around quickly.

“Geez Catra, Adora just woke up and you’re starting in already? At least wait long enough for us to say hello!” Glimmer scolded with her hands on her hips.

Adora and Catra smirked at their friends, not at all ashamed or embarrassed. They had been caught too many times before for this small incident to phase them.

“I had to make sure she was alright before I presented her to the rest of you, so why don’t you two take off so I can go back to my assessment?” Catra said as she moved behind Adora in an embrace, her head resting on Adora’s shoulder, her purr still present but lower now.

“Not. A. Chance.” Glimmer said with a bright smile, taking a seat on the bed. Concern suddenly filled her sparkling purple-pink eyes and she placed a hand on Adora’s leg. “How are you feeling? Do you remember anything?”

Adora concentrated, thinking back to the mission to the First One’s temple. “I remember we were going to open the portal, picking up that black crystal, placing it on the altar and saying, ‘Master of the Universe’. There was a series of strange images, then nothing, just blackness.”

Bow had moved behind Glimmer, placing his hands on her shoulders. “It was like the altar had a hold of you or something. Entrapta thought it was electrocuting you, so Catra and I used my bow to knock you off. You instantly transformed back to She-Ra and were completely unconscious on the floor.”

As if summoned by name, Entrapta entered in a rush, Emily right behind. “ADORA!!! YOU'RE OKAY! I’M SO GLAD!” The diminutive princess bounded onto the bed, wrapping her arms and ponytails around Adora and by proxy, Catra. She showed no concern or hesitation at invading such an intimate space between the two women, but Catra and Adora did not mind; they were used to Entrapta’s obliviousness.

She broke the embrace and sat back, still gushing with happiness. “Adora, it's so good to see you fully functional again!” Emily pulled up, emitting a series of happy beeps. “Emily expresses her relief also.” Entrapta translated, then pulled out a recorder and held it out, pressing the ‘on’ button. “Tell me everything! Don’t leave anything out, not a speck of DATA!”

Glimmer grabbed Entrapta by the shoulders and began to pull her back. “Easy girl, let’s give Adora a little space to breathe, she *just* woke up.”

Catra shook her head at Entrapta like an exasperated parent. “Geez, Entrapta, you know it’s not all about data all the time. Right now, Adora needs her rest”.

Bow smirked at Catra. “You’re one to talk, Catra, it didn’t exactly look like you were letting Adora rest when we entered.” Catra stuck her tongue out as Glimmer, Bow and Adora shared a laugh.

“Ulterior motives aside, Catra is right. Entrapta, let’s take it slow with Adora.” Glimmer said and Entrapta looked down glumly, turning off her recorder.

Before she could tuck it away, Adora spoke up. “No, it’s okay guys, I’m fine. Entrapta, turn that thing back on.”

Adora started from the beginning, slowly remembering the vision she had before blacking out, then retelling her dream story in greater detail. Catra clutched her tighter when she mentioned the water again. She finished her tale by suddenly waking up in bed, safe in Bright Moon. When she finished speaking, everyone momentarily stared at her in silence.

“FASCINATING!!” breathed Entrapta, her ponytails raising above her in exclamation.

“What do you think it means, Entrapta?” Bow asked, puzzlement on his face.

“No idea!” she exclaimed brightly. “But with the data I collected at the First One’s temple, plus this interview, I’m determined to find out!”

Catra was suddenly suspicious. “Just data, right? You didn’t snag any weird magical tech and bring it here when I wasn’t looking, right?”

Entrapta was immediately affronted and confused. “What? Me? Why would I do that when you told me not to?”

Bow piped up. “Oh, it’s because when we tell you not to do something, sometimes you end up doing it anyway. Remember when I told you not to mess with Adora’s ship— I’m sorry, Darla— and you did it anyway?”

Entrapta’s confusion deepens. “Well in the case of Darla, it turned out to be for the best remember? It came in handy getting off Horde Prime’s ship. In this case, it was obviously not for the best, so I listened to you.” Entrapta said this as if it made complete logical sense. Everyone looked at each other confused, completely lost at Entrapta’s line of reasoning.

“Entrapta, how would you kno –” began Glimmer before stopping herself, holding the bridge of her nose, feeling a tension headache coming on “Okay, you know what, never mind. Don’t bother responding, I don’t want to know.”

“Okay...” Entrapta drew out while looking at everyone, seemingly satisfied, understood now. “I’m going to get to work on this back at my lab in the Crypto Castle. I also have to check in on Hordak. He must be worried SICK about me as he hasn’t seen me since we left on our trip.”

“Wait...” Adora said leaning forward and putting her hand on Entrapta’s, “How long have you been here? And for that matter, how long have I been out?”

“You’ve been out for almost a week now, Adora...” Bow responded.

“A week!?” Adora almost shrieked.

“Yeah... we were starting to get really worried. I had my father take a look at you and he said it was best just to let you sleep.” Glimmer smiled tiredly.

Adora was not only stuck by the length of time she was out, but also by the fact that Entrapta was able to focus long enough to stay by her side. She was touched by how along far the “tech-mad” princesses had come. Either through genuine concern or just by becoming more aware of social queues, Entrapta had done something very thoughtful.

“Let us know what you find out as soon as possible, Entrapta,” Adora said and then added, “Thanks for staying by my side all this time. It means a lot to me.”

Entrapta blushed. “You got it, Adora!” she replied, then turned, and left the room along with Emily for their journey back to Dryl and the Crypto Castle.

“So guys, our first mission was a complete failure and we are no closer to finding out where the First Ones went, let alone completing our greater mission of bringing magic back to the galaxy. What’s next?” Bow commented inquisitively, looking at his friends.

“What’s next?” Catra smirked. “What’s next is that you two get out of here so I can spend some time with my girlfriend. Also, Adora, we are spending the *entire* day together, we are not going to say a single word about First Ones, bad dreams, bringing magic back the galaxy or most importantly, about swimming in water of *any* kind!” She declared triumphantly. She made a shooing motion with her hands, garnering laughter from everyone as Adora relaxed back into her arms.

“That sounds like a perfect dream to me!” Adora said.

* * *

The Outcast surveyed the busy village before him, watching the residents go about their day carefree, unaware of his scrutiny. He was getting close now, he could feel it. He had overheard one of the residents refer to their village as Thaymor. His intended destination, Bright Moon was next on the road he followed.

The Outcast had managed to leave Twilight using his "Life-Sense" spell to find what appeared to be an outpost. Using another one of the Other's gifts, "Sight Unseen", he was able to become invisible and infiltrate the Outpost, enabling him to stow away on a ship. This vessel brought him to another planet. When he sensed the spore was not there, he simply found a different ship to stow away on to another planet. He did this for two days, growing increasingly frustrated every day, having a limited idea of just how big the universe was.

He decided to try a different tactic— he decided to become visible and interview the locals in an effort to find She-Ra's planet. This was not as straightforward as it may have seemed though; the myriad planets and people he found on them were vastly different and he could not speak their language. For this task, he used the gift, "Stranger's Speech Known", and set to work gathering intelligence, listening in on conversations and interjecting when something sounded promising. After about half a day of this, he came across an old trader speaking of a strange new planet that had appeared a year ago, and this planet was the home to a magical warrior woman, and where the tyrant Horde Prime met his end. This trader said he just so happened to be going there to explore and see what this new world had to offer in trade.

"That's it, my Prince!" the Other had shouted in his head. "*That must be the home of the She-Ra! We must go, go, GO, GO!"* The Other's excitement grew in the hunt, making it impatient and neurotic.

Since the trail was simple to follow, it took a short time to reach this world, landing at its only port for space-faring vehicles. He exited the trader's craft under the cover of "Sight-Unseen" and gazed at this strange new place. Looking around, he saw what

appeared to be a city, the buildings covered in plant growth. He overheard one of the locals refer to the place as "the Old Fright Zone". This was a strange name to him; it did not seem apt for there was nothing to him that was frightening about the place.

"These fools know nothing about true fright, my Prince." the Other cooed in his mind. He found himself reluctantly agreeing with the Other. The place he found himself in was tame in comparison to the dark place he came from, the place of Night.

Once on She-Ra's planet- Etheria, as it became known to him— the energy spore was so strong that local intelligence was not needed to find his quarry. His journey took him from the so-called "Fright Zone" to a large forest, a truly beautiful place full of lights and whispers, the exact opposite of the dark, haunted forests of his home. Its beauty was so overwhelmingly intense, the Outcast had to wait for nighttime and use "Dark Vision" to cross it, otherwise, he would have been driven to absolute tears.

It had not taken him long to find this village of Thaymor, after finding a rough road whose trail brought him in the same direction as the energy spore. From here, the tales of She-Ra were abundant, and he discovered She-Ra resided in a place called Bright Moon. He was so close to completing his mission but felt no excitement or enthusiasm, only a kind of emptiness.

"Don't start getting morose on me," the Other complained. *"The least you could do is take a little enjoyment in your work, especially if you're not going to let me out. Your weak emotions sour the taste of the kill."*

"I have no care for your enjoyment, your "tastes", or anything else that you preferred I'd do," he snapped back to the Other. "I just want to get this over with."

"Ugh, you're so weak! Why did your father curse me with such a weak host? He knew you were such a pathetic subject too— he always told you so!"

The Other wanted to fight with him, beat him down with all the old insults and taunts in the hopes of driving him to extreme anger and securing its escape. There were so many juicy victims in this town, and the Other wanted blood.

"Just shut up! I'm not doing this with you, I know what you're trying to do anyway." the Outcast said, irritated.

"Oh yeah, what's that? Succeed where your father failed by making a proper man out of you?"

This made the Outcast angry, not because he felt he didn't measure up, but because his father's definition of manhood was idiotic. Hunting the weak, dominating your underlings, ruling by fear; if these things made you a man, then the Outcast wanted nothing to do with the label.

"Nice try, but you're not going to get a rise out of me with that old idiocy." the Outcast said.

The Other would not be silenced so easily and responded in his mind. The Outcast became distracted as he continued to bicker with the Other, not paying attention to his surroundings.

The Outcast was slammed from behind by an immense force, the momentum of it driving him to the ground. The "Sight-Unseen" spell was broken and he immediately materialized as he lay on his back, stunned.

* * *

"Oh boy, oh boy, oh boy, I'm in such big trouble," Scorpia said, using her usual preference of speaking aloud her inner monologue, "Perfuma is going to be so disappointed in me!" She wailed. Scorpia was walking briskly through the village of Thaymor, completely focused on finding what she needed.

"You did it again Scorpia. You were so focused on planning your first Ball and completely forgot that it's our one-year anniversary!"

she said, completely exasperated with herself. “The Ball isn’t for months anyway!”

Scorpia and Perfuma had been together for almost a year now, their budding friendship blossoming into romance during the hard times of The Trial. With the extenuating circumstances of Scorpia’s defection from the Horde, she was allowed to leave confinement and walk the grounds surrounding Bright Moon. Scorpia and Perfuma had spent many hours on the grounds, under the shade of the trees or by the water, going over Scorpia’s defense.

The act of delving deep into Scorpia’s character and her motivations for leaving the Horde had given Perfuma a look into the other woman’s heart and soul, and Perfuma fell in love with her. Perfuma stuck by Scorpia throughout the trial, her loyalty impressing a woman who held that trait in the highest regard. The love and understanding Perfuma had shown Scorpia was what the larger woman had always sought in a partner— love and understanding that never wavered, even when the evidence of Scorpia’s participation in some of the biggest Horde conquests came to light. Scorpia fell in love with Perfuma in return, and the two women began a strong loving relationship, a relationship that was soon approaching its first anniversary.

Once Scorpia had realized this fact, she panicked and went to the village closest to her kingdom with the most specialty boutiques, Thaymor. She was trying to remember where the specialty tea shop was, a new tea set for Perfuma’s morning tea ceremony would be perfect.

A burst of color caught her eye and she turned to see a mannequin wearing an orange open-breasted short sleeve shirt complete with black pants with a yellow stripe running down the legs.

“Oh, wow, *that* would look so cute on Catra!” she exclaimed before stopping herself. “Focus, Scorpia! Tea set for Perfuma!”

Finally, her destination caught her eye: Thaymor's Premium Teas. She rushed in that direction; she was a woman focused on a mission.

Scorpia had just taken a few steps when she suddenly felt a body slam into her. Confused, she looked down and she saw the strangest person sprawled before her. The figure was dressed head to toe in black; black boots, black loose-fitting pants with a black hooded shirt, a black armor chest piece over the shirt with matching black gauntlets, and shin guards on the arms and legs. A black cloth covered the figure's lower face so only their eyes were exposed. They were dark and wide, wide from the shock of being slammed by Scorpia's indomitable stride.

"Oh man, are you okay?" She said as she helped pick the person off the ground and set them on their feet. "I'm so sorry, I didn't see you. That was totally my bad."

The other stood straight and looked up at her, their eyes momentarily widening again as they took her in. The figure then spoke to her in a weird, whispery language with lots of S's.

"Uh, come again?" Scorpia asked, completely dumbfounded.

The figure spoke a short phrase in that strange language, paused, then spoke in a language she was more familiar with.

"No madam, I apologize, the fault is with me." The figure stated.

"Madam! Oh, man, no one ever calls me that!" Scorpia laughed, claws to her chest.

"They don't? You have my apology again if I offended you." the other said, their voice tinged with worry.

"No, no, I like it. It's great!" Scorpia said happily.

Scorpia noticed the other had a slight accent, one she has never heard before. The voice was also clearly a young man, not too far out of his teens.

“Are you from around here? Do you need any help getting around?” asked Scorpia kindly.

“No, no, I will be just fine. I am sorry to have disturbed you, I must be on my way.” the other replied, quickly walking in the direction of a small alley between two shops.

“Okay, have a nice day!” Scorpia brightly shouted after him. “What a nice fellow,” She said to herself. “Nice, but very odd. Now, where was I? That’s right, tea set!”

* * *

The Outcast rushed out of view behind a shop, while the Other laughed in his head.

“Grant me Sight-Unseen,” the Outcast growled inwardly.

“Oh, granted,” the Other replied, still chuckling. *“That was hilarious! That huge beast of a woman almost killed you!”* The Other’s laughter was loud and mocking.

The Outcast was fuming, not at his mocking, but by the Other’s description of the woman. He had only briefly interacted with her but got the sense that she was a kind, generous soul— those were few and far between back in the realm of Night. Traits that he cherished and tried to hold on to when he found them in others.

The Outcast had enough. The Other’s nonsense almost got them caught and could potentially ruin the mission. He had to regain control or there was no point to any of this.

“Listen here and listen good,” he spoke firmly, brimming with anger. “If you keep up with the constant taunts and mind games, I swear, I will end this right now.”

The Outcast pulled out a dagger, its meaning fully known to the Other.

“I will end this right now, and we will *both* be sent back to the corpse-pools to be stitched back together by the Death-Binders! Once we are whole again, we will *both* face the displeasure of my Father! Just test me again and see!” The Outcast growled lowly.

The Other was silent as they knew the Outcast would do it; he had done it before. The Other was loath to end the fun so soon, to go through the ordeal of congealment followed by the wrath of the Lord and ruler of their realm.

“Very well. I will behave, I promise.” the Other replied.

“Good,” the Outcast replied, satisfied. He turned to the road exiting Thaymor, starting on the path to Bright Moon, content in the peace and quiet his threat afforded him.

“Don’t mess with my Grrrl.”

Chapter Summary

Entrapta and Hordak make a discovery which only deepens the greater mystery.

Catra and Adora spend a day together.

The Outcast is close to completing his mission, to kill the bearer of the She-Ra.

Catra has to fight wearing only her underwear.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Entrapta frantically ran through the maze of her castle, trying to remember the correct path all while disabling any traps, Emily in tow. She was completely and utterly in the throes of her single-minded drive to achieve one objective.

Using one of her ponytails, she hurriedly typed what she believed to be the correct code into the pad, trying to open the door to the secret passage. The door and passage were the end of the maze and the entry into her inner sanctum, a term she more recently began to call her living space and labs. In her haste, she typed in the wrong code and was instantly electrocuted.

“Ahhhh!” she screamed as she pulled away. “Drat! Curse you! That was the right one, right? The first ten digits of Emily’s personality code?”

Entrapta stepped back and rubbed her chin, tongue sticking out in thought. Emily beeped a suggestion to her. Entrapta listened, then entered in a different code and the door opened.

“Ah-ha! You were right, Emily! It was the last ten digits of your locomotion sub-routine!”

The door opened and she leaped in, yelling in absolute joy. Emily followed, emitting her own excited beeps.

“Oh, Hordaaaaak! I’m HOOOOOME!” Entrapta yelled, drawing out the words.

Entrapta bounced and skipped, peeking into different chambers and labs as she sought her love.

“Hordak! Hordak? Where are you, you rascal?” Entrapta called.

“Here my love,” Hordak responded, appearing from one of the labs at the end of the hall. He was smiling and holding something behind his back.

“EEEEEEEEEEE!” Entrapta squealed as she ran to him. Using her ponytails to lift herself to Hordak’s level, she wrapped her arms around him, delivering quick kisses to his smiling face. Emily ran up as well, rubbing against Hordak’s leg like an affectionate pet.

“Easy, my love, easy!” Hordak chuckled. With his free hand, he cupped her face and kissed her. It was a simple, innocent kiss, with pure love behind it.

They parted and Entrapta took a little step back, taking him in.

Hordak’s appearance had changed immensely since he was the master of the Horde. Instead of power armor, he now wore simple black, red and brown robes, like a scholar. Under the robes, he wore an electro-mechanical support harness created by Entrapta, which made up for the weakness in his clone body. Hordak was able to enjoy a brief sense of rejuvenation while he was under Horde Prime’s influence, but this slowly left him once he was free.

His body slowly reverted to his old form, his hair darkening and the green coloring being replaced by red.

Hordak's old appearance had not fully returned, gone were many of the hard lines in his face, replaced by softer ones. His eyes had changed as well, the inquisitiveness was still there but the cruelness was replaced by a kind of sadness. He also decided to give in to what he perceived as weakness and began to wear glasses; his eyesight had always been poor, and he was loath to show weakness to his subordinates by wearing glasses.

Entratpa turned from his face, seeing his arm was behind him. "What do you have there? Is it DATA?" She asked curiously.

Hordak chuckled. "No, Entrapta, even better. It's a present— for you."

He held out a small object to her, poorly wrapped in tissue paper.

"I asked Scorpia to look for it in our old lab in the Fright Zone. It arrived just the other day." He explained. Entrapta tentatively took it in her hands and slowly unwrapped it, revealing the gift.

"It's a six-sided hex driver. Hordak, we have lots of these." Entrapta looked confused.

Hordak shook his head. "No, it's not just any six-sided hex driver, it's the same one you sought in my sanctum. It is the one that brought us together." He said softly.

Slowly, Hordak's meaning slowly became apparent to Entrapta and her look of confusion turned to one of warm endearment.

"Oh, Hordak! That is so ROMANTIC!" She gushed as they embraced and kissed again.



They parted and Entrapta lowered herself to the ground, cradling her new gift.

“How did the mission fare, my love? Did Adora find what she was looking for?” Hordak asked her.

Entrapta started from the beginning, going into detail about the dark appearance of the elementals, the First Ones runes and the temple itself.

“Fascinating...” Hordak said, astonished.

“I KNOW, RIGHT?! That’s what I said!” Entrapta exclaimed.

Entrapta continued to tell him about the mission, recounting Melog’s refusal to enter and their reasons, the dark journey through the tunnels and the chamber within. She spoke of the “data-port”, black data crystal and portal arch, how Adora had volunteered herself to be the one to insert the disk and enter the command. Hordak looked thoughtful when Entrapta repeated the

command, *Masters of the Universe,* to him. Commenting that it seemed in line with what he knew of the First Ones. Entrapta continued, how Adora appeared to be held by the data-port, apparently being electrocuted, and reverting to her natural form once released, then falling unconscious.

"Is Adora alright?" Hordak asked, trying and failing to seem unconcerned. Deep behind his emotional walls, Hordak was concerned. Contrary to what he once said to Adora while she was held captive, Hordak did care about her. He also did not believe her to be inconsequential. He felt a fondness within his hidden heart for the woman who was once the small baby he found so long ago. He believed, at the time, that the best option was to give the baby over to Shadow Weaver. Perhaps the old witch would have some maternal instincts deep in her withered heart and be best suited to raise the girl... well, the best-suited person that could be found within the Fright Zone.

"Yes, she is fine now. Let me finish, Hordak!" she scolded, her ponytails seeming to frizz up.

Entrapta continued with her tale of how Glimmer became sick when she attempted to use the magic there, then, their escape and return to Etheria, how long Adora was unconscious for, the wait for her to awaken, and then the dark dream she recounted to them when she regained consciousness.

"I'm sorry it lengthened our time apart, my love, but I am glad you stayed by your friend's side while she recovered," Hordak said comfortingly once her tale was completed.

Entrapta beamed at him for a moment, but then looked a little downcast. "I told them I would use the data and information I gathered to try and make sense of the whole business, but I'm actually at a loss as where to start," Entrapta said sorrowfully.

"Hmm..." Hordak looked thoughtful. "You said this planet was called 'Twilight', correct?" Entrapta nodded.

“Well, let’s start with that bit of information. I was able to download much of Horde Prime’s data off of his ship, the Velvet Glove. Perhaps there is an old star-chart that shows this planet, with details or a link we can follow.” Hordak suggested.

“Great idea!” Entrapta beamed.

The two entered a lab, smaller in size than the main one they shared. This lab served as Hordak’s personal space to work on his many projects. Though these projects were varied and seemingly unrelated, they all shared a common purpose— the betterment of Etherian-kind. There was an experimental power-generator, a device for efficient crop harvesting, and even some medical devices; prosthetic limbs, hearing aids and replacement organs.

They passed these and each took a separate seat before a data screen and terminal, Hordak deftly typing in commands. A series of archaic charts appeared on the screen with the labels of planets, stars and systems appearing to be in the tongue of the First Ones, a language neither of them could read. In spite of this, they were able to zoom in on the system the planet Twilight was located in, but what they found was puzzling.

“Right there, Hordak,” Entrapta pointed to the screen. “This is where it is located, I’m positive, but this other planet was not there”

“Strange then,” he replied. “It appears that this planet Twilight was actually a moon of another world.”

Entrapta squinted. “Hmm, maybe it was destroyed? There were no asteroids or planetary debris though, where did it go?”

“Perplexing,” Hordak said, hand rubbing his chin. “Perhaps if we knew the name of this mystery planet we could dig up some history. I cannot read this label though, the First One’s language always eluded me.”

Entrapta looked up brightly, hand and ponytail pointing to the air.

“Adora would know!”

* * *

The Outcast sat in a tree at the forest’s edge and took in the view before him, it was magnificent.

Bright Moon.

Never in all his most fantastic and hopeful dreams did he imagine such a wonderful place could exist. Two massive rock pinnacles rose from a crystal water bay, a fantastic white castle nestled among them. Below this castle was a series of white towers of various sizes, some with white bridges between them. There were lush trees and gardens among the towers, and there seemed to be a small peaceful village near the water.

Using the spell, “Focused Vision”, he could see guards in purple, blue and white robes. On their heads were white helmets with blue face masks; the bottom portion of their faces was exposed revealing stern countenances. On the top of the helms were purple horse-hair plumes, which extended down their backs. In their hands, they held vicious pikes with sickle-moon blades at the ends.

Best be wary of them, he thought to himself. *By themselves, they should be no match for me but banded together, they can send me back to the unkind ministrations of the Death-Binders.*

He saw that many of these guards were uniform in height, but he caught sight of two standing guard together that stood out like misfits. One was short and had dark skin, the robes they wore seemingly too big for their short stature. The other was taller, with green skin, a lizard-like snout and what appeared to be a long, thick tail. This one was not as tall as many of the other guards, but extremely broad and powerful looking. The fact that the Bright Moon guard was composed of diverse races was not a new concept to the Outcast, as his dark world was composed of many different races as well.

He turned his attention from the guards to the people living and working in Bright Moon; they were so carefree and untroubled by many of the concerns that haunt the people of his benighted world. He was envious of their happiness, for the Outcast would never know true happiness again, not while the Other was still a part of him.

Then there was the true splendor that drew his eyes again and again. At the top of what appeared to be a very long, thin pedestal was a glowing, oval-shaped object of such beauty, it made his soul ache. It emitted a radiance not just of light, but of peace. It almost made him feel a sense of joy if he kept staring at it.

For no reason he could think of, it suddenly made him think of the Set'Heth-un'dar, the only source of light for his planet. The Set'Heth-un'dar was much, much larger than this beautiful object, and the light it emitted was cold and unpleasant. It seemed that the Set'Heth-un'dar was the exact opposite of the glowing oval object he gazed upon. The Other broke him out of his reverie.

"That pathetic thing is no match for the power and beauty of the Set'Heth-un'dar, don't you agree?" the Other asked. Their need for conversation had overcome their sulking, so they tried to start a conversation on a topic they felt they both agreed upon.

The Outcast most definitely did not agree, and thus did not respond.

"Ah, I sense that you do not. That makes sense, I will say no more. I wish not to upset you." The Other always started their road back to full-blown hostility with passive-aggressiveness.

"So, what is our plan? Are we going to sit here gazing at that ugly stone or complete our mission?" the Other continued.

"Yes. I'm going to sit here, wait for the cover of darkness, then move in." the Outcast said, tersely.

"Why?" the Other asked, exasperated. *"Just use my power to cloak yourself from sight. We have no need of night."*

"Because I will probably need to use 'Dark-Sight' to sneak along dark passages, and 'Stranger's Speech Known' to listen in on conversations and gain intel. I know that using too many of your powers at once taxes you, and thus weakens them all as a whole." The Outcast rolled his eyes at the Other's impatience.

"I see what you did there, that was a particularly good stab at me, My Prince*."* The Other chuckled.

"I did not mean— ugh, I'm not trying to start fighting with you again! What I said was true and you know it. Besides giving us the cover of darkness, nighttime is also most likely when the bearer of the She-Ra will be asleep. I want this to be a clean, quiet kill."

The Other did not like the idea of a clean quiet kill but did not comment on that and agreed to wait.

* * *

Adora and Catra were the embodiment of absolute happiness. They had begun their day together with a picnic breakfast on the beaches by the bay of Bright Moon. Glimmer made sure the kitchen packed their picnic basket full of all sorts of pastries, sweet and tart jams, fruit, and three varieties of juices. A delicious lunch was also packed for them, three different kinds of sandwiches and a salad, in case they wanted to stay wherever they ended up. They had spent their morning laughing, talking or in contented silence, enjoying the morning sun sparkling on the crystal-clear waters. They stayed this way until lunch, in no hurry.

CATRADORA

After lunch, they moved along the beach to a field of flowers on the sea-ward side of Bright Moon, slowly meandering and picking

the most beautiful ones for each other. Adora had eschewed her normal attire for a light sundress with a green, yellow and white floral pattern and flat white sandals on her feet. She had also let her hair down, free from any restrictions.

Catra was in a brown, wide-legged jumpsuit made of a light, flowy material. It was open at the top with two thin cloth straps and a cloth belt tied around the waist. Her mane of hair was pulled into a ponytail with her bangs down, and of course, she had no footwear on.

Adora had just put the flower that Catra found in her hair when reached to place one of her own in Catra's hair.

"NO!" Catra squealed, laughing and pushing Adora's hand away. "You are *not* putting that in my hair!"

Catra ran away giggling, Adora following in hot pursuit with the flower in her hand. Catra led her in the chase; she was easily able to outrun the other woman, but this was not her intention. After a short distance, Catra let Adora catch her, who playfully tackled her into the flowers. They rolled, laughing and giggling, until they came to rest entwined together. Adora was on top, flower in hand, which she held to Catra.

"I swear Adora, if you put that in my hair I'll yank it out and... and eat it!" Catra said in a high-pitched voice.

"Ewww Catra, flowers actually taste pretty gross. That's an empty threat!" Adora made a funny face, then burst into giggles.

Catra laughed. "Try me!"

Adora gently placed the flower in Catra's hair, then from there she caressed her hand down her ear and rested it on her cheek.

Adora gazed into Catra's eyes. "I love you so much, Catra."

Catra giggled. "I know, dummy. Just kiss me!"

Adora's eyes softened and she leaned in for a kiss, this field of flowers was the perfect place to…

"Hey guys, I've been looking all over –" a voice rang out, disturbing their peaceful reverie.

Bow.

Adora flopped down on her back as both women groaned audibly.

"Bow, how in the name of Bright Moon, Etheria and all the stars did you find us?" Adora growled.

Bow stood before them holding his data pad, a look of mortification on his face.

"Eeeeeeep!" was Bow's response.

"Speak up, Punchy," Catra said coolly. "I mean, after this morning's interruption, your fate is already sealed."

"My fate is sealed?" Bow gulped. "You mean during our next sparring session?"

Catra did not answer, she only lifted her arm, her hand cupped up and extended her claws, still looking at him coolly.

"Catra, stop teasing Bow," Adora soothed. "Bow, I'm sorry I was angry. You just caught us off guard. It must be something important for you to have tracked us down."

Bow suddenly looked very unsure of whether or not that was true, and hoped very much his friends decided it was worth interrupting their day.

"Glimmer said you were down by the beach, but I checked and couldn't find you. I did see Catra's distinct footprints and followed them along the beach and behind Bright Moon. I walked until I found your picnic baskets by this field, then spotted you in the distance."

“Oh boy, mystery solved,” Catra said dryly. “Now, the reason you chased us down?”

Bow held out his pad. “Entrapta has been driving me CRAZY. She keeps contacting me saying she needs to speak to Adora, so I figured—", Bow stopped, realizing he was going to repeat Adora’s words. “I figured it must be important?” His voice trailed off questioningly, still completely unsure of himself.

“Oh great, I should have known Entrapta was behind this. This keeps getting better.” Catra said, rolling her eyes.

Adora smiled at her friend. “Okay Bow, let’s have it. Bring her up.”

Bow pressed the commands to dial Entrapta and the data pad beeped when she picked up.

“Bow!?” Entrapta yelled through the pad, the usual signs of manic excitement obvious to everyone. “DID YOU FIND ADORA YET!?” She screeched at the top of her lungs.

“Yes, Entrapta, I did.” Bow was exasperated. “You owe me for this.”

“Okay, whatever, PUT ADORA ON!”

Adora took the data pad and gazed down at Entrapta’s face. “I’m here Entrapta. What’s up?”

“Hey, Adora!” Entrapta yelled, putting her face so close to her screen that all Adora could see were her violet eyes. “You know how I said I was going to keep working on the First One’s mystery? I found something! Well, Hordak and I, that is!”

In spite of herself, Catra suddenly looked interested, sitting up and looking into the screen.

“Oh hi, Catra! Ooooooh, nice outfit!” Entrapta commented, easily distracted.

Catra smiled thinly into the data pad's camera and waved dismissively while Entrapta continued talking

"I was telling Hordak all about our trip and everything that happened to us— the temple, the black crystal, you using the crystal, you being seized by the data-port, being knocked off, you becoming unconscious –"

"Entrapta!" Adora and Catra both yelled into the screen. "Please, Entrapta, get to the point." Adora asked tersely.

Entrapta snapped back into herself. "Right! So Hordak was really interested in the planet Twilight. We brought up some old star charts from Horde Prime's ship, trying to locate it and found some clues. What we found is why I contacted you."

Entrapta brought her screen over to the data port screen showing the star chart. For being a computer image, the old star chart was archaic and filled with First One's runes for labels.

"We found the planet Twilight here." Entrapta pointed to indicate where the planet Twilight was.

"Entrapta, I'm sorry, but that can't be it," Adora said kindly. "The planet you are showing is a moon to another planet if I'm reading these orbit lines correctly."

Adora squinted, looking at the label for the celestial body Entrapta was claiming was the planet Twilight, "According to the label for this moon it is called Dark Moon, not Twilight."

"Adora," Entrapta began, speaking like a parent to a small child. "My calculations are correct, **plus** I had Hordak check them. I am one hundred percent certain this—", she jabbed her finger at the data terminal screen, "— is the planet Twilight— or Dark Moon. What I need for you to do is read the label for the planet that Twilight used to orbit."

"Okay, okay, Entrapta, I believe you," Adora said placatingly. "Just give me a second."

Adora squinted, quickly realizing she had seen this symbol before.

“Oh, I know that one, that’s the rune for Eternia.” Adora proclaimed.

“Eternia is a planet!” Bow, who up until now was trying to keep a low profile, gasped.

Entrapta turned her head, trying to peer at Bow through the screen.

“Exactly! It was the planet the Twilight orbited once long ago. Maybe it was a First One’s planet or THE First One’s planet, their homeworld!” Entrapta yelled excitedly.

Adora, Catra and Bow looked at each other questioningly.

“So... where did it go?” Bow asked, positioning himself next to Adora. “Was it destroyed?”

“Nope,” Entrapta said matter-of-factly. “There is no evidence of debris from a planetary explosion of that size. My theory— and it’s a sound one— is that it was pulled into another place, perhaps another dimension!”

“Like Etheria...” Adora whispered.

“Exactly!” yelled Entrapta into the screen. “Anyway, thanks, Adora. That’s all I need for now. I will contact you again if I need anything else!”

“Entrapta, wait —”, Adora yelled into the screen, but it was too late.

“She hung up.” Bow said apologetically.

They stood silent for a moment, the bright sunlight of the day stifled by a strange creeping chill they all felt inside their bodies.

“What do you think it all means?” asked Bow.

Catra gently put her hand on Bow's shoulder and smiled threateningly. "What it means, Punchy, is that your mission is over. You delivered Entrapta's message and NOW—" she gently pushed him back. "It's time for you to GO." She emphasized.

Adora smiled at Bow. "Thanks, Bow, I'm sorry you were put in this position, but can you do me a favor?"

"Yes, anything." Bow replied.

"Please just turn that data pad off, at least just for the rest of today?" Adora pleaded.

Bow laughed, switching off the pad and turned to walk away. "I'll see you guys later, sorry about interrupting you again. Have a great day!"

Adora smiled and waved while Catra only curled her lip, exposing a small fang.

Adora turned to Catra, pushing her down in the flowers with a smile. "So, where were we?" She said, eyes softening.

* * *

It was evening in Bright Moon. The Outcast stood at the bottom of a cliff, the footholds obvious to his trained eye. At the top of the cliff, there was a tower, one he sensed the She-Ra energy spore emanating from.

"This is it!" The Other stated excitedly. *"Are you ready? Are you prepared?"*

The Outcast thought on this. Climbing the cliff and the wall was no challenge, for he was an able climber. It was what he found at his destination that he needed to be prepared for. Hopefully, the bearer of the She-Ra was asleep and the kill would be simple. If not, then he would need to fight.

In his mind, he ran through his inventory of weapons. *I have my assassin's short sword as my main weapon, duel evisceration knives that can be thrown, blood discs, punch claws, strangle barbs, razor powder, heart thorn, and sleep needles plus a blow tube.*

"Yessss, with all your training plus my powers she will be no match!" the Other hissed in glee.

"Yeah..." the Outcast said sadly. "Let's get going."

The Outcast spoke the phrases for "Dark Vision" and "Stranger's Speech Known" and began scaling the cliff.

* * *

* IN EACH OTHER'S ARMS *

Adora and Catra lay back in their bed in Bright Moon. Adora was on her back while Catra snuggled against her side, sleeping gently with a soft purr. Adora was still awake, gazing out the window at one of Etheria's moons, absentmindedly stroking Catra's hair.

They had spent a fantastic day together. After Bow and Entrapta's interruption, they had gone down to Enchanted Grotto, now owned by Double-Trouble, and caught an early show. They had watched a silly but highly enjoyable comedy, and Catra and Adora laughed until tears came to their eyes.

Dinner was served for the patrons of the show, a variety of food harvested from the sea; fish, shellfish, clams, mussels with kelp and seaweed for greens. Double-Trouble had enchanted the top chef away from Mermista's kingdom of Salineas to work for them at the Enchanted Grotto. Mermista was not pleased about this and refused to ever set foot in the Enchanted Grotto again. Suffice to say, the food was delicious and the atmosphere Double-Trouble created was fabulous. Double-Trouble themselves showed up to their table to complement their appearance, gossip, tell jokes and generally just be a scoundrel.



At the end of their busy day, the two lay together, completely at peace in their closeness.

Catra shifted in her sleep, mumbling something and Adora felt her legs and feet twitch.

Adora smiled at this. *Is she dreaming of running?* she thought to herself while stifling a chuckle.

Adora thought of how lucky she was to have Catra, here, now, like this. Just how many times had they been drawn together, just to be forcefully pulled apart? Pulled apart by their circumstances, by Shadow Weaver's manipulations, by being on opposite sides of a war, and by Catra's hurt and damage. How many times had Adora come to losing her? That time on Horde Prime's ship, watching Catra hurt her while trying to hurt herself, under Prime's control. Catra falling off the ledge to what was supposed to be her death, only to be saved at the last moment by She-Ra's powers. Going through Catra's anger and confusion resulting from her life being saved, saved by her supposed enemies. Catra did not know what to do with the emotions roiling inside her; guilt mixed with feelings of gratefulness and hope. It took an extremely difficult move on Adora's part to draw that line in the sand, telling Catra she was free to leave and never see Adora again, for Catra to see the light and reach out. There were other instances that their love could have been lost forever, and Adora remembered them all.

Adora was filled with such overwhelming love and tenderness for Catra. She gently put her arms around her, pulling her on top of her. Catra shifted and whined like when they were little, but went limp and allowed Adora to move her. Adora then drew the covers up to the top of Catra's head, wrapping her arms around her body tightly, as if her arms and the covers could protect Catra from all the hurts in the universe. Adora put her mouth near Catra's ear, so close it flickered from her soft breath.

"I love you so *much,* Catra. You are so precious to me." Adora whispered tenderly. "You are my very *heart*."

Catra shifted and mumbled, “Mmmm, huh? Mmmm, art? No, I didn’t, Adora... mmmmm”

Adora smiled, tears filling her eyes, then rested her face in Catra’s hair. Catra began purring louder now and Adora focused on the deep rhythm radiating into her chest. The beautiful white noise slowly drew her deeper and deeper into sleep.

* * *

The Outcast sat outside the open window peering in. His target was inside and she appeared to be asleep. With his Dark-Vision, he could make out her sleeping form on the bed and was startled by what he saw. He could see her head, and below that, the shape of her form under the covers. She was massive, her chest bulging up and extending far from her face.

She is big, he thought to himself. *I guess that makes sense since she is a powerful warrior.*

“She is also asleep, so what are you waiting for? ***DO IT!****”* The Other’s blood lust was up, and they were impatient. He felt the Other’s intense need for killing. It made him sick.

Pulling out the blow tube, he placed the sleep needle in the end and inspected the sleeping form. There— her foot was exposed at the bottom. A perfect place for the needle, since shooting the needle blindly into the covers was a gambit.

Putting the tube to his lips he aimed and blew firmly, the needle flying straight into the target’s foot.

He watched the foot twitch, then, strangely, her chest seemed to twitch as well, then tense and then go still.

Strange... he thought to himself.

The Outcast unsheathed his short sword, the absolute blackness of its blade reflecting nothing, and moved silently into the room.

* * *

Catra woke up, alert and on edge. She felt that something was wrong with Adora, but before she could call out her name, she sensed the danger she was in.

Catra lay absolutely still and listened, straining her ears, hearing an intruder enter the room quietly. The sound of a sharp weapon being unsheathed was unmistakable, and Catra prepared herself for a fight.

Someone just made a huge mistake, she thought, fury slowly boiling to the surface.

* * *

The Outcast slowly approached the bed and raised his weapon over his head, aiming for the target's neck.

Quick and painless, he thought.

Before he could bring the sword down, the covers exploded in a mass of hissing teeth and tearing claws, knocking him back. He stumbled onto his rear, then stood up and backed away. On the bed was a creature on all fours, growling, tail twitching in irritation.

"You fool! It's a trap! The She-Ra had some vicious pet waiting for you!" The Other screamed into his head.

The "pet" slowly rose on two legs and the Outcast saw that it was humanoid in form, obviously female from its outline. He could also tell she was just wearing undergarments, although even through Dark-Vision, he could discern no details. *Not a pet, a lover then,* He thought.

"Quickly, you fool, kill it before others are alerted!" The Other was apoplectic in its panic.

"Grant me Sight Unseen," the Outcast spoke, and he became invisible.

* * *

Catra stood and watched as the intruder backed away from her. She saw they were dressed all in black garb, a wickedly curved black blade in their hand. She emitted a low, threatening growl. *She was going to make them pay.*

Suddenly, the intruder spoke, it seemed as if they were hissing at her as well.

That's my thing! Catra thought to herself.

Catra watched as they became invisible, and she hissed in displeasure.

Oh no, you don't, she thought smugly.

Taking deep breaths, she inhaled the scents in the air. *There it was*, the strange muskiness of the intruder— alien and strange, but not unpleasant.

Catra's ears twitched and strained, searching for sound. She heard something; the soft rustling of the intruder's outfit, the armor shifting, the creaking of leather boots.

Catra closed her eyes and focused on all these senses, combining them and letting them complement each other. She then opened her eyes. Focusing, she could see them now, a humanoid shape in a hazy outline.

She smirked. *Got you,* she thought.

* * *

The Outcast slowly walked around the female, trying to be as quiet as possible while getting behind her to deliver the killing blow.

He saw her head tracking his movement. *How did she see him? That's impossible!* He thought.

"I can see you, idiot." the female said.

He lunged at her, stabbing toward her stomach with his sword. The sword was deftly knocked out of his hands and he was kicked backwards. She lunged at him, all vicious claws and hissing fury. He was barely able to block her slashing claws with his armored gauntlets. Sparks were flying.

The female leaped over the Outcast in a somersault, delivering a kick to the back of his head. She then slashed his back as he stumbled forward.

"YAAAAGHHHHH!!" he screamed, incredulous at her speed and agility, the pain of his cuts burning in agony.

She laughed. "You like that? There's more coming."

He reached behind his chest plate and spun around, flinging three blood discs at her. She hissed again, batting them out of the air.

What can I use against this foe? he thought. *Heart thorn? No. Strangle barbs? No. Punch claws?*

"Not Punch Claws you fool! She has claws and she's way better at using them than you!" the Other screamed. *"This foe is too great for you! It is time. RELEASE ME!"*

Not a chance, he thought. However, he reluctantly agreed that he was outmatched and needed to make an escape. He looked for something to throw at her. Looking down, he saw a glass of water sitting on the table next to the bed.

The Outcast picked up the glass and flung it at his enemy. She attempted to grab it with her claws and emitted a high-pitched shriek as the water spilled all over her face. She put both hands to her face, desperate to wipe it off.

Finally, a weakness, he thought as he lunged past her toward the window. He crouched on the ledge and looked down realizing he would not survive this jump.

Oh well. Back to the corpse-pools and to the Shen'Aan-war's wrath, he thought.

Before he could leap to his death, a hand grabbed him by the ankle and yanked him back in, slamming his head on the windowsill.

"Oh no you don't," she growled.

After pulling him in, she slammed him down on his back, wrapping one clawed hand around his neck. She picked him up and forcefully pushed him into the wall.

She leaned into his face, forming a clenched fist with her other hand.

"Don't mess with my grrrl," she snarled, ending the last part in a low growl.

She slammed her fist into the Outcast's face, and he knew no more.


I love you so much
Mmmm... Hm?
fwip
?
!
!


Disappear
~BREATHE~
I can see you, idiot.
!
Dodge

Chapter End Notes

Illustration of Entrapta and Hordak by @Yoritomito.

Illustration of Catra, Adora and Double Trouble by @Ansdrela.

Mini-comic by @emileedoodles.

Bad Dreams and Good Memories

Chapter Summary

More bad dreams for Adora.

The Outcast wakes from his fight with Catra with a bad headache, Glimmer has questions for him.

The Outcast relives a fond memory.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora is running through a forest of lights and whispers. It is night and she is in the Whispering Woods. She is momentarily confused as to why she is fleeing when she suddenly feels it; a malicious and cunning presence is chasing her, seeking her. She cannot see it, but she somehow knows they are above her, using the trees to chase her.

As Adora runs, she holds out her hand to summon her sword and then She-Ra.

"For the honor of Grayskull!" she yells.

Nothing happens.

Keep calm, you're not helpless without She-Ra, Adora, she thinks to herself. *I recognize where I am, I'm close to the edge of the forest, once I'm clear whoever is chasing can no longer use the*

trees. We will be on equal footing. The way to Bright Moon will be on the other side.

As she runs, she feels light above, shining down on her; it is the moon.

Wait, that's no moon, she thinks, suddenly.

She sees it now for what it is— a malicious and hateful orb radiating cold, oppressive light down through the branches. It seems to be watching her, thriving on her fear and panic.

Suddenly, it seems as if all the lights and life of the trees are seeping into the ground, leaving only dark dead husks behind. The Whispering Woods she knows and loves suddenly become dark, deadly and sinister. She can hear unfamiliar creatures hooting, crying and howling in the distance. There are hungry eyes shining between the trees.

She hears it then, a voice calling to her from the darkness. It is a man's voice, deep, ancient and cold.

"She-Ra," he calls, then again with a chuckle. "Sheeeeeee-Ra!"

"You betrayed me..." he says, anger bright. "Join meeeeeeeee, Sheeeeee-Ra!"

Loud laughter radiates through the trees, mocking and cruel.

Adora keeps running, the laughter giving her an extra burst of speed. She sees it, the clearing ahead.

Almost there! she thinks.

Adora breaks through the clearing but is instantly brought up short; what she sees making her suddenly weep.

Bright Moon. Bright Moon; in ruins.

The previously white shining castle is smoldering and shattered, the towers crumbled and ruined. There are no lights, fires or signs of life, just darkness. Most tragically of all, the pedestal the Moonstone occupies is shewn in half, the upper part laying in pieces on the ground. Next to it, the Moonstone lies broken into shards.

"NO!" she cries.

Between her and Bright Moon, there is evidence of a great battle. Bodies are strewn about, nothing lives. Tears are streaming down Adora's face as she starts to run through the corpses. Adora casts about, desperately hoping not to find a friend or loved one. Her path leads her to a large pile of lifeless bodies. What she sees at the bottom brings her to her knees.

At the bottom of the pile of bodies are Glimmer, Bow, Entrapta. The Princesses, all her friends; dead.

Her eyes suddenly focus on one lifeless corpse and she howls, crawling to reach it.

"CATRAAAAA! NOOOOO!" she screams, as she reaches the body, lifting and cradling it, stroking her lover's cheek. Her tears rain down on Catra's face, whose eyes are open and expressionless.

One of her worst fears had come true— they had finally run out of chances. Cruel fate caught up with them and her dear soulmate is gone forever. The opening chasm in her heart and soul is so deep and black, that she suddenly feels something that she never felt before; she is losing her mind.

She hears cruel laughter above her, and she looks up.

At the top of the pile is a throne, with a large figure perched atop it. The figure is hooded, its face in shadow, long gray hair flowing down on either side of the cowl. On top of the figure's head and over the hood sits an ugly, wicked crown, all sharp blades and edges. The figure wears dark gray armor encompassing their shoulders, extending down each arm in segmented plates, ending

in sharp clawed gauntlets that rested on each armrest. Under the shoulder armor the figure wears a sleeveless robe, hiding the rest of the figure's form.

Framing the figure perfectly from behind the enthroned figure, is the dread orb, shining its hateful light as if in triumph.

The figure rose from its throne, and she sees the handle of a sword behind its shoulder; it is massive, for she sees the tip of the blade on his opposite side. The figure slowly, purposely, descends the pile down toward Adora, as if descending a staircase.


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“It didn’t have to be this way, She-Ra.” The figure says, the same man’s voice she heard before, then, almost kindly, “It DOESN’T have to be this way.”

As the man got closer, he holds out an armored hand, open in offering.

“You can join me, you know, and all this senseless death won’t happen,” he says.

Adora looks down from the figure to the body in her arms, Catra. Catra; so bright, beautiful and full of life, hers. Catra; who is so fierce, wild, never to be tamed, who would never let anyone bully her. Adora’s face darkens, deciding her choice.

“No” she says flatly.

The figure snarls, the upturned hand turning to grasp her, clawed fingers open.

The figure raises its hood and what she sees makes her scream.

Under the hood is a white, fleshless skull, black sockets leering hatefully down at her…

* * *

“NOOOOOO!!!!!!” Adora screamed, sitting up in bed, glistening in sweat.

Two hands suddenly rested on her shoulders, a familiar face with heterochromatic eyes peering at her.

“Adora! It’s alright! You were dreaming!”

“Catra!” Adora cried, relief in her voice. She was so overjoyed, she wrapped her arms around Catra’s shoulders, burying her face into her neck and began weeping uncontrollably.

Catra's eyes widen in shock and she slowly wrapped her arms around Adora, pulling her in tight.

"Shhhh, Adora, it's okay, I'm here." She said, then repeated herself with a small laugh, "I'm here, it's alright. Shhhhh." She began rocking Adora in her arms.

"Oh, Catra, it was horrible! The most horrible dream!" Adora was still weeping, the pain in her voice raw.

"It's okay, it's over." Catra said, still rocking Adora. "Was it the water dream again?" She tentatively asked.

"No, worse, much worse." Adora answered, then recounted her dark dream in detail to Catra.

When Adora was finished, they both sat in silence for a moment as Catra continued to rock her. Then Catra stopped, grasped Adora by the shoulders and pulled her up so she could look in her eyes.

"It's okay, I'm here, I'm alive! Nothing happened to me, and I can assure you, everyone else is fine too." Catra said, imploringly.

"I know, Catra, I know." Adora was slowly regaining her composure. She took in the other woman fully now, seeing that she was dressed in her usual outfit— red sleeveless leotard, dark collar, burgundy and black leggings.

"What's going on, Catra? Why are you dressed?" she said, then looked around, seeing the light outside. "Is it afternoon already?"

"Adora, you won't believe what happened last night." Catra said.

Catra went into full detail about how she woke up, sensing something was wrong with Adora, and the danger they were in. Then, she told Adora of the intruder and the fight that ensued, the intruder trying to escape and Catra's capture of them.

“The guards burst through the door and saw me in my underwear!” Catra said with a hint of glee. “I had to explain to them that it wasn’t some game, but that we were actually attacked.”

Adora found herself chuckling at Catra’s tale, the imagery that came to her mind was hilarious.

“They dragged the assassin away... I think to the new quarters they built for the Trial.” Catra continued. “Micah, Castaspella, Bow and Glimmer were all here, the guards woke them up in the night. Castaspella found a dart or needle in your foot, it must have had some sleep poison on it.” Catra explained.

Adora looked down at both of her feet, seeing nothing.

“I wonder why they just wanted me asleep?” Adora wondered.

“Well with me under the covers, I don’t think they knew I was there. Boy, did *they* get a surprise!” she smirked. “After they found the dart, Micah and Castaspella did their ‘magic thing’ on you and said you were just asleep, and it should wear off eventually. I’ve been sitting here patiently ever since.” Catra smiled lovingly at Adora.

Adora’s eyes softened. “Thank you,” she said gratefully. “So, what happens now? What are they planning to do with the prisoner?” Adora asked.

“They’re going to interrogate him soon. It was some young guy, our age, I think. Weird looking too. Anyway, I'm glad you woke up because I wanted to be there.” Catra said.

“Wait, I’m coming too!” Adora exclaimed.

“No, no, no, no! You just woke up, and after what happened to you last night, plus that dream, there is no WAY you’re facing someone who tried to kill you, not right now at least.” Catra said firmly.

"Catra, you're my girlfriend, not my nursemaid." Adora retorted, starting to get up.

Catra pushed her back down. "No, don't make me kick your butt—you know I can too," she said with a kind grin.

Adora wouldn't relent, so Catra then tried a different tactic. "Please, Adora, for me? I was up all last night worrying about you. Just stay here and relax, please? Promise me?" Catra pleaded.

The rare pleading tone in Catra's voice did the trick.

"Okay, fine," Adora said, crossing her arms like a petulant child.

* * *

The Outcast suddenly awoke, a searing pain in his head. He rubbed his temples, moaning.

"That was SOME night we had, eh, my Prince?" the Other said, amusement evident in their voice.

"What…what happened?" he asked, sitting up and holding his head. He could tell by the limited vision in his right eye that it was swollen. He also noticed that his shirt, hood, boots and all his weapons were gone; he only had his black baggy pants on.

"Let's see, you lost the element of surprise and fell into a trap, you were attacked by some kind of lover-pet, and with all your training, weapons and abilities you STILL managed to get yourself beat up and captured. Oh, and this creature had NO weapons, did I mention that you had weapons? Like, a lot of weapons?" The Other drawled.

"She *had* weapons, her claws." He retorted.

"Oh yes, she gave you a pretty nasty scratch too. How's your back?" the Other asked, not really caring.

The Outcast's back was slightly itchy, and reaching behind, felt what seemed like bandages there.

"Fine, actually, just my eye is hurting, and my head, ohhhhh…my head." He moaned.

"You deserve it. The least you could have done was jump out that window and get us a trip back to the corpse-pools, but nooooo, you got captured." the Other said mockingly. They were starting back in on the taunts already.

The Outcast ignored the Other and took in his surroundings. He appeared to be in the center of some bedroom or dormitory, for there were many beds there, pushed back against the wall. It was a plush, luxurious room full of pillows and light, pastel colors and bright, but pleasant light.

He looked at his immediate surroundings and saw he was encased in some form of circular light field. When he placed his hand against it, his hand was forcibly repelled.

"Magic..." he stated, dumbly.

"Yes, yes, my Prince, good eye." the Other taunted. *"Wait! Quiet! I sense that someone is coming."*

The Other was correct as the door opened and a few figures entered. A short, pretty young woman entered first; she was dressed in purple and blue garments, a sparkly blue cape, and matching sparkly pink and purple hair. She walked in like she was royalty and seemed to be a leader of some sort.

Behind her walked in a young man; he about the same age as the woman, dark-skinned and very handsome, with a gold heart-shaped breastplate and something on his back— a weapon of some sort. His long hair was tied in a ponytail behind his head. He had what appeared to be the scruffy beginnings of a goatee.

Behind them came an older man and woman with dark hair, both in wearing robes. They took their place behind the young woman

and next to the young man. They looked like they could be related, perhaps they were siblings maybe?

A dark-skinned armored woman wearing a stern expression walked in. She had pointy ears, and her hand resting on a sword at her waist. She stayed in the back, by the door. Then another figure entered, and from the outline he remembered, he recognized her.

"*The lover-pet!*" the Other exclaimed.

The Outcast looked at her; seeing her without Dark-Vision, he saw that she was striking. She was wearing a skin-tight, sleeveless maroon and black outfit; he could see light tan fur with stripes on her arms. She was young as well, extraordinarily pretty and fierce looking. She had wild dark hair that began with short bangs and ran down behind her head, two brown "tufts" sticking down behind her large, dark, pointy ears. A dark tail swished back and forth behind her as she walked.

She moved to the front, ahead of the dark-skinned young man and next to the young woman with the pink and purple hair, folding her arms. Yellow and blue heterochromatic eyes gazed at him murderously.

Oh yeah, that was definitely her, the Outcast thought darkly.

The young woman with the pink and purple hair spoke to the young woman with the tail next to her. He could not understand what they were saying, the magic he used the other night was broken by the blow to his head. The other shook her head and responded. Then the young woman with the pink and purple hair began speaking to him.

"Grant me Stranger's Speech Known." The Outcast said, and then, in the Etherian's language, "Greetings, can you please repeat that last part?"

* * *

Glimmer stared at the figure imprisoned before her. To say his appearance was strange was an understatement.

He sat cross-legged, torso held up straight, hands on his knees. He was wearing only pants, the shirt, armor and boots removed for she was told there were many weapons hidden on him— ugly deadly weapons, some whose intended use was unknown. He was lean, taut muscles showing under the skin, and she could tell, even though he was sitting, he was about Adora's height.

He was a young man, about her age, with shoulder-length shaggy black hair framing an oval face. He was handsome, she realized, with fine features and a patrician look about him. He studied them with dark eyes; curious eyes, with a hint of sadness in them.

This was not what made him unusual to look upon though, it was when she looked down at his naked torso that she stifled a gasp.

Tattoos covered his entire exposed body, in the shape of runes, starting from the base of his neck and traveling down his entire body, including his bare feet. Glimmer recognized them as First One's runes, but they were strange, twisted, like the ones on the Twilight temple; they glowed with a faint ghostly light.

The runes were everywhere under his chin except for an oval-shaped spot on his chest where his heart should be. There in the center of his chest, was what made Glimmer cringe.

There was a long, hideous, vertical scar, like an incision. It looked like it was made cruelly, with no regard to the pain it must have inflicted. It was red and swollen, like it was still healing.

"Geez, Catra, was that you?" she asked, turning to the other woman.

Catra shook her head. "Nope, my claws make nicer cuts than that. I got him in the back really good, though." She chuckled lowly.

Glimmer then turned to the prisoner, and in her most firm and regal voice, began questioning him.

“Why have you come to my kingdom and assaulted two of my subjects? Two of my friends?”

The prisoner looked at her confused, then spoke a phrase in a strange, whispery language, using lots of S’s. He spoke again, clearly and with a slight accent.

“Greetings, can you please repeat that last part?” he asked.

“Why are you here? Why did you come to kill my friends?” Glimmer asked, dropping her tone.

The prisoner shrugged. “I was sent here to kill the bearer of the She-Ra,” he replied simply.

“So, you’re an assassin?” Micah stated angrily.

“Yes, I am an assassin. Although not a very good one, it seems,” the prisoner replied sorrowfully.

“I’ll say,” quipped Catra. “I beat you in my underwear and with no weapons, you’re the worst assassin!”

The prisoner looked over at Catra and smiled warmly. “Yes, you did beat me. You were amazing, you… stopped me...” He said the last part with a slight hint of relief in his voice.

Everyone looked at each other confused.

“Although, I would not say you were weaponless.” The prisoner continued. He held his hand up with his fingers curled, like claws, and moved his hand in a downward motion.

“Yeah, don’t make excuses,” Catra retorted. “I don’t need my claws, buddy. Give me another shot and I’ll beat you, no claws, and one hand tied –”

“CATRA!” Glimmer yelled at the other woman. “Enough.”

Glimmer turned back to the prisoner, “Don’t mind her, she’s kind of nuts.” Glimmer made a crazy face with one finger circling her ear, not seeing Catra scowling at her back.

“So back to where we were... you were sent to kill the bearer of the She-Ra. Why?” Glimmer asked.

“Because the Shen’Aan-war said it must be, so he sent me.” The prisoner responded.

“The shen-a-wenna-who?” Bow asked, confused.

“The Shen’Aan-war, my Lord.” the prisoner said simply.

“Okay, we got that, why though?” asked Glimmer.

“The Shen’Aan-war’s true reasons are his alone, I am only the instrument. He told me he wanted her out of the way for his plans.” The prisoner shrugged.

“And those are?” Chimed in Castaspella.

“To take over your realm, your universe, as it is.” The prisoner responded.

“Wow, the Shen’Aan-war sounds like he has some simple goals,” Bow retorted. “You seem pretty open with your answers, so why are you telling us all this?”

The prisoner shrugged again, miserably. “Because you asked? Also, because there is no hiding the truth as you can do nothing about it.”

“Yeah, we’ll see, buddy!” Catra yelled, ears down in anger. “We beat his assassin and we will beat anything else he sends back to us. I say we wrap this guy up in a ribbon and send him –”

“CATRA!” Glimmer yelled, holding her brow in frustration. She then turned and walked up to the magical barrier and squatted down in front of the prisoner.

“Let’s start over. I was very rude and did not introduce myself,” Glimmer said as she held her hand to her chest. “I’m Glimmer. The guy behind me is Bow. The angry lady you met last night is Catra. The two in the robes are my father and aunt, Micah and Castaspella. The stern lady in the back is General Juliet, she is head of my guard. What is your name?” She asked kindly.

The prisoner looked down. “I am called ‘The Outcast’ by my people. I go by other names as well; ‘Betrayer’ and ‘Fallen prince’ are my other titles.”

“Hmmm, I don’t really like those names, they don’t seem very nice. Don’t you have an actual name, not just a title?” Glimmer said with a smile.

The prisoner looked up and past Glimmer, a faraway look on his face. “My…name? My name was…is…Shen’Thran-zanmar’eth…”

“Wow, that is *quite* the name.” Glimmer said with a laugh. She then tried to pronounce it. “Shen-than-zansmar-eth”... wow, I’m not sure about saying that all the time, how about we just call you ‘Shen’?”

The prisoner frowned. “You want to call me ‘Shen’ instead of my whole name, a nickname then?”

“Yeah, sure, why not?” Glimmer said brightly, and then in mock sternness, “It’s better than ‘The Outcast’ or ‘Betrayer’.” She stated.

“If it is intended as a nickname or shortening of my name, then it is not correct. Everyone on my planet shares the first name ‘Shen’.” the prisoner said, shaking his head.

“Is it like a title or something? Like Mr. and Mrs.?” asked Bow.

“No, nothing like that. Shen simply means ‘Dark’ or ‘Of dark’.” The prisoner responded.

“Wow, really cheery people huh?” Castaspella said sarcastically.

The prisoner turned to her. “I come from a dark place and there is little light. When you live your life in such a place, the darkness surrounds you. There is no escape. You have two choices: fight against it and be consumed by your despair or embrace it and make it your own. My people have chosen to make the darkness their own. Every day, every birth, every life, every new love begins with darkness... and so does every name.”

Everyone went silent at this, absorbing the impact of the prisoner’s words.

“Well buddy, *you’re* pretty dark, so, the nickname suits you. We are going to call you ‘Shen’.” Catra said flatly.

The prisoner, now Shen, shrugged. “It matters not. I don’t care what you call me,” he said, defeated.

Glimmer focused on his torso now. “Does that hurt you?” she asked, pointing to his scar.

“This? No, worse things than this cut have been done to me. It is a small thing.” Shen replied, quietly.

“Who did this to you?” Glimmer continued, empathy in her voice.

Shen turned away and down. “The Shen’Aan-war. I betrayed him.” He became angry now, more withdrawn.

“How did you betray him? What was so bad for this to have happened to you?” Glimmer asked.

Shen pulled his legs together, wrapping his arms around them and putting his head down. “I have answered enough questions. No more, please leave me,” he said, pain in his voice.

“Please? Maybe…maybe we can help you? Maybe we can help each other?” Glimmer asked, kindness pouring from her.

Shen became angrier at her words. “LEAVE ME!!!!!” he screamed.

Glimmer turned to Catra. “You want me to…?” Catra asked, knocking one fist into her other open hand.

Glimmer only scowled at her and turned to face everyone. “I think that’s all we can get out of him today. Let’s let him rest for now, we’ll return tomorrow.”

As everyone left the room, Glimmer turned, holding the door, and looked at Shen. Even though he was for all intents and purposes her enemy, she could not help feeling immensely sorry for him. He was still holding his legs with his arms, and he had begun to rock now, his head pressed down on one side so she could see his face. Her heart ached as she saw tears starting to fall from his closed eyes; he looked like he was trying to keep all the pain in the universe from pouring out. She silently turned away and closed the door.

* * *

Shen continued to rock himself, eyes closed, not wanting to look at them as they left.

He remembered their faces all staring at him. They were beautiful, kind faces. Well, the one they called Catra’s face was beautiful, but he did not see kindness there. He did not blame her; based on how he met her, She-Ra must be her girlfriend. Her girlfriend that he was sent to kill. She must hate him for that, they all must hate him for coming to kill their greatest warrior, their friend.

He expected them to kill him for that and send him on his way... but they didn’t. Instead, they dressed his wounds and held him in this beautiful cell, unharmed. They had come with stern faces, but he did not see the hate he so well deserved… The one called Glimmer had even smiled at him, and was kind, all she did was ask him questions. When he didn’t want to speak anymore, they simply left. The undeserved kindness they had shown him made him angry and the hate he sought in their faces he found in himself.

Hate for the Other, whose presence inside him he could never escape, who constantly nagged and berated him, who constantly reminded him of the horrible things he was responsible for. There was hate for the Death-Binders, the ones who helped put the Other inside him, who was always there at the corpse-pool's edge after congealment, always ready to welcome him back when all he wanted was the sweet release of oblivion. Hate for the Set'Heth-un'dar, whose damned baleful stare rained upon his world, the power behind all this torment. Hate for the Shen'Aan-war, his father, who instead of showing kindness and love for his son, cast him down into damnation.

Finally, there was the greatest hate, the brightest. The hate he held for himself.

Hate for being so weak, for allowing himself to be caught and turned into a monster. A monster, who in turn, destroyed all he had loved on that black world. *Hate, hate, hate, hate.* He hated himself so much at that moment that he started to believe he totally deserved the damned state he existed in.

He felt it then, blackness and despair coming over him and slowly, and the binds holding the Other began to loosen.

"Yesss...my Prince…" the Other cooed.

"NO!" he gasped, and immediately clamped down on the hate. He started his old routine again, going through his few happy memories, the singing, round and round until he finished off with the final memory to hold the other in their prison.

Shen'Dara.

"Ahhhhhh… you tease me, my Prince, no fair! But I knew you would catch yourself in the end, it was too good *to be true!"* the Other whispered.

Shen continued with the memory of Shen'Dara, lingering on it, refusing to let it go, and he decided to stay for a while. He

lingered on a thread, the beginning, the sweet beginning when they first met.

"Yuck! Not this again, please stop!" the Other groaned.

Shen ignored the Other and smiled as the memory began.

* * *

It started when he just started to be allowed to leave the castle grounds by himself; up until then, he was only able to leave when he accompanied his father, the Shen'Aan-war, on excursions or the one and only hunting trip he was brought on.

He was riding in a royal carriage, pulled by four Sekth, on a day excursion with his love interest at the time. The carriage had four lights on each corner to help illuminate the ground around them. The Set'Heth-un'dar was at its highest, but its ghostly light was not entirely reliable for travel.

Hmmm... what was her name? he thought to himself. *Ah yes, Shen'Amorith*.

She was very beautiful and a lot of fun at parties. He realized that this day excursion was a mistake, for it made him realize that besides her company, they had nothing in common. There was no spark.

Oh, well, he thought at the time. *There are plenty of other potential suitors in the royal court.*

They were far outside the castle grounds now, the Set'Heth-un'dar high in the sky as they crossed the moors, the Ghoul Woods in the distance, when they were accosted.

A hooded figure on a Sekth had ridden upon them from their blind side, slashing the harness connecting the four Sekth to the carriage and driving them away. They must have been hiding in the moors until the carriage passed, then shadowed them until they were ready to strike.

Shen had leapt out of the carriage to face their attacker, sword in hand, finally able to use all the training gained from his father's best warriors.

The bandit had laughed at Shen holding his sword, a bright laugh filled with mirth. He jumped down to engage him, pulling out a sword of their own.

"You sure that's the way you want to hold that?" the bandit said. The voice was pleasant and melodious, a male's voice, Shen could tell.

"Perhaps after I take it away from you, I might teach you how to properly use it?" the bandit taunted.

This had made Shen angry, for this was when he still believed his father's concept of manliness still had merit and he was loath to look weak in front of Shen'Amorith.

He lunged at the bandit, beginning the moves his teachers had taught him to explore his opponent's weaknesses. The bandit deftly turned these aside, giving up nothing for Shen to use against him. Shen had then tried more complicated moves, transitioning between different styles, trying to be constantly on the offensive until it dawned on him— *he was being toyed with.*

The bandit turned the tables with a laugh, putting Shen on the defensive, driving him back until he was up against the carriage. The bandit then broke Shen's guard and quickly disarmed him, placing his own sword against Shen's neck.

"Do you yield?" the bandit said, playfully.

"Yes, damn you," Shen growled back.

"Good!" the bandit said, "For I would hate to have to slice off such a pretty head!"

Shen'Amorith quickly leapt from the carriage, running to Shen's side.

“Just take our valuables and go!” she had cried.

The bandit looked thoughtful. “I think I just might do that! Thank you for the suggestion, my lady.”

He bowed to her and as he raised from the bow he stopped suddenly, studying Shen. He removed his hood and mask and Shen was stunned by the face beneath, lit by the carriage lights.

He was the most beautiful person Shen had ever seen. He was of the Shen’Elvar people, that was most obvious. He had an oval face with fine features and pointed chin, framed by long, straight white hair, flowing down to his chest. Two long, pointed ears stuck out between strands of the hair, straight. His skin was a light blue and seemed to glow in the light. However, it was the eyes that really drew him; like all the Shen’Elvar, the sclera was a dark blue, but instead of the usual light blue irises, this bandit had bright gold ones.

The bandit caught him staring. “Like what you see? *My Prince*? For that’s who you are, right? You’re the mighty Shen’Aan-war’s son, our Prince.” He drawled.

Shen said nothing. The bandit was sure of himself, and there was no point denying it.

“You’re not just a bandit, are you?” asked Shen’Amorith. “You’re part of the rebels. Not just any rebel either, you’re Shen’Dara, ‘The Rake’!”

The bandit, Shen’Dara, mockingly gasped at her. “Oh no! You found me out! And me removing my mask and all, how silly of me! Oh, and that whole ‘The Rake’ thing? Totally unfair.”

“So, what now? Are you going to kill me?” asked Shen.

“Why would I do such a thing when I could take all of your valuables *and* take you as ransom!” replied Shen’Dara.

“What about me?” asked Shen’Amorith.

“My lady, you have this cozy carriage to stay in. I’m sure someone will notice you’re missing and come looking for you,” Shen’Dara chuckled.

With that, Shen’Dara began to ransack their carriage for valuables, putting the most valuable ones into a pouch he latched to his side. He left any food and drink for Shen’Amorith.

When he was finished, he bowed to the lady and leapt upon the Sekth, turning to Shen and holding out a hand.

“Come, come, my Prince.” He said sternly.

Shen took his hand and was lifted behind Shen’Dara. He wasn’t sure if he was supposed to put his hands around him or not.

“Come on, don’t be shy!” Shen’Dara teased. “You’re going to need to hold onto me, for Shen’Jojin here is mighty fast. Oh, and don’t try anything like trying to push me off or something equally silly like grabbing my sword.”

Shen was so embarrassed he stayed silent, only putting his arms around Shen’Dara as the other prodded the Sekth into a trot.

Behind them, they heard the bellows of horns. The Shen’Aan-war’s guards had been watching the carriage the whole time from afar and were on their way.

Shen realized he could push himself off the back of the Sekth; he might sustain minor injuries, but he was sure Shen’Dara would have no time to turn around for him and escape the pursuers at the same time. Just as he thought of this, he suddenly realized that was the last thing he could possibly want at this moment and held onto Shen’Dara.

“You’re going to have to hold on tighter than that!” Shen’Dara proclaimed as he spurned the Sekth to gallop faster.

Shen had never gone this fast on a Sekth before. He had always been told that once you go beyond a certain point with the

beasts, they were completely out of your control. Shen'Dara seemed to know this but trusted his mount— Shen'Jojin he had called it.

They were going so breathtakingly fast now that Shen felt a giddiness come over him and he started laughing. He could not stop the laughter for it was as out of control as the galloping Sekth... Shen'Dara started laughing with him, his white hair flowing behind him and tickling his nose. It had a pleasant muskiness to it, spicy and seductive, and he had to stop himself from burying his face into it.

They had quickly approached the Ghoul's Woods edge and entered it without stopping.

"I was always told these woods were haunted," Shen whispered in the other's ear.

"Pah! Nonsense! The only thing haunting these woods are rebels!" Shen'Dara responded.

They followed a path that only Shen'Jojin seemed to know, twisting and turning through the dark trees until they came to a rock face and then a cave. Shen'Dara now in control of the Sekth, pulled it to a halt.

"Here we are, home sweet home. This is one of our hideouts." Shen'Dara said.

They both dismounted the Sekth and approached the cave entrance, Shen'Dara leading the way.

"So, it is true— you are part of the rebels." Shen had asked.

"Oh, most certainly." was Shen'Dara's reply.

"I was told the rebels were murderers, killers and malcontents who only wanted to bring down the Shen'Aan-war's rule and create chaos." Shen had stated at the time.

Shen'Dara turned and glared at him then, pulling out his sword. "Oh, it's all true," he snarled, cold fury in his voice now, walking toward him menacingly.

Shen backed away. *Idiot!* he thought. *You were seduced into the woods by this rogue who is now going to kill you for sport, great plan!*

Suddenly Shen'Dara broke out in laughter, "Oh, how rich! Your face!"

Shen, who unknowingly had both fists clenched in preparation for a hopeless fight, began to relax, but he was still wary of this rogue. *Is he crazy?* Shen thought.

Shen'Dara approached him and put his hands on Shen's shoulders, squeezing gently, and looked into his eyes with those golden ones. Shen felt like he could almost fall straight into them.

"You know, *My Prince*," he teased, "you really need to lighten up! Open up your heart, smile! We live on a dark world, but it doesn't mean we have to live dark lives!"

* * *

Shen sat in his cell, holding the fond memory in his mind, Shen'Dara's words still echoing in his mind. Shen'Dara had let him go not too long after that, without any ransom paid, but not before making a rebel out of him and stealing his heart. Shen smiled; his hate and anger had vanished.

Shen continued to sit there, reminiscing... and then he started to sing.

[* THE MOMENT ANGER AND SHAME ARE DEFEATED *]

Chapter End Notes

Illustration by @Miledibuja

Late Night Revelations

Chapter Summary

Hordak and Entrapta make more discoveries.

Adora and Shen meet.

The Other has its day.

Entrapta and Hordak sat side by side at their own data terminals in the main laboratory of their home; the Crypto Castle. They usually spent much of their time together in that fashion, either working on their own individual projects, or teaming up to tackle a big challenge together. Both were contented introverts, lost in their individual trains of thought but they found comfort in being close together, for even the biggest introvert never truly wants to be alone. Emily was in the back, powered down for a recharge cycle, beeping softly as if dreaming.

It was late at night and Entrapta was slurping up her favorite purple fizzy drink through a straw while Hordak sipped one his favorite bitter teas. There was a platter of tiny snacks between them— various cupcakes and cookies— and they would absentmindedly take one here and there, not looking away from their terminal screens. This was one of those instances when they combined their intellect to work on a single project together; they continued to hunt down any scrap of information on the planet Eternia.

This was a truly monumental task; to search for one First One's symbol in a thousand years' worth of data was no small task. Entrapta had written an algorithm to help narrow down the

search, but it was still slow work. They decided to divide the task between them. Hordak would work backward through the first five hundred years while Entrapta would work forward through the last five hundred.

They were coming to the ends of their individual searches when Hordak spoke up.

"My love, I've found something," Hordak said.

Entrapta, who until then had been completely focused on her work, turned as if waking from a trance.

"Hmm....what?" Entrapta replied, her ponytails raising like ears perking up.

"I am near the end of my search and I might have found something— a video recording, from…a thousand years ago," Hordak said, whispering the last part in wonder at the length of time he was referring to.

Entrapta fully snapped back into herself at Hordak's words.

"Well, bring it up! What is it?" Entrapta asked.

"I believe it is the view of an external camera on one of the ships within Horde Prime's fleet. I remember they had those. He liked to record his greatest moments in battle to view later at his pleasure." Hordak explained.

He brought up an image. Other ships were surrounding the camera's point of view. They were part of a large fleet— Horde Prime's fleet. They were slowly approaching a planet, with two moons.

"Is that Eternia?" Entrapta asked.

"I believe so. This video recording was labeled with the rune for Eternia." Hordak replied.

They continued to watch the recording. The fleet was slowly approaching the planet, taking their time, savoring their inevitable victory.

As the fleet neared land, they were able to get a closer look at the planet. From what they could see, its landscape was a mixture of all kinds of topographies; lush forests, mountainous terrain, deserts and other more fantastic landscapes. It reminded them of the space views of Etheria they had been able to start taking, now that they explored beyond the realms of their planet.

Around this planet— Eternia, they were certain— they focused on the two moons, almost on opposite sides of the planet. One appeared on the dark side while the other was on the light side. They were just barely in sight of each other with what appeared to be a beam of bright light connecting them, like concentrated sunlight. The beam seemed to be generated on the light moon and was being shared with the dark moon.

At the spot where the beam of light connected with the dark moon, there was a sudden explosion of darkness. The darkness seeped up the beam of light, consuming it, faster and faster. It was blacker than black, blacker than space. It traveled toward the light moon until it hit, the spot of its impact imploding. The surface of the bright moon cracked, broke apart, and seemed to be drawn into the point of the dark beam.

As the edges of the bright moon collapsed inward, a dread light was revealed on the edges in the exact shape of the original bright moon. The rocks and debris were slowly sucked into the middle until nothing was left but a hideous, dead orb. Suddenly, the dark beam disappeared, and the orb pulsed with light, as if a dark god was born and it was crying out in exaltation. The orb then grew in size, faster and faster until it was bigger than the planet Eternia. Eternia was drawn into it, slowly at first, then increasing in speed, until it was engulfed by the orb. The dread orb then rapidly shrunk to a small point, which exploded in a cloud of darkness.

Entrapta and Hordak stared at this image a while, completely dumbfounded at what they just witnessed.

"What *was* that, Hordak? That did not look like the portal technology the First One's typically used." Entrapta stated, looking at the other, her eyes wide.

"I don't think it was, I believe that…that was magic, Entrapta! It looked like a kind of…dark magic." Hordak said in disbelief. They stared at each other for a while, uneasy at what they just witnessed and its implications.

Their silence was broken by a voice behind them.

"My brothers! I have more midnight nourishment!"

"AAAACCKKK!!!" Both Hordak and Entrapta shrieked, jumping at the intrusion.

They turned, seeing Wrong Hordak standing there in an apron, holding a tray. On the tray was, of course, tiny snacks.

"My brother," Hordak began, trying to stay calm, "I appreciate your efforts, but please knock?" Hordak entreated.

"Yes. I apologize, my brother, I'm working on it. Until then, here is your nourishment!" Wrong Hordak said, placing the tray down between them. Then he turned on his heel and quickly exited, off to bake more goodies. Wrong Hordak's cooking experience with Glimmer aboard Darla had awakened the inner chef in him, and he had taken over the kitchen upon arriving at the Crypto Castle.

"Hmmmm…" Hordak said. "We need to figure out what our next step is. What do we do with this information?"

"I don't know, Hordak. Magic is outside of my realm of knowledge. Hmmm…We can always ask someone in Mysticor. There is the Queen's advisor, Micah— he is a powerful sorcerer." Entrapta said, thoughtfully.

“Yes…yes, good idea. That can wait until morning, my love. Until then, we need our rest. My old clone body can only take so much.” Hordak said, standing up with his hand outstretched.

Entrapta beamed as she rose, using her ponytails to lift her body into Hordak’s arms. She raised her own arms and ponytails in a yawn, then gently settled back with a sigh. This had become their nightly routine.

“Oh, Hordak…” Entrapta said, sleepily.

Hordak made his way to their bed, carrying Entrapta in his arms, who had fallen fast asleep.

* * *

* A PURSUIT IN A DARK FOREST *

Adora is running, running through a forest of lights and whispers. It is night and she is in the Whispering Woods. She is momentarily confused as to why she flees when she suddenly felt it— a malicious and cunning presence, chasing her, seeking her. She cannot see the other, but she somehow knows they were above her in the trees, chasing her.

As Adora runs, she holds out her hand to summon her sword and then She-Ra.

“For the honor of Grayskull!” she yells.

Nothing happens.

Keep calm, you’re not helpless without She-Ra, Adora, she thinks to herself. *I recognize where I am, I’m close to the edge of the forest, once I’m clear whoever is chasing can no longer use the trees. We will be on equal footing. The way to Bright Moon will be on the other side.*

As she runs, she feels light above, shining down on her; it is the moon.

Wait, that's no moon, she thinks, and then suddenly, *Wait… I've done this before, I'm dreaming.* Suddenly the rest of the memory, the dream comes to her. She knows how this ended and does not want to go through that horror again.

Might as well let whoever is chasing me find me, maybe I will just wake up then, she muses.

She hears it then, a soft rustling in the trees above her.

"Might as well come out and get this over!" she yells, turning around slowly. As she says this, a cloud covers the dread orb in the sky and she is given respite from its horrible light.

She hears someone light of foot land in the soft mossy grass that covered the ground in the Whispering Woods.

She quickly whips around, coming comes up short.

"Catra!" she yells in relief.

Catra smiles back at her and begins to walk forward towards her, arms open wide. Adora laughs and runs to meet her, so happy that this dream will not end as the last one did.

She is wrong, its worse.

Just before Adora reaches Catra, the cloud moves away from the dread orb and Catra is bathed in its light.

Catra's face suddenly changes, her beautiful eyes becoming bright red, her face bigger and sharper. Catra opens her mouth, now filled with razor sharp teeth and lunges at Adora. She clamps down on her neck, tearing, rending, eating.

"NOOOOOoooarrgggggggggaackk." Adora's strangled cry runs through the peaceful forest.

* * *

Adora woke from her nightmare, still screaming. She felt arms around her, a body pressed against her back. The arms tried to hold her tightly but Adora struggled against them. The arms let go and Adora spun around.

It was Catra.

Adora screamed louder and pushed her away, falling off the bed. She was still trying to back away when he saw the raw hurt in Catra's eyes. *Her* Catra. She stopped backing away and began to sob loudly.

The hurt Adora saw was immediately replaced by concern as Catra bounded off the bed, putting her hands on Adora's shoulders and looking in her eyes.

"It's okay Adora! It's okay, it me! Calm down. You were having another nightmare!" Catra consoled.

Tears shone in Adora's eyes as she hugged Catra, holding her tight. She let her tears fall, soaking into the fur on Catra's shoulder. Catra returned the embrace; Adora could feel Catra's claws gently pressing into her back.

"Tell me, Adora, what happened? Was it the same one as last night?" Catra asked, gently pushing Adora back so she could look into her eyes.

"It started off that way, but then I kind of snapped out of it and realized it was a dream." Adora started.

She went into complete detail of facing her pursuer, how it was Catra at first, then turning into a monster to rip Adora's throat out.

"I'm so sorry, Adora... wonder you reacted the way you did." Catra said. "You know that I would never—"

"Catra, you don't have to say it, I know." Adora said, caressing Catra's cheek.

Adora got up and started to get dressed, putting on her gray pants and white long sleeve undershirt.

"Adora, where are you going? It's still in the middle of the night?" Catra said as Adora put on her boots.

"I'm not going to be able to go back to bed, Catra, I am just going for a walk, to think." She said, putting her hair in her distinctive high ponytail.

"I'm coming with you—" Catra started.

"No, Catra, its okay. I've messed with your sleep enough, waking you up now, plus you stayed up all the other night. You need your rest." Adora said as she tried to push Catra toward the bed.

"No, it's okay –"

"Catra these dreams are really starting to worry me, don't make me start worrying about you too. Just stay here and relax, please promise me." Adora said, almost using the same exact line as Catra this morning.

"Okay, fine." Catra said, sitting down on the bed in a huff.

* * *

Adora made her way through the corridors of Bright Moon, though going for a walk was not her intention. She was heading toward the extension for the Trial, where Catra mentioned the prisoner was being kept. Adora was sick and tired of her nightmares; they made her feel like she was the target of some malicious force, a force that was completely unknown to her. Plus, someone had tried to kill her in the middle of the night, someone who might give her some answers. She just wanted to get to the bottom of this.

Glimmer had filled Adora in on what they found out during the interrogation, that the assassin, Shen they were calling him, was sent by some leader to kill the host of She-Ra. This would enable

this leader to "take over the universe", as it was. *Was it another Horde Prime?* Glimmer also said that this Shen character seemed like a very reluctant assassin who was relieved that Catra stopped him.

Strange, but I can work with that, Adora thought to herself.

Adora approached the large doors that led into the dormitory extension, the two Bright Moon guards standing out front letting her pass with no question. Adora was Protector of the Realm after all, and higher ranked than them.

She was about to ask which room the prisoner was in when she heard singing. Adora followed the sound, drawn to the room the song emanated from. The song was strange but beautiful, in a language she never heard, but she felt like she could almost understand it. The meaning was on the tip of her tongue, but continued to elude her.

Just as she went to open the door, the singing abruptly stopped. Opening the door, she saw the prisoner, Shen, sitting in the cylindrical magical force field. He was sitting cross-legged, hands on knees. Adora took him in. The description Glimmer gave her was spot on, but did not prepare her for the reality of the strange tattoos and the wicked scar over his heart.

As she walked toward him, he twitched and a strange intensity came over his eyes. This quickly passed and continued to stare at her, curiosity in his eyes now.

Adora could not think of how to start her interrogation, so she went for what always seemed to work for her when faced with an enemy.

Bravado and cockiness.

Adora put her hand up, speaking the words of activation, summoning her sword, and transformed into She-Ra. She then abruptly entered the magical field and menacingly stood over the prisoner, sword in hand.

“So, I heard you wanted to kill me?” She-Ra/Adora asked in her deepest voice.

Shen backed up on his rear until his back hit the field and he was repelled with a magical shock. He yelped and moved forward, away from the field, still staring up at her. She-Ra/Adora saw amazement and wonder in his eyes, but no fear. There was great sadness and pain in his eyes that seemed beyond the realm of fear. Shen put his head down in resignation, seeming to deflate.

“Yes, that was my intention, but not my desire,” he stated.

“So, you wanted to kill me, but you didn’t want to kill me? That makes no sense.” She-Ra/Adora responded harshly.

Shen didn’t respond but just kept his head down, staring at her feet.

“Well!?” she yelled.

Nothing.

Okay, Adora, I don’t think the bully tactic will work, time for something else, she thought.

She-Ra/Adora squatted down until her head was almost at Shen’s level, then, gently lifted his chin until she was looking into his eyes.

“Shen, right? That’s what Glimmer said to call you, right?” she asked gently.

“It’s a poor nickname but I’m fine with it. You may call me Shen,” he assented.

“Why did you come to Bright Moon to kill me? Glimmer said you seemed reluctant, and you have just confirmed that. Please make sense of this for me.” She-Ra/Adora said pleadingly.

Shen stared at her for a while, seeming to think. He seemed to be distracted, like he was listening to something.

"My Lord, the Shen'Aan-war, said you must die. He tasked me with the mission. If I did not do it, the result would be worse. If you had to choose between doing a bad thing or letting a much more horrible thing from happening, which would you choose?" Shen asked.

"I would choose the third option, doing neither." She-Ra/Adora retorted.

"Ha! If only it were that simple. There is no third choice for me! You have *no* idea what you're talking about!" Shen responded angrily.

"Then help me understand, Shen. Explain it to me." She-Ra/Adora implored.

Shen looked to the side as if thinking, the same distracted look in his eyes.

"I have…another…inside me…" he said, clutching at the scar on his chest.

"Like a dark side? We all have our dark side Shen, we all have our demons." She-Ra/Adora said.

"No, this is not some symbolic description for my darker nature. This *demon* is REAL." Shen looked at She-Ra/Adora, a haunted look in his eyes.

She-Ra/Adora looked into his eyes, seeing the sincerity there. Either he was crazy or telling the truth, something told her the latter as she gazed down at the scar; she had an idea.

"Shen, I want you to hold still while I try something, Can I put my hand on your chest?" She-Ra/Adora asked.

Shen looked into her eyes, and the distracted look became more intense.

"Yes!" he said through gritted teeth.

She-Ra/Adora closed her eyes, summoning her healing abilities, and she began to glow. When she opened her eyes, they were burning with a bright, pure light. Shen gazed into those eyes with his mouth open, completely enraptured.

She-Ra/Adora placed her glowing hand on Shen's chest. The tattoos surrounding the scar seemed to brighten with a cold light, as if trying to bar the way for She-Ra's healing light.

She-Ra/Adora focused on the scar, felt the pain of it making, then went deeper. She felt Shen's inner being; trapped, tormented, hurting, but beyond that, his soul was strong, and bright like a sun. There was something attached to his bright soul, like a sunspot, but darker and more sinister. As she focused on the spot, she immediately felt the Other's presence. Ancient, evil, blood-thirsty, and full of hate, it immediately clawed out at her in defense, throwing her consciousness out of Shen and back into herself.

She-Ra/Adora was thrown past the barrier and onto the floor, instantly transforming back into Adora. Adora sat there, upright but leaning back on her hands, legs splayed out, staring at Shen in shock. Shen had leapt up and was standing by the barrier wall, concern on his face.

"Are you okay, She-Ra?" he asks, not knowing that there was a difference between her and Adora.

"Yeah, yeah, I'm okay. I felt it... it was horrible. I believe you, Shen." Adora waved off his concern.

Adora stood and walked back toward the barrier. She stopped at the edge, not wanting to enter.

“You don’t have to call me She-Ra. Please just call me Adora.” She gently told Shen.

“Adora, okay.” He replied. Suddenly Shen seemed to focus inward. “I don’t know what you did... but…the Other…seems to be suppressed now. Asleep.” Shen looked gratefully at Adora.

“You’re welcome, but I don’t think I want to keep doing that,” Adora said with a weak grin. “It felt like it was going to grab me.”

“Yes, they did not like me talking to you. They were screaming at me when you were about to put your hand upon me.” Shen admitted.

“Why did you let me?” Adora asked.

Shen had another distant look on his face now, not haunted this time, but pleasant. “I heard another voice in my head... it was a memory, someone I loved, who is gone now.”

“What were they telling you? This memory.” Adora asked.

“To open my heart.” Shen had a warm grin on his face now.

Shen and Adora shared a smile; a spark of a connection seemed to have formed.

“Ah but it won’t last, the Other will be awake again, back to normal,” Shen said, defeated tone now.

“Is that what it is called, the Other? What is it exactly?” Adora asks.

“I call it the ‘Other’, but it has a name for itself that I refuse to use. It is a grandiose self-given name, but kind of apt.” Shen said. “It calls itself the Demon-Heart.”

“Demon-Heart?” Adora grimaced. “Why?”

"Because that is what it is," Shen said. He then began to tell his tale to Adora.

"My mother died when I was young, I was raised by my father, the Shen'Aan-war—"

"Wait, so the guy that wants me dead and wants to take over the universe is your *Father*?!" Adora exclaimed, incredulous. Adora was sitting cross-legged now, listening to Shen.

"Yes, I'm sorry, that is correct. Adora, please, don't interrupt me. I'm really bad at telling stories as it is." Shen pleaded.

"Whoops, sorry, I'll be quiet," Adora said, shrugging her shoulders with an apologetic smile.

"My father was very distant and strict with me. He felt that I was weak and soft-hearted. The first and only time he brought me on a hunting trip, he was enraged when I couldn't kill our quarry. It was a young Sha'Ha-we, a beautiful creature. I had it in the sights of my spike-lance and couldn't understand why we had to kill it. What was the need for such a merciless kill?

"My father was angry and said something stupid like 'if you're not the hunter then you're the hunted.' Or was it 'the purpose of the weak is to be dominated by the strong'? It was one of those sayings— tired, hateful things he would always quote to me."

"My father sat me down to have a talk after that, to try and instill his values into me. He told me that not only do we reside in a dark universe and live on a dark planet, but we were also meant to live dark lives— it was the absolute truth of life. Love, friendship, compassion were all lies meant to keep the strong weak and that we— he and I— were the strong. We were meant to use our power to dominate, for why did we have it if not for that purpose?"

"I became very depressed after he told me that. I could not believe that this was true. Even though the evidence of its truth was all around me, the dark world I lived in and its oppression, I

just knew it was not true. I can't tell you how I knew this, I just did. I knew then that I would never have any place in my father's empire. I became disillusioned and lost interest in fulfilling my duties as Prince. I became listless and started engaging in stupid frivolities to pass the time when I met someone, someone special I fell in love with."

"This person, his name was Shen'Dara. He was part of the rebellion, but he taught me that there was me another way, one of friendship, hope and love."

"So, I joined the rebellion with him in secret. It was a rebellion against the Shen'Aan-war, my father, and the power he had sided with. We had fallen asleep after one of our missions; these were various acts of sabotage and theft to thwart my father, it was then that the unthinkable happened."

"We had been betrayed, and my father's agents came for us. We had an escape route, but the agents were already inside, so someone had to delay them. I volunteered for this job, for I foolishly thought at the time that I would face no real repercussions as the Prince. The others would be killed on the spot, so I felt I was the best choice. Shen'Dara begged me not to do it, but he relented after I refused to go with them. We said goodbye there, and shared the last kiss we would ever share in this lifetime."

"I fought the agents, the sword lessons Shen'Dara had taught me enabling my friends time to escape, but I was quickly overcome and captured. I was bound and brought before my father. Instead of the anger and disappointment that I expected, he seemed not to care, as if his own son betraying him was inconsequential. I was to face repercussions though. My father said that henceforth, I was no longer the Prince or his son, and I was to be given to the Death-Binders. They had discovered something special and needed a subject. This subject had to be someone with meaning, who better than the Shen'Aan-war's son?"

“The Death-Binders were a hideous group of individuals. I guess you would call them sorcerers, like your Micah and Castaspella, but evil. They brought me deep into the castle dungeons, where they delved into their secrets. There, they conducted their ritual.”

“They used their magic to paralyze me. I had to watch, fully awake and aware, as they used a malevolent dagger to cut my chest open and remove my heart. The pain was great, as you could imagine, but I could not move or scream in pain. The pain was so intense that I was waiting to die and be free from it.... but I did not die. I watched as they brought the most hideous thing I’ve ever seen over to me— it was a beating black heart that pulsed with an inner red light. They placed it in my chest and bound it to me using their magic. It became my heart, beating inside me, pumping my own blood through its hideous mass and back into my body. Only as they were stitching me back up, was I then finally allowed to pass out.”

“When I awoke, I was in a cell designed to hold me and my new passenger. It started to speak to me there. I thought I was losing my mind at first, but slowly began to realize that what had happened to me was far worse than insanity. The Other, as I began to call it, explained to me the nature of our new relationship; how it would give me power and in return, it would need my body to sate its hunger to kill and cause destruction.”

“I rebelled against this, of course, refusing to allow myself for this purpose, but it was a fruitless fight. The first time the Death-Binders summoned the Other from within was also the first time I was sent out to hunt and kill for the Shen’Aan-war. The Other took over my body, and I had to watch through my own eyes as the Other, the Demon-Heart, went out into the night, to hunt and kill rebels. To kill my friends. I was a hapless prisoner within my own body.”

“I watched my friends in the rebellion be hunted down and killed, slowly over time, for they were well hidden. This culminated in the last hunt, the hunt for Shen’Dara, the last rebel. The one person who I loved more than anything, the one person who showed me

that life need not be dark, the one person who opened my heart, died... with my hands around his throat. I almost lost my mind… maybe I already have…" Shen's voice trailed off as he put his face into his hands, starting to weep. Adora stood up quickly and walked toward Shen through the magical barrier and kneeled next to him, wrapping her arms around him.

"I'm so sorry, Shen. That is the most horrible thing I have ever heard." Adora said, tears in her eyes. Shen tried to stifle his tears as he continued his tale.

"With the rebellion dead, I was placed back into my cell until I was needed again. That was when I was awoken to kill you. I believed that I had to do it or they would send the Other, and they would have if I refused. I'm trapped, Adora! I have no control, I'm damned!" Shen cried.

"I'm sorry if this is an ignorant question, but can't you just run away or hide from these Death-Binders?" Adora asked.

"No, that doesn't work. I've tried. The Other is always there inside me, waiting to trip me up and escape. You see, dark emotions like hate and great pain can be used to summon the Other. The Other is good at slowly beating me down until they get the appropriate response out of me. It is impossible to escape them when they are always there, inside my head."

"I have learned over time that I can subdue the Other by thinking of happy memories over and over again and maintain my focus to keep them from escaping. This does not always work though." Shen explained.

"Your focus? Like constantly thinking happy thoughts? What about when you're asleep? Or unconscious like when... Catra... knocked you out..." Adora said the last part sheepishly.

"No, it's not a mental focus. It's hard to describe, almost like my very being contains the Other." Shen said, trying to choose the correct words.

Adora remembered Shen's soul shining bright like a sun, and the barely perceptible dark spot within it.

"I think I understand, Shen. Go on." Adora encouraged.

"I tried ending myself as well, but that does not work either for I cannot die. Every time I do, I just go back to the Death-Binders who put me back together and send me back out. The best place is to be in the cell, locked away in the dungeons of my Father's castle. It is the safest place, for everyone else. Adora, I see that you are a great and kind person. All the people I have met here are, and I fear you are all in horrible danger while I'm held captive here."

"We have magic, this cell... we can hold you safe while we figure this out," Adora said, trying to placate him.

"No, I don't think it is enough, Adora. The Other is powerful. If they got out, they would destroy everyone here and leave this beautiful place in ruins." Shen said, pleading with her.

Adora suddenly thought back to her dream; Bright Moon ruined, the corpses, Catra…

"What do you think we should do, Shen?" Adora asked.

Shen thought about it for a moment. "You need to get me out of Bright Moon. *You need to kill me*. Once I'm dead, I will just go back to the corpse-pools. I will be put back together and sent back but by then, maybe you could put up a blockade around your planet." She suggested.

Adora was absolutely horrified by his response and backed away from him slightly.

"I'm not going to *kill* you, Shen, *that's horrible!* Sent back to the *corpse-pools*?" Adora was incredulous.

"You don't want to know," Shen replied, the haunted look in his eyes again.

Adora placed her hands on either side of Shen's face, looking into his eyes with absolute certainty in hers.

"Shen, there is always a 'third choice', I'm an expert on finding it!" Adora let out a weak laugh. "I won't let you suffer. I won't let this demon hurt anyone. I promise!"

Shen stared into Adora's eyes and saw the pure goodness in her, her absolute focus of will. He slowly allowed himself to believe her, to believe the person he was sent to kill could save him.

"Okay," Shen said, almost peacefully.

* * *

Shen continued to sit cross-legged in his prison, long after Adora left him, focusing on positive memories to maintain the barrier holding the Other in place. Adora had actually convinced him that there was hope, and he was instilled with a sense of purpose, determined to do everything he could to hold out until she returned. Before she left, Adora said she had to talk to someone who might know how to help him, someone named "Madame Razz".

Shen remembered how angry the Other was before She-Ra had placed her hands on him. They had screamed of betrayal, of how he would pay. He was loath for them to awaken and wanted to be ready.

It was an hour into this, that the Other finally awoke.

Shen felt it, like a small sliver of ice in his heart; the Other was angry. They seemed to growl, then they spoke.

"That was a mistake, Shen'Thran-zanmar'eth." the Other said coldly.

Shen froze, the Other never referred to him by his true name before, he always called him "my Prince."

*"Betraying your father was one thing, but to betray **us**, is another."* the Other stated in a deadly voice. *"I didn't exactly come with a set of instructions when I was bound to you, did I? You really don't know all the **rules**."*

"What are you talking about? I owe you nothing. There was nothing to betray!" Shen replied.

"***Wrong***." the Other replied.

Shen started to feel the bonds holding the Other unraveling. He doubled up on his efforts to re-establish them. His chest was starting to glow with an inner red light.

"By betraying us, you broke a sacred rule, and thus, lost all right to keep us bound." the Other said, cackling.

"NOOOOOO!!!!" Shen screamed.

The light was getting brighter now, red and intense, his ribcage, lungs and veins showed in the light; in the center, a beating heart.

"Ahhhhhhh...so many delicious morsels here, and that stone, I shall have to visit it…." the Other said, in absolute rapture.

The light became more and more intense as darkness seemed to seep out of Shen's eyes, ears and pores, encapsulating him and forming a shell of blackness over his entire body.

Shen closed his eyes.

The Demon-Heart opened them.

Flowers for Madame Razz

Chapter Summary

Madame Razz remembers a hurtful memory and shares a day with Swift Wind.

The friendship squad fights a terrible foe, the Demon-Heart.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It was late at night in the Whispering Woods when Madame Razz returned to her small cottage, contentedly humming to herself, a large basket full of Moon Asters in one hand. Nighttime was the best time to pick the beautiful flowers, especially when the moon was out; the Moon Asters were known to make a sweet ghostly chime when the moon shone upon them. The moon was full tonight and the flower's song floated through the Whispering Woods, drawing Madame Razz to a meadow with a large patch of the light blue flowers glowing in the moonlight.

Razz sought these flowers, in particular, tonight, for Moon Aster petals made the most soothing tea. That tea could be used to calm a melancholic heart which she had in abundance that evening.

The day had begun pleasant enough, with bright sun streaming through the window and birds chirping, when that strange, talking horse popped his head through her door to greet her. A strange beast, he was all white with rainbow wings and a long, pointed horn on his forehead. He was very beautiful... but kind of

annoying. He came by from time to time to see how she was doing, which she found touching in her ancient heart.

"Morning Madame Razz!" the winged beast greeted.

"Aghhhh!" She exclaimed, whacking him on the snout with her broom. He was ALWAYS startling her.

"Ouch, Razz! Stop, it's me! *Swift Wind*!" the creature said dramatically. "Remember, Swift Wind? I always come by and you feed me apples?"

"Ah, yes, yes... Madame Razz remembers now. Mara's horse." Razz said, slowly.

"Adora…Adora, remember? Also, *I'm nobody's horse*!" Swift Wind's retorted.

"Yes, yes, you're always telling Madame Razz that," Razz says quietly, her memories finally clicking into place.

"I'm Swift Wind, brave freedom fighter, fighting to free my oppressed brothers and sisters, one stable at a time!" Swift Wind continued.

Madame Razz froze, hanging on to a piece of what Swift Wind just said.

"What did you say?" Razz asked.

"I fight for the freedom of my oppressed brothers and sisters!" Swift Wind repeated. Seeing the faraway look on Razz's face, he continued dryly, "I free other horses from stables. It's like, my thing."

"Brothers and sisters…*sister*…" Razz continued, still seeming far away. For some reason, today of all days, the word sister resonated with her, bringing back old memories. She began to feel very melancholic.

"You okay, Razz?" Swift Wind said, now concerned. He entered the house through the door and stood next to Madame Razz.

Razz snapped out of her memories. "Oh what? Yes, yes, I'm fine. Madame Razz was just thinking about someone." Razz said.

"Who?" asked Swift Wind.

"Who what?" she replied.

"Who were you thinking of just now?" Swift Wind asked.

"Madame Razz wasn't thinking of anyone, what are you talking about? Crazy talking horse…" Razz exclaimed, forgetting her previous train of thought.

"Never mind." Swift Wind said, annoyed but used to Madame Razz's memory lapses.

"Anyway, why do you always come here to visit Madame Razz? Why aren't you with Adora? Why don't you go find a nice horse friend?" Razz asked.

"Adora doesn't need me as much now. Most of her new adventures take her out to space where I can't follow her, and when she's home she spends a lot of alone time with Catra. Catra, Catra, Catra!" Swift Winds exclaimed plaintively. "Don't get me wrong, I'm happy for Adora, I really am. I just miss our time together." His shoulders sagged for a moment, but he shook his head and quickly changed the subject.

"Anyway, I like checking up on you. You feed me apples! Maybe we can hang out more together? I mean you looked a little down there, how about we spend the day together? Maybe a sleepover too?"

Madame Razz looked thoughtful. *Hmmm... do I really want this talking horse hanging around me all day? Well, he can fly…* She thought.

“Okay, whatever, you can stay with Madame Razz for a bit. We will spend the day together and then you can sleep here for the night... Madame Razz doesn’t really sleep so you have to be able to sleep with her puttering around in here, though.” She conceded.

“Deal!” Swift Wind exclaimed.

Madame Razz and Swift Wind spent a pleasant day together cleaning up Razz’s shack, picking apples, and watching butterflies. They even flew through the clouds or in formation with the many strange and beautiful flying creatures that inhabited Etheria. Madame Razz found that she enjoyed her new friend’s company, for the sadness she felt earlier was still with her.

After dinner, Swift Wind decided to retire for the day. Razz found some old blankets and made him a make-shift bed in the corner of her shack. She left him sleeping there to go pick Moon Aster petals.

Razz entered her cottage and went to her stove, filling the kettle with water for tea. Using a mortar and pestle, she crushed the petals when she felt her melancholy rise up again. At the heart of this blossoming sadness, a memory and a name came to the forefront.

“Zzar,” Razz whispered to herself. “Oh, my poor, dear, sweet sister. Zzar, why did you do it?”

Razz continued her preparations, filling a tea ball with the crushed petals and placing it in a steaming cup of hot water. She let it steep for a while, the hot water taking on a bright light blue hue.

Razz was about to take a sip of the hot tea when a sensation hit her, like ice stabbing her heart. She dropped her cup on the floor where it smashed to pieces, hot tea splashing her. The burning tea did not seem to affect her for the cold feeling had spread from her heart to the rest of her body. Razz let out a cry as she doubled over, clutching her chest.

Swift Wind was startled awake. "Razz! Razz! What's the matter?" He said, rushing to her side.

Razz did not respond to his questions. "No…No…here? No, not here, please…" She moaned, still holding her chest.

"Razz, talk to me, what's happening?" Swift Wind pleaded.

Razz focused her gaze on him, determination in her eyes. "Adora…Adora is in trouble. We must hurry, Swift Wind!"

Razz summoned her broom and raced out the door, Swift Wind in tow. Once outside, she again used her telekinesis to lift herself onto his back.

"Where are we going?" Swift Wind asked, spreading his wings.

"To Bright Moon! HURRY!" Razz exclaimed, panicked.

Swift Wind lifted into the air, straight in the direction of Bright Moon, his rainbow wings driving them as hard as they could.

* * *

Castaspella was up late, rummaging for leftovers in Bright Moon's kitchens. She couldn't sleep; she was too excited about the previous day's events.

I finally did it! I finally got the nerve up to ask her out and she said yes! Castaspella thought over and over in her head, humming contentedly to herself.

She found a piece of cake began to pick at it with a fork, taking tiny bites while dancing around the kitchen, still engrossed in her memories.

She had been walking the grounds of Bright Moon with Micah, discussing the earlier interrogation and its implications, when she spotted *her* in the distance. She was standing with two royal

guards, a short dark-skinned female and a larger, green-skinned reptilian one, and appeared to be giving them a lecture.

General Juliet.

Castaspella quickly looked away, her face flushed. Micah had stopped talking, and looked at his sister, concern on his face.

"Cassy? What's wrong?" he asked, using her old nickname.

"What? Oh, nothing, nothing, it's nothing…" Castaspella responded, trying to be nonchalant.

"Cassy, you're blushing like a little girl who got her hand caught in the cookie jar!" Micah teased, looking over at what had caught his sister's attention. "Ah... I see." He said knowingly.

"You see what?" Castaspella snapped at her brother's tone.

"Don't think I haven't noticed the way you look at the General, Cassy. Why don't you go speak to her? I mean, come on, you're the head sorceress of Mystacor, surely you can handle asking someone out for a date?" Micah said.

Castaspella blushed even harder, looking away.

"Cassy, you're acting like a little girl, like when we were young and you had a crush on one of our classmates. Stop acting like a baby and just go talk to her!" Micah exclaimed.

"Fine!" Castaspella responded, sick of her brother's badgering. "If only to get away from you and your nagging!"

Castaspella headed off toward Juliet, exasperated, her brother chuckling behind her.

Juliet had just finished lecturing the two misfit guards on royal etiquette when Castaspella had reached her, exasperation replaced by nervousness. The two guards walked away, sheepish in their chastisement.

“Ah, head Sorceress Castaspella. What can I do for you?” Juliet asked, all business.

“Oh, General, please call me Castaspella... or Cassy if you’re so inclined.” Castaspella stammered out nervously.

“Oh, sure, Castaspella…er…Cassy.” Juliet had said, unsure of using the nickname.

“Oh, it’s a wonderful day, isn’t it?” Castaspella asked, beginning to panic.

Juliet looked around at the clear blue sky, then back over at Castaspella. “Sure, it’s nice, I suppose.” She agreed.

Castaspella just stared at Juliet, the panic almost making her burst at the seams, her face red.

“Are you okay, Cassy? Did you just come over here to ask about the weather?” Juliet asked, confused.

The panic spilled out of Castaspella in a torrent. “Anychanceyouwouldliketogooutsometime?” She rushed out in one breath.

“I beg your pardon?” Juliet asked.

Castaspella took a deep breath and shyly tried again... “General, I wanted to know if you’re interested... that is, if you would ever be willing to go out.... for dinner or something? Or whatever.” Castaspella looked down, wringing her hands in nervousness.

Castaspella’s jumbled words began to make sense and Juliet smiled, a little blush of her own forming on her dark skin. “I think I would like that, Cassy.” She responded softly, all business gone.

Castaspella quickly looked up in surprise, then beamed.

“Oh, and Cassy?” Juliet had said.

“Yes?” Castaspella responded dreamily.

“Please drop the General, call me Juliet.” Juliet stated, a beautiful smile forming on her face.

Castaspella was still reminiscing on this memory when she heard something in the distance, coming from the Trial Extension.

It was a roar, loud, piercing and terrible. She had never heard anything like it in all her travels; it made her blood run cold.

“What in the name of Etheria was that?” she exclaimed.

Castaspella dropped her cake and began to run out of the kitchen toward the Trial extension. As she ran through the halls, she was joined by guards also heading in the same direction. They finally came to the Trail extension main doors and stopped, seeing more guards trying to bar the door.

There was a terrible banging coming from the other side. The doors were thick wood and huge, but something was bashing into them, creating dents. The roaring continued from the other side, mixed with hideous shrieks of anger. Castaspella looked over to see Juliet helping bar the door and approached her.

“Juliet, what’s going on? Is it the prisoner? What is in there?” Castaspella asked, panic taking over her voice.

“I don’t know what’s in there, but it’s weird and pissed off, whatever it is!” Juliet grunted, struggling with the door.

Suddenly the door exploded inward, sending everyone flying back. Castaspella, Juliet and the guards collected themselves and sat back up, looking at the open passage where the double doors previously stood. A figure stood there, a dread figure from their worst nightmares.

The figure was of an average Etherian man’s height, humanoid, slender and black. In the center of its chest, an eerie red light pulsed like a heartbeat. The figure’s rib cage and internal organs

could be seen through the red light, but that was not the worst. The worst was its head. Flaming red eyes sat in a horrible leering face, its mouth hung open, exposing sharp red needle teeth. On top of its head, black smoke-like hair stood erect, dancing back and back and forth like a flame. Long arms were held out to each side, hands ending in sharp talons.

It saw them and screeched as it moved toward them slowly, its body moving strangely, jerkily as if out of step with time. Castaspella screamed and erected a magical barrier that just barely held it at arm's length, just barely. As it fought against the barrier, Castaspella could feel her grip slipping; the figure had immense strength and power.

Juliet and the guards gathered behind Castaspella, drawing their weapons, unsure if they could hurt this creature. It lashed at the barrier, clawing, kicking and biting it.

Juliet turned to a subordinate guard. "Sound the alarm. Hurry!" She yelled.

"Get the Royal Advisor, Micah, too!" yelled Castaspella, through clenched teeth.

The guard turned and ran. Mere moments after he left, the clanging chimes of the Bright Moon alarm resonated loudly.

* * *

Adora entered Bright Moon from the Whispering Woods, her search for Madame Razz fruitless. She had arrived at the shack where the old lady lived and peered in, seeing only her friend and faithful steed Swift Wind sleeping in the corner. Not wanting to wake him and deal with a million questions, she left and returned to Bright Moon.

She was almost frantic now, remembering Shen's desperation and the horrible presence inside of him lashing out at her. She had to find someone who would know how to deal with something like

this, to help Shen and banish this evil. Adora felt as if she was running out of time.

She was about to head toward the dormitories Micah resided in when she heard the alarm. Dread filled every fibre of Adora's being.

"Oh no, I'm too late!" Adora cried as she ran across the grounds toward the Trail extension.

* * *

Catra awoke to the sound of the alarm, instantly looking for Adora. The bed was empty.

Catra groaned. *Adora, you were supposed to just 'go for a walk'*. She thought to herself.

She sprang out of bed, dressed quickly and secured her gold headpiece; she was ready for a fight. Before she left the room, she closed her eyes and concentrated.

"Melog…I think we need your help…please come." Catra pulsed through their bond.

She felt an affirmation pulsed back Melog was far away but she felt they were coming swiftly.

As Catra left her room, she saw Bow and Glimmer leaving the room they shared, looking dazed.

"Catra, is this your doing?" Glimmer groaned, wiping sleep from her eyes.

"No such luck, Sparkles, I just woke up. Although I think Adora might be involved. Knowing her, she is probably in the middle of this." Catra said.

"So where is the action? This alarm is coming from everywhere with no clear source." Bow stated.

Just then, a Bright Moon guard ran down the hall toward them, panicked and out of breath.

"Your majesty! You're needed in the Trial extension! The Head Sorceress Castaspella and the Royal Advisor Micah are holding back…" The guard broke off.

"What? Holding what?" Glimmer asked, impatiently.

"They're holding back some kind of monster." The guard gulped.

Glimmer, Bow and Catra dashed off down the corridors, toward the hall that would take them to the Trial extension.

* * *

Castaspella was weakening. The creature on the other side of her barrier was too strong and she could not hold it back, even with the power her brother added.

"Cassy, it's too strong. We need to fall back." Micah growled to his sister, arms outstretched.

"How will we hold it back *and* retreat, Micah? This thing is too strong. These guards will be killed!" Castaspella cried in desperation. She was thinking of Juliet holding her ground behind her.

Before Micah could answer, the creature answered for him, it stopped fighting and seemed to hold the barrier in a grip of its own. It tensed and flexed, a wild grin on its hideous face as the magical barrier started to crack. To everyone's horror, the cracks spread until they reached the source of the barrier— Micah and Castaspella.

The barrier exploded.

* * *

Adora was almost to the Trial extension when a portion of it exploded, throwing her back. Adora rose to her feet and stuck out her hand.

"For the honor of Grayskull!" she shouted, transforming into She-Ra. She cautiously approached the gap caused by the explosion in the wall.

"Adora!" a voice cried behind her; it was Catra.

Adora/She-Ra turned, seeing Catra, Bow and Glimmer running toward her from the other side of the grounds.

She then heard a growl coming from her original destination, and saw a figure jumping down from the hole.

It was a vision from her worst nightmares; all black darkness, pulsing red light, teeth and claws. It saw her and screamed. There was only one thing it could be. *This is what Shen was warning her about,* Adora thought.

"Shen? Shen, I'm so, so sorry... I'm too late!" She-Ra/Adora cried, tears brimming.

Then the creature spoke, its voice screeching like nails across stone. "THERE IS NO SHEN, ONLY THE DEMON-HEART!!!"

It flew at her then, jerking and speeding up like it was out of sync with time. Adora/She-Ra raised her sword and charged, screaming at the top of her lungs. They met in a clash of blade thrusts and slashing claws. She-Ra/Adora immediately went on the defense, the Demon-Heart's fury and power immense. Demon-Heart broke her guard and backhanded her in the face, sending Adora/She-Ra careening back, her sword dropping.


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“Adora!” Catra screamed, finally reaching the battle. With her speed, she was way ahead of Bow and Glimmer.

Catra immediately flew at the Demon-Heart in defense of her love. She did a front flip up and over it and landed on its shoulders, slashing its head and face with her claws. It snarled and shook her off and she landed behind it in a crouch, giving it her most fearsome snarl in return.

The Demon-Heart turned slowly and menacingly toward her. When it faced her fully, it drew in a breath and exhaled in a roar of such fury Catra cringed back, ears lowered.

She-Ra/Adora had since got back to her feet, sword in hand, and saw what was about to happen.

“CATRA, NOOOO!!!” She-Ra/Adora screamed, running forward.

The Demon-Heart sped forward in its strange jerking motion, too fast even for someone like Catra. It backhanded her with such force, she flew back into the Trial extension wall. She bounced back off the wall and slid to the ground, her headpiece flying off. She rose momentarily on shaky arms and then fell back down again, still.

“CATRAAAA!” She-Ra/Adora screamed, horror in her voice.

The Demon-Heart turned to her, laughing maliciously.

“THAT WAS YOUR LOVER-PET, WASN’T IT? I THINK I MIGHT HAVE BROKEN HERRRRR!” it said, mock sorrow in its voice.

She-Ra/Adora screamed in absolute fury as she tore toward the Demon-Heart, sword raised to strike it down.

As she brought the sword down, the Demon-Heart caught it in its claw, halting its descent. With its other hand, it punched She-Ra/Adora in the chest, alighting her heart-rune and sending her flying back. She landed on her back again, groaning, out matched by her enemy.

By then, Bow and Glimmer had reached the battle, horrified at what was happening to their friends.

"Bow, I'm sorry, I don't think your arrows will do the trick here. Go check on Catra!" Glimmer yelled. Bow nodded, trying to run around the Demon-Heart to his fallen friend.

The Demon-Heart tracked Bow and was about to lunge at him when Glimmer blasted it with her power.

"Hey, ugly! Try me on for size!" She taunted.

The Demon-Heart screamed and charged at Glimmer. Once it was almost upon her, she teleported to another location, blasting it again. It whirled and screamed in fury as Glimmer kept this up; for the moment she was distracting the deadly foe.

Bow reached Catra, gently turning her over and cradling her in his arms. She slowly opened her eyes, looking up at him.

"Bow?" Catra wheezed then coughed, a small amount of blood dribbling down her mouth.

"I'm here, I got you, Catra. Stay with me." Bow cajoled, then trying to distract her, "Hey what is this 'Bow' nonsense? What happened to 'Punchy'?"

"I don't know, I feel like *I* deserve that title now." Catra wheezed with a smile.

Bow gave a small laugh, relieved his friend's sense of humor was still intact. He looked up as he felt water drops on his face; it was rain. Clouds had slowly moved in late in the night, covering the sky and blocking the moon, and it had begun to rain hard.

"Oh no!" Catra gasped.

She-Ra/Adora had since risen unsteadily to her feet, sword in hand, watching the deadly dance between Glimmer and the

Demon-Heart. The Demon-Heart was furious at its elusive prey, screaming in rage every time Glimmer teleported away.

The Demon-Heart suddenly stilled and closed its red burning eyes, clawed hands clenched at either side.

“What’s wrong, ugly? Are you frustrated?” Glimmer taunted with a laugh.

The Demon-Heart opened its eyes and smiled, suddenly moving so quickly, it appeared to teleport. It grabbed Glimmer by the throat and lifted her off the ground, cackling in her face. Glimmer attempted to teleport away, but she screamed, turning hazy and red, glitching like she had after Shadow Weaver cursed her. She was completely at the mercy of her enemy.

“GOT YOU, LITTLE PEST. YOU LOOK TASTY!” it said, opening its mouth wide to clamp down on Glimmer.

Before it could consume Glitter, a snarling shape landed on its back, slashing and tearing. The Demon-Heart dropped Glimmer, who immediately teleported away, appearing next to She-Ra. She saw the Demon-Heart fighting madly with a biting purple and blue biped.

“Melog!” Glimmer cried.

The two fought viciously, tearing at each other with no thought to defense. They suddenly broke apart with a cry of pain from Melog, who limped away, favoring one paw. The Demon-Heart was about to finish the job when Melog vanished, eliciting a hiss from its enemy.

Two bright blasts of magical energy unexpectedly blasted into the Demon-Heart from the direction of the hole in the Trail extension. Castaspella and Micah had recovered from the explosion, mostly unhurt and no worse for wear. They were ready to join the fight.

The Demon-Heart screamed angrily at the thought of being ensnared in their magical net again. It turned back to She-Ra and

Glimmer, but something new caught its attention. It roared in rage, heading toward it in a mad sprint, intent on destroying its new goal.

“Adora, it’s heading toward the Moonstone!” Glimmer yelled.

“Glimmer, teleport us into its path. It’s going too fast to catch on foot!” She-Ra/Adora cried.

Glimmer grasped She-Ra and instantly teleported them in the path of the charging Demon-Heart. It halted, hissing menacingly.

“Uh, Adora...? Maybe this plan needed a little more thought?” Glimmer asked, falteringly.

She-Ra/Adora didn’t respond, shrieking in rage and charging at her enemy, who in turn, charged at her. They collided again, sword to claw, She-Ra/Adora fighting in pure anger, hacking at her enemy with all her might.

The sword was again knocked out of her hands, and they brawled, rolling in the mud, the rain saturating the ground. She-Ra/Adora furiously kicked and punched her enemy, who slashed at her torso. She-Ra/Adora ignored this pain, desperate to destroy her hateful foe. She wrapped her hands around its black neck, trying to strangle it.

The Demon-Heart pulled its legs in and kicked out at She-Ra, breaking her grip on its neck and sending her flying back. She landed with a wet splash on the muddy ground; she was bloody, completely covered in mud, and drained of energy. She-Ra/Adora tried to rise, but fell back down, transforming back into Adora.

The Demon-Heart rose with a chuckle and strode toward the fallen Adora.

“AHHHH, THAT WAS A GOOD FIGHT! THE BEST ONE I’VE EVER HAD! I SHALL SAVOR EATING YOU!” it grinned, reaching out as it approached her.

Adora was conscious but weak. She tried to scramble backwards in the mud, unable to escape her doom.

"Adora!" a voice cried from above.

The Demon-Heart and Adora both turned in unison as a rainbow-winged horse landed near them, a small figure on its back.

"Madame Razz?" Adora whispered, incredulous. "No! It's too strong for you!"

Madame Razz leaped from Swift Wind's back, broom in hand. She held it out like a staff as she approached the Demon-Heart.

"NOOOOOO…ONE OF YOUUUU???" the Demon-Heart cried, as if recognizing her. There was fear in its voice.

Adora watched as the small old woman she knew seemed to change before her eyes. The short squat woman became taller and thinner until she was as tall as the hologram of Light Hope that Adora remembered. She appeared to be wearing a large robe made of stars, a hood up over her head. Her face had changed as well, becoming strange, cold and very alien. It was blue and faceted, like gems, and two bottomless eyes gazed out; Adora could see infinitesimal galaxies within. Madame Razz raised the arm that held the broom. However, instead of a broom, it had become a long thin black staff, the head a bright light, like a fallen star. She raised the staff above her and beams of rainbow-colored light streaked down from the sky, alighting on the end of the staff. She then lowered the staff and pointed it at the Demon-Heart.

"NOOOOOOOO!!!" the Demon-Heart screamed.

A bright ribbon of pure starlight shot forth from the staff, encircling the Demon-Heart.

It shrieked hatefully as it was encircled and banded, with more and more ribbons wrapping it until its entire body was covered. Its cries were slowly muffled as it was wrapped up, the hideous red light of its heart dimming through its bindings. Finally, its cries

ceased, and the ribbons burst apart, revealing a naked young man lying on his stomach. It was Shen, transformed back to his own self, his tattoos burning bright reacting with hate at being touched by such wondrous magic.

Adora looked back to Madame Razz, who was once again the small old woman holding a broom, a melancholy expression on her face.

Madame Razz moved past Adora and approached the fallen form of Shen. As she passed, Adora could hear her whisper.

“This was you’re doing, wasn’t it, Zzar?” the old woman said, sadly.

Razz knelt by Shen’s fallen form. Somehow, he was still alive, yet was unconscious and breathing. She placed an old, withered hand over the scar on his chest.

“You poor, poor boy.” She shook her head.

Before Adora could comment, Glimmer practically slid into her, wrapping her arms around her.

“Adora!” Glimmer cried.

“I’m okay, Glimmer, I’m okay,” Adora replied, hugging her friend. “Catra! Glimmer, take us to Bow and Catra!” She suddenly exclaimed.

Glimmer nodded and they disappeared, reappearing next to Bow and Catra. Micah and Castaspella had joined them, inspecting Catra’s injuries with magic. Adora knelt by her love; Catra was conscious and still wheezing, blood still dribbling down the side of her mouth.

“Hey, Adora!” Catra wheezed.

“Oh Catra, Catra.... you brave idiot!” Adora said, tears in her eyes.

Micah looked over at Adora after completing his inspection. “She has five broken ribs on the right side, as well as a punctured lung. She also has a fracture in her upper right leg.”

Adora immediately held out her hand, transforming into She-Ra and accessing her healing abilities. She opened her pure glowing white eyes and placed her healing hands on Catra’s chest. The healing light spread over Catra’s body and she gasped, the wheezing gone. Micah repeated his inspection after the light dissipated.

“The lung has sealed up and the broken bones are mending, but she will still need a lot of time to heal. I suggest we move her to your bedroom so she can rest. Castaspella and I can use magic to do it without jostling her.” Micah reported.

She-Ra/Adora looked down at Catra, relief in her eyes. “Catra, how do you feel?”

“Oh Adora, I don’t know if it worked. I’m still all wet.” Catra said with a grimace, the rain still falling on them.

She-Ra/Adora laughed, leaning down to kiss Catra’s wet face.

Chapter End Notes

Illustration done by @CeroCrown.

The Third Choice

Chapter Summary

Lonnie goes to visit her old Horde Commander, with cake.

Adora, Glimmer, Castaspella, Micah and Razz decide what to do with Shen.

Catra is the WORST patient ever.

Chapter Notes

(Authors Note, 10/23/2020) - Totally forgot about the Imp and added him to Lonnie, Kyle and Rogellio's story.

Lonnie had just gotten the off morning shift of Bright Moon guard duty and began to head over to the mess hall. It was lunch and she intended to pick up a slice of cake for someone who sounded like they needed it— Catra.

Up until now they two women shared an uneasy relationship; not quite friends but not exactly enemies. This was the state of things between them after their mutual desertion from the Horde. They mostly avoided each other, but whenever they were forced in the same general proximity, they nodded in greeting or exchanged lame hellos.

After the Trial, Catra apologized to Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio for throwing them out into combat over and over again with no concern for their well-being. She apologized for taking their friendship for granted, for they had all grown up together and

Catra had dismissed this in her rise to power within the ranks of the Horde.

Like the dummies Lonnie thought they were, Kyle and Rogelio accepted her apology straight away, ready to forget the hurts and become friends again. Lonnie was not so quick to forget. She couldn't forget Catra repeatedly getting in her face, threatening her if Lonnie didn't do as Catra commanded, so when Catra came to her with apologies right after being convicted of her crimes, Lonnie had a hard time accepting it. She could not forgive Catra.

After the trial, Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle had settled down together, getting a place in the small village at the base of Bright Moon, next to the bay. They had gone through so much— growing up together, fighting in the Horde, and eventually deciding to defect — that their bonds ran deep. Their transition to a more intimate relationship came naturally, although, they had to admit, they made an odd throuple.

On top of forming a relationship, the three had adopted a…ward. Ward was the best word, for he was not exactly a child, but not exactly able to take care of himself either. The "Imp", as he was previously called, was re-named "Charlie" by Kyle, and the small creature took to the name.

Before formalizing the adoption, they had discussed it with their old Horde boss Hordak, who was also fond of Charlie and did not like the idea of being parted from him for good. An accord was struck; Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio would have him during the week and Hordak would have him on the weekend. It worked out for everyone in the end, especially Charlie.

Lonnie and Rogelio, being good soldiers and fighters, wanted to continue to serve and they wanted to serve the best. When they applied for the Bright Moon Guard, General Juliet was hesitant at first, but after recommendations from Adora and Catra, they were accepted. Lonnie and Rogelio were extremely proud to wear the purple, blue and white of the Bright Moon guard, even though they sometimes ran afoul of royal rules and regulations.

However, the Bright Moon Guard was not for Kyle; he always hated fighting and was not good at it. He chose to follow a different path, opening a specialty games shop in the nearby town of Thaymor. It was quite popular too, and on certain days Kyle would host an open game night for enthusiastic players. Catra and Scorpia were known to sometimes attend game night for their monthly "girls' night out". They usually could be seen in a corner, wearing matching leather jackets, playing their favorite board game.

When Kyle went to work in his shop, Charlie would go with him; he had become the store's mascot. Kyle was worried about Charlie making mischief at first, but he ended up being quite useful. Charlie's recall ability was especially handy when you had one hundred sets of different game rules to memorize. He also had a knack for organization and would spend hours organizing all the games into the correct categories.

Since Kyle owned his own shop and made his own hours, he could usually be home before Lonnie and Rogelio and make dinner; they had a pretty nice set-up.

When Lonnie and Rogelio heard the alarms in the middle of the night, they rushed to report for duty but by the time they got there, the action was over. From what they gathered, some kind of monster broke out of the Trial extension and wreaked havoc on Bright Moon. It took the combined power of She-Ra, Micah, Castaspella, Glimmer, Catra, Bow, a guard contingent *and* the General to take it down. They now had it contained in a "spare bedroom" since the Trial extension was in ruins; She-Ra herself was standing guard over it. Lonnie had no idea why they bothered — back in the Horde, they would have just gotten of something like that, but what did she know? She was just a line-guard.

From what she gathered, there were just a few minor injuries, and no one was killed. Well, minor injuries except for Catra, who had taken a beating and had to be healed by She-Ra. Catra was now on mandatory bed rest in the chambers she and Adora shared.

When she heard about Catra being hurt, Lonnie was conflicted on how to feel. Then she remembered what she found in her cubby in the Bright Moon guard change area before her morning duty today. It was a crude, handwritten drawing of what appeared to be Lonnie, Kyle, Rogelio, Catra and Adora dressed in their training garb back in the Horde, fighting training bots. Lonnie would find little presents like this from time to time, and knew it was Catra's way of reaching out. Catra must have left it for her yesterday to find today, before she was almost killed. Lonnie had folded it and put it in her pocket, to be put with the other presents she had started keeping in her old Horde footlocker back at home.

That was when Lonnie had decided, it was time to go visit her old Horde commander, to see if she was ready to forgive Catra.

Lonnie was crossing the grounds to the tower where she knew Catra and Adora resided. As she carried a cake on a plate, she took in the destruction caused the other night. It looked like a farmer had plowed up the meticulously kept lawn of the Bright Moon grounds; here and there, guards could be seen filling the worst of these rents in the ground with dirt. In the distance, a gaping hole could be seen in the Trial extension wall. She could only imagine what the inside looked like.

Lonnie made it to the tower and entered, going up the stairs to the right level and walked down the dormitory hall.

Hmmmm…I think I'm close, Lonnie said to herself. Then she heard Catra's voice emanating from a closed room down the way, she sounded angry.

Sounds familiar, Lonnie said, again to herself, unsure if this was good idea.

As she got closer, she could hear Catra's voice plus another, a male voice speaking soothingly to her.

"Punchy, I swear, if you don't cut it out…" Catra warned.

“Come on Catra, open uuuuuupppppp…say ahhhhhhh!” the male voice stated.

“NO! Stop! I’m not a baby!” Catra yelled.

“Here it comes, wearrrr-owww-wowww!” the male voice again. Then, “OWWW! Catra you bit me!”

“I told you to stop!” Catra yelling again.

Lonnie was at the door, ready to turn around and leave when the door opened. A dark-skinned young man was there sucking on his finger. *Bow*, she remembered, *his name is Bow.*

“Oh hey! You here to see Catra? Lonnie, right?” Bow said pleasantly.

“Uh, yeah, I brought her something…” Lonnie said lamely, holding the cake.

Bow turned and yelled back into the room. “Catra, Lonnie is here to see you! You better be nice!”

Bow then turned to Lonnie. “Good luck!” he said as he walked past her, sucking on his finger again.

Before Lonnie entered, she heard a strange mewling sound which Catra responded to. “No Melog, I don’t think I overreacted, he totally deserved it!”

Lonnie entered and saw Catra lying in bed, propped up with pillows. She appeared to be wearing a gown that opened in the back, blankets covering her legs. A blue and purple creature of some kind sat next to her, staring intently at Lonnie.

“Lonnie? You came to see me?” Catra said, incredulous. There was also a slight hint of happiness in her voice, but Lonnie didn’t hear it.

“Uh, yeah... Catra, I wanted to see if it was true, that something could actually kick your butt.” Lonnie said, nonchalantly.

Catra laughed, then stopped quickly, grimacing. “Oww…my ribs, please don’t make me laugh.” Catra complained. “Yeah, I got my butt kicked. It was the fastest fight and worst beating I’ve experienced.”

“How bad are your injuries?” Lonnie, now concerned, walking to Catra’s side, across from the blue and purple creature.

“Five broken ribs and one broken leg, it was worse until Adora used her glowy healy-ness on me.” Catra stated.

“From what I heard it was some kind monster. The descriptions were horrible!” Lonnie said.

Catra had a distant look in her eyes. “Yeah, it was some kind of freak. I’m not sure where it came from, but I think it had something to do with that guy, Shen, who tried to hurt us the other night. Did you hear about that?” Catra asked.

Lonnie nodded.

“It had just knocked Adora, who was She-Ra at the time, back on her butt like she was nothing. I rushed ahead to fight it and it swatted me like a fly into a wall.” Catra said, still distant.

“Where is Adora now?” asked Lonnie. *Why is she not here with you?* She thought to herself.

“Oh, she was here this morning to make sure I was alright, then assigned me my ‘nurse-maid’. I guess they somehow have the monster in custody, and she went to deal with it. She referred to it as Shen, so it is definitely the creepy night-wacko. I don’t understand all the particulars, they gave me a tonic that makes me a little dizzy and numbs the pain, so thinking isn’t my strong suit right now.” Catra admitted.

Lonnie had a biting rejoinder to Catra's last statement, but decided to keep her mouth shut.

"I hope Adora is beating the snot out of him in She-Ra form— the guy totally deserves it." Catra finished. Catra looked down at the cake in Lonnie's hands.

"Did you bring me cake?" Catra asked brightly.

Lonnie looked down at it. It was big piece of the "cake of the day"— white cake with blue and purple frosting for the Bright Moon guard colors. Moon-shaped candy in all its different phases was sprinkled on the frosting.

"Uh, yeah, just something I grabbed." Lonnie said, embarrassed now.

"Looks yummy." Catra said, then frowned. "Ugh, but I can't really move my arms, its hurts my ribs too much. I need my 'nurse-maid' to feed me, but he likes to play stupid baby games with me."

Lonnie looked over at the nightstand table, seeing a plate with food and silverware sitting there. Next to it, there was a chair. She picked up the fork, wiping off the residual food on a napkin and moved the chair closer to the bed.

"Uh, I guess I could help. Help feed you, if you want. I promise I won't play any games." Lonnie said sheepishly.

Catra looked at the cake. "Uh…okay…I'm okay with that." she said hesitantly.

Lonnie sat in the chair and proceeded to cut a small piece of cake off with the fork, a nice piece with lots of frosting. Catra slowly opened her mouth as Lonnie brought it over to the other woman's mouth. Then she remembered Bow, sucking on his finger and stopped.

"Please don't bite me." Lonnie said.

Catra snapped her mouth closed and shook her head. “I won’t, I promise.” She said, then popped her mouth back open.

Lonnie brought the piece over and into Catra’s mouth. She began chewing slowly, closing her eyes.

“Mmmmmm…shooow mm-good.” Catra said, with her mouth full.

Lonnie smiled and sliced another portion, and, more confidently now, fed Catra the piece.

A troubled look came over Lonnie’s face and she placed the plate on her lap. Catra looked at her with an expectant look on her face, mouth open.

“Catra, I didn’t just come here to bring you cake. I had something I wanted to say.” Lonnie said, almost apologetically.

Catra popped her mouth closed and said nothing, letting the other woman talk.

“I was so angry at you for the way you treated us in the Horde, especially toward the end. We all grew up together, and even though we didn’t always see eye to eye, I still felt like we all had a connection and you and I were like sisters… or friends…” Lonnie said, starting to lose her train of thought.

“Lonnie, I’m so—” Catra started, but was interrupted by Lonnie.

“Please, let me continue.” Lonnie said, firmly yet kindly. “I was so angry, angry at you, and after the Trial, angry at the Horde. When you apologized to me that time, I was still processing all that anger, and didn’t take your words at face value. I wanted to hang on to that anger. I told myself you didn’t deserve my forgiveness. I have been hanging on to that all this time, even though you tried reaching out, leaving me those ‘presents’.” Catra smiled sheepishly but did not respond.

“When I heard that you were hurt last night, that you almost died, it suddenly hit me. I wasn’t really angry at you because of how

you treated us, it was because you distanced yourself even more than usual from us. I felt like we lost what connection we had, and I lost a friend, my sister…it made me angry at you. I wanted to come to say… I do forgive you Catra. I forgive you, and I want us to be sisters again, sisters that fight a lot, but still... sisters."

Catra smiled, and even though it pained her, placed her hand on Lonnie's. "I would like that Lonnie."

Both women smiled and let out a laugh, tears starting to fill their eyes.

"Anyway," Lonnie, said, cutting another piece of cake and holding it up, "Now that that's out of the way, more cake?"

Catra smiled and nodded like a small child. "Yes, please!" She exclaimed.

The two old Horde comrades, friends and sisters once again, sat there a while longer, one feeding cake to the other and reminisced about old times.

* * *

Adora, Glimmer, Castaspella, Micah, Swift Wind and Madame Razz were all in the guest bedroom, arguing about how to best approach this particular situation. Shen, still unconscious but fully dressed now, was firmly secured to the bed with chains around his torso and legs, plus a magical restriction spell in the form of a glowing disc over his chest. No one actually believed that it would do any good if the Demon-Heart came back.

"There is great magic in Mystacor. We could bring him there and bind him, using a cabal of ten sorcerers taking turns in rotation to hold him." Castaspella was saying.

"Then what, Cassy? We do that forever? Because from what Adora said, *he can't die*." Micah responded, exasperated.

“Yes! If that’s what we must do, then so be it! It would give the senior students something to do instead of partying!” Castaspella said, throwing her hands in the air.

“As long as someone doesn’t slip up then yes, that would work. But mistakes are always made, especially with people involved. Even more so with students. No, Cassy. It won’t work.” Micah said, placatingly.

“Then what do you suggest, oh wise brother?” Castaspella responded, scathingly.

“I’m loath to suggest this, I really am... but I remember when Shadow Weaver first fell under the sway of dark magic. She had opened a rift to the void to swallow up Norwyn, the Head Sorcerer at the time. I believe I could do the same if I have to. I could use dark magic to send this evil away from us.” Micah said, pain written on his face at the idea.

“NO!” Adora yelled. “No, you can’t do that! This evil is attached to a person, Shen, someone who at his heart is good, I felt it! He does not deserve that kind of fate!” Adora pleaded.

“Adora, you have to think of the greater good! You have to make a choice; keep this poor boy contained but with the risk of harming everyone if he turns into Demon-Heart and escapes, or send him to the void and keep everyone safe. Think of everyone in Bright Moon, Adora— Think of the people close to you; Glimmer, Bow…Catra.” Micah said, sorrowfully.

“That is completely unfair, Micah!” Adora, yelled back. “I will NOT be compelled to choose between the only two decisions YOU state are our only course of action! I choose the third option! There is always another way!”

Madame Razz, who was silent through all this, smiled at Adora.

Just then Shen began to stir, groaning. “Adora...? Is that you?” he asked weakly.

Adora, Glimmer and Razz moved to his side. Micah and Castaspella held back, looking at each other. They both remembered the power of the Demon-Heart, unable to be contained by their combined magics.

Adora moved to his side and placed her hand on his forehead.

"I'm here, Shen, I'm here." She said, smiling kindly down at him.

"I'm so sorry, Adora. The Other found a way out, I couldn't stop them." Shen said, whispering. "How is your love, uh, Catra?" he said, miserably.

Adora remembered that Shen said he always saw through the Demon-Heart's eyes when it took over. That meant that Shen knew what the Demon-Heart did and what had happened to Catra.

"She's fine, she's healing. Don't worry about that right now." Adora said gently.

"Adora, I hate myself *so much* right now. If I had killed one of your friends or your girlfriend last night—" Shen choked up, tears starting to fall through clenched eyes. "You were just trying to help me, you are so kind, you didn't deserve to face that." He whispered brokenly.

"Shen, we're working on a plan, a way to free you and rid us of the Demon-Heart. We were just talking about the different choices…" Adora said, her voice trailing off.

Shen looked up at her intensely. "Adora, make the safest choice. Make the choice that keeps everyone safe! If it means I'm worse off, so be it! I won't be responsible for more people getting hurt!" Shen declared.

Adora didn't respond. She stood up and looked away, tears falling from her eyes. Her jaw was clenched in an effort to stop the tears when she felt an old hand on hers.

"Adora, there *is* another way." Adora looked down to see Madame Razz looking up at her, her eyes magnified behind her glasses.

"Excuse me... Madame Razz, is it? What other way? Also, what kind of magic were you using out there last night to subdue the monster? I've never seen anything like it." Micah asked, confused as to why they would listen to a crazy old woman.

"Magic? What magic? What are you talking about, you silly boy?" Razz asked Micah, trying to swat him in the face with her broom.

"Adora? Are you really going to listen to this old woman over us? Castaspella and I are the premier sorcerers on Etheria." Micah cried, pointing at Madame Razz.

Glimmer, who had been mostly silent, spoke up. "Dad, Madame Razz has helped Adora in the past. Adora trusts her and we should too."

"Fine. I have other duties to attend to. Let me know if you need me to do as I suggested. Cassy, are you coming?" Micah threw his hands up in the air as the two older sorcerers left the room. Adora watched them leave with a heartbroken expression on her face, but Glimmer took her by the hand.

"Don't worry about them. Old people *always* think they know better. Also, the good thing about old people is that they forget easily. I'm sure they'll get over this." Glimmer said encouragingly to Adora.

They turned back to Razz, who was inspecting Shen and squinting as if listening to something.

"Oh, shut up, you!" Razz said, gently poking at Shen's scar with her broom handle. "Madame Razz has heard about enough of that! You are a nasty, horrible thing!"

Shen looked at Razz mystified, as were Adora, Glimmer and Swift Wind.

“Uh, Razz... remember we talked about talking to imaginary friends, like Loo-Kee? How you shouldn’t do it when other people are around?” Swift Wind said, looking at Glimmer and Adora with an apologetic look.

“Yes, and remember how I told you to shut up? Stupid talking horse!” Razz snapped.

Shen looked at Razz, realization on his face. “You can hear it, can’t you? You can hear the Other.” Shen stated, awe in his voice.

“Yes…yes, my poor, poor boy,” Razz said soothingly. “It is so horrible. You must be so strong not to have been completely lost to madness.”

“I’m not so sure about that…” Shen said, closing his eyes.

“No, no, you are not mad. Madame Razz can see it.” Razz said, then waved her hand over his eyes. “Sleep.” She said, gently. Shen immediately fell unconscious.

“So, Razz, you were talking about another way?” Adora said, steering the conversation back.

Madame Razz turned to her, intensity and focus in her eyes. “Yes, there is, Adora.” She stated.

Adora was taken aback by the sudden lucidity in Razz’s eyes; she had never seen this before.

“How, Razz?” she asked.

“Using my power in unison with She-Ra’s, you must enter Shen’s psyche and go to his very soul. There, you must sever his connection to the Other. You must use your heart to do this.” Razz said.

“My heart?” Adora said, confused. “Razz, can you please not be ambiguous? I need straight answers.”

“Yes, your heart, silly,” Razz said, using the end of her broom stick to poke Adora in the chest, alighting the heart rune there.

“This?” Adora said, even more confused. “The old ‘fail-safe’? Its power is gone... we used it to release the magic of Etheria.”

“No, no, silly girl. It is not just some ‘fail-safe’, it’s much more. There is old power, power the First Ones bound in this rune. Its uses are many but its prime ability— to break bonds— is still there. You can use it to break Shen’s bond to the demon within him. It is a dangerous task though, Adora, for by using the heart rune this way, you are risking being taken by the demon. Both you and Shen could be bound to it... forever.”

Adora let this sink in for a moment, Glimmer still holding her hand in support. She turned to look at Glimmer and smiled warmly; Glimmer returned the smile.

“I know what I have to do then, Razz,” Adora said simply.

“We must move the boy to my place deep in the Whispering Woods, where the magic is pure.” Madame Razz said, looking around. “The magic here is too stodgy and strict.” She said with disgust on her face.

“Okay, I have to go see someone first before I do this. I have to go see Catra. I promised her I would never run into something dangerous without letting her know, if I had the chance, that is.” Adora said.

“Fine, fine, take all night. Swift Wind and I will take the boy. It will take me a while to get the preparations in place.” Razz shrugged. “Meet me in the morning. It will be best to do this in the pure light of the day.”

Adora didn’t ask about the implications of Razz’s last statement. She was about to ask her if she needed help moving Shen when she watched Razz reach her hand out, magically removing the chains, banishing the magical ward and lifting him over and onto Swift Wind.

Adora and Glimmer walked out of the room together and back to the tower to see how Catra and Bow were faring. Since Catra was hurt badly and needed tending to, Bow volunteered to act as her "nurse-maid" for the time being.

Adora hoped that Catra hadn't killed him yet.

They were just coming up the steps and into the hallway their rooms shared when they heard yelling.

"Oh boy.... that's definitely Bow and Catra." Adora groaned.

As they got closer, they could make out words through the closed door.

"Why are you so mean to me?" Bow yelled. He sounded as if he was going to cry.

"*Because*, you're not doing it right! I said I wanted five pillows behind me AND to fluff them. You put *six* pillows behind me, with *no fluffing*!" Catra said, practically screeching.

"I put the sixth pillow behind you to make up for no fluffing! How can you notice the fluffing when you end up sitting against them anyway, pushing them all together?" Bow yelled back.

"BECAUSE I CAN!! Where are you going?" Catra said, still screeching.

"I need a break from you. You're too much, the worst patient ever!" Bow yelled as he opened the door. He saw Glimmer and Adora standing there and sighed.

"Oh, thank Etheria!" Bow exclaimed, just as a pillow smacked him on the side of the head.

Bow pushed them back out and slammed the door, to the chagrin of Catra yelling inside.

“Adora, I can’t do this anymore. She’s horrible! The worst! I’m sorry, but I quit!” Bow was practically squeaking in his anger.

“Bow, Bow, slow down, it’s okay. Catra is just having a hard time.” Adora said, trying to placate him.

“Hard time? Adora, all I have been doing all day is waiting on her, and what do I get? Hissing, growling and yelling!” Bow cried.

Glimmer pressed against Bow, hugging him. “Aww, did my poor baby get yelled at all day? I’m here now. I’ll save you from the nasty Catra.” Glimmer soothed.

“Bow, it will be okay. Catra loves you, I know she does.” Adora said, soothingly.

“Loves me?” he said, squeaking again as he held up his bandaged hand. “Loves me? She bit me! Hard! The last time she did that, she was in the Horde.”

Bow then gasped, eyes widening in fear.

“Horde Catra is back.” Bow whispered.

Adora and Glimmer looked at each other, rolling their eyes.

“There, there my poor baby,” Glimmer said, leading Bow back to their room, “Let momma take a look at it.”

Adora watched her friends walk away with a scrunched up look on her face. *Did Glimmer just refer to herself as Bow’s mom? They are so weird sometimes.* She thought to herself.

Adora walked into the room and ducked just in time to miss a pillow aimed at her head.

“Catra!” Adora yelled.

“Whoops! Hey, Adora, I thought you were my pillow fluffer.” Catra said apologetically.

Adora looked at Catra. She was a mess; her hair which was usually a little wild was in complete disarray over her head, her eyes had a glazed look to them and there appeared to be some kind of blue and purple stains on the front of her gown.

"Is that frosting?" Adora said, walking over and rubbing her finger on the stain and licking it. "Yep, it is."

Catra looked up at Adora, a big grin on her face. She also had a dazed look in her eyes due to the tonic she took for pain, which made her dizzy and kind of silly.

"I missed you so much!" she exclaimed.

Adora sat next to her and gently kissed Catra on her head, pushing some tangles out of the way.

"I missed you too. I heard you were very bad today though. You were mean to Bow. Did you bite him, Catra?" Adora said, a little scolding in her voice.

"Humph!" Catra exclaimed, pouting. "He deserved it! He kept messing with me when he was spoon-feeding me, trying to pretend the spoon was Swift Wind and that he was 'coming in for a landing'. Why would I want to pretend your stupid horse was going to land in my mouth?! I told him to stop, but he didn't, so I bit him." She shrugged, looking away.

Adora shook her head, a smile on her face. Melog, who lay at the foot of the bed, looked over at Catra and mewed to her in their language.

"Fine, fine, go. Sorry to have kept you." Catra said, exasperated.

As Melog walked away and out the door, Adora could have sworn the purple and blue alien gave her a look that said, *Good luck.*

"So, how did it go with the prisoner? Did you pound him good for me?" Catra asked.

“No, nothing like that Catra. That’s actually part of the reason I had to come by.” Adora said.

“Why do I have a bad feeling right now?” Catra asked, suspiciously.

Adora explained her conversation with the prisoner during the night in detail, while she was supposed to take a walk. Catra scowled at that part but remained silent. Adora continued with her search for Madame Razz and subsequent return to Bright Moon. Adora didn’t have to fill Catra in on the battle that ensued, for Catra was most familiar with that story. She ended her story with the discussion on how to best handle the situation, including Madame Razz’s plan to save Shen and banish the demon inside him.

“So, let me get this straight, you have two choices. One: Micah opens a portal and shoves the guy who tried to kill us into the void, thus keeping everyone from danger, or two: Adora trusts some crazy old lady who lives in the woods to help her enter the creep’s mind to fight with a demon. A demon who could end up taking you too. Do I have that right, Adora?” Catra said, a little menacingly.

“Catra, did you listen to what I said about Shen? What happened to him and what I felt? He’s the biggest victim in all this.” Adora implored.

“Ugh, here we go again. You go risk your life to save people while I have to sit back and hope you come back to me.” Catra said, her anger rising.

“Catra, I feel like it’s the only way. I have to help him. But I love you, and I promised I wouldn’t make decisions without you. If you don’t want me to go through with this tomorrow, I will find another way. Another way that does not involve sending Shen into the void, that is.” Adora said.

Catra looked away, out the window and growled. “Urrrrrrrhhhh… NO,” Catra sighed in great irritation.

“You’re okay with it then?” Adora asked.

“I’m not okay with it, but I won’t try stopping you, even if I was physically able to,” Catra said, sighing deeply. “I love you Adora and I love everything about you. Even your thick-headed need to be the hero. I love you and I know you need to do this; you wouldn’t have chosen to do it if it wasn’t the only way.” Catra said, with a small smile on her face.

Adora smiled and leaned in, kissing Catra on the lips.

“So, is that it? You got your permission and now you head off?” Catra said, annoyance back in her voice.

“Nope, I’m here for the night. We’re leaving in the morning. What would you like to do?” She said, sitting next to Catra.

Catra thought about it. “How about you read to me?” she asked tentatively.

Adora grinned. “Sure, what book would you like?”

Adora already knew the answer but loved drawing this out, Catra mumbled something back.

“Huh? What was that Catra?” she said, oozing with mischief.

Catra was blushing now. “Come on Adora, stop teasing me, read me the book about the little girl who lives with her horrible adoptive mother and finds out she is actually a princess.”

“Oooohh, I’ll read my wittle pwincess her little pwincess book!” Adora teased as she retrieved the book in question.

Catra, still blushing, grinned as Adora snuggled next to her and opened the book.

“There once was a little girl,” Adora began, “She was a good, kind girl who lived with a wicked and cruel parent…”

A Piece of My Heart

Chapter Summary

> Adora attempts to save Shen's soul by entering his psyche, reaching his soul and breaking the his connection to the Demon-Heart using the fail-safe heart rune.

It was early morning, just before sunrise. Adora stood in front of the mirror, putting her hair up. She was dressed in her usual outfit; dark gray pants, white undershirt and her blue and purple jacket over it. She looked in the mirror.

Okay, I'm ready as I'll ever be to go into someone's head and banish a demon. She thought to herself.

Adora suddenly remembered her dream from last night. It was another nightmare, which was becoming a regular occurrence. She was in a large, dark, chamber; looking in the center, she saw a throne on a raised dais. It was a dark throne and the armored figure from the other night was sitting on it, gazing down at her. A bright shaft of terrible light was shining down on him from above. He seemed to be bathing in it, gaining power.

He was wearing the same shadowed cowl as before, and as he turned his head, she saw the leering skull within. He started cruelly laughing at her, when she had woken up.

Adora shook the memory from her mind and tried to concentrate on the day ahead. The task that lay before her was too great to be bogged down by bad dreams.

Catra was still asleep behind her, propped up on five pillows and snoring. Adora did not want to wake her up to say goodbye... Saying goodbye would make it seem like there was a chance she couldn't come back, and she didn't want to think about that. Besides, they said their goodbyes last night.

Just as she was thinking that, a light knock could be heard at the door, eliciting a loud snore from Catra.

Adora opened it to see Glimmer.

"Shhh, don't wake the monster," Adora whispered to her friend.

Glimmer looked over at the snoring Catra, her hair still a mess.

"Ewww…is that your girlfriend?" Glimmer teased.

"Where's Bow? I need to leave soon?" Adora asked.

"Bow isn't coming. He said he wouldn't deal with 'Catra, Princess of Pillows' again. He's going with you while I watch sleeping beauty today." Glimmer whispered.

"Okay." Adora said, looking back at Catra. "Any chance you could clean her up a little today?" Adora asked.

"Adora, I'm not sponge-bathing your girlfriend. There are limits to what I will do." Glimmer said, still teasing with a smile.

"Okay, at least brush her hair and change her out of that filthy robe, please?" Adora pleaded, still whispering. Just then Catra elicited another loud snore. Glimmer made a face.

"We'll see." She said, then hugged Adora, kissing her on the cheek. "You ready? You better be careful today."

Adora returned the hug. "I am and I will. I'll be back, I promise." She whispered in her friend's ear.

Glimmer looked at Catra, then back at Adora with another grimace. “You better.”

Adora glanced at Catra, blew her a kiss and walked out the door. She walked down the hallway to see Bow waiting for her.

“Ready?” He asked.

“Yep, let’s do this.” Adora said, simply.

Suddenly, Bow’s pocket started beeping and he pulled out his data pad. Someone was trying to contact him.

“Let me guess... Entrapta?” Adora said.

Bow nodded. “Yeah... she’s been calling me since yesterday morning, but I was so busy with Catra, I didn’t answer. I guess she’s starting in again early.”

“Considering what we are doing this morning, I think it can wait longer,” Adora said. Bow turned the pad off and put it back in his pocket.

Adora and Bow exited the tower and strode out onto the grounds. The sun was peeking over the horizon, and it looked like it was going to be another beautiful day. They saw Swift Wind nearby, grazing on the grass while waiting for them.

“Hey, Adora! Are you ready?” Swift Wind asked, all enthusiasm.

“Yes, I think so,” Adora said, getting tired of being asked if she was ready. “So, I hear you’re Madame Razz’s horse now, is that true?” Adora asked, smirking.

“I’m nobody’s hors—” Swift Wind began to exclaim.

“Just teasing buddy, got ya!” Adora said, hopping on his back.

“Har, har.” Swift Wind said sarcastically as Bow hopped on behind Adora. As soon as Bow was on, he flew up into the sky, heading in

the direction of the Whispering Woods.

As they flew through the sky Adora marveled again at just how beautiful Etheria was. She saw the sun rising in the distance, and on the opposite darker horizon she could see dark clouds with fire lightning dancing within. Light and dark. As the sun got higher, the dark clouds in the distance shrunk, the fire lightning fading. *Light chasing the dark away, as it should be*, Adora thought, feeling confident now.

They soon arrived at their destination and landed near Madame Razz's cottage.

Adora, Bow and Swift Wind entered the cottage. Looking around, they saw blue candles placed everywhere, covering the inside with a warm blue glow. The candles covered every surface except for the center, where Shen lay on a large bed, unconscious. There was room for one more next to him. Madame Razz was there fussing about. She glanced at them, seeing that they were studying the candles.

"The wax is infused with Moon Aster petals, which are helpful to banish all kinds of darkness." She said.

Swift Wind was at the door still, hesitant to walk in and risk knocking over the candles. "Razz it's light outside, what dark are you talking about?" he asked.

Madame Razz turned her scornful gaze on the horse. "Shut up, please. Or Madame Razz will revoke your invitation to stay here."

Swift Wind backed up slightly but stayed in the door to watch, wisely deciding to be quiet.

Madame Razz looked at Adora and Bow, then looked around, as if searching for someone else. "Where is the other one, the sparkly one?" Razz asked.

"She's doing me a favor and watching our friend, who was hurt pretty bad." Bow answered.

Razz looked disappointed by this, while Bow and Adora shared a puzzled look. Then Razz just shrugged her shoulders. “Oh well, maybe later then,” Razz stated mysteriously.

She turned to Adora. “Are you ready, dearie?” She asked, not realizing that she was the fourth person to ask Adora today.

“Yes,” Adora responded, no hesitation in her voice.

“Good. Now, turn into She-Ra and lie down next to the boy. Madame Razz will use her power to connect the both of you, allowing you to enter his psyche. From there you will be on your own. You must make your way to his soul and break the bonds connecting him to the demon.” Razz instructed.

“Okay, that’s it? No detailed instructions on what to do, just enter his mind, find his soul and cut the binds with the heart rune on my chest?” Adora said, frustration clear in her voice.

“Adora, Adora... my silly Adora. You are doing it again. You’re afraid and asking old ladies what you should do. You have She-Ra, you will know. Madame Razz trusts your instincts, you should too!” Razz stated.

Bow came up to Adora and hugged her. “You’ve got this Adora. I will be right here by your side the whole time watching over you.” He said reassuringly.

Adora smiled back and raised her hand, speaking the words of summoning and transforming into She-Ra. Looking down at the bed, she saw the space next to Shen was just big enough for She-Ra to fit. She lay down next to him, placing her hands on her chest and closing her eyes.

Bow and Swift Wind watched as Madame Razz moved to stand behind them. Both of her hands were grasping the broom, which was held vertically before her, handle pointing up. Suddenly, her hands and forearms changed colour, her skin becoming blue and faceted, like a gem. The skin extending past her elbows remained the same, pink and wrinkled.

Her broom suddenly became much longer and straighter, with a bright light at the top, like a star. She opened her eyes; they were not the eyes of an old lady, they were the infinite reaches of the universe, swirling galaxies and nebulas. The connection was made.

* * *

* INSIDE A DARK MIND, CLOSE TO A BROKEN SOUL *

She-Ra/Adora falls for what seems like a long time; she falls in darkness until she starts to slow then lands softly on ground. She looks around, noticing it was dark, night? Looking up, she sees a familiar object, the dread orb of her dreams, gazing down on her. She looks around. As her eyes adjust, she sees a small black-haired boy, his arms held down by what appeared to be a black armored figure, its face covered by a masked helmet. The boy is crying for his mother. Looking in the direction of the boy's stare, she sees what appears to be a dwelling large enough for a family.

As she looks at the boy, she can feel his emotions; fear for his mother, a need to protect her, and anger— anger at the guards for holding him and anger at himself for being too small to help.

A massive figure comes out of the doorway, ducking his head down so he can fit through the door. He wears a sleeveless black robe, hood over his head, a wicked crown on top. He has armored shoulders extending in segments down his arms, ending in clawed gauntlets. The claws are absolutely covered in blood and gore. She recognizes this figure from her nightmares.

She looks at his face under the hood, she can see it clearly now, but instead of a skull, it is a man's face, huge and broad. It is a very cruel face; she sees no pity there. Gray hair cascades down to his chest. The massive sword is there as well, on his back.

The figure walks to the boy, who looks up at him, tears streaking his face. "Where is my mother?" the boy asks. She-Ra/Adora can feel his anger rising.

The figure gently touches the boy's face as if wiping a tear, spreading blood there. Then he cups the boy's chin. "Your mother is gone. I am your Father. I will raise you now, you are mine."

The boy screams.

She-Ra/Adora falls in darkness and lands on ground again. She is in a dark forest, the dread orb shining down, bright. Next to her stands a black-haired adolescent boy; it is Shen, she now realizes, even though he is younger. He is holding a long shaft against his shoulder. She realizes it must be some kind of weapon, a blaster or gun.

Shen is pointing the end of the gun at an animal in the distance; it was completely unaware of its current situation. It is a strange, beautiful creature, with long limbs, coarse shaggy fur and a bushy tail. It is a silvery color and seems to glow in the light of the orb above. It turns its head to the young man, showing long snout with two canines protruding and two big pointed ears held up at attention. It turns its bright, silvery eyes on Shen, studying him.

She can feel Shen's emotions again; a need for approval mixed with the awe of seeing such a majestic creature, and confusion as to why he must end its life.

The creature studies Shen, not running away. It seems to almost trust him, as if knowing Shen would not harm it.

She-Ra/Adora then feels another emotion from Shen, a decision based on the need to protect, not destroy. He lowers the gun and smiles at the creature, which cocks its head in return and runs away.

"SHEN'THRAN-ZANMAR'ETH!!!!" A loud, terrible voice booms from the darkness behind. Shen winces and drops the gun.

She-Ra/Adora falls and lands softly again, the fall even shorter now.

She sees Shen again, the same age as her previous vision. He is sitting at the top of a large hill overlooking an incredible vista. In the light of the dread orb she can see the hill is bare except for short, straw-colored grass. In the distance there are rolling hills, a large forest, and past that, jagged dark mountains. Even though the light from the dread orb is unpleasant, there is something truly beautiful in the view, the light giving the landscape an ethereal, dream-like quality.

She-Ra/Adora feels conflict within Shen; his father had just told him the dark truth of life and the concept was just too unacceptable for him to face. It blankets him in oppression, for to the young man, his father's words were absolute and true.

Shen holds a knife in his hands, and slowly turns it toward his heart, ready to plunge it in. Absolute conviction is on his young face.

"No!" She-Ra/Adora tries to scream, reaching to him, but she is unable to emit sound or move.

He holds it there for a moment, then his hands began to shake. Suddenly, he pulls the knife away and stands up. He screams as he throws the knife into the distance.

He stands there, clenching his fists, gazing into the distance. She-Ra/Adora can see tears streaking down his face, but there is absolute firm resolve there.

"NO." Shen declared.

She-Ra/Adora experienced the falling sensation again, followed by another vision. Shen with a beautiful man; he had light blue skin, long white hair and pointed ears. This must be Shen'Dara that Shen had spoken of. They are gently kissing full of passion. Adora feels pure happiness and love emanating from Shen.

Falling, another vision. Shen and Shen'Dara are with a group of others, allies, fighting a group of mixed individuals; some fully encased in black armor, some in black robes and… others. The

others are horrible, shambling forth in a ragged array of clothes, their skin gray and pallid, faces empty of any expression. They look dead, but aren't.

Shen, and his friends fight these enemies, each one's fighting style complementing the group. Shen'Dara is a laughing, whirling-dervish with two swords as he cuts down foes. He is beautiful and savage at once, and She-Ra/Adora is suddenly reminded of Catra and how she fights.

At Shen'Dara's back is a figure all in black, hood over his head and face concealed. Over the black clothes, the figure wears a black armor chest piece, black armor shin guards and black armor wrist gauntlets. The figure has a black sword in one hand, cutting down foes and protecting Shen'Dara's blind side. From Catra's description of the night they were attacked, this must be Shen, his identity concealed from his father's men.

There were others; a large woman, she is burgundy-skinned, bald with horns, she has a large hammer which she uses to smite foes, booming with laughter every time she lands a blow.

A slender, scantily clad pink-skinned humanoid figure, neither female nor male, their face concealed in a white mask. They are gliding and sliding through the battle, slashing out at enemies with two double-bladed knives.

There is a tall, grim-faced man with short blond hair. She-Ra/Adora grimaces as she sees that his eyes appeared to be sutured closed, blind. He strides into the battle swinging a large chain, a razor blade on the end. He swings the chain around his body or whips it in a stabbing strike, his skill with the weapon confident, seemingly unaffected by his apparent blindness.

There is a small, female, child-like being, with wings folded at her back, darting about the enemy's feet. She appears to be throwing small objects on the ground, spikes protruding at all angles. Her enemies step on these and scream, jumping and holding their feet or falling on their backs where the small being waits for them with

a knife. The sharp objects do not seem to affect the shambling figures though, for they stride over these as if they feel no pain.

There are others too, Shen's friends, and she feels it now, his absolute love for all of them. He would die to protect them, to save them from hurt, to protect them from his father's dark empire.

She-Ra/Adora falls again, but instead of landing, she begins seeing images and visions, seemingly from Shen's point of view.

Waking, hearing shouts. His father's agents had found them! Running, running for the escape route. The enemies are too close, they will not all make it in time! Shen decides to stay behind and hold them off, Shen'Dara pleads for him not to do it. Finally, Shen'Dara acquiesces to Shen's desire and they mark their farewell with a kiss. Unbeknownst to either, this will be their final one.

Then, Shen fighting, Shen captured, Shen being brought before the dread figure. The dread figure is Shen's father, Shen'Aan-war, She-Ra/Adora finally realizes, putting the name to the person who haunted her dreams. Shen expects anger, rage but there was nothing in the Shen'Aan-war's face; he seems unconcerned.

"From this moment forth, you are no longer the Prince. You are no longer my son." The Shen'Aan-war says, then he turns to a robed figure, at the head of a small group of them. "You may take him for your…experiment. He should be perfect for what you need." He states dismissively.

Shen yells and he sees the robed figures moving toward him. She-Ra/Adora almost screams as well when she sees their faces under the hoods; expressionless, pallid skin, sutured eyes. They reach for Shen.

Then, a series of intense images filled with fear and pain; darkness, bindings, the pallid faces with sutured eyes, a knife, blood, reaching in, removing…then the Demon-Heart brought

forth. It is just as Shen said; a pulsing black heart with a small red light glowing from within. It is horrible and they were going to put it inside him; how is he alive?

Then, waking in a dark place, a terrible voice speaking to him. The Other. The explanation by the Other detailing their new and intimate relationship…No! How can this be? This is damnation!

She-Ra/Adora is starting to get confused now; she doesn't know if she is watching Shen, watching through Shen's eyes or if she *was* Shen. The visions continue.

The robed figures come for me, Death-Binders, that's what they are called. They take me down to the ritual chamber, bind me again, tell me I must kill the rebels. NO! My friends! I would DIE before I would do that. The Death-Binders laugh, perform their magic on me; I feel rage and pain, I have no choice, I change. They send me out, out into the black night.

I hunt; Shen'Shenji is first, I find him in his usual spot, the place where people gather to drink. People scream and run, he turns, chains in hand, to fight me. I ROAR! I lunge, I STRIKE, his chain's barb bites deep, but I do not hurt. I kill, I eat.

Next is Shen'Ono; she will be in the Spider Glade, her favorite spot to pick Venom Berries. THERE SHE IS, basket in hand! She sees me, SHE SCREAMS, she runs, opening her wings to fly away. I LEAP, catching her. She is MINE.

SHEN'BERIA is walking the street, WHISTLING as she walks back from her girlfriend's abode. SHE DOES NOT SEE ME above her on the roof. I SCREAM AS I LEAP DOWN ON HER! She is caught unaware, but SHE IS ALWAYS READY. She shakes me off. LIFTING THE HAMMER, SHE STRIKES ME DOWN. I am un-hurt; I AM THE DEMON-HEART, I take HER heart.

SHEN'EN-WA IS SLEEPING IN THEIR BED. THIS IS THE BEST TIME TO GET THEM FOR THEY ARE NORMALLY SO FAST! I

COVER THEIR MOUTH WITH MY HAND, THEIR EYES OPEN IN SHOCK. I HUSH THEM, BACK INTO SLEEP, INTO DARKNESS.

I HUNT THE OTHERS; ONE BY ONE, THEY FALL TO MY POWER! I CANNOT BE STOPPED FOR I AM THE DEMON-HEART!

TONIGHT IS THE NIGHT! THE LAST ONE, I WILL FIND HIM TONIGHT! I HUNT, THERE ARE MANY PLACES HE COULD BE. AH, A MEMORY, FROM THE OTHER, SHEN'THRAN-ZANMAR'ETH, I KNOW WHERE HE WILL BE! THE PLACE WHERE THEY FELL IN LOVE.

I GO THERE, I FIND HIM, HE TURNS…and…

"Shen'Thran-Zanmar'eth, is that you? My love…" Shen'Dara says, pure sadness in his voice. "When you disappeared, I lost all hope, I thought you were dead or imprisoned. Then I heard our friends were being killed off, one by one. I thought your father had tortured their locations out of you, that you were still alive. Only when I talked to the few witnesses left alive from the attacks and heard their descriptions did I begin to suspect it was much worse. What did your horrible father do to you?"

Shen sees Shen'Dara through the eyes of the Demon-Heart, unable to stop what is happening. He tries to speak through its mouth.

"Shh…dara…runnn!" he manages through needle teeth.

"No, no, I will not leave you like this. There is another way, remember the Shea'Har-the, it can heal you, I know it!"

"Noooo…it…too…late!" Shen pleaded.

"I will subdue this form you have been forced to take and save you, trust me!" Shen'Dara pleads.

Shen can longer answer, and the DEMON-HEART charges forward. Shen'Dara FIGHTS THE HARDEST Shen had ever seen, HE

FIGHTS TO SAVE Shen. It is no use though, THE DEMON-HEART IS TOO POWERFUL.

I GRAB THE SWORD IN MY CLAW, BREAKING IT IN TWO. THE PEST STRIKES ME WITH THE OTHER, I BITE IT APART! I BACK-HAND THE FOOL INTO THE WALL. HE TRIES TO RISE, I PUT MY HANDS ON HIS THROAT, HE SAYS SOMETHING ABOUT LOVE. PITIFUL!! I HATE LOVE! I DECIDE TO MAKE THIS SLOW SO THE OTHER CAN WATCH, WATCH HIS LOVE DIE!

The vision vanishes and She-Ra/Adora feels herself falling again, the residual hate she felt though the Demon-Heart fading away.

She is surrounded by pure darkness as she starts to fall slower, slower, then lands slowly on soft ground. She-Ra/Adora rises to her feet; looking down, she sees her own body as She-Ra. Her She-Ra form is glowing softly, pushing back some of the dark. She hears a voice calling out.

“Shen?!” she yells. “Shen, is that you? Let me know where you are!”

“Adora...I’m here.” Is the reply, in the dark.

“I’m coming!” She-Ra/Adora yells, running in the direction of Shen’s voice.

She runs until she sees a figure ahead; it is Shen, wearing just pants. His back is to her, his tattoos are glowing brightly. She-Ra/Adora comes near him but suddenly stops, unsure about finding Shen now for some reason.

“Shen?” She asks hesitantly.

“Adora, I’m so glad you found me,” Shen says, back still turned. “You saw that last vision, didn’t you? The one where the Dem… where I killed Shen’Dara?”

“Yes, yes Shen, it was horrible. I’m so sorry.” She-Ra/Adora says, pain in her voice.

“Yes…yes? It was?” Shen says, now a question. Shen sounds very strange now, not like the person Adora connected with the other night. He sounds colder, more alien.

“Shen... what is wrong with you?” She asks, confused.

“Ah, yes. I have watched that memory time and time again in my mind. Over and over again, it gave me great grief and pain, pain so bad I wanted it to swallow me up and to die. This time, though, I let the Demon-Heart take complete control. Do you know what I felt?” Shen asks.

She-Ra/Adora didn’t respond, and Shen turns around. She-Ra/Adora is horrified.

Shen’s face is a mixture of the Demon-Heart and Shen. Red glowing hateful eyes with red slit pupils, a mouth open in an evil smile, revealing needle teeth. The teeth are red and covered in blood.

“I felt RELEASE!” he says, in pure rapture. “It felt so good to give in to the hate, the anger. Ohhhhhh…”

She-Ra/Adora begins to hear other sounds in the dark. She has heard them before in her nightmares, strange shrieks and cries, horrible sounding.

Shen cocks his head, then turns as if looking for the sound. His face is in profile; he raises his head, closes his eyes and opens his mouth in a sigh. As this happens, a light begins to rise in the distance through the trees; it is the dread orb rising. They are in a dark forest now, like the dark version of the Whispering Woods in her nightmare. The cries became louder as the ghostly light rises, howling in their joy.

“Ahhhhh…soooo beautiful…can you hear them, Adora? My new friends, they call for me to join them!” Shen says, face still in profile, eyes closed.

“So, what.... you’re a Demon now, Shen? Are you going to attack me?” She-Ra/Adora asks, raising her sword.

“No, no, never, Adora! I am partly giving in to the Demon-Heart for you! For you and your friends.” As Shen says this, she can almost hear Shen’s old self without the coldness.

“How does that work, Shen?” She-Ra/Adora asks, incredulous.

“The Demon-Heart knows your plans to banish them from me. They told me if I give in to them, we will just go back to the corpse-pools, but not as Shen and the Other- as ONE, the Demon-Heart. They said it was the easiest way, that if you tried to separate them from me, they would take you. I couldn’t let that happen!” Shen cries.

Some of the more demonic aspects of his features seem to subside and the old Shen reappears. He is still in there— the Demon-Heart has not taken him fully yet. Then his features change back, and he turns, looking back at the dread orb.

“Ahhhhh…they *were* right, the Set’Heth-un’dar is so *very* beautiful!” Shen exclaims.

She-Ra/Adora looks down and touches her chest, the heart rune appearing there. She thinks about Shen, who he is, what she saw in the visions. How Shen would die for his friends, the people he loved, to fight with all his heart to protect them. She remembers their connection the other night during their discussion. A connection between friends; she feels that she is Shen’s friend and she knows he feels she is his as well. She strokes the heart rune, then a feeling comes over her. It is deeper than instinct, deep as her soul.

She-Ra/Adora strides toward Shen, grabbing his shoulder and turns him around. With her other hand she somehow grasps the heart rune on her chest and pulls; it flashes, and an identical heart rune appears in her hand. She slams the identical heart

rune into Shen's chest with a blinding flash of light. Shen doubles over.

Shen rises back up, his face completely back to normal. He looks down at the heart rune on his chest, horror spreading across his face.

"Adora, no! Why? It can take you too now!" Shen screams, pure agony in his voice.

"I guess you have to fight it now, Shen!" She yells back into his face.

Shen looks back at She-Ra/Adora, resolve replacing the horror on his face. He grits his teeth and closes his eyes.

"NOOOO!!! YOU WILL NOT TAKE HER!" he screams.

Suddenly, red eyes appear all around them, screams of rage echoing. The eyes start rushing toward them and black demonic forms appear as they get closer, She-Ra/Adora holds her sword up to defend herself and Shen. As they run toward her, she slashes at them, but they simply pass by, doing her no harm. They are going for Shen, clutching him, holding him, imploring him, tearing at him. Shen is bent over, hands forming fists, he is covered in the black demons.

Shen screams in agony.

There is an explosion of pure white light... and then, nothing.

* * *

Adora woke with a start, sitting up and clutching her chest, the heart rune appearing. She was just Adora now, having reverted while unconscious. She looked down at Shen and was amazed at what she saw.

He lay there, just as she remembered, tattoos and all, with the painfully red scar in the center of his chest. Then, slowly, a heart

rune like hers appeared over the scar; it flashed brightly. Suddenly, the silvery tattoos turned black, then into a fine ash which blew away and vanished. The heart rune grew even brighter, and as it did, the scar seemed to dissipate, until it was just a thin line. Then, the heart rune dimmed and flashed out. Adora reached out and touched Shen's chest and the heart rune appeared, just like hers would when touched. She smiled.

Suddenly, someone hugged her from the other side. "Ooooohhhhh, thank Etheria you're alright!" Bow exclaimed.

Adora returned the embrace and heard a whinny behind her. Swift Wind had entered the cottage in his excitement, but Madame Razz was trying to push him back.

"No, no, silly horse! You will knock the candles over and burn down Madame Razz's shack!" Razz yelled.

Adora heard a groan next to her and turned to see Shen sitting up. He touched his chest and gazed at the rune there.

"Hey, Shen, how do you feel?" Adora asked, putting her hand on his shoulder.

Shen looked up at her with the most genuine look of joy Adora had ever seen. He leapt toward her, drawing her in an embrace. She could feel tears on her neck.

"I can't believe it, you did it! You saved me!" he said, disbelief in his voice.

"Of course, Shen, that's what I do," Adora said, hugging him back, her eyes wet.

"Adora, I'm yours! I'm your man forever!" Shen said, continuing to hug Adora.

Adora suddenly became very aware she was hugging a half-naked man in a bed and awkwardly disentangled herself from him.

“Okay…okay…Shen,” Adora said with an uncomfortable chuckle. “That’s great but you have to know... I’m already taken... I have a girlfriend.” She stuttered.

Shen laughed loudly. “That’s not what I meant, Adora. I meant I will always be there for you, whatever you need me for, you friend forever. Always.” Adora smiled, touched by the sentiment.

Madame Razz came around the bed and gazed at Shen, a warm smile on her face.

“How does it feel, my boy?” she asked.

Shen looked down at his chest again. “Is the Demon-Heart gone? What has taken its place if I’m still alive?”

“The demon is gone, but the heart remains. It is your heart now.” Razz said simply.

Shen kept touching his chest, the absolute joy and happiness on his face making everyone smile.

Suddenly he looked confused. “Wait, how am I talking to you all? I got that power from the Other. With the Other gone, I should be speaking my own language.... wait—” Shen, paused and started speaking in that strange hissing language.

“I can still speak She-Thar too.” He said, amazed. He looked at Razz who shrugged in response.

“Magic, silly boy.” She said, as if it was the answer to everything.

Maybe it was.

Star Stone

Chapter Summary

After their ordeal, Adora, Bow and Shen return to Bright Moon.

Glimmer visits Razz and begins her new journey.

Adora sits down with Shen, time for answers.

It was late morning. Adora, Bow and Shen were on their way back to Bright Moon, walking through the Whispering Woods from Madame Razz's shack. Adora was listening as Bow chatted away amicably to Shen; they talked about the various trees and animals they encountered. Bow had grown up in the Whispering Woods with his two dads, so he was practically an expert of the flora and fauna there. Shen was silently listening to Bow and staring around in amazement, as if he was a child seeing the world for the first time.

Adora was smiling at them, but then frowned as she remembered what Madame Razz said to her before they left.

The old woman had brought Adora to the side as Bow introduced himself to Shen, Swift Wind yelling his introductions from the door. Shen was holding a mug of hot, light blue tea Madame Razz had given him.

"We did it, Razz! We banished the demon and healed Shen!" Adora had said to the old woman, excitedly.

Razz smiled sadly at this but nodded. “Yes. Yes, we did, dearie. The demon is gone, but healed the boy? No. You must watch out for him during this stage, Adora. You saw what he went through. Keep an eye on him. His soul is bright but there is a dark spot there where the demon had resided. It will haunt him from time to time.”

Adora had remembered when she used his healing power on Shen, she could also see a dark spot on his soul, like a sunspot.

“Do you mean dangerous?” Adora had asked.

“Not to you and your friends, no. Only to himself, for he sees you as his friend and will go far beyond what is required to look out for you. Up until now, his body could not truly be harmed, and he will still feel invincible. That in combination with his altruism could make for a bad combination for his tenuous hold on this existence. Look out for him Adora, not just because all life is sacred. This boy will be very important to you in the future. Important to She-Ra.”

Adora looks questioningly at Razz. “What does that me—” She trailed off as Madame Razz gave her a hard look.

“Fine, fine,” Adora said, rolling her eyes in exasperation.

Razz swatted lightly at Adora. “Don’t you roll your eyes at Madame Razz! Anyway, Madame Razz wants to ask you something else. Your pretty, sparkly friend, Glimmer? Tell her to come see Madame Razz, alone.”

“Glimmer? Why?” Adora asked.

“Don’t you mind, Adora. You have to share Madame Razz, you can’t keep her all for yourself!” Razz snapped.

“Ugghh…I just want to know what to tell Glimmer. She is going to want to know why you want her to come all the way from Bright Moon to the Whispering Woods alone to visit you.” Adora said, exasperated.

“Just tell her Madame Razz wants to show her something. Something that can help her in her journeys among the stars.” Razz answered mysteriously.

Adora didn’t even bother asking what that last statement meant, she was tired from the morning’s ordeal and just wanted to see Catra.

Before they left, Razz had given Shen a light, waist-length, black jacket to wear. Adora could not identify what it was made of; the material was glossy, like bird feathers, and the material seemed very tough. It was collarless and had five silver buttons that ran up the front. The jacket suited Shen and he was very pleased with the gift; he put it on but did not button it up. Unfortunately, Razz didn’t have any footwear to give him and Shen left barefoot, but he didn’t seem to mind at all.

Adora shook herself from her memories as they neared the edge of the Whispering Woods; Bright Moon was in the distance.

“We’re here! Your new home, buddy!” Bow said enthusiastically, elbowing Shen lightly.

“Really?” Shen asked, in complete awe. “You’re going to let me live here? After everything I did?”

“Of course! I mean, we let Catra live here and she was way worse than you!” Bow exclaimed.

“Bow, leave my girlfriend out of this,” Adora said, a false warning in her voice. “Yes, Shen, you are going to stay here with us— if you want that is. What you did was out of your control. I... we don’t hold you responsible for it.”

“Well…we might have to explain the situation to a few people. Like Micah, Castaspella and the General. Oh, and Catra. It’s a good thing she is stuck in bed right now. Hoo-wee!” Bow exclaimed.

“Yes, we have met,” Shen said with a small smile, suddenly reaching up to his face where the bruises were still fading.

“Don’t worry about all that Shen. We are going to find you a room, something to eat, and let you rest. Later, I want to get together and talk. I want to ask you about these nightmares I’ve been having. I feel like you might have some answers.” Adora said.

“Of course, Adora, anything,” Shen replied.

They made their way over the bridge crossing the small bay and up the stairs and paths to the white towers. The whole time, Shen would stare at the Moonstone whenever it came into view. He seemed to be bathing in its light, like a plant seeing the sun again after a long period of darkness.

Finally, they made it to their tower, and upon entering the hallway, once again heard yelling from Adora and Catra’s room.

“The guards must be so sick of this,” Adora grumbled.

“Ohhh...I hope Glimmer is okay.” Bow said, worry on his face.

His fears were unfounded, for as they got closer, they could slowly hear the yelling from within.

“Heeeeellppp!!! Help me! Someone heeeeeeellllpp!”

It was Catra.

Adora turned to the guards standing watch at the end of the hall; they didn’t make a move.

“Hold still, you big baby!” Glimmer cried, a laugh in her voice.

A high-pitched scream could be heard. “Stop, please stop. I want Punchy back!” Catra yelled.

Adora looked at Bow. "Maybe you should just take Shen and try to see if you could find a spare room, preferably in this hall. I want him close if I need anything."

What she really meant was she wanted him close so she could keep an eye on him, remembering Razz's words. She didn't want to say this in front of him, of course.

Bow looked at the door. "Yeah, sounds like Glimmer has things under control. Also, I heard Catra say she wanted me back as a nursemaid? That's not gonna happen. Come on buddy, let's see about a room for you. Oh, and hey, like your style. I'm just a bare torso guy but the bare chest and torso thing is cool too."

Adora entered the room and immediately burst out laughing. It looked like Glimmer did indeed clean Catra up.

Somehow, Glimmer had found a clean robe which was bright pink, and managed to get it on Catra, without being sliced to ribbons. And speaking of ribbons…

Glimmer was in the process of brushing Catra's hair and putting ribbons in it. Ribbons of every color of the rainbow. It looked like Glimmer was almost finished. Catra had the biggest frown on her face, a frown so deep Adora didn't think Catra's face would ever go back to normal. Then Catra saw Adora and the frown vanished.

"Adora! Thank you, thank you, you came back! Please get her out of here!" Catra begged.

"Don't move, Catra, I'm *almost* done!" Glimmer beamed.

Adora walked to the edge of the bed and stood there, admiring Glimmer's handiwork.

"Wow, what did you do to the monster? She looks so beautiful!" Adora teased.

"Oh, you know, Catra has been long overdue for a make-over, and I added my own special brand of sparkly magic to her

appearance." Glimmer had finished and had stepped back to admire her work. "She still looks very frumpy though."

Catra growled.

As Adora got closer, she noticed something else in Catra's hair. "Wait, did you put sparkles in her hair?"

Glimmer put her hands together next to her face and beamed. "Oh, that's not all. When I was brushing out all the tangles, I added a few drops of my best perfume! She looks AND smells pretty now."

"Stop talking about me like I'm not here," Catra growled.

Adora laughed and leaned down, kissing Catra on the forehead.

"Soooo…what happened? Tell me everything. Also, where's Bow?" Glimmer said.

Adora told them what transpired this morning with the ritual and entering Shen's consciousness. She covered the basics of that experience, not really going into detail of what she witnessed in Shen's psyche, much of it being too personal. She continued with how she created an identical heart rune and placed it on Shen's chest, banishing the demon. How Shen's tattoos vanished, the scar receded, and that he now has a heart rune of his own, much like Adora. She finished with coming back to Bright Moon and how Bow went to find Shen a place to stay.

"So, let me get this straight, Adora. I give you permission to go do something dangerous and you basically end up giving your heart to some random guy?" Catra accused.

"Catra…" Adora started.

"Ha, got ya!" Catra said with a wicked grin. "Had to get you back for making fun of me. Sounds like you did an incredibly brave thing. Stupid, but brave; your usual style."

Adora beamed down at her.

“I should be going.” Glimmer said, then leaning toward Catra, pointing at her hair. “Oh, and *that* was for Bow.”

Catra leered back.

“Wait, Glimmer,” Adora said, catching her. “There is something else.”

Glimmer stood and looked at Adora, curious. “Yes?”

“Madame Razz wanted me to ask you if you could visit her, at her place in the Whispering Woods. She has something to tell you.”

Glimmer’s curiosity increased; up until now, Madame Razz has only been interested in Adora.

“Please don’t ask me what it’s about, she won’t tell me, but knowing her and what we have seen her do, it must be important.” Adora continued.

Glimmer nodded. “Yeah, I’ll go see her after I catch up with Bow and get the new guy situated.”

Adora and Catra watched Glimmer go, then Adora sat next to Catra and smiled.

“Oh, Catra, you poor thing.” Adora chuckled, starting to undo the ribbons. “When are you going to learn to be nice? I think you might have gotten what you deserved.”

“I am nice now! Did I tell you Lonnie and I made up yesterday?” Catra said, brightly.

“Wow, that only took a year... but yeah, that’s good. Lonnie is a good person and she is like our sister, I’m proud of you.” Adora said, pulling out more ribbons.

"So... I guess you expect me to be nice to this new guy, Shen, hmm?" Catra asked.

"Yes, Catra, you have to be nice. I'm not going into detail of what I saw him go through when I was in his head, but I can assure you, it makes what we went through in the Fright Zone seem like fun times. He is a good person and we are going to need his help." Adora explained.

Catra didn't look happy. "I owe him one for putting me in this bed. Can't I bite him, just a little?"

* * *

Glimmer teleported outside of Madame Razz's cottage, unsure about what she was getting herself into. It was mid-afternoon by the time she got there. Dealing with Bow and Shen's room situation had taken a while. Adora said she wanted him close, so Glimmer had to do some finagling, moving a high-ranking guard officer to another tower so Shen could have a room right down the hall. Being the Queen had its perks.

She was still a little unsure about Shen. He seemed like a nice person and all, but she kept remembering the darkness and pain in him when she interrogated him. She also remembered the fact that he turned into a monster, a monster capable of catching her and making her glitch. A monster that threatened to eat her.

Adora said he had good in him, and I trust her. She also said we should trust Catra, and that worked out in the end. Catra has her rough edges, but she is now one of my best friends. Maybe after a while, this Shen guy will turn out great. she thought to herself.

Glimmer pushed thoughts of Shen out of her head as she entered Madame Razz's cottage.

"Hello? Madame Razz? Anyone here?" She called.

There was no response.

"Okay, I guess she's out with Swift Wind. I'll just wait here." She said to herself, a little nervously.

Glimmer started looking around, taking in the strange old woman's abode. The bed and candles Adora mentioned were gone. It was a pretty bare-bones place; stone floor and walls, a large stove in the corner. Some vase-like pots sat on stone protrusions in the wall. There was an odd assortment of other junk, including what looked like a monster skull with five eye sockets.

"Ewww!" Glimmer exclaimed upon seeing it.

There were quite a few objects she recognized, such as First One's ration boxes, which, after looking into them, appeared mostly to be sugar.

"At her age she should be laying off the sugar." Glimmer commented to herself.

Looking up, she saw an orange bottle with a stopper and next to it, a keepsake box high above her.

Now, Glimmer was a lot of things; great friend, excellent girlfriend to Bow, stubborn yet fair Queen, but there was another thing she excelled at.... and that was being nosy.

Hmmm…can't hurt to take a peek. She thought to herself.

Teleporting up on a stone ledge near the box, Glimmer lifted it up and teleported down. She sat on a lower stone ledge and placed the box on her lap. She opened the box, but there was nothing inside.

"Humph. Boring!" She exclaimed.

She slammed the box closed and was about to teleport it back up to the shelf when she felt the box seize her. She sat, frozen in place on the stone ledge, blank-eyed.

Glimmer started having a vision.

* * *

She is standing on a large, green plain, a river snaking through it, she can see sharp, craggy mountains in the distance. There is something to this place. It has the feel of Etheria— old, mysterious and magical. It is also beautiful like Etheria; where Etheria's beauty is radiant and bright, this beauty is harsher and rawer.

In the middle of the plain is a tiered city sitting on top of a large rock, the rock protruded up from the grassy plain. The city is composed of small buildings and huge towers. At the summit of the city stands a large domed building. The city is of a mostly uniform color, dark and light pinks.

Her attention is drawn to two figures standing nearby, a short-statured old woman holding a broom and a taller, younger woman.

She immediately recognizes the short old woman as Madame Razz, as she looks the same as she did the last time Glimmer had seen her. The other woman though... she has never seen her before.

She is twice the size as Razz, maybe as tall as Adora, and just as blond and beautiful. But where Adora's beautiful face expresses kindness and compassion, this woman's face exhibits arrogance and a hint of cruelty. Her hair is short and slicked back. She is wearing all black, a black jacket that shimmers like bird feathers with five silver buttons running up to a short collar. She wears tight black pants made of the same material.

Wait...isn't that Shen's jacket? Glimmer thinks.

Under the jacket she wears nothing, it is open just enough to expose a hint of cleavage, creating a very seductive appearance. On her feet, she wears slim, black, leather high-heeled boots, the tops running up to her knees. In her hand she holds an all-white

staff, the top ending in a yellow, warm light. The light is the only thing appealing about the woman to Glimmer.

The two women stand together gazing at the city; they seem to be arguing.

"Why have you come to Eternos, Razz? Why do you bother me? I have much work to complete back in the city, work you are keeping me from." the taller woman says to Razz.

"It is about this work that I have come to speak to you, Zzar. Using the power of life, the power you were tasked to protect, to empower its opposite is not right. I worry for you, my sister." Razz responds. She is not speaking in her usual third person and there is fear in her voice.

"Ha! Go back to your meddling on Etheria, Razz. That's where you belong. There is a war going on, a war we're losing. I am working on finding a way to beat our enemy, and if I have to twist my powers to accomplish it, so be it!" The taller woman, Zzar, declares with pure condescension in her voice.

"Our duty is not to get involved! We guide, we don't steer the course! You are too intimately involved; you are too involved with HIM!" Razz accuses.

"Ah, yes, there it is. Maybe if you took a more appealing form like me, you could get a better hold on those you 'guide'. Believe me, it's *much* easier." Zzar smirks knowingly.

Razz shakes her head in disgust. "I didn't want to do this, but the others tasked me with this job. I have been allowed to leave Etheria to complete it. I am to bring you back."

"Try it and you will pay. You will see how much progress I have made in my work, *firsthand*!" Zarr threatens.

Razz doesn't listen to the threat, and with a speed that belies her appearance, leaps forward and grabs Zzar by her jacket sleeve. Razz quickly raises her other hand, her forearm changing to blue,

faceted skin, the broom transforming into a slender, star topped, black staff. Beams of rainbow light shoot down from the sky to the top of the staff, and the light grows.

Before Razz can do anything more, Zzar screams, slamming her own staff down. The top of her staff flashes with dreadful light. Zzar disappears, leaving the black jacket in Razz's hands. A disembodied voice booms down from the sky.

"Razz, my sister, that was foolish. Leave now, I will let you. But know that your plans are known to me now. I will not come with you. Return, and I will destroy you." Zzar says coldly, from above and all around.

Razz, still holding the jacket with a disappointed look on her face, slams her own staff down, disappearing.

* * *

The vision faded and Glimmer suddenly came back into herself. As she focused, she realized she was staring into two large, bespectacled eyes. Glimmer screamed and dropped the keepsake box, which hit the floor with a loud clatter.

It was Madame Razz, staring at her with a look of pure anger, a look she did not think the old woman was capable of.

"Boy, you're in trouble." Swift Wind commented from the doorway.

Madame Razz looked away from Glimmer to the box, and she held out her hand and lifted it, with magic, to its original resting place.

"I..I..I'm s— so sorry Madame Razz!" Glimmer cried, fearful of the look in the old woman's eyes.

Madame Razz turned back to Glimmer and the anger vanished. She chuckled and patted Glimmer on the hand.

"Ah, you young people, always going places you're not supposed to. Madame Razz should know better than to leave her things

lying around, especially if she doesn't want people poking their noses into them."

"Wha…What was that I saw?" Glimmer asked, emboldened by Razz's kindness.

Razz gave her a hard look. "Don't push it dearie. *That story* is not for you."

Glimmer asked her no more on the subject, wisely deciding not to press her luck.

"Adora said you wanted to see me?" Glimmer asked tentatively.

"Yes, yes, Madame Razz does, young one," Razz said. "The other night, when Madame Razz used her power, what did you see?"

Glimmer looked thoughtful. "I saw you transform into something, I was not sure what—"

"Not that part, concentrate on the other…" Razz said, soothingly.

"You raised your broom, which then turned into staff, a sorcerer's staff, I think. There was a bright light at the top. It was like a star, only brighter. Like a star that was no longer far away, but near, with us."

Glimmer paused and Madame Razz nodded sagely, asking her to continue.

"There were beams of light that came down from the sky. I couldn't see exactly where they came from because it was raining. The beams collected on top of the staff and the light at the top grew brighter. Then you pointed the staff at the Demon-Heart, somehow binding it using ribbons of starlight and transforming it back in Shen."

"Yes, yes. Did you feel anything, when you witnessed this power, this magic?" Razz asked, hopeful.

Glimmer concentrated on the memory; her brow furrowed. “Yes, kind of. The magic was... familiar. Like my connection with the Moonstone, only *bigger* somehow.”

“As Madame Razz suspected,” Razz said, joy in her voice.

“What was it? It wasn’t like the power I gained from the Moonstone. Was it…was it some kind of Star Magic?” Glimmer asked.

Madame Razz smiled broadly. “Very close. It is the power of the universe, but yes, the Stars are a big part of it, for Stars are the source of life in the universe. Their light and energy warms everything around them, banishing the dark, the cold.”

Madame Razz suddenly held her broom upright, handle up, and Glimmer once again saw her forearm and hand transform, the broom becoming the staff with the Star at its top.

“This is the source of many of Madame Razz’s powers. It is also her ward, it is the Starstone.” She said, gesturing to the bright, glimmering light at the top. It pulsed with greater light when Madame Razz named it.

Glimmer looked at the light in awe. “Starstone... So are you a Princess like me?” She asked.

Madame Razz laughed, loud and bright. “Ha! when you put it like that, perhaps? A very old wrinkly Princess though.” She grinned.

Glimmer laughed with her, feeling much more comfortable with the strange old woman.

“So, what does this have to do with me?” Glimmer asked, already suspecting the answer.

“Oh, come now dearie, don’t be obtuse with Madame Razz!” Razz said playfully. “You can use this power too when you are far from Etheria, far from the Moonstone. I, Madame Razz, will help you.”

“How? I am an Etherian Princess, my power comes from the Moonstone. I know nothing about Universe or Star magic.” Glimmer said, plaintively.

“Yes, the power of the Moon... but where does that power come from? You have gained the Moon power, now look further, to the Stars.” Razz said, gazing deep into Glimmer’s eyes.

Glimmer thought on this, mulling the idea over in her head. The more she thought about it, the more appealing the idea seemed. *Learn more magic? Yes, please.* She thought.

“Okay, I am up for the challenge. Please teach me this magic, Madame Razz. Teach me to use the power of the Stars and Universe.” Glimmer asked confidently.

Madame Razz smiled. “Good, you’ve taken your first steps into a much larger world. Here, take Madame Razz’s staff.”

Razz handed the staff over to Glimmer who took it hesitantly, for she was afraid it would change back. It didn’t, it stayed the same — a long staff with the Star top; the Star flashed when she grasped it, as if a connection was made.

Holding the staff, Glimmer looked at Razz. “Okay, show me what to do.”

* * *

Adora and Bow strode down the hall, on their way to meet up with Shen in his new room. Now that Shen had time to settle down and collect himself and Adora had handled “her situation”, Adora was ready to talk. She was hoping Shen could shed some light on some of the mysteries that were surrounding her, and perhaps she could help him as well.

Adora had spent the rest of the day tending to Catra’s needs, giving everyone a break from dealing with her. Catra was a lot more pleasant with Adora and easier to manage, taking her sponge bath with limited growling and not biting when spoon-fed.

Adora had tucked her in after lunch and had given the "special tonic" which made Catra a little silly, and thankfully, sleepy. She left Catra there, snoring away, but left the door cracked in case she woke and called for her. Adora would be just down the hall.

Bow and Adora knocked on the door, which was already partly open, and Shen called for them to enter. He was sitting at a small table, with two chairs, ready for them.

He was wearing dark gray pants and the black jacket Razz had given him, but he also wore a white collared shirt under the jacket and a pair of black leather ankle high boots on his feet. His long black hair was tied back in a loose ponytail. He looked relaxed, happy.

"Hello, friends. Come in," he stated simply.

"Awww, you got rid of the bare chest and torso look." Bow said, sadly. "I thought we were going to be bare torso buddies." Bow sighed.

Shen looked down and laughed. "No, my friend, that's not my style. Besides, if the two of us started running around like that, there would be a riot of admirers. No, your gorgeous torso is too much for Bright Moon alone."

Adora stifled a giggle and saw Bow blush the brightest she had ever seen.

"Uh, wow, thanks buddy." Bow stammered.

Then Adora saw it, a glimmer in Shen's eye, it was mischief. He was messing with poor Bow.

Wow, he is coming around fast, Adora thought to herself. *I thought it would be a while before he began to shine its way back through his horrible experiences. He is pretty resilient.*

Adora and Bow sat down across from Shen, Bow still blushing and smiling a little.

“Bow’s gorgeous torso aside, how are you settling in, Shen?” Adora asked.

Shen looked around at his room, it was spacious and bright, like all their rooms. A huge four-post bed sat in the middle, with a large vanity and mirror on one wall. The room was adorned with crystals, bell pull, tea nook, skylights and…

“I like it very much, but I have one question. The waterfall.... is it for bathing?” asked Shen.

“That’s what I thought when I first started living here!” Adora laughed.

“Sure man, you could use it like that, but I mean, there *is* a large bathtub right in the corner too.” Bow said helpfully.

Shen looked at it. “I see...No, I think I’ll use the waterfall. It looks faster.”

Adora saw Bow shrug and then she turned to Shen; she was ready to start.

“So, Shen, are you ready? I don’t really want this to be like an interrogation, so feel free to ask me anything. Just know that I have a *lot* of questions for you.” Adora said.

“No, it’s fine. My questions can wait. Go ahead.” He said pleasantly.

“Where are you from? I mean, I’m not sure anyone went over that with you. What planet are you from? You mentioned to Glimmer that it is very dark.” Adora began.

“My planet is call Shen’Dar-oom and when compared to Etheria, yes, it’s very dark.” he said simply.

Bow looked thoughtful. “I remember you said ‘Shen’ basically means ‘dark’, or ‘of dark’. What does the rest of the word mean?” He asked.

“Dar-Oom is day, so it’s basically called ‘dark-day’ or ‘Night’, a name it shares with that particular daily cycle.” Shen replied.

“Is your planet far from a star or something? Is that why it’s dark? Is it far from Etheria?” Bow continued, curious now.

Shen had a distant look on his face. “No, no star is near it. There are no stars anywhere, though I wish there were, for I see they are beautiful. There is nothing but the darkness and the Set’Heth-un’dar, for my planet does not reside in this universe. We reside someplace different entirely.”

“Like another dimension?” Adora asked.

Shen thought on this, his brow furrowed. “Not really sure about this word ‘dimension’, but if it fits the description I gave, then it must be so.”

Adora suddenly thought about what Entrapta said to her, how the planet Twilight was once a moon to a planet called Eternia and how it must have disappeared somewhere else. She suddenly felt a bone-chilling sensation in her body.

As if summoned by name or thought, Entrapta suddenly burst through the door.

“AH HA!” she yelled, running straight to Bow.

“Entrapta, how did you find me—” Bow started, then yelled as Entrapta lifted him bodily off his chair with one of her ponytails. With the other ponytail she rummaged through his pocket, looking for something.

“Hey! Watch it, you can’t touch me ther…ahhh!” Bow screamed. “I’m going to have to tell Glimmer about this!”

Entrapta found what she was looking for, his data pad, and placed Bow back down in his seat. She turned the data pad on then looked at Bow, confused.

“Bow, this device works! Why haven’t been responding to me?” She asked sadly.

“Entrapta, I wanted to, but we have been extremely busy here. Let me explain.” Bow said, filling in Entrapta on the past two days. Entrapta absorbed it all with her photographic memory.

“WOW! Fascinating! Did you get any samples of this ‘Demon-Heart’? Where is this Shen guy? Maybe I can get a sample from him.” She stated gleefully.

“No, Entrapta, the Demon-Heart is gone. Be calm for this next part, please?” Adora asked.

“Okayyy…I promise.” She replied, the glee still there but a little less mad.

“So, I want to introduce you to someone. This is Shen. Please don’t take samples of him.” Adora said, gesturing to Shen across from her. “Shen, this is Entrapta. She is our friend, science expert and genius. She might be intense, but she won’t hurt you...I hope.” Adora stated, a little unsure.

Entrapta lifted herself up and over to Shen using her ponytails, landing next to him. She began to take out instruments from her various pockets but stopped herself and put them back. She then held out her hand.

“Hi, my name is Entrapta.” She introduced herself, slowly and calmly for once.

“Nice to meet you. I’m Shen.” He replied, shaking her hand. Shen smiled, charmed by this new acquaintance.

“We’re just asking Shen a few questions, trying to answer a few mysteries. We were just talking about where he is from— it sounded like another dimension.” Adora explained.

“Oohhh…my kind of conversation,” Entrapta stated, to no one’s surprise. “Tell me!”

Shen described the place he was from; it was a short description for there was only darkness, the glowing orb of the Set'Heth-un'dar and his planet. He described how he was able to enter their galaxy using the energy the Shen'Aan-war had taken from She-Ra when they explored the mysterious temple on Twilight.

"So that is what I felt, when I put the black crystal into the altar and spoke the command 'Masters of the Universe.' It was this Shen'Aan-war somehow taking hold of me. Your fath—" Adora said, breaking off at the last part.

Shen looked at Adora in her hesitation. "Yes, Adora. My father. He is very powerful. He was able to share the energy he stole with our sorcerer caste, the Death-Binders, who were then able to create a tether to this universe. Using the tether, they opened a small passage for me to enter. They also imprinted some of your energy on the Other. That is how I found you across space." Shen explained.

"WOW!" Entrapta said. "I really have to learn more about this magic stuff, it's SO FASCINATING!!" Entrapta exclaimed.

"I don't think you want to know about the magic I'm familiar with, my new friend." Shen looked at Entrapta.

"Ohhh…friends? We're friends now? Yayyyy!" Entrapta beamed, clapping her hands.

"Okay guys, let's slow down here. There are a lot of things Shen has said that I have questions about. Let's not get into magic yet." Adora said, trying to get a handle on the conversation. "Let's back up a little. This 'glowing orb', you say it's called the Set'Heth-un'dar. The way you talk about it makes me think it's the one I've seen in my nightmares." Adora stated.

"Yes, that would be a place to see it. The Set'Heth-un'dar is the only source of light for our world, it lights what we call 'day'... although, after being on this planet and feeling your sun, I don't

think there really ever was a ‘day’ on Shen’Dar-oom.” Shen said sadly.

“What is it, a moon? A dim sun?” Adora asked, already feeling that she was neither.

“No, it’s not. It is a power— The sole source of power for the Death-Binders— and also augments the Shen’Aan-war’s already incredible might. It is huge and some say it is sentient, for it seems to maliciously gaze down on us. Its name, Set’Heth-un’dar, means ‘Dead God’s Eye’, but it is also called the ‘Deathstone’.”

“Deathstone?” Adora said, in a horrified whisper. She looked at the window, seeing the Moonstone glowing in the distance.

Shen turned, looking at what she was seeing. “Yes, much like the Moonstone, but its power is in complete opposition to what the Moonstone represents.”

They were all silent for a moment, feeling a chill in spite of the afternoon light.

“Hey, I just remembered why I came! You guys distracted me!” Entrapta yelled suddenly, making everyone jump.

Entrapta reached into her pocket to pull out a data pad of her own. She turned it on, pressed a few buttons and turned it so everyone could see.

“Hordak and I have been digging through the data we downloaded from the Velvet Glove, more than a THOUSAND years’ worth of data! This is a video recording Hordak found, from almost one thousand years ago. It is from a ship in Horde Prime’s feet as they approach the planet Eternia— is the name of the planet we suspect Twilight used to orbit as its moon. On the labels of the old star chart we found, we suspect Twilight is the moon called Dark Moon. There is another moon called Light Moon; from the video you are watching, it appears to have been destroyed.” Entrapta said, in full hyper mode.

They watched as the fleet approached the planet and saw two orbiting moons, one moon sending solar light to the other, light to dark. Then, the dark explosion on the dark moon, the beam of darkness creeping back to the light moon, imploding the light moon and creating the horrible orb. Then, the orb sucking in Eternia and disappearing.

Entrapta turned off the data pad and put it away.

"Hordak and I suspected it was magic which destroyed Light Moon and created the portal which drew Eternia to somewhere else, perhaps another dimension like Despondos. Neither I nor Hordak have experience with such things, so I tried reaching a sorcerer like Micah, but he always ignores me. I've been trying to reach Bow to talk to Glimmer, but he's been ignoring me too." Entrapta said, pouting.

"That orb at the end was definitely the Set'Heth-un'dar. I would recognize it anywhere. What we just witnessed must have been what my people refer to as 'The Fall', which is when our planet entered the dark dimension and started its new life under the dark gaze of the Set'Heth-un'dar. I do not know what else I witnessed — the two moons and the dark beam, the destruction of the one to create the Set'Heth-un'dar." Shen said, apologetically.

"So, logically, your planet, Shen'Dar-oom, must be Eternia, the planet referenced by so many First One's texts as possibly being the homeworld of the First One's." Bow said, awe in his voice.

Adora turned to Shen, realization on her face. "You're a First One?" she whispered.

Shen shrugged. "I have heard of neither Eternia nor First Ones. The people who live on my planet are varied and diverse, much like Etheria. They all have their own different names, but we are all the Set'Heth-un'dar Sho-heim, or 'Children of the Dead God's Eye'."

“Shen, I am a First One. I was brought to this planet by a First One’s hologram named Light Hope. Light Hope opened a portal from wherever the First Ones reside and brought me to Etheria. Does that mean I’m from this planet, Shen’Dar-oom?” Adora asked solemnly.

Shen shrugged again. “I do not know, although it would please me greatly if we were both of the same people. If you did come from my world, then this Light Hope did you a huge favor.”

“There is no certainty that you did come from Shen’Dar-oom, Adora. According to some of the records Hordak and I found, the First Ones had outposts and planets all over the universe, Eternia was just one of many.” Entrapta said.

Bow decided to change the subject. “We are not going to find out anything going down that path. Let’s go back to this Shen-am-war or whatever, Shen’s father, and his plans for taking over this universe. What kind of foe are we talking about?” He asked.

“The Shen’Aan-war is, by himself, very powerful. He has a whole cabal of Death-Binders, sorcerers who can use deadly magic. They are a truly terrible foe to face, especially from a distance. Then there is his elite guard, his Shen’Sho-heim. I grew up around them and they trained me in combat, but don’t let my poor representation of their skill fool you— they are deadly armored warriors. There are other various soldiers and agents in his empire, but the most dreaded are the Szi’th, the reanimated dead army. They are legion.” Shen said.

Adora remembered the shambling pale figures she saw in Shen’s memory; it gave her another chill. She was finding that this new enemy was truly terrible.

“While I was in the Resistance, before I was taken by my father’s men and turned into a monster, I heard rumors of work being done in space using old ships that came with us during The Fall. I do not know the extent of this work. I went on many missions with the rebels to sabotage my father’s designs, and there were

many places where we found raw materials that were intended to be used elsewhere. My guess at the time was that they were intended for the project in orbit around the planet."

"Perhaps they are building ships?" Bow asked.

Shen only shrugged again. "I'm sorry, I don't know. I do not have all the answers."

"No, Shen, thank you. This is good stuff. Back to your fath…the Shen'Aan-war's plans." Adora said, sheepishly.

"Adora, I do not care if you refer to the Shen'Aan-war as my father. Unfortunately, he is. It's not like you're hiding a secret from me." Shen said, smiling kindly.

Adora smiled back. "What do you think his next move will be? Does he know you failed in your mission?"

"Perhaps. I do not know if he knows or cares what happened with me. He will not wait though; he is hungry to come here and conquer. He has been waiting a very, *very* long time. The Death-Binders will use their power in combination with the tether' they created to create a better pathway to this universe. Then, they will come through, and with their combined power, make an even bigger path, big enough for the Shen'Aan-war's entire army to come through. They are probably even now on the planet you call Twilight." Shen said, solemnly.

Adora could feel the dread grow inside her; only a year after Horde Prime, they already have to deal with another deadly enemy.

"So, back to your father, the Shen'Aan-war. Tell me more about him." Adora asked Shen.

"Hmmm... to start off with, he is a horrible father." Shen said, eliciting a small laugh from his friends. "He is the most powerful being on my planet, a powerful warrior and sorcerer, much like She-Ra."

“So, he is your leader, what is his title? We are already familiar with ‘Shen’, so does Aan-war mean king? Dark King or something?” Bow asked.

“No, but that is a good guess, Bow. Aan-war is our word for what he was called before The Fall. You see, he was already a powerful warrior before our planet was drawn into the dark place. After The Fall, his already considerable power was augmented by the Set’Heth-un’dar.” Shen replied.

“So, what does Aan-war mean then?” Bow continued.

“Hmmm… the translation is funny. It is two words which basically mean the same thing.” Shen replied.

“Like a synonym?” Bow added, helpfully.

“Yes, that’s the word! When they are used in combination it’s quite a silly title, really.” Shen said, chuckling.

“Just spit it out!!” Entrapta yelled, impatient as ever.

“He-Man” Shen said, simply.

Memories of Mara

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

* THE REALM OF NIGHT *

The realm of Night was an endless black universe of darkness and nightmares; infinite, but not empty. Creatures made their home there, black, hateful things, demons. There was a recent addition to the numberless demons, one that had returned from a brief absence; it screamed in rage at being denied access to the physical realm.

Among the blackness was a glowing orb alighting a tortured planet; the pitiful, spiteful light it provided gave just enough illumination for the people of the planet to have a pseudo day. It was the Set'Heth-un'dar orbiting the planet Shen'Dar-oom, its dance around the planet more akin to a parasite than a moon. On the night side of Shen'Dar-oom where the residents had a respite from the Set'Heth-un'dar for a brief night, glowing red eyes could be seen in the sky in place of stars.

There were numerous small villages, towns and a few scattered cities on Shen'Dar-oom; the biggest of these cities was Shen'Aan-war, named after the demi-god who resides there. When not walking among his people, the Shen'Aan-war spent most of his time locked away in his castle. He was there now, within his sanctum, brooding in his throne room.

He sat upon his huge black throne, large enough to fit his great bulk, illuminated by a beam of the Set'Heth-un'dar's light. This

terrible light was channeled into the throne room through a series of magically enhanced mirrors to create a beam of pure concentrated power, which shone down on the Shen'Aan-war when he sat upon his throne. He bathed in its light; it strengthened him, but it did not project much light in the surrounding chamber, for the light of the Set'Heth-un'dar was not true light.

It was a large cavernous space, the edges filled with shadows and darkness. Among these shadows were numerous members of the Shen'Aan-war's court; advisors, heads of his various fighting forces, members of the Shen'Sho-heim standing guard, the High Priest of the Death Binders and various other aristocratic heads of powerful families. They all gazed upon their lord, who in turn, paid them no attention. His thoughts were elsewhere.

Not too long ago, the High Priest delivered news of the Demon-Heart's return to this dark realm, not bound to the Outcast or his heart. It was cast screaming into the black void to join its kin, and made itself known to the Death-Binders, eager to be contained within another vessel. The cabal of Death-Binders were attempting this task at that very moment, and the High Priest was eager to be dismissed and join her coven. She would be disappointed, for her master was lost deep inside himself.

The Demon-Heart was destroyed, this means the Outcast is destroyed as well. The Shen'Aan-war thought to himself. *He was always weak, I am not surprised, but the Demon-Heart... it was truly powerful, I felt it myself. This new She-Ra must be powerful indeed.*

His thoughts then turned, to ancient memories, stirred by the thought of She-Ra and her power. It took the Shen'Aan-war a great deal of concentration to dig that far back to his memory, perhaps around seventy generations of his people. There were no years in this dark place, and the only way the Shen'Aan-war can count the length of time was through the lives of his people.

It was before The Fall, before the realm of Night and before he became the Shen'Aan-war. He had other names. One name he still retains in a different form, but there was another name... his birth name. It slowly rose from the murky depths of his memory and he spoke it aloud to himself.

"A…Ad…Adam…" The Shen'Aan-war said to himself, eliciting murmurs and whispers among his court.

The memory suddenly came to him, a memory of a person once dear to him speaking his name. He could hear her voice in his head, chastising him.

"Adam!! You didn't have to do that; you didn't have to kill her! There was another way, a way without death!" she had said.

Then, another name rose to the surface as well, rising even faster than the one for his name. He spoke the name aloud, clearly.

"Mara." He said, raking his gauntleted claws on the armrests of his throne, eliciting more whispers from the dark.

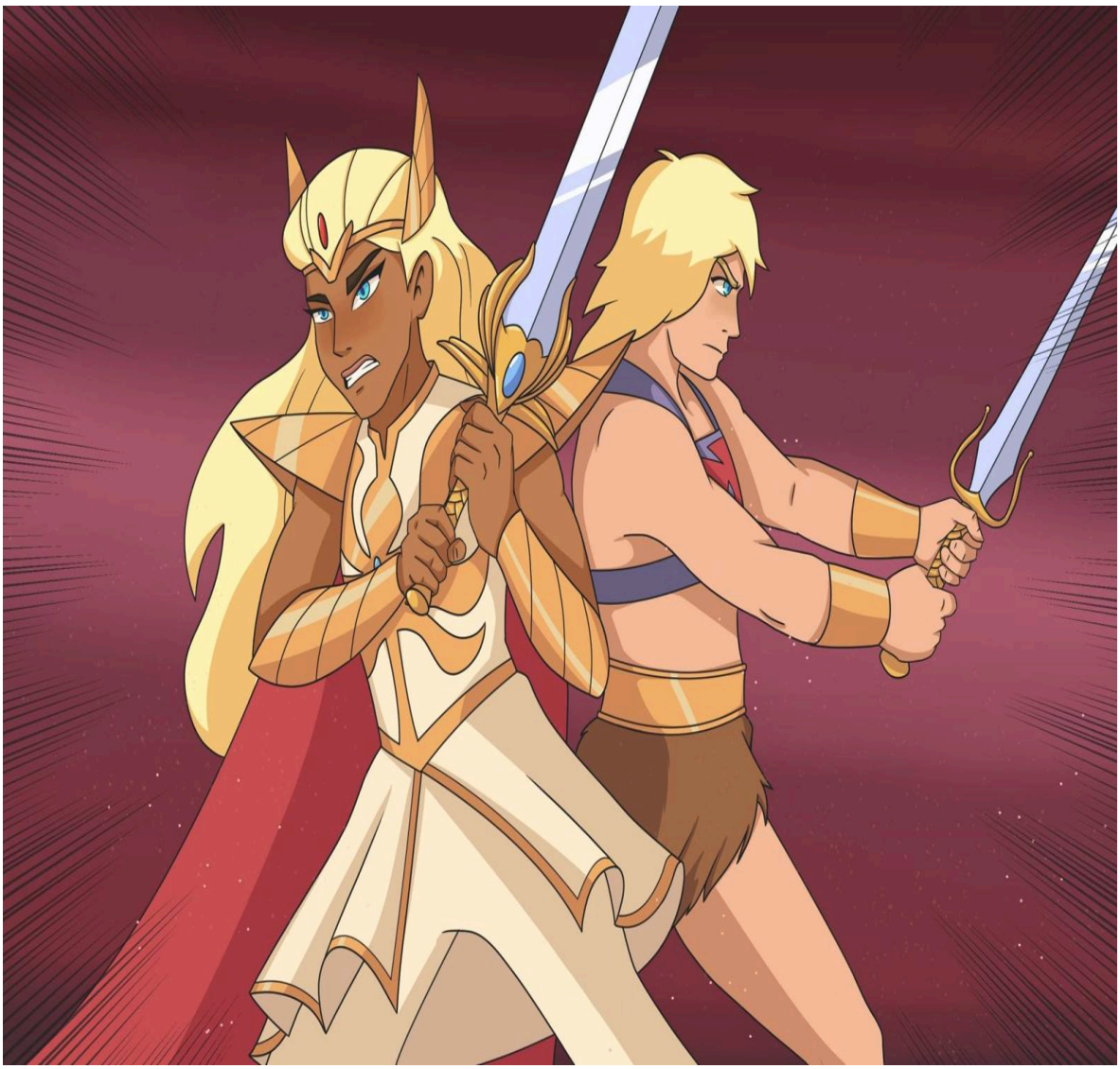
"L…l…lord?" a court member asked, tentatively. He was new to court, and thus, did not know proper etiquette; he would have to learn the hard way.

The Shen'Aan-war was jarred from his memories by the inquiry. He was displeased by this interruption. He turned to one of the many Shen'Sho-heim standing guard and spoke two words.

"Kill him." The Shen'Aan-War commanded, pointing at the man who dared to speak.

The doomed man tried to run but there was nowhere to go; the Shen'Sho-heim were everywhere in the chamber. He was quickly silenced and dragged away, presumably to the many corpse-pools that filled the castle's depths. The Shen'Aan-war paid no attention, he was falling back in his reveries. He had unearthed a full memory, a memory of when he, Adam, fought alongside Mara.

It was back when they both fought for the mighty Empire, one which encompassed the galaxy at that time, before Horde Prime had rebelled against them and drove them to darkness. He, Adam, alongside Mara, were one of many individuals gifted with great power to stand guard and maintain the rule of the realm. Adam was gifted with the power of He-Man, and Mara, the power of She-Ra; they fought side by side on many missions, two knights sent forth to do the will of the Council of Elders.



Adam had loved being He-Man, the aspect of He-Man he took being one that represents his ideals of the perfect warrior. His blond hair was chin-length with short bangs, exposing his broad, handsome face. His extremely defined and muscled body was exposed for all to see, the body of a supreme man, a supreme

warrior. The only items of clothing covering his body were a gray sword harness crisscrossing his chest and back with a red cross emblem on the front, a red-fur pelt loincloth held in place with an orange belt to cover his dignity, and two red fur-topped boots. This was a representation of the tales told of the ancient Eternian barbarians, of whom Adam held in high regard. On his back he carried his Sword of Power, the source of his power as He-Man granted to him by the Council of Elders.

Mara's She-Ra aspect was completely different from Adam's He-Man; she wore form-fitting white pants with knee-high gold-trimmed white boots, a sleeveless skirted tunic with a gold starburst pattern on the front, two large gold shoulder pads and gold gauntlets on each forearm. On her head, she wore a gold crown with two wings on either side, her long blond hair flowing behind her shimmered with radiance. The only similarities between the two warriors were they were both tall and had light, glowing blue eyes.

On occasion, Adam would comment on how it was a shame Mara only showed off her bare arms, when he showed off as much skin as possible. Mara always laughed these comments off, saying she was not ready to start wearing only a fur loincloth. Adam was always angered by this retort, but kept silent, not wanting to show Mara that her words bit him deeply.

There was one other aspect of Mara's She-Ra form that really bothered Adam; the fact that she was perhaps an inch taller than him. He knew that it was silly, but this fact constantly niggled at him, and try as he might, he could not influence his He-Man form to become taller. He even tried learning to walk with a slight lift to his feet, but this was always hard to maintain. Mara, being the kind, compassionate person she was, never commented on this fact. Perhaps, Adam had thought at the time, she didn't say anything out of some form of pity.

The Shen'Aan-war's thoughts then turned to the memory from which Mara's admonition had come from, when they were both sent to the planet Karthis to settle a dispute between two families.

It was a silly dispute, he thought at the time, something to do with the color schemes they painted their huge, scaly bodies in. These colors supposedly clashed between the families in question and they were close to open fighting.

Both he and Mara were at a loss to mitigate this dispute, not sure how they could resolve this, wishing the council sent actual diplomats instead of warriors. They tried their best, and ultimately, these attempts failed, and they found themselves in the middle of open fighting.

Now, even though Adam thought their dispute was foolish and silly, there was nothing silly about the Karthisians themselves. They were huge, reptilian beings, a full head and shoulders tall over a standard human. They had thick, purple scaly hides, four arms that ended in five razor-clawed digits, two powerful legs and an equally powerful tail. Their heads were massive, long snouts with sharp teeth, two beady black eyes and one sharp horn on their brow.

Adam and Mara were no match for these foes, for foes they were, both sides seeing the outsiders as being a representative of their enemy. They quickly transformed into their alter egos, He-Man and She-Ra, and took to a fighting retreat, fighting to defect claws, teeth, tails and horn from harming themselves and each other.

"Mara! Behind you!" He-Man/Adam shouted, just as he blocked a tail swing aimed at his head with his sword.

She-Ra/Mara turned just as a Karthisian was running straight at her, head down and horn pointing at her to impale her. She front-flipped over the charging foe, and as she was inverted over it, she slashed its horn off. The Karthisian howled and crashed into an opposing foe, and in turn, they began fighting each other.

"Thanks, Adam!" She-Ra/Mara yelled, smiling radiantly back at him.

He-Man/Adam was struck by her beauty as she beamed at him, as he always was, for he was in love with her. A love that would never be reciprocated for, he knew, she would never feel the same about him. They are, and always would be, good friends in her mind. He knew she loved him though, a love shared between warriors who fought to protect each other's lives on countless occasions. A love shared between good friends.

His momentary distraction had cost him; a Karthisian had come up behind him and pinned him in a crushing hug, all four arms squeezing the life out of him. It was a huge alpha female, taller and more muscular than even He-Man. Even with his massive strength, He-Man/Adam could barely force the arms open, but this was not enough, for the Karthisian was trying to get her head down to stab him in the back of the head.

"Adam!!" She-Ra/Mara cried, running to his aid.

The Karthisian was almost ready to end him when She-Ra/Mara arrived, grasping it by the horn and smashing it in the mouth with her fist with such force the Karthisian released He-Man/Adam. He-Man/Adam whirled on the Karthisian and impaled her on his sword, screaming in fury at the indignity of being almost killed. At the indignity of looking weak in front of Mara.

"Adam!! You didn't have to do that; you didn't have to kill her! There was another way, a way without death!" She-Ra/Mara cried, horror on her face at his brutality.

He-Man/Adam grimaced; he did not like it when she was mad at him, her beautiful face scowling at him. He also resented it a little, for he felt like a child when she did that; it made him angry.

"We have no time for weakness right now, Mara!" He-Man/Adam yelled. "We have to get out of here! Our mission is a failure and to die here among these foul creatures is an indignity I cannot tolerate!"

"Mercy and compassion are not a weakness, Adam! These people are not creatures, they are sentient beings, beings we were sent to help- and we failed them! We did not come here to kill them!" She-Ra/Mara yelled back, angry now at his callousness.

The Shen'Aan-war scowled at this last sentiment in his memory. He raked his gauntleted claws on the throne again, eliciting sparks this time.

"There always was another way for you, wasn't there, Mara?" The Shen'Aan-war growled to himself.

Another memory came up, one when Horde Prime was crushing them in the war to become masters of the universe.

It was when they had been separated. Mara was sent to oversee a project on the planet Etheria, the 'Heart of Etheria' project. It was an important project to help protect their only hope, however, not much else was known about it. Adam was to stay on Eternia and protect the capital of their failing empire.

He remembered being jealous of Mara being given such a great responsibility instead of him, but this jealously took a back seat to his grief at her absence, her radiant soul and outer beauty greatly missed from his life. His love for her at this time took a whole new aspect with her absence. He coveted Mara; he wanted her so bad it hurt to his very core.

This pain was soothed by the few and far between communications he received from Etheria, for Horde Prime had Eternia surrounded and most communications were jammed. These communications were simple one-way messages, of course, brief videos of Mara telling Adam how her days were going, about how beautiful and strange Etheria was, meeting a friendly old woman and descriptions of how The Heart of Etheria project was progressing. As time went on, these messages became more and more focused on The Heart of Etheria project; they were also starting to disturb Adam.

Mara was starting to show hints of doubt about their great plan, for she had discovered that the Heart of Etheria was a weapon, a weapon that used the magic of Etheria to strike at their enemies. She told Adam that the weapon she was in charge of protecting was too dangerous. Too much collateral damage could take place, too many innocents would die when they used it. It was the same old thing with Mara, talking about "another way" and "mercy and compassion". She even talked about how she was thinking of countering the project, working to stop it.

Adam's messages back to Mara were full of pleas to stay the course, to not become a rebel against the Council. If she was found out, she would be stripped of She-Ra and cast down. Adam could not bear the thought of Mara enduring this, throwing everything away based on weakness and compassion. They were He-Man and She-Ra, mighty warriors fighting for their empire, not weak cowards who would turn on their people.

Mara's messages ended after one of his more passionate entreaties. Adam was deeply hurt by Mara cutting off their communication. He tried telling the Council of Mara's plans, however, they told him there was nothing they could do about it; they were cut off from Etheria and it was up to someone called "Light Hope" to stop her. Adam became fraught with hopelessness. He wanted to go there himself to stop her and bring her back, to save her from herself and to save the project.

He was about to board a ship and risk capture by Horde Prime when the news hit them. Etheria was gone, nowhere to be found. Mara had done it somehow, she had either destroyed Etheria or sent it somewhere else, taking the weapon with her, taking their last hope with them.

Adam's sadness and pain at this news quickly changed into hurt and anger. Mara had turned from them, from him, turned away from them over some silly sense of morality. Morality based on weakness and compassion, compassion for people other than Adam. This anger turned to rage, which in turn, became hate. He hated Mara; Mara the betrayer.

It was during this time that the entire council of Elders was wiped out by a Horde clone ship; it had broken through the planetary defense network and smashed into the Grand Assembly hall in Eternos, killing everyone. This left Adam as de facto ruler of a crumbling empire, surrounded by enemies.

He was desperate and alone, desperate to hold together his empire. It was then that she came to him, Zzar. They had already become very close. How he could not remember, but she temporarily filled the void inside him left by Mara's absence. She was a powerful sorcerer; she was the sorcerer of the castle and advisor to the Council of Elders. She knew many of the secrets kept deep inside the castle and she came to him with one, a secret that could help them win the war.

Zzar had told him of her power, the Power of Life she was tasked with guarding. The Life Gem it was called, which resided at the top of her beautiful white staff. Her power as it was could not save them, but she had found a secret spell deep within a buried crypt deep in the castle. With this spell, she could summon the inverse of her power, the Power of Death. With this power, nothing could stop them. They would crush Horde Prime and retake lost ground, becoming masters of the universe once again.

However, this spell required a sacrifice of life, though a sacrifice through betrayal would be even more powerful. She spoke of going to Dark Moon and conducting the ritual at the solar temple there, where the Dark Moon collected light from its generous neighbor, Light Moon. There, she would corrupt the temple and conduct her magic, summoning the power of Death and sacrificing the population of Light Moon for their cause.

Adam did not hesitate at sacrificing so many of his people for this cause. What were a few million lives to save the countless trillions that made up what was now his Empire? He gave Zzar the permission she needed, and she left for Dark Moon via the portal connecting the castle to the solar temple.

Adam watched from the castle battlements as the ritual was conducted; he could see both Light and Dark Moon in the sky. He watched as the dark energy bloomed on Dark Moon and the black beam of pure darkness followed the solar beam, striking Light Moon. He watched in both horror and fascination as Light Moon crumpled within itself, birthing a terrible orb— the Set'Heth-un'dar.

The Set'Heth-un'dar, once fully formed, had pulsed its terrible energy, and every living soul on Eternia could hear a terrible scream of triumph. Adam had to cover his ears; its cry was simultaneously horrible and beautiful to him, speaking to him of great power and darkness. A part of his soul cried out in despair at this birth cry, but an even greater part cried out in pleasure, for this power was what he always sought.

Suddenly, the orb grew in size, larger and larger until it completely enveloped Eternia, swallowing it, and then…darkness.

The Shen'Aan-war shook himself from his revelries, realizing a group of his Death-Binders were laid before him in supplication. They were patiently awaiting his attention, for they knew not to disturb him and receive his wrath.

Disgusting, foul creatures, these corpse magicians, he thought to himself. *If I did not need them, I would have them flayed and dumped into their own disgusting pools.*

"What is it?" the Shen'Aan-war growled.

The High Priest rose and approached his throne, keeping her sutured eyes down.

"Dread Lord, I come bringing much fortuitous news!" she rasped up at him. "We were able to bind the demon to another heart. It is ready for a new host! Once a prime candidate is selected, we will be able to send another assassin out into the greater universe to kill the She-Ra!"

The Shen'Aan-war waved his hand dismissively. "We have no more time for that, for the She-Ra is aware of us. We must strike

quickly! What is this other good news you have for me? It better be good, or I will remove your arms and sew the ends into your eye sockets!”

The High Priest quaked at this. “Yes, Dread Lord. The other news is that our brothers and sisters on the other side of the tether have managed to increase the pathway between our two realities. They are even able to project the portal into space, a portal big enough for our fleet.”

This pleased the Shen’Aan-war. “Excellent, High Priest. You get to keep your arms where they are... for now.”

The High Priest nodded and backed away, grateful to be away from her master’s attention. The Shen’Aan-war turned his attention to the heads of his fighting forces: The General of the Black Army, The Suzerain of the Shen’Sho-heim, The Director of the Hidden Knives, The Szi’th Husbander, and the newest addition; The Admiral of the Fleet.

They had spent great quantities of materials and effort to build a fleet in the darkness of space on the night side of Shen’Dar-oom. The fleet’s construction was kept secret, for the Shen’Aan-war feared it falling into the hands of the rebels and being used against him. Even though he wiped out the latest iteration of rebellion, there were always new fools to take their place. The Shen’Aan-war had been forced to crush countless generations of rebellion during his long, dark reign.

The fleet was to be used once the time had come, when access to the greater universe was finally established. The fleet combined with their armies and new allegiance to the Power of Death, Horde Prime or whatever new enemy they found would be no match for them.

“Admiral, is the fleet ready? The answer better be yes,” The Shen’Aan-war growled, full of malice.

The Admiral was an older, gray-haired man in a black uniform with silver trim. He snapped to attention.

"Yes, Dread Lord. All ships are complete and manned. The crews are inexperienced, but I'm sure we will blood them fast in this greater universe."

"Excellent, I want the fleet in first, then the entirety of the Black Army and Szi'th through the temple on the ground to scour the Dark Moon of any opposition. Once the Dark Moon is secured, I will enter along with my entire Shen'Sho-heim and a cabal of Death-Binders and make the temple my base of operations in this greater universe. From there, I will direct the conquest. We will crush She-Ra and this weak universe and I will become its master." The Shen'Aan-war said, finally cracking a smile.


@MILEDIBUJA

Chapter End Notes

Illustration of He-Man and Mara done by @Yoritomito on Twitter.

Illustration of Shen'Aan-War done by Miledibuja.

Itches that Need Scratching

PART II

…my friends, and together, we helped heal each other,

Catra had just finished tugging her form-fitting maroon and black outfit on. It had been almost three weeks since she had been able to wear her usual outfit. Before that, she was only able to wear that ridiculous gown or loose baggy pants and shirts so she wouldn't irritate her healing ribs and leg. It was good to get it back on, although putting it on was a chore because her legs were still stiff.

She inspected herself in a full-length mirror, pleased she had gotten the outfit flat where it needed to be... then it hit her.

"Grrrrrrrrr…this blasted itching!" she growled, trying to reach to her back where the latest itching attack started.

Lying on her back for so long had created a whole plethora of issues for her; stiffness, loss of mobility, more irritability than usual, but most of all, her entire backside itched terribly. Even her tail itched sometimes, which started again as she inspected herself.

“Grrrrrr…mmmmm…that feels better…” she murmured, stroking and scratching her claws along her tail. She had to stop herself from biting it when the itching became too much for her.

With the itching subdued for now, she began stretching herself out, trying to loosen the tightness in her ribs and right leg. She started by putting both hands behind her head and leaning to the left, trying to get to the stiff ribs on her right side. Nothing. She then tried leaning back, hands pushing into her lower back. No relief. She even tried pushing her fingers between the individual spaces between her ribs, but all it did was hurt them.

“Ow, blast it!” she cursed.

She decided to try working on her leg now, starting by massaging it gently, trying to relieve the tension and soreness before starting her stretches. As a test to see where she was in mobility, she tried lifting her right leg high enough that she could touch her face with her shin. This was something she could do no problem before her injury.

She had almost gotten her right leg level with her hips when she lost her balance and fell straight into the mirror, knocking it over. It smashed to pieces on the ground as Catra caught herself with both arms against the floor, keeping herself from hitting the ground and damaging her healing body. She gently laid herself down, away from the glass, and rolled over on her back.

“BLAST IT!” she screamed.

Suddenly, there was a rapid series of knocks at the door.

“This is the Bright Moon guard. Is everything alright in there?” the Guard queried; she was all business.

Catra closed her eyes and went into the meditation ritual that Perfuma had been taught her. She held both her hands down against her thighs, her index and thumb together in an “O” with the rest of her fingers spread away from each other.

"Ommmmm…" Catra chanted.

"Hello? Catra, I know you're in there. Are you okay?" the Guard called, worry in her voice now.

"Om, Om, Om, Ommmmmm…" Catra continued chanting.

"I can hear you in there. What are you doing? Are you moaning? Answer me or I will break this door down!" the Guard was yelling now.

Finally, Catra stopped her chanting. She had found her center; her frustration and anger bled away.

"It's okay, Elizabeth, I'm fine, just being clumsy. Please don't break the door down. Adora and I won't have any privacy in here if you do that. Not that it will stop us from doing anything…" Catra called out mischievously.

The Guard, Elizabeth laughed. She was one of the guards who broke in the night of the attack and saw Catra standing in her underwear over an unconscious assassin.

"Okay, Catra. Just yell if you need help," she called, humor in her tone as she walked back to her post.

Catra sat up, trying other stretches for her leg, although she was only half paying attention to what she was doing. Mentioning Adora made her think about the past couple of weeks.

Ever since Adora's talk with Shen, the day Catra swore Adora gave her an extra dose of tonic to make her fall asleep, Adora had been constantly worried and distracted. Catra could understand that, though, as Adora had explained to her in detail the horrible new enemy they faced. Catra had been filled with dread, although she didn't show it, when Adora described the living dead in the vision she had of Shen's memories, how there was a whole army of these creatures on their way to this universe from another dimension.

Catra looked down, her itchy tail was now bristled up and twice its size.

This tail, I swear it's always giving everything away. Can't a girl keep her emotions to herself? she thought, massaging the fur back down along her tail.

On top of her worry, Adora was still having nightmares every night. Catra wanted to be able to fall asleep with her arms around Adora for the inevitable moment she woke screaming. She would have, if not for her healing body; Adora was strong and could set Catra's healing back if she hit Catra while flailing or struggled out of her arms. So, Catra would spend a lot of time awake, watching Adora while she slept, waiting for her to start moaning or struggling she would then gently wake her, stroking her face or shaking her gently by the shoulder.

Then, there was the fact that Adora went to the new guy, Shen, to talk about her dreams. She would tell Catra the details, but she spent far more time discussing them with Shen.

When Adora had come back from saving Shen, explaining to Catra how she had created an identical heart rune to sever the demon's connection, and leaving him with an identical copy on his own chest, Catra had joked with Adora that she didn't really care. This was not the case.

Catra and Adora had faced death together when they used the fail-safe to release the magic bound in the Heart of Etheria. It was the moment when their mutual love for each other was made known, their pure and real love— that was the moment that kept them from being killed by the released magic. Every moment they spent together since then had been a gift, and every time Catra saw the heart rune on Adora's chest she was reminded of this fact. Sometimes she would purposely activate it with her touch just to see it.

Now, this guy had the same exact heart rune on his chest, and she was beginning to resent it. She also resented the fact Adora

shared her nightmares with him; it was like she was going to him for comfort.

Am I jealous? she thought to herself.

Maybe a little…well... maybe a lot, if she was being truthful with herself. She didn't think Adora would ever leave her, she knew Adora loved her more than anything. They were soulmates bound for life. No, it was something else... perhaps jealous of her time? Maybe.

Catra suddenly smiled wickedly to herself as a recent memory came to the forefront of her mind. She had run into this guy, Shen, in the hall; it was the first time they had seen each other since the interrogation. She was pretty confident she set him straight and made her feelings for him known in the most straightforward, "Catra way" possible. Adora would be furious if she found out about Catra's interactions with her new friend. Hopefully, he wasn't a whiny crybaby.

Catra suddenly realized she had someplace to be.

"Curses!" she yelled as she slowly started to rise, being careful not to overextend her right leg.

She was supposed to be at the gathering in the Bright Moon council chambers to discuss the looming threat from outside their universe. She walked over to her dresser, picking up her gold headpiece and setting it in place on her head.

Considering we are talking about a potential fight, I should come looking the part, she thought to herself.

She left the room as fast as her aching leg could take her, hoping the meeting hadn't started yet.

* * *

Shen was in his room, getting dressed for the meeting in the Bright Moon council chambers to discuss the inevitable invasion of

this universe by the Shen'Aan-war and his army. He pulled on his white shirt and black jacket, which had become the staples of his appearance, and tied his long black hair into a ponytail.

The past few weeks were the most amazing of his life, besides, of course, the short time he had with Shen'Dara. Etheria and its people were on a level beyond his wildest dreams, and every day there was a new wonder.

Bow had taken him on trips to the Whispering Woods, during both day and night, and the beauty of the place still took his breath away, although now he was able to enjoy it without weeping. They visited Madame Razz's cottage and met up with Swift Wind who flew them over the forest, regaling them with tales of his adventures with Razz. Their adventures mostly involved watching mushrooms, picking apples and flying in butterfly migrations.

Glimmer— the Queen and now, his friend— had taken time out of her busy schedule to show him the many luxuries of life, comforts that he never even would have imagined existed. Cake. Cookies. Ice-cream. Something called a manicure and pedicure. She had even taken him to a place called Mysticor, with a plan to visit the cloud beaches, followed by the healing thermal springs, tranquil gardens and finally, massages. They never made it past the cloud beaches; Shen found such peace there he slept the day away on the shores.

Adora was who he spent the most time with. They had talked about their lives; Shen giving more details to some of the images Adora was privy to in his mind and Adora telling him about her life growing up in the Horde, finding the Sword of Protection and becoming She-Ra, eventually defecting and fighting to free Etheria from both Hordak and Horde Prime's rule.

Since she was privy to some of Shen's very private moments, Adora told him of how she and Catra grew up together, growing intimate with each other, how neither of them really knew the extent of their relationship at the time they were both in the Horde. Then, their tumultuous split after Adora left the Horde and

their bitter years of fighting each other. How Adora constantly strove to bring Catra to her side, and ultimately having to let her go, thinking her very close friend was gone forever, lost to evil. Then, Horde Prime's arrival, Catra's selfless sacrifice, Catra's rescue and rehabilitation, and finally, their mutual affirmation of love for each other, releasing the magic with the heart rune and stopping Horde Prime.

"That's truly amazing and beautiful." Shen had said once Adora was done with her tale.

Adora smiled. "Yes, most days I just can't believe we made it, and saved everyone. Now we're together. Every day she's with me seems even better than the last." She sighed.

"I know how that feels. I still can't believe the Other is gone, that I am not damned anymore, that I have free will and don't have to worry about being taken over by a monster. I owe you so much, Adora." Shen had said earnestly.

"Shen, stop. You don't owe me anything. Your life is your own to do with as you please, not mine. If you wanted to, you could simply walk away from Bright Moon or leave Etheria to visit other planets, and no one would stop you. Although, I would like it if you stuck around for a while... we could use your help." Adora replied, smiling.

"No. I feel like my place is here, with all of you. I can't imagine doing anything else right now. I feel like I need to be here, helping you. I know it sounds overly dramatic when I say this but…I don't know how else to say it... *I believe in you*, Adora. What I've seen you do so far is amazing, and not just as She-Ra. I believe if anyone can stop the Shen'Aan-war, it's you." Shen said, the same earnestness in his voice as before.

He saw that Adora was embarrassed by this, but she smiled. "Thanks, Shen, that means a lot, especially from where you're coming from. I should know too…"

They had both chuckled at this. To most people, having someone take a glimpse into your deepest darkest moments would feel like the worst violation, but somehow, he felt safe knowing it was Adora who saw it.

His time in Bright Moon had been special so far, like it was healing his soul. He could feel his old self returning; his appreciation for life and beauty, waking up with hope for once, instead of dread. When his sense of humor had returned, it was then he truly knew that he was coming around, for to find humor in life is to have the ability to soften the worst hurts life can throw at you. This was something he found out with his time with the Other; when his sense of humor had died, his hope died too.

He was finishing up his preparations and was getting ready to leave when he heard a door close in the hall, Adora's room, and then soft footsteps past his room, footsteps with the slight clicking of claws on hard stone floor, an unsteadiness to the step as if the person walked with a slight limp.

Catra.

Hmmm…better wait a bit before leaving. Shen thought to himself.

Shen wasn't afraid of Catra, for no physical threat really made any impact on him anymore, but he didn't like the idea of antagonizing the woman any more than she already seemed to be. He didn't like the fact that Adora's girlfriend didn't seem to like him, which she made clear to him the other day.

He had just returned from an outing with Bow and was walking down the hall. As he turned a corner, he saw Catra leaving her room and walking toward him. They both stopped and looked at each other; she was wearing what looked like baggy cloth pants and a loose sleeveless shirt. This was the first time he had seen her since that night when he watched the Other almost kill her. He felt a lot of guilt over that, and their sudden meeting had completely thrown him off.

“Oh, hello Catra, I’m glad to see you up and about!” he said truthfully, but lamely.

She said nothing, just stared at him and started walking toward him, with a slight yet discernible limp to her gait. He kept still and broke eye contact; her gaze was intense, and he stared straight ahead. For some reason, an old instruction came to his mind, how when faced with a dangerous animal, it was better to keep still and not to look into its eyes.

She was just about to pass him when she stopped and turned slightly toward him, she was extremely close. He glanced at her face and saw that she was looking down at his chest. She lifted one clawed finger, placing it at the center of his chest, where his heart was. The heart rune lit brightly at her touch.

They both looked up at the same time, eyes meeting. Catra then finally spoke.

“Remember that night, you know... when we first met? Remember, when I was just in my underwear?” she said, saying the last part like it was a secret. “You remember what I told you then?”

Shen thought for a moment. “‘I can see you, idiot?’”

Catra put her finger to her chin and looked thoughtful. “Nope, that’s not it, try again.”

“You like that? There is more coming?’” Shen answered. He was being purposely obtuse now for he didn’t like being bullied.

“Nope, but you are getting close to my point*.” She said, emphasizing the last part by tapping a claw on his nose. “Try again.”*

“Hmmm… if it’s not those, then it’s ‘Don’t mess with my girl’, except you growled the last part,” Shen answered.

Catra sharply snapped her fingers in his face. "Got it!" she exclaimed with false enthusiasm, a wide smile on her face.

Before he could respond, she had suddenly walked away, tail swishing behind her; that was an intense reunion, to say the least.

Now, to Shen, 'don't mess with my girl' could mean a lot of things. The most obvious was the fact he had come to Etheria to kill Adora, and so, Catra still didn't trust him not to try and carry it out. She had been laid up for a while and really didn't know him.

'Don't mess with my girl' could also mean something else, a variation of what was said to him in the past out of jealousy, before the Other was bonded to him. Catra may have thought that Shen was going to try and seduce Adora or steal her away somehow, which was ridiculous. Shen was just getting his life back, just becoming ALIVE again, for up until Adora had saved him, he was basically dead, no better than one of the Szi'th. He wasn't ready for the highs and lows of seduction, not yet anyways. Besides, his relationship with Adora was *far* too dear to him to trivialize it with physical pleasure.

He looked down at his chest and remembered how Catra had gone straight for the heart rune there, seemingly fixated on it. He remembered what Adora had told him; how she and Catra had released the magic of Etheria and kept themselves alive through their love for each other, that their love was somehow focused through the heart rune, the "fail-safe" she had called it. He didn't understand the particulars of what had happened, but he was starting to make sense of Catra's anger toward him. That, combined with the fact that Adora had been seeking his council regarding her terrible dreams, Shen began to believe Catra's jealousy was based on something way more intimate.

Shen sighed. There was nothing he could do about that. The heart rune was a part of him now and he would never withhold his help to Adora, no matter what. He was just going to have to

bear the brunt of the anger of a jealous girlfriend. A *dangerous* jealous girlfriend.

Once he was sure she was gone, Shen left his room and made his way to the council chamber, which was all the way across the grounds and up various flights of stairs to Bright Moon castle itself.

As he entered the chamber, he was taken aback by the number of people standing and chatting before the meeting was to adjourn. He could see the Princesses of Etheria seated or standing near the chairs around the main council table, some he had met, whereas others were strangers to him. Adora was chatting with a tall, dark-skinned princess with long dark hair wearing a turquoise outfit with gold trim.

There were various military personnel in uniforms some were from Bright Moon and others from the other princess's kingdoms. He recognized General Juliet standing and talking to Castaspella.

His gaze was caught by one military leader in particular, a green-skinned woman with one yellow and one glowing red eye; the red eye looked like it was some form of cybernetic. She wore a bright white uniform with gold trim and there appeared to be what looked like green tentacles at her back. She was talking with Queen Glimmer who was wearing a strange new robe; it was full-length with a hood as opposed to the small cape she usually wore. The robe was completely black and seemed to shimmer with stars.

There were other functionaries and dignitaries whose roles Shen could not begin to determine; the chambers were almost packed. He took his place at the back of the chamber, leaning up against the wall, and then he saw her.

Catra was also leaning up against the wall with her arms crossed, about ninety degrees from him on the right. She was wearing her maroon and black outfit and her gold headpiece on, the one he remembered her wearing during the fight with the Other. It was a

striking headpiece, with two wings on each side flaring out on each side over her ears. It gave her an even more predatory look, like a bird of prey.

Huh, Shen thought to himself, *But she's already like a cat, so what does the headpiece make her then? A "bird-cat"?* Shen started chuckling to himself, enjoying his stupid joke.

"Hey buddy, what's so funny?" a familiar voice said from his left.

"Bow! Good to see you. Oh, I was just thinking of a nickname for someone. I think you will appreciate it, actually." Shen said, smiling at his friend.

"Tell me later. I gotta take my seat next to Glimmer." Bow said, patting Shen's chest in affection before walking away.

Looking down, Shen saw that Bow had inadvertently activated the heart rune, it was glowing brightly. Feeling a set of eyes on him; he looked to his right and saw Catra staring at it. Their eyes met, and Catra quickly looked down and back up, as if telling Shen to look lower. He did; she was holding her fingers cupped upwards with her claws fully extended.

Shen looked back up at her face; she was smiling with all teeth exposed, showing off her upper and lower fangs. Her eyes were full of malice and she was raising her eyebrows up and down. She looked completely psychotic.

She looks like she is out of her mind, Shen thought to himself. *Like a jealous, crazy, bird-cat.*

He laughed out loud to himself and was instantly treated to the pure fury on Catra's face. She was no longer smiling, but her blue and yellow heterochromatic eyes were still full of malice, her ears were lowered, her mouth was clenched, and he was sure she was growling.

He noticed that Catra seemed to be absentmindedly scratching herself, her backside mostly. It seemed to be all over; her back,

her legs, her rear, and tail. He instantly thought of the Sekth his father kept— the furry beasts were always infested with some kind of vermin and were constantly scratching themselves.

A jealous, crazy, bird-cat with itchy bugs in her fur, he thought to himself, starting to laugh hard now.

Catra was absolutely furious now at his laughing and seemed to be mouthing something. Shen tried to make it out.

"Your head?" he said out loud, even though Catra couldn't hear him. "Oh, I got it, you're saying 'You're dead. Huh."

I've been dead before, won't be a problem for me, he thought to himself, and for some reason, this was even more hilarious to him. Shen kept laughing to himself and looked away; he knew he was going to pay for this somehow. It was worth it though.

"Something funny young man?" A stern voice to his left asked.

Shen turned and instantly recognized the older man. "I was, but now seeing the look on your face, Royal Advisor, all humor has left me," Shen replied to a scowling Micah.

"You have a smart mouth. It's a trait I usually find to be a good quality in a person, but for you, it's a detraction. I am having a hard time seeing any good qualities in you, in fact." Micah said, his voice ice cold.

Great, Shen thought to himself, *I've got Catra on my right and this guy on my left, hating me from both directions.*

"I hope you understand the seriousness of this meeting. It is no laughing matter." Micah continued.

Shen was instantly angry. "I understand more than you know, old man." He spat.

Anger blazed in Micah's eyes, but he said nothing and continued to walk to the center table, taking his old seat there.

Shen noticed that the princesses were taking their seats, Bow, Micah, Castaspella, the General and the woman in the white uniform included. Everyone in the back stopped their conversations and faced forward. The council was beginning.

* * *

Glimmer stood and looked out into the full council chamber, collecting her thoughts. As Queen of Etheria, it was her duty to lead the meeting and present the issue they faced— really, the issue the whole Universe faced— to the people of Etheria. She was actually a little nervous.

She looked at the circular table before her and saw all her friends smiling back at her in support. Clockwise around the table were Bow, Micah, Castaspella, General Juliet, Star Admiral Octavia, Mermista, Entrapta, Scorpia, Perfuma, Netossa, Spinnerella, Frosta, and Adora.

She looked out at the people behind them and saw many faces; some she recognized and some she didn't. There was Sea Hawk standing behind Mermista, she could see Huntara representing the Crimson Waste. The Star Siblings were there— Tallstar, Starla with Glory on her shoulder and Jewelstar; they had important information gathered from outside Etheria.

Up against the wall in the very back, she could see Catra. After her experience with leadership in the Horde, Catra was hesitant to take up anything resembling a leadership position again. During one of their more private discussions on the matter, Catra said that she didn't like who she had become when she had authority. Glimmer respected this, but still offered Catra a seat at the council table. Catra declined and Castaspella took her seat instead; Catra would rather hang back and watch, providing her input when needed.

Glimmer was happy to see her friend up and about in her preferred outfit. She was even wearing her gold headpiece, which

meant Catra was ready for business. What Catra was doing at the moment though, Glimmer couldn't figure out.

Catra was pressed back up against the wall, slowly inching to her left, her face intent on some objective.

Ugh, Catra, can you at least pay attention to this? This is important! Glimmer thought to herself.

Glimmer looked away from Catra. She had no time for her friend's antics. She had a meeting to start.

Glimmer stood, holding up her hands. "Friends, dignitaries, people of Etheria, the council on the matter of the threat from outside our universe is about to commence. Based on the numbers gathered today, I would ask that you all wait for the presentation to be completed before asking questions or giving input. Even then, please raise your hand before speaking. This includes you Entrapta." Glimmer said, projecting her voice with magic and smiling warmly at Entrapta.

Entrap looked unaffected by the attention, she just smiled and Mermista teasingly elbowed her in the side.

"Okay, where are the T.I. people with the holographic projector?" Glimmer asked looking around.

The integration of the Horde with the Princess alliance brought many new technological wonders to Bright Moon and a new branch of personnel was needed. This branch was simply referred to the T.I. branch; the abbreviation standing for Technology Interface, the interface supposedly being with magic.

The two T.I. people arrived, pushing a cart carrying the holographic technology up though the crowd. They stopped the cart in front of Shen and carried the precious technology to the council table, placing it in the center. It was a holographic projector and some sort of data pad, along with all sorts of cables and plugs. They fussed with it, muttering to themselves.

“Okay, so the projector has an IMDH and a micro-IVD port, and the data engine only has a ATAS-e and port marked “display”, hmmmm….” T.I. guy number one said to the other.

“Find the appropriate conversion cable and hook the projector IMDH port to the display port on the data engine.” T.I. guy number two responded, anxiousness in his voice. “Make sure the data engine has the correct display function selected.”

They fussed away, selecting and connecting a cable between the two units. T.I. guy number two pressed a button on the data engine; it beeped, but nothing came up on the holo-projector.

“Try the micro-IVD port and switch between display functions!” T.I. guy said, frantic now.

Everyone was staring at them. Glimmer had her arms crossed, not amused.

“AHHH! I can’t take it!” Entrapta yelled, putting her fingers between her lips and whistled.

Emily came scurrying in and made her way to Entrapta, pushing and beeping through the crowed.

“Give me that!” Entrapta said, yanking the data engine from T.I. guy number two. “And give me this!” she yelled, grabbing a cable from T.I. guy number one.

Entrapta fussed with the data engine and connected it to Emily, then pressed a button on the data engine and Emily emitted a low beep. A three-dimensional projection emitted from her, displaying a perfect image of the galaxy above the table.

“Thank you, Entrapta. Perhaps I should put you in charge of our T.I. department.” Glimmer said, glaring at the two T.I. guys as they sheepishly exited the chambers, leaving the cart behind.

“Okay, let’s begin.” Glimmer said. “You all have been counseled on the nature of this new threat we face, so I will not go into detail

on that. This meeting is to discuss recent intelligence on our enemies' movements in our Galaxy. According to intellig—"

Glimmer was suddenly interrupted by a loud crashing. The crowd parted to show Shen lying entangled in the cart the T.I. guys had brought in. Behind him, Catra leaning against the wall, surprise written on her face. *That was totally Catra, she doesn't fool me with that look,* Glimmer thought to herself. *What is her problem with Shen?*

Someone helped Shen to his feet, who was smiling and patting dust off his jacket.

"Are you okay?" asked Glimmer.

"Sorry Queen Glimmer, I'm so clumsy... that cart just seemed to jump right at me!" Shen said with a laugh, walking away from the cart. Glimmer noticed that he went to the opposite side of the room that Catra currently occupied.

Ugh, Catra, it's always something with you. Glimmer thought to herself. *I'm going to have to deal with this later.*

"Okay, let's continue." Glimmer started, "According to intelligence by the Star Siblings, there have been reports of a massive fleet near Twilight. This fleet has been engaging neighboring star systems. Many of these systems don't have any ships of their own since they are just rebuilding from years of Horde Prime's rule. I will turn this over to the Star Siblings."

The two sisters and brother approached the table and stood next to Glimmer, who sat down in her chair.

"Zoom in on the Twilight system and the neighboring systems there," said Tallstar, pointing at the projection of the galaxy.

Emily focused on the spot, showing Twilight at the bottom right and two neighboring systems, Karthis to the left of Twilight and Rham above. Both systems were named for their prime inhabited planet.

“We were on the planet Rham when the fleet attacked. They bombarded the main cities from orbit and landed ground troops once the bombardment ceased.” Jewelstar said, pain in his voice. “We captured these images before we escaped.”

Jewelstar handed a disc to Entrapta who inserted it into Emily. The galaxy vanished and was replaced by a three-dimensional image. People were running in one direction, screaming as soldiers in black uniforms charged forward. Behind them, shambling in clusters, were the Szi’th, the undead. Some of the inhabitants were brave enough to shoot at these invaders, but the shots were blocked by an invisible field. Black hooded and robed figures came into view holding their arms outstretched, they were the ones projecting the field. They were obviously the sorcerers, the Death-Binders. The image fizzled out as one of the Death-Binders pointed in its direction, a beam of deathly light projected from the figure’s outstretched hand.

“We managed to get to the planet Makkina and attempted to make contact with Rham, with individuals there that we knew would resist. Unfortunately, we couldn’t make contact— this new enemy seems very good at stamping out rebellion.” Starla said, continuing on where Jewelstar left off. “We moved from Makkina when reports came in that the fleet was advancing.”

“We have been running ever since. We decided if anywhere was safe, it had to be Etheria,” said Tallstar, finishing their presentation.

“Thank you for that presentation. Admiral Octavia, please present on our fleet disposition and the best course of action.” Glimmer said.

The woman stood and bowed in a salute. “My Queen, all ships are fully crewed and ready. We simply await your command. As for the best course of action—” Admiral Octavia paused and asked Entrapta to bring the galaxy map back up.

The galaxy projection showed a spiral consisting of two main "arms" around a circular swirl that twisted into a bright middle. Etheria was on the upper "arm" which was labeled "Rainbow Arm", while Twilight was below, in the edge of the circular swirl. Between them was an area marked "Maelstrom Gulf", which Octavia pointed to.

"As you can see here, Etheria and Twilight are separated by a natural boundary in the form of the Maelstrom Gulf. No ships can cross it because the solar forces there are too strong. Any ship caught there would be annihilated." Octavia said. She then pointed to a section to the left where Maelstrom Gulf ended, and Rainbow Arm met the inner swirl. "Our plan, if we are fast enough, is to meet the enemy and engage them here, what we call the "Omiros Bridge". Our primary objective is to destroy them, the secondary to hold them."

"What happens if those two objectives fail?" asks Adora.

Octavia looked at Adora with a small smile. "Always thinking of the third option, Adora. You always were the brightest of my cadets. If those two plans fail, the plan is to make a fighting retreat, delaying the enemy long enough to evacuate Etheria."

Loud whispering and murmurs began at this statement, and alarm spreading through the crowd like wildfire.

Glimmer stood up and projected her voice over the crowd. "We will not let it come to that!" She shouted, not through magic this time but through the force of her will.

Everyone stopped talking and looked at the Queen.

"While the Princesses, with the exception of Entrapta and Scorpia, stay on Etheria to guard our home, I, your Queen, will accompany our fleet to meet this enemy. I will be joined by our greatest warrior, She-Ra. Together, we will push this enemy back into the hole of a dimension they came from!"

Smiles and loud cheers met this proclamation, with a few unsure glances. One of these detractors spoke up.

"My Queen, no disrespect, but you're an Etherian princess. Your place is here. You will be too far from the Moonstone and won't be able to use your powers." a lady timidly said.

Glimmer smiled, stroking the edges of the cloak Madame Razz let her borrow. She knew this would come up.

"I have some new tricks up my sleeve." She replied.

* * *

The council concluded shortly after Glimmer's bold proclamation and the members stood milling around with each other, discussing what they heard.

Not Catra though. She was scanning the room, looking for her quarry; she was not finished with Shen, not by a long shot.

I saw him laughing at me itching myself, She thought, angrily. *He was probably making up stupid jokes in his head about how I have itchy bugs in my fur. Shoving him into the cart was just the beginning.*

She had just spotted Shen leaving when she felt herself being lifted from under her arms from behind. Looking down, Catra saw two red claws holding her.

"Oh no, Scorpia, please! Be care—" Catra squealed.

"Shhh…it's okay Wildcat! Giving great hugs doesn't mean they have to be crushing." Scorpia said, lifting Catra into a gentle embrace. "I know I have to be gentle with you."

Catra went limp and settled into the hug, laying her head against the other woman's shoulder; it was all she could do with both arms pinned. Scorpia gently put Catra back down just as Entrapta strode up, beaming at them both.

“Looks like the Super Pal Trio is back,” Scorpia said to them both, smiling warmly.

“Yes, and this time, IT’S IN SPACE!” Entrapta said, excitement shining in her eyes.

Catra rolled her eyes at them. Inwardly though, she was just as excited as Entrapta. *This time, I’m going to treat these two like they deserve— like my friends,* Catra thought to herself. She smiled at them both.

“Together again,” Catra said to them. “I wouldn’t miss it.”

“Yep. Oh hey, I left you a little something in your room. You’re gonna love it.” Scorpia grinned widely.

Catra grimaced. “It’s not another robot mouse, is it?”

Scorpia laughed. “Nope, way better, you’ll see.”

Catra left the two women behind, they were chatting excitedly about all the hot chocolate they would drink and the songs they would sing in space together. She exited the room where she saw Shen leave, but there was no sign of him.

Whatever, I know where he lives, she thought to herself.

Catra’s curiosity was piqued by Scorpia’s words and she headed back to the room she shared with Adora. Walking in, she saw a box on their bed, a card with an inscription lying on top.

“For the snappiest dresser at the Princess Prom, Love, Scorpia, OOOOOO. P.S. I thought maybe you could wear this at my Ball, no pressure though!” Catra read aloud.

“Oh man, she got me clothes? Maybe I should just burn this box...” Catra said to herself, thinking of the outfits Scorpia initially chose for the Princess Prom.

Catra opened the box and her initial reaction was erased from her mind. Nestled under tissue paper was an orange open-breasted short sleeve shirt with a high collar. It had a single button adorned with the gold wing symbol associated with She-Ra- the same wing symbols her head piece was adorned with.

"Wow, this is actually nice!" Catra said to herself, beaming.

Under the shirt were a pair of dark gray pants with a yellow stripe running down both sides.

"Oh, these pants are so *cool*!" Catra exclaimed, excitement in her voice.

Catra went over to her vanity and took out a pair of scissors, expertly cutting a small hole in the seat of the pants, a clothing alteration she was most familiar with. She carefully wiggled out of her maroon and black outfit and pulled on her new outfit, looking at herself in the vanity mirror.

"Oh, wow, Scorpia, you're amazing!" She said to herself, admiring her new look. "I won't be fighting in this, but it would definitely be good for special occasions or just hanging out. Needs something else though…hmmm…"

Sometimes We Slip

* TRYING NOT TO SLIP *

Shen walked down the hall, trying to make it back to his room without being noticed, making himself as small as possible. He wasn't trying to hide from Catra though; he was trying to hide from everything and everyone, all of reality if possible. Today was one of those days that he *slipped*.

It wasn't anything new. He had days like this even before the Other was placed inside him, and when the Other was with him, he knew nothing but these kinds of days. Days when he woke and the dread was there to greet him, days when the moments that seemed to stretch into infinity the day before seemed like today they became so small that he felt like he was going to suffocate. Days where there seemed no real tomorrow, only the reality of the darkness now.

When he had these days, he felt it was best to just stay away from other people, for he became more fragile and emotional during this period. Things were more likely to affect him, and his reactions tended to embarrass him when this darkness took over him. He definitely did not want his new friends to see him in this weak state, especially not Adora. The only person he ever felt comfortable seeing him like this was Shen'Dara... but he was long dead, and so was any form of comfort he could find.

These *slips* usually came out of nowhere to haunt him, but he knew this time, it had a specific cause.

It was yesterday, after the council meeting; everyone was gathered in Adora and Catra's room. All the princesses and friends were together, sharing a moment before they had to say a temporary farewell.

Shen had entered the room; it was packed with talking, smiling faces and much of the group was surrounding Mermista.

"So, like, I told this idiot that there was no way he was running off to join the Star Force." She was exclaiming to the group in her usual monotone voice.

"Mermista, darling, please, it would only be a temporary commission." The man next to her was saying. Sea-Hawk was his name, Shen remembered.

"Oh, yeah? Just like how you want to temporarily change your name to Star-Hawk?" Mermista said, almost sounding bored.

Everyone laughed or groaned at this, and Shen smiled at their close familiarity with each other.

He nervously looked around, making sure Catra wasn't sneaking up on him again, like yesterday when she shoved him into the cart. Then he saw her, laying on the bed on her stomach, feet in the air. She was wearing a new outfit; an orange short-sleeved shirt and dark pants, with a yellow stripe running down each pant leg. Next to her was the larger woman Scorpia; they were smiling and laughing while looking at a picture book together. It looked like a book on different outfits.

It was then that Adora came up to him, smiling.

"Hey, Shen, I wanted to talk to you." She said, gently guiding him over to the window, away from everyone else.

"What's up, Adora?" He asked.

Adora had seemed to be searching for words, so Shen spoke, feeling like he should say something.

"So, that was a really great speech by the Queen, Glimmer. I mean...with all of us together, the Shen'Aan-war doesn't stand a chance— and I'm speaking from experience with the man." He said, trying to be funny. He was starting to have a funny feeling about this interaction.

"Yeah, I really hope so, Shen. It's going to be hard out there in space. All of us have to be able to rely on each other, rely on that the other person to make the right choices." Adora had said, distracted.

"You can rely on me. I would always make the right choice where my friends are concerned." Shen stated, sincerity in his voice.

Adora met his gaze then, searching for something in his eyes. "I know you would, I really do. I mean... let's say, one of us was in trouble, not like they were going to die trouble, but just trouble. You could do something about it, but it would mean even greater danger for yourself and the likelihood of success would be slim. There may be other choices, but this is the one that comes to mind first. I have the feeling you would make that choice. Am I right, Shen?"

Shen didn't realize at the time that he was being tested. He didn't even hesitate in his enthusiasm to make Adora understand that he would do anything for her.

"Totally, without a second thought Adora. If any of you were in trouble, I would do anything to help. Anything." he said earnestly.

Adora had turned away from him at that moment to look out the window, gazing out at the Moon Stone. She then turned back to him, smiling brightly.

"That's why I want you to stay here in Bright Moon. I need you here helping to protect our home." She smiled with a hint of sadness in her eyes.

Her words hit him in the chest like an explosion of ice, spreading out from his heart and radiating to his extremities. His head felt

light, tingly. The icy feeling slowly left, but a sense of dread stayed.

"Wh…what? Why? I mean... I know this enemy... you need me out there, Adora." He stammered, his voice cracking.

"We got this, Shen. I mean, I saw the enemy in your head, so I have that experience to take with us. We need your experience here, just in case they get around us and attack here in Etheria. I need you to be okay with this, Shen. I need you here." Adora implored.

"Okay, Adora. I said I would be there for you whatever you needed, and if you need this, I'm okay with it." Shen had replied, almost whispering.

She smiled at him then and squeezed his shoulder, walking back toward the group.

He left and headed straight back to his room, anxiety growing in his chest. He spent the rest of the night tossing and turning, unable to sleep. When the morning arrived, the anxiety and dread had blossomed and bore fruit; he had a long, hard day ahead of him. He was hoping to just get through it and be okay tomorrow, for tomorrow was the day Adora, Glimmer and Bow were leaving with the others. He wanted to be there to say goodbye and not be the weak person he was now.

He was just returning from the kitchen, where he had forced himself to eat something, and was trying to sneak back to his room; he was almost there. Suddenly, Adora's door opened and out stepped Catra.

* * *

Catra was in her room, by herself packing for tomorrow, when she smelled him out in the hall. *Shen*.

Got ya, funny guy, she thought with a smile, walking quickly out her door and into the hallway.

There he was, walking near the wall, toward her; she was between him and his room.

Now, don't even try to run this time, she thought to herself, remembering the two other times she almost caught him since the council meeting. This guy was slippery to evade a hunter like Catra.

He stopped, not looking at her. He grimaced and continued to walk forward. He was trying to get as close to the wall as possible without making eye contact with her.

Does he think I will just let him walk past if he pretends that I'm not here? Fat chance, she thought as she glided over to intercept him.

He was just about to walk past her when she placed her arm in front of him, stopping him in his tracks. He just sighed and looked down, seeming to deflate.

"You thought you were *pretty* funny yesterday, didn't you? Laughing at me while I was scratching myself? Maybe I need to scratch a different little annoyance today? Hmmmmm?" She growled in his face; her voice full of menace.

He continued to look down and did not respond. Catra did not like this, and placed two fingers on his chin, raising his head so she could look into his eyes. Shen finally lifted his gaze into hers, and she was instantly shocked by what she saw there; her eyes went wide and her ears lowered.

She remembered those eyes; they were the same ones that would look back at her in the mirror during her darkest days in the Horde. The pain and the hopelessness were there, the loss of friends leaving her due to her actions. She was frozen in place, all thought of vengeance on Shen lost.

Shen raised his hand slowly, placing it on her hand holding his chin, and gently moved it down. He put his fingers directly over hers, wrapping her fingers around his neck, pressing the tips of

her claws so hard they drew blood. She looked down at what he was doing with her hand, helpless in her shock to stop him.

"Catra, I'm getting really *sick* of you dogging my steps, I'm really *tired* of your undeserved anger toward me. I'm sorry if you see something in me you don't like, I truly am, and I'm sorry that you don't appreciate the time I spend with Adora. But know that I won't stop helping her, so if you really want to stop me, just tear my throat out with your claws right now and get it over with. If not, then *just get out of my face*." Shen said, enunciating every word slowly and quietly in her face, the sincerity of his words driving deep into her.

Catra finally snapped out of it, yanking her hand back and stepped away from Shen; she was still shaken though. She looked down at the hand that he had held, seeing drops of red blood on the very tips of her claws. She quickly wiped them against her leg, trying to rid herself of the sight as fast as possible. For all her anger, bluster and fighting capabilities, Catra never enjoyed hurting people. It was hurting people that almost destroyed her.

* * *

Shen stared at her for a moment, then turned and continued walking as quickly as possible back to his room. He was close to bursting into tears and felt *her* continuing to watch him. He would have let her kill him then and there, but he would be damned if he let her see him cry.

* * *

Glimmer and Bow teleported outside of Madame Razz's cottage. Glimmer and Razz had become close over the past couple of weeks and she wanted to say her temporary goodbyes.

When her duties and other responsibilities allowed, Glimmer would teleport over to the old woman's cottage, eager to continue her studies. In their short time together, Glimmer had learned much from Razz, like how to focus her current connection to the

Moonstone to drive higher, toward the power that governed the Moonstone. It was a tentative connection, one that was immediately strengthened when using Razz's staff.

Using the staff, Glimmer could teleport even faster, seemingly blinking from place to place. She even learned to summon Star Fire, blasting enemies with a power even greater than her photo-kinetic blasts. Glimmer also gained the ability to levitate for short periods of time. This in combination with her new teleportation gave her the advantage of placing herself out of harm's way while hitting her enemies with spells.

She was still working on other abilities, but there was one she really wanted to know before leaving Bright Moon— the Cosmic Binding ability she saw Madame Razz use on the Demon-Heart. Glimmer felt that this spell in particular would be the most useful for her, although up until now, how to cast it eluded her. Hopefully, one last cram session would do the trick.

Glimmer left Bow outside with Swift Wind and entered the shack, letting her eyes adjust to the dim light. There was Razz, fussing about; it appeared she was baking, for she was pulling out a tray of cookies.

"Oh boy, looks like I'm just in time!" Glimmer exclaimed. She loved fresh baked cookies.

Madame Razz, looked up, a smile on her face. "Oh, Zzar? Madame Razz is so happy to see you!"

Glimmer rolled her eyes. *Here we go with this again, thinking I'm that woman from her vision,* she thought.

"Madame Razz, it's me, Glimmer. Remember, you have been teaching me magic for the past couple of weeks?" Glimmer asked, slowly and kindly.

"Yes, yes, Madame Razz knows that. You think Madame Razz is a silly old woman?" Razz said irritably.

I won't answer that... Glimmer thought. "No, of course not Madame Razz. I think you're the wisest person I know, and as Queen, I know a lot of wise people." Glimmer said, trying to placate the old woman.

"Hmph, now she tries to butter up Madame Razz, hmm… maybe it's working. Have a cookie, dearie." Madame Razz said, holding out her tray.

"I thought you'd never ask!" Glimmer exclaimed, happily snatching up a cookie and munching on it.

Madame Razz turned to Glimmer now, her previous senility seeming to vanish. "How is my robe working for you, dearie? Does it help?"

Glimmer stroked the robe. It had marginally strengthened her abilities, but not as much as the staff.

"It's fantastic, Madame Razz, I wear it all the time. It helps me focus and be in tune with the universe, the stars." Glimmer said, gratefully.

Madame Razz pinched Glimmer's cheek. "Good dearie, you are such a smart student, one of my best."

"How many students would that be?" asked Glimmer, already knowing the old woman would not remember.

"One million, two hundred thousand, seven hundred and thirty-ONE," Razz said, poking Glimmer in the chest with her broom handle, emphasized the one at the end.

Glimmer was stunned, not only at the old woman's sudden recollection but at the vast number of students she had in her long life… and she said Glimmer was one of the best.

"So, dearie, did you come for a lesson? Are you going to work on the Cosmic Binding some more with me?" asked Razz.

“That was the reason I came, Madame Razz… I feel I’m going to need it for what I also came here to tell you about.” Glimmer admitted.

Razz’s gaze became intense. “You’re leaving Etheria, aren’t you? You are going to face this evil?” Razz whispered.

Glimmer wasn’t really surprised by the old woman’s foresight. “Yes, I came to say goodbye for now. I am leading our forces out into space to face this enemy. The reports we’re receiving are grim, they are attacking and taking over planets, using some form of horrible magic to do it— some kind of Death Magic. The situation seems worse than with Horde Prime, for at least magic was his weakness.”

Madame Razz looked very sad at this. “Yes, yes, unfortunately, you must. But you will go armed properly. Here, take this.” Razz held out her broom, her forearm and hand transforming into that strange faceted skin. The broom once again became the magnificent Star-topped staff.

“You’re giving this to me? The Starstone?” Glimmer asked, awestruck.

“No, silly girl! I am just letting you borrow it! You are going to give it back when you’re done.” Madame Razz exclaimed, holding the staff out.

Glimmer took the offered staff. The power she felt within the Starstone was incredible.

“Now, remember what I told you, concentrate. Summoning the Cosmic Binding is not like hurling Star Fire at your enemies. Instead of intending to harm an enemy and harnessing your ill intentions, when you summon Cosmic Binding you are, in fact, helping an enemy. You are freeing them; you must concentrate on your empathy toward your enemy. This is why Cosmic Binding is so hard— to use it on your foe, you must feel compassion for

them.” Madame Razz instructed. “Now, pretend my vase here is an enemy. Summon the binding upon it.”

Glimmer did as she was instructed, and failed, laughing.

“Oh, Madame Razz, pretending the vase is an enemy is just too silly!” Glimmer exclaimed, still laughing.

Razz sighed. “Oh, the young.” She said looking up. “Instead of pretending, focus on a memory from your past, where you faced an enemy and instead of anger, you felt pity for them. Focus on that memory and direct it toward the vase.”

Glimmer searched her mind for such a memory and found one. One where she entered an enemy’s stronghold, ready to face and battle with her ultimate opponents at the time, but upon reaching her goal, found only a broken shell of a person.

It was Catra, laying up against the wall after defeating Hordak and her betrayal at the hands of Double Trouble. Glimmer had expected a fight like the one they had in her secret hideout in the Whispering Woods, but only found a dejected woman, asking Glimmer to just finish her off. Glimmer remembered her anger fading away and replaced with the pity she felt at seeing such a proud enemy brought so low.

Glimmer focused on this, concentrating it into the staff held upright in her hands. Beams of rainbow-colored light suddenly came down through the roof from every direction, alighting on the staff top; the Starstone grew bright.

She then pointed the staff at the vase, releasing the magic in the Starstone. Ribbons of starlight shot forth from the staff and encircled the vase.

At that moment, Glimmer finished recounting her memory of that time with Catra. She remembered Scorpia asking her not to hurt Catra, and Glimmer’s response was “We are the good guys, remember?” Glimmer did remember. She remembered that she

wasn't truthful to Scorpia at that time; she was angry at Catra and ready to do whatever it took to stop her. She was ready to kill her.

Suddenly the ribbons of star light burst into millions of small dancing lights. The spell failed.

Glimmer groaned, and Madame Razz shrugged her shoulders.

"Maybe just stick to the Star Fire?" Madame Razz suggested helpfully.

* * *

Adora was heading back to her room after a quick meeting with Admiral Octavia and General Juliet going over additional details of the departure tomorrow. The Admiral was going with them into space, but the General was staying behind to help guard their home. Adora was helping the General with potential strategies for repelling a ground invasion if it came to it. Adora loved that kind of stuff, it helped to keep her mind off the task ahead of them.

Entering her room, she was brought up short. There was Catra, sitting on the small couch by the window, looking out. She didn't turn when Adora walked in, but just kept sitting there, both legs folded under her, her arms crossed tight over her chest. Something was wrong.

Adora walked over to her. "Catra, are you okay?" she asked, full of concern.

Catra then turned, and Adora could tell she had been crying, tear tracks evident in the fur on her face.

"Oh, Adora…" She cried and Adora rushed forward, wrapping her arms around Catra.

Catra buried her face into Adora's neck. She started to cry harder now, shaking in her grief.

"Catra, shhh. What happened?" Adora soothed.

“I don’t know what’s wrong with me! I just…I just…keep *slipping*…slipping into my bad thoughts! Slipping into my bad actions! I keep thinking I left it all behind in the Horde, but it keeps creeping back!” Catra cried, her grief heartbreaking.

“Oh, Catra…just tell me what happened.” Adora gently coaxed.

Catra went into detail about the past couple of weeks, how she felt about seeing the heart rune on Shen’s chest, what it meant to her. How she began to resent it, and how she resented the fact that Adora would go to Shen for comfort for her nightmares. How Catra had tried to warn Shen away, and then the warnings turned into bullying.

Then, the encounter in the hallway earlier, what she recognized in Shen’s eyes and how it made her realize she was once again on the wrong path. The path that had led her to grief and sorrow, to being alone, to almost destroying her.

Adora pushed away her initial annoyance at Catra’s description of threatening Shen; now was not the time for that. Besides, Catra came to the correct conclusion on her own.

“Shhh…it's okay, Catra, it happens to all of us, sometimes we slip back into the people we don’t want to be, the people we thought we escaped. But it’s the knowledge that we are slipping that keeps up from falling too far. You did that Catra. You recognized that what you were doing was wrong. You’re not the same person as you were in the Horde, you’re a good person, Catra. I love you.” Adora stated softly. She was crying now too, the pain she saw in Catra too much for her to bear.

They stayed that way for a while, holding and comforting each other, until finally it subsided and Catra lifted her head to look into Adora’s eyes.

“So, you’re not mad at me? For not telling you about how I felt about Shen and what I did?” She asked.

"I wouldn't say that Catra, but I do forgive you," Adora said, a grin on her face. "This is why you need to talk to me when you start having these thoughts and feelings. We could have talked this through, we could have stopped this from happening. What is it that Perfuma is always telling you? I forget." Adora said, looking into Catra's eyes.

"Open your heart," Catra said, looking away with a little annoyance in her voice.

Adora remembered that was the same thing Shen said to her, the first night they met, as to why he decided to trust her.

Probably not something to mention right now though, considering the context it could be taken in, Adora thought.

"Well, they are words you should start living by and not something to annoy you, Catra," Adora said, just a hint of reproach in her voice.

Catra sighed deeply. "Yes, you're right of course," she said in acceptance, a small smile on her face.

"Now, this might make you mad, but I will push my luck. You should probably talk to Shen and apologize to him for the way things turned out between you. It sounds like he is going through something and it might make him feel better. I mean, I basically asked him to stay here instead of going with us, and I think he is taking it hard." Adora persuaded.

Catra tensed and Adora braced herself for anger, but it didn't come. She looked back out the window, some annoyance in her eyes. "Maybe, Adora... although you *are* pushing your luck now," she said, in a low voice.

Adora remembered getting scratched in the face when they were little for suggesting she make up with Lonnie and decided not to press it.

“Come on, let’s get our stuff together, we’re leaving tomorrow, remember?” Adora said, gently running her hand along Catra’s back. “If we get our stuff packed, we can go do something...or we can stay inside and *do something*. You pick.” She slyly suggested.

Catra smiled; she had the perfect idea for how to spend their evening. “Any chance we could just stay here, and I could get you to like, itch my entire back side? Tail included?”

* * *

The next morning, Adora was down by Bright Moon Bay on the small landing pad that served the air and space vehicles that visited Bright Moon. The landing pad plus the nearby motor pool were recent additions to accommodate some of the new technology gained from their absorption of the Horde. It was a bright day, just like any other Etherian day, but today was the day they were leaving for space, again. Adora thought on how the last time they went to space, they created this whole mess they were in now.

Looking up, she could see the Etherian Star Force fleet high above them, in low orbit. The white and gray dagger-shaped ships gleamed in the light reflected up from Etheria. They were all pointed in the same direction, the direction of the war. Small ships were ferrying back and forth supplies from the star port in the Old Fright Zone, trying to cram in as much as possible before departure.

She looked over at Darla, their ship, seeing Entrapta and Emily doing the same. The woman and robot had used every one of their appendages to carry as much stuff as possible. The plan was that Adora, Catra, Glimmer, Bow, Scorpia, Entrapta, Melog and Emily would take the ship up into orbit, docking with Admiral Octavia’s flagship, *Etheria’s Light.* Currently, the two were pushing a very large container on wheels up a side ramp into a larger storage hatch in the side.

What could that be? Knowing Entrapta it's something we will definitely need, Adora thought to herself.

They almost had the container in the hatch when Entrapta slipped. Just as the container was about to drive them back, Huntara strode up and heaved it bodily into the ship. The powerful woman smiled down at Entrapta and gave her the thumbs up, while Entrapta laughed, clapping her hands.

Everyone was there to say goodbye. All the princesses and their friends were hugging and exchanging humorous or tender words. Scorpia and Perfuma were both weeping. When they parted, Perfuma handed Scorpia a beautiful wildflower, one she grew on the spot.

"I poured all my love for you into this flower. It will stay beautiful the entire time you are away from me. It is a part of me so you will always have me close." the smaller princess said, gazing up at the larger one.

Bow, Glimmer, Netossa, Spinnerella and Frosta were happily talking, exchanging hugs. Catra and Melog stood nearby with Mermista and Sea-Hawk; it looked like the two women were poking fun at Sea-Hawk who was bathing in the attention. One last laugh before departure.

Everyone was there... except one. Adora looked around, disappointment written on her face.

"What's wrong with you?" Mermista asked, masking her concern with a bored tone.

"Oh... I was just hoping someone would be here, to see us off." Adora responded.

"It's that guy, Shen, right? The new guy?" Mermista asked. She was more insightful than she put on.

"Yeah, I think he took it pretty hard the other day when I said he should stay here. It was a lame reason I used to mask another

one. I think he saw through it." Adora said.

She explained to Mermista how she tested him, to see if he was ready or if he was going to be a big risk to himself and therefore, a risk to them. He had confirmed Adora's fears and Adora asked him to stay because it was the best option for them all.

"I don't know Adora. Like, maybe you were a little too hard on him. I seem to remember a certain person who charged into battle after battle as if she was still invincible, even after she lost her She-Ra powers. Like, we had to basically drag you off the field after you tried to take on that group of clones by yourself. That was also kind of a big risk for us, I might add." Mermista said, reproachfully.

"Oh please. I saw the light after that and changed my ways. It wasn't a problem after that." Adora said, a little smugly.

"Yeah, well, at least you got the chance to prove it. Sounds like you're not even giving this guy a chance. But, whatever, what do I know? I only took over temporary leadership responsibilities during that whole Horde Prime thing." Mermista walked away, and rejoined the group teasing Sea-Hawk.

Is she right? Am I being a hypocrite? Adora thought to herself. Then Adora thought of what Catra told her she had seen in Shen's eyes. *No, Adora, you're right. There is just too much damage there. Maybe he can be given his chance, but now is not the time.*

Just as she was about to give up on waiting and walk toward Darla, Adora heard a voice call behind her.

"Adora, wait!"

It was Shen, running up to catch her.

"About time! We're leaving soon, you almost missed us!" Adora said, relieved.

“Yeah, I’m sorry. I had to go over to the Guard quarters to get one of the weapons they confiscated off me when I was captured. I wanted to give it to you.” Shen ran up to Adora with something in his hand.

He opened his hand displaying a black silky bag with a silver drawstring chain. He upended it into his other hand and a smooth white stone landed in his palm.

“This is called the Heart Thorn. It has a few purposes, one being an assassin’s killing tool. I won’t go into detail about that, for I don’t think you would want to use it like that. Don’t worry, it’s safe. Its magic can only be activated by my command, so it can’t hurt you. What will be useful for you is its other property— it repels Szi’th. If they get too close, the power that gives them life fails. You don’t have to do anything, just keep it in your pocket.” Shen said, holding the Heart Thorn out to Adora.

“Wow, no one’s ever given me a Heart Thorn before.” She smiled, taking it in her hand.

“It’s the least I can do. If I can’t be there to help you, this is the next best thing.” Shen said, smiling.

There was no hint of recrimination in his voice, but Adora could tell he knew that she tested him the other night.

“Shen, about you not going... I—” Adora started.

“No, you don’t have to explain yourself to me, Adora. I understand. I’m an unknown element, untested. Bringing me out with you to face an enemy like the Shen’Aan-war and his army would be a bad idea. You have enough on your mind without having to deal with that.” Shen said.

Adora smiled and hugged him, relieved at his understanding; he returned the embrace.

“Be careful out there, my friend,” he whispered in her ear.

* * *

Shen watched Adora walk up the ramp into her ship. There was a lump in his throat, but he continued to smile as she walked up and waved goodbye to all her friends.

Glimmer and Bow came up and hugged him from both sides.

"Are you going to be okay, buddy?" Bow asked as he broke away.

Shen was touched. Bow was going off to face the Shen'Aan-war, yet here he was asking if *he* was going to be okay.

"Yeah, I'm just worried about you guys. This is a terrible enemy. Don't underestimate their cruelty." Shen replied, worry on his face.

"Oh, we got this. Crushing despots is our thing." Glimmer stated confidently.

"Don't forget— every night in Bright Moon is cake night and really early morning is the best time to get the pastries in the kitchen." Glimmer turned around and called before walking away with Bow.

He laughed and waved to them both as they walked up the ramp, with Scorpia, Entrapa and Emily behind them.

He saw Catra and Melog parting from Mermista and Seahawk and felt a pang of guilt at his behavior yesterday. As usual, when he slipped, he did something over the top and over-dramatic, and Catra received the brunt of that. He couldn't imagine what she thought of him now; probably what Adora thought— that he couldn't be trusted.

Telling someone to basically kill you may not be something these people are used to, Shen," he thought to himself.

It had worked though. Catra seemed to just be ignoring him now, instead of trying to scratch his face off. This was not what he really intended. He wanted to at least be cordial with Adora's girlfriend, but it looked like that would have to wait.

As Catra and Melog were boarding the ramp, Shen called out to Catra. “Catra, good luck out there. I mean it.” He yelled.

She stopped, but still faced forward. She seemed to tense, her tail twitched and one of her ears flicked.

She turned her head, not looking at him and nodded slightly—then she was gone.

The ship slowly powered up and lifted, higher and higher, hovering for a moment, then blasted off and up toward the waiting fleet.

He stood there watching the ship get smaller and smaller as the loneliness inside him grew larger.

He suddenly felt arms snaking around his right side and a hand clasping his left shoulder on his left. Turning side to side, he saw Perfuma on his right and Mermista on his left. Frosta, Netossa, Spinnerella, Sea-Hawk and Huntara were standing around them.

“Don’t worry, you won’t be alone while they’re gone,” Perfuma whispered kindly.

Shen turned to Mermista, who grinned lopsidedly at him. He felt his loneliness starting to fade, and they all turned their gaze upwards.

They all watched the sky as one by one, the ships jumped into hyperspace.

We Found the Enemy

Catra exited Scorpia's cabin, listening to Scorpia and Entrapta loudly singing away behind her with Melog mewling in the background. It sounded horrible and Catra grinned to herself.

Poor Entrapta is so tone-deaf, but Scorpia... she's actually pretty good, despite what I used to say to her. Her Ball is going to be great… when we finally get to have it, Catra thought to herself.

It was two days into their space journey to the Omiros Bridge. Catra had spent much of her time with Adora or hanging out with the Super Pal Trio. Catra had spent the last hour or so singing and drinking hot chocolate with them. She left to try and walk off the sugar high she built up.

She was still humming the last tune they sang together, one of Double Trouble's show tunes. She forgot the name of the show, something to do with having to pay someone for a place to live.

"Hmmm, hmmm, hmm… Five hundred twenty-five thousand moments so dear…" She contentedly continued to hum and sing out loud.

She strolled down the ship's passageway, inside the flagship, *Etheria's Light,* heading toward the officer's mess. Catra needed something stronger to offset all the sugar coursing through her.

She was on the port side, next to the ship's hull. There were portals showing the external view. It was all bleary colors and lights of hyperspace.

Catra's leg and ribs were feeling a lot better now. She felt like much of her flexibility had returned and she was ready to put up a proper fight. All that time healing and resting had given her a boundless wealth of energy. She wanted to run and leap down the halls, but restrained herself; the navy personnel and clones would probably be alarmed to see a sugar high Catra careening off the walls.

She laughed to herself at that image as she found the officer's mess, the automatic doors parting to allow her entrance. The place was mostly empty, with a few clones and officers Catra recognized some of the officers as ex-Horde. The figure at the bar was who really caught her attention; Catra strode up and sat next to the older woman.

"Whatcha drinking, Admiral?" Catra asked pleasantly.

Admiral Octavia turned her yellow and red bionic eye on Catra and smiled. "Oh, a little something that would make your tentacles twitch." She purred, giving Catra a toothy grin.

Upon her conviction and oath swearing after the Trial, Octavia had joined the burgeoning Navy; she was already a sort of Navy officer in the Horde, so the transition made sense. She found her niche in life in the Star Force and rose quickly through the ranks with her sense of duty and discipline. After only a year, she filled the empty position of Admiral, adding her own unique style of command to the Etherian Star Force. Admiral Octavia was not an aloof leader. She tended to mingle with personnel under command, so finding her in the officer's mess was not a big surprise.

"Barkeep, get my friend here a glass of my usual," Octavia told the robot bartender.

The robot did as it was asked, pouring a good-sized portion of the amber fluid into a glass, and sliding the glass down to Catra who caught it deftly. She took a sip; the fluid burned down her throat, warming her insides and making her tail frizz up.

“Whoooweee!” Catra exclaimed, as she started coughing. Octavia laughed knowingly and slapped Catra on the back.

Catra cleared her throat. “Ah-hem…so, when do you think we will reach the Bridge? Any report of whether or not we will find our quarry there?” Catra asked.

“From the scout reports, it sounds like they made it past the Omiros Bridge, taking the planet Omiros itself and Thenlor. Thenlor is a heavily populated city-planet. Reports we’ve gathered say they gave up without a fight because they didn’t want to risk any heavy loss of life.” Octavia said, all business now.

“That was a good idea. No one out here has the capability to protect themselves from these invaders, no one but *us*. I can’t wait to get my claws on these guys.” Catra declared. Suddenly, Catra was getting feisty.

“Ha! That’s the Catra I remember! Yes, we have yet to test the full fighting capabilities of this fleet, but from the constant drills I run our crews though, I know we are ready. Once we find these invaders, we will crush them.” Octavia stated, certainty in her voice.

“What about the reports I’ve heard... that the enemy fleet is able to use magic? That they have their sorcerers on board, what are they called... the Death-Binders.” Catra asked.

“Pah! Magic-wagic. With the fire power this fleet sports, no magic will stand a chance. Besides, with Queen Glimmer with us, we have magic of our own. From what she told me, she’s able to harness a different power, one that she can use in space, away from the Moonstone.” Octavia replied reassuringly.

Catra took another sip of the liquid, and thought of her friend Glimmer, how she had started wearing that strange new robe, a robe seemingly made of stars. Glimmer also started carrying a new staff with a bright light at the top, her old one attached to

her back. Glimmer radiated energy and power now, the sparkles in her hair and eyes more intense. Like stars.

Catra turned to look at the other woman, glancing at her bionic red eye, suddenly feeling guilty.

"You know, Octavia, I'm really sorry about the whole…" Catra said, pointing to Octavia's right eye.

"Bah!! Don't worry about it Catra, you were a little kid. Besides, during the trial, I had a lot of time to think of my time in the Horde, how perhaps, I didn't do a lot of things the right way. I was too hard on you kids. Trying to make you learn to swim was a waste of your talents, Catra. We should have been honing your strengths instead of making you waste time on a regimented set of skills that everyone had to work on. You showed us, though, in the end." Octavia said, knowingly.

Catra smiled sheepishly, she was suddenly feeling so sentimental right now. "I'm really glad you found your place here, in the Star Force, now look at you! Admiral! I hope you know you can always count on me." Catra said, smiling at the other woman.

Octavia beamed at Catra. "You can count on me as well. I would do anything for an ex-Horde sister, Catra. I want you to know that."

Catra thought about that as something caught her eye. On the back of Octavia's chair was her Star Force Admiral's jacket. It was all white with gold shoulder pads and large gold service stripes on both sleeves. It had holes in the back for Octavia's tentacles, but other than that it was a striking jacket.

"Come to think of it, that is a very cool jacket. Any chance I could get one just like it? Without the holes in the back?" Catra asked, hopefully.

* * *

Bow and Glimmer were in their cabin together alone, doing one of the few things you could do in the boredom of space.

They were playing with Bow's table-top miniatures.

Bow was using a ruler to measure the distance between his She-Ra figure and Glimmer's Catra figure. The figure of Catra was a representation of her when she was fighting for the Horde, clothed in her old two-toned reddish leotard sleeveless top over torn reddish-violet leggings and a crimson headpiece on her head.

"Ok, so at a distance of five, my She-Ra's sword blast only has an effective damage of plus five, but this is nullified by Catra's agility of plus eight, so…hmm…"

Glimmer was only half paying attention; she was resting her head in one hand and leaning over the table about to fall asleep.

"I guess I'll just roll the dice this turn and see if I can get close enough for melee damage." Bow said absentmindedly to himself.

"Mmm-hmm…" was Glimmer's response.

Bow suddenly looked at Glimmer and smiled to himself. He knew she hated playing this game, it was outside her realm of interest, but she played it for him. She did it because she loved him, and she knew how much he enjoyed this game. His thoughts were suddenly drawn in another direction. There was something that he had been thinking of asking Glimmer for a while now. He kept putting it off though, afraid of her response. But looking at Glimmer now, how she was willing to play this game with him even though it wasn't her favorite thing to do, made him realize that his fears were most likely unfounded. Bow made a decision.

"Glimmer?" he asked quietly.

"Hmmm?" was her sleepy response.

"When this is over, when we are back on Etheria, let's take the Vow. Let's take the Vow before the Moonstone and all our friends.

I want it to be official. I want it known to everyone that our love is forever.” Bow said, tentatively but emphatically.

“Whaaaaaaat?!” Glimmer exclaimed, raising herself back up, her voice rising to a crescendo. She was suddenly jolted wide awake by Bow’s proclamation.

“I mean it, let’s do it. I’m asking you; will you take the Vow with me, Glimmer? I love you so much, and I know you love me just as much.” Bow asked, a slight misting to his eyes.

Glimmer’s eyes suddenly softened. She smiled, a little misting to her eyes as well.

“You have interesting timing, Bow…yes, yes, I will take the Vow with you. I want to be with you for as long as I live. I love you so much.” She agreed, crying now.

They joined hands over the table and leaned over, knocking over all the miniatures as they kissed. When they parted, Glimmer stood up and walked around the table. She snuggled up against Bow, wrapping her arms around his chest and laying her head on his shoulder. Bow put his arm around her and laid his head on top of hers. They gazed out of the room’s portal together, the lights of hyperspace reflecting on their happy faces.

“Well, I know who I want as my Vow Paranymph. I’m definitely asking Adora.” Glimmer said. She was already dreaming of the ceremony.

“Not fair! I wanted Adora! Okay…fine.” teased Bow, not really upset.

“So, who are you going to ask then?” Glimmer asked, looking up at him.

“Hmmmm…what about Catra?” Bow said, uncertainly.

They both broke out into laughter.

* * *

Adora was holed up in the cabin she shared with Catra, going over the reports they had been receiving. It didn't look good. The enemy had progressed farther than originally thought; they made it past the Maelstrom Gulf and through the Omiros Bridge. They took two planets as well; Omiros and Thenlor, two planets that her forces were counting on having as way points.

They had only so many resources they could direct toward fighting and had to make a choice between which of the planets to liberate. Thenlor had the biggest population by far, but Omiros was the key to holding the Omiros Bridge, if they could hold it and control the Bridge, then perhaps then could go back and free Thenlor. That was unlikely though; they had to push forward once they controlled the Bridge.

Adora gritted her teeth. She hated this, hated being forced to choose the more sensible choice, the "correct" choice. There had to be a third option, but she just wasn't seeing it. Not yet, anyway.

She concentrated on Omiros, bringing up the intelligence they had on the planet. From what they knew, it was sparsely populated with a main capital city; Ackle. Adora selected an image, bringing up a view of the planet's surface.

The image showed a fantastic view; rolling green hills covered in yellow and blue flowers, two large snow-capped mountains in the distance. Among the hills were various buildings and settlements, no two the same.

There was a purple and blue tower composed of what looked like pipes, bending in all directions. It was almost mechanical looking, and Adora found herself thinking that it looked like a place Entrapta would love to vacation in.

There were yellow houses with purple roofs, perched on top of blue trees.

There was a series of stone platforms spiraling up to the sky. Some of the platforms had towers with sharply peaked roofs.

There were other fantastic buildings, with no two looking alike, and Adora was struck by how creative these people were. They seemed so peaceful and prosperous, but now they were under the control of a terrible enemy.

No, there was no third choice needed here. In every choice, there were people that needed Etheria's help, they needed She-Ra's help.

According to some of the intelligence the Star Siblings had gathered, the enemy was focused in the city of Ackle, holding the city and the nearby star port. The star port was the only one on the planet Omiros, so holding that was important. The enemy ran sorties and raids outside of the city, but mostly focused on the city itself; the rest of the planet's civilization was too spread out to maintain control over.

She brought up maps of the city and star port. The city was composed of one long white wall that spiraled into itself, the wall's height increasing with its journey into the center. At the center of the spiral was a tower, Ackle Keep, which was where the royal family lived. It was the tallest structure in the city. Between the spiral walls were various buildings; homes, shops and other structures that composed a city, they were all different shapes and sizes but none of them were higher than the adjacent walls.

Outside of the city was the star port. It was a circular pad, about half the size of the city, with a control tower at the edge and circular platforms of various sizes filling the rest of the pad. In the picture they had, various ships filled the pad, but Adora was sure that by now, they would be uniform; the ships of the invaders.

A plan started to form in Adora's mind, one she felt should be brought to her friend Glimmer's attention. If they could use their fleet to drive away any opposing ships, they could land a force which could then be divided into two smaller forces; one force to

take the city and the other to take the port. With the dual application of force, they would keep the enemies in the port and cities from retreating into each other and would simultaneously overwhelm them.

T*he two teams would need to be led by experienced leaders, not just the ground force sergeants. Perhaps Catra, Bow and I on one team, and Glimmer, Scorpia and Entrapta on the other?* Adora thought to herself, but quickly dismissed that idea. *No, it should be Catra with Scorpia and Entrapta. They already have past experience fighting alongside each other, same with Bow, Glimmer and I. I just need to convince Catra to become a leader again.*

Adora smiled as she thought of the symmetry of that plan; two forces that fought each other in the past, now fighting together for the same cause. It was perfect.

Adora spent the rest of the time writing out the details of her strategy on her data pad. The information there would be sent to Glimmer, the Admiral and the Colonel of the Etherian Star Force ground troops. Much of it depended on how well the Etherian Star Force fleet performed, for they had not yet engaged the enemy fleet in battle.

She had just finished and stood up to stretch her back when the room's communicator beeped. Adora pressed the button for the microphone.

“Adora here.” She prompted.

“Adora, it's Glimmer. We’re needed on the bridge.” Her friend said, her voice tinny through the speaker.

“Any idea what this is about?” Adora asked while putting on her purple and blue jacket.

“We found the enemy.” Was Glimmer’s ominous reply.

“Be right there!” Adora replied, running out the door.

* * *

Admiral Octavia had just entered the bridge, taking in the bustling chambers with a glance. The bridge was bustling with activity, clones and Etherian crew working together. The chamber was shaped like a long triangle. Long rectangular viewports ran along the two front edges of the triangle showing hyperspace outside of the ship. Monitors and crew stations ran along the edges as well, under the view ports. In the center of the bridge was a large recessed alcove with more crew stations along the sides and in the center.

Octavia had just come from the officer's mess, wanting to see if there were any updates while she had been away. The ship's captain approached her and saluted.

"At ease. What do you have to report, Captain Keylon?" Octavia asked.

The Captain indicated toward her second in Command. "Commander Longshot here has the report, I will defer to him."

Like all second-in-commands aboard the ships of the fleet, Commander Longshot was a clone and ex-intergalactic Horde. Since the Etherian crews were new to space travel, much of the fleet was integrated with the more experienced clones, and the second in command acted as liaison between the Etherian and the clone crew. Since none of the clones were allowed names under Horde Prime's rule, many of them took names that others had originally given them as nicknames once freed. Longshot's name came from the fact that many of his tactical suggestions were, in fact, long shots.

"Greetings, brother Admiral." The clone said, his voice the same resonating tone typical of all clones. "I will direct you to our holographic display terminal, please."

I don't mind these clones, but I wish they would stop calling me brother, Octavia thought, annoyed.

The three officers walked to the round terminal; the top was concave with four small emitter arms on the edges spaced equally apart from each other. Command Longshot entered in a command and the local quadrant was brought up, showing the systems for Omiros, Thenlor and Spira. They formed a kind of triangle, with Omiros and Thenlor being the base and Spira the top.

"We are approaching the Spira system. According to our sensors, the planet Spira is being engaged by an unknown enemy. They are calling for aid." Longshot reported.

Octavia rewarded him with her signature toothy grin. "Good, our first catch of the day." She said enthusiastically.

"I beg your pardon, brother?" The Commander said, confused.

"Oh, never mind, Commander. I was a sea captain before becoming a space Admiral, you wouldn't understand." Octavia snapped. "I want us to redirect our course to the planet Spira. There, we will engage this enemy and drive them away from the planet. I want all ships of the fleet on high alert and have their Star-Wing Commanders ready to launch fighters. I want this to go smoothly and by the numbers."

Both the Captain and Commander of the *Etheria's Light* snapped to attention, doing an about face, ready to carry out Octavia's commands.

* * *

Outside the planet Spira, all one hundred and forty-seven ships of the Etherian Star Force jumped out of hyperspace. Immediately upon arrival, all ships launched their complement of Star Wing fighters, the small single person fighters shooting forth to engage the enemy. The blue, white and purple fighters were shaped for their Star namesake, a sharp forward fuselage and four wings, with the two forward wings pointing down and the two rear wings pointing up. The fighters were a new addition to the old Horde

fleet, their design being one of the few technological weapon advancements that Hordak was allowed to work on.

The enemy fleet was caught unawares, for their attention was directed toward the planet's surface. The small fighters quickly overcame them and began to harry the larger ships.

As the Etherian fleet neared their enemy, their sensors were better able to project a clear image of the foe they sought. The Shen'Aan-war's ships were nowhere near as numerous as the Etherians, but the similarities in ship design were obvious. Both shared the same arrowhead design; a long sharp forward section with a smaller "tang" in the rear, where the engines were. It was almost as if they came from the same set of blueprints, blueprints that had been since lost to the sands of time. However, where the Etherian ships retained the original lighter colors of whites and grays, the Shen'Aan-wars's ships were pitch black against the planet behind them; it was as if the two fleets were light and dark reflections of each other.

The Shen'Aan-war's ships began to turn slowly, trying to face the approaching fleet while shooting broadsides at the attacking fighters.

* * *

Admiral Octavia watched from the Etheria Light's viewport, pleased with the way this fight was turning out. Behind her, she could hear the automatic doors of the bridge's entryway open as Glimmer, Adora and Bow entered.

"Admiral, we received news that we have engaged the enemy. Status, please." Glimmer said, authority in her voice.

"Yes, my Queen. We had received word that the nearby planet of Spira was currently under attack, and I ordered the fleet to change course for Spira. We are currently closing in to engage their ships while our fighters wear them down. They have yet to

deploy fighters of their own. Even without our fighters, we have their ships outnumbered five to one." Octavia reported.

Bow approached one of the crew stations, a close-up view of the enemy ships showing on one of the screens.

"The enemy ships sure do look a lot like ours, besides the color scheme, of course." Bow observed.

"Yes, our ships do share many similarities in design with theirs. I have no answer to that. Perhaps this Shen'Aan-war was once part of Horde Prime's fleet? I can only guess at this point. I would say we would have the advantage in knowing the enemy ship's weaknesses, but they would know ours as well. If not for our superior numbers and fighters, we would be evenly matched." Octavia answered.

At that moment three more figures entered the bridge, Catra, Scorpia and Entrapta. Entrapta immediately bounded ahead on her ponytails, going from one crew terminal to another, getting as much data as possible. Scorpia simply strode in, raising her arms in an extravagant yawn, looking around and smiling at everyone.

"Good morning, Bridge!" she said brightly. "Or is it still night? You can't really tell out here, can you, Wildcat?"

"Yeah, I hate space, reminds me of being on the Velvet Glove," Catra said, walking up to stand next to Adora.

The group turned back to the battle. The fleet had finally reached engagement distance and was firing on the enemy, who in turn, started to ignore the fighters and fired back at the larger enemy. Bright laser beams zipped past each other on divergent courses, alighting on shields and dissipating.

"The enemy ships are moving sluggishly. It's like they are inexperienced in manning their own ships, inexperienced with space combat." Captain Keylon stated as she walked up to her superior officer.

“Yes, Captain, this battle is turning out way better than my most optimistic projections. If the rest of the battles are like this, then we could be heading back to Etheria victorious in the next couple of weeks.” Octavia said, full of confidence.

Adora didn’t like it. It was too easy. Either the enemy had more ships, or superior technologically firepower was not their true weapon. She felt like it was the latter, but they had yet to see evidence that the Death-Binders were present.

“I think we should stay cautious Admiral, optimistically cautious, but still cautious,” Adora said, persuasively.

“Bah, Adora, we are crushing them!” Octavia said gleefully.

Just as she said that, one of the enemy ships lit up in a slow cascade of explosions, culminating in a massive fireball. The enemy ships surrounding the spreading mass of debris started to turn away from the Etherian fleet.

“Look, they’re running!” Glimmer shouted.

“Ha! See, these invaders are no match for Etherian might!” shouted Octavia.

“Admiral, should we pursue?” asked Captain Keylon, enthusiasm in her voice.

Admiral Octavia watched as the enemy fleet’s rear engines increased in power, the brightening of the rear thrusters intense. They were intent on a quick getaway to their jump points.

“No, Captain, let them go. We achieved what we came for, to help the people of Spira.” Admiral Octavia said quietly.

Glimmer smiled at the Admiral, feeling that at that moment, she was completely justified in giving the Ex-Horde Force Captain command of the fleet.

The Shen’Aan-war’s ships had by then gained the appropriate distance from the planet to make their jump. One by one, they vanished into hyperspace.

* * *

The Shen’Aan-war looked down at the shriveled, desiccated corpse of the unlucky messenger. The bearer had just delivered news of his fleet’s first encounter with the enemy, and the news had displeased the Shen’Aan-war enough to take his frustration out on the poor man with his power.

The Shen’Aan-war waved a gauntleted claw, indicating to one of his Shen'Sho-heim to remove the corpse. He did not know where it would be taken, for they were no longer in his castle on Shen’Dar-oom, and there were no corpse-pools for it to be deposited in.

The Shen’Aan-war was currently in the temple on the planet Twilight, or as he knew it, Dark Moon. The temple served as the perfect place for his base of operations in this universe, for it was already saturated with the dark power he was aligned with. He even had a make-shift throne created out of local stone and placed in front of the portal arch; it was there that he sat now.

The chamber was lit by magical scones placed on each of the pillars that ran the length of the chamber, the light they gave off simulating the light which the Set’Heth-un’dar projected, although not as intense. The chamber was now both simultaneously darker and brighter than when Adora and her friends visited it.

Up until now, the conquest of the greater universe had gone off without a hitch. They had arrived on this planet and secured it quickly, wiping out the local outpost with ease. From here, his forces had taken the planets Rahm, Makkina and Karthis. He had smiled when he was told about Karthis; he would enjoy visiting that planet again to relive some fond old memories.

They had taken other planets, some with the same old names, some with different new ones. His intelligence agents had gathered information on the planets taken, and through interviews, interrogations and data retrieval, pinpointed the location of the planet She-Ra was located; Etheria. It was also the planet the enemy fleet supposedly originated from.

He was completely shaken to his core when he heard that name again... and it took a lot to shake one as old and powerful as the Shen'Aan-war. Etheria was back, back from wherever Mara had taken it. It would make sense for it to be back though, for if She-Ra was back, then the planet she was last seen must have returned as well.

Once his initial shock had passed, he was filled with both trepidation and enthusiasm. If Etheria was back, then so must be the weapon, the Heart of Etheria, it was called. Would they use the weapon against him? Did they even know about it? Better yet, could he get his hands on it? Perhaps, but first, he must reach Etheria, which was on the other side of the Maelstrom Gulf. Even back in his day, the Gulf was there, and it was just as treacherous then. He had sent his forces ahead to take the Pass to the outer spiral arm, where Etheria was located.

There they had taken the ancient planet of Omiros to safeguard the Pass, and then to other planets as a further bulwark; Thenlor and Spira. Spira he remembered, but not Thenlor. From what he was told, Thenlor was a planet covered by an entire city. It sounded like there was much life there, much there to appease the power constantly hungering at the back of his soul. Its lust for life could be felt now, like a hunger pang, only deeper, and the desire far more immediate.

It was the news that the attempt to take Spira failed that had caused him to kill the courier, although whether it was out of anger or hunger, the Shen'Aan-war was not completely sure— nor did he care. From the reports gathered, his forces were greatly outnumbered by a superior fleet. The enemy also had smaller ships that were able to be launched from the larger, to rush

forward to attack his fleet. They were quite effective from the damage reports, able to get in close and exploit weaknesses.

The reports also stated that the enemy fleet was composed of old Empire ships, ships that Horde Prime had requisitioned and repurposed during the War. These Etherians must have captured them after defeating Horde Prime, and it seemed they captured many ships and could use them effectively... more effectively than his inexperienced crews. That was not an issue, for, in the end, it wasn't technology his people relied on, it was magic.

"High Priest, where are you?" the Shen'Aan-war called into the gloom of the chamber.

"Here, my Dread Lord." The head of the Death-Binders whispered as she walked from behind a pillar. She kneeled and lay her body flat in front of him, arms out in supplication to her master.

"And you, Admiral? Come forth before me." the Shen'Aan-war called.

The black uniformed, gray-haired man also appeared from behind a pillar. All his servants seemed to be hiding from him.

"Lord," he said as he crouched on one knee, one arm resting on the bent leg and the other ending in a fist against the floor, head bowed.

"High Priest, I want you to gather five covens and send them to our fleet guarding the Pass. You are to accompany them, and there, you will use your combined power on the Etherian Fleet. Admiral, I want you to leave the ships guarding Thenlor where they are, for that planet is a prize we must not lose. The ships guarding Omiros must fall back into the pass, strengthening the fleet there. We must hold the pass until it can be reinforced. Our ships at Rham, Makkina and Karthis must be immediately redirected to the Pass. Once reinforced, the fleet will push forward and drive our enemies back. The ground forces at Omiros will stay where they are to hold the planet without reinforcements. Do not

fail me, either of you.” The Shen’Aan-war said to both, the threat of horrible death not needing to be spoken aloud.

They both scurried back into the gloom, to carry out his orders and escape his gaze.

Etheria Strikes Back

* CATRA UNLEASHED *

Catra and Melog reached the crest of the hill and looked down at the city of Ackle. Portions of it were on fire from the ensuing battle. The flames danced and reflected off Catra's gold headpiece and her slit eyes, eyes that were now hooded in anger.

Catra had just led the attack on the Star Port, crushing all opposition there. It had only been guarded by a squad of the black uniformed soldiers and twenty of the foul Szi'th. The Star Port was now under their control, the captured soldiers guarded by a portion of her ground troops left behind. She had brought the rest of her forces to the city to meet up with Queen Glimmer and her team.

The past month of inactivity had built up to this breaking point. She was a rolling force of unadulterated fury, fury for these invaders who, up until now, had only the weak to prey on. She watched as a group of civilians ran from a break in the city wall, a group of black uniformed soldiers and Szi'th in pursuit.

Catra growled in fury, sprinting on all fours down the hill, Melog close behind her. Her friend was completely in tune with her anger, as they were now larger and bright red.

Catra absolutely hated bullies. She hated people that needed to hurt those weaker than them in order to feel empowered. She remembered all those in the Horde that would take advantage of her insecurities to make her feel small, their stupid faces grinning down at her and idiot eyes gleaming. That was, until Catra gained her confidence and turned the tables on them, beating them all

one by one until she led the Horde. Being on the receiving end for so long made it the only choice for Catra, and she took what she had learned and sharpened it, making it her weapon.

What she hated most of all about bullies was that she had become one in the end; she had become the ultimate bully in the Horde, using violence on her adoptive mother Shadow-Weaver, then using the threat of violence to control Hordak. At the time, when she was standing over both of them on the ground, she thought it would make her feel good, but it didn't; all it did was further dredge out her soul.

She thought she was past all of that when she defected from the Horde, leaving that toxic environment behind her. She thought she left behind Catra the bully, but when she saw Shen's blood on her claws, she knew that part of her was not fully gone. The damage was deep, but was it too deep? Was she too damaged? She wanted to claw out that part of her, she wanted to be the opposite of a bully; she wanted to be like Adora. For once, she wanted to be the hero.

Melog and Catra were almost to the group of fleeing people when they both leapt, feet up and claws out, over the entire group of screaming civilians. With both feet extended forward, Catra struck the lead soldier in pursuit in the chest, folding them over and on their back. Melog pounced into the one behind, biting and scratching them. Catra continued her momentum in a roll, taking her into the middle of the group of soldiers, then stood, half-crouched. The soldiers turned, surrounding her, holding out various weapons; clubs, knives, short swords, and stun batons.

"You better put those away, otherwise you're going to make me mad." Catra snarled lowly, before crouching lower and roaring at them, claws out, ears down and tail twitching.

Many of the troopers were taken aback by her fury; the ones in the back pushed their fellows forward to goad them into action. Then, gaining bravery in their supposed superior numbers, they rushed in to attack her.

The first soldier tried to bring a club down on her, but Catra easily dodged this and rewarded them with a knee to the sternum; the soldier doubled over onto the ground. Someone tried to stab Catra with a knife, but she expertly redirected the blade away from her body, bringing her other hand down in a chop on the forearm. It snapped and the attacker screamed, dropping the knife and holding their wounded limb. Two soldiers tried to rush Catra from both sides. She performed a handstand, kicking out in two directions, driving her clawed feet into their faces, they fell unconscious to the ground. When someone raised a sword to strike her from behind, she spun around in a flash and sliced the wrist holding the sword with her claws. The man screamed, dropping the sword, holding his bleeding wrist.

"Don't fight dirty with me, buddy," she growled at him.

By now Melog was at Catra's side, and they fought as one, constantly on the move; they seemed to be one whole terrible animal bent on the punishment of the Shen'Aan-war's forces.

More soldiers rushed in to try and take on this whirling dervish of claws, kicks and karate-chops when a voice rang out.

"Catra! Wait for us!"

A white-haired, red-armored juggernaut slammed into the crowd of soldiers surrounding Catra, flinging bodies in every direction. Scorpia had finally caught up with her fleet-footed friend and was desperate to reach her side.

She stopped, panting, in front of Catra, claws on her knees. "My word, you're fast." She gasped.

"Here I come! AHAHAHAHA!" A laughing voice called from the direction of the hill.

A purple and blue shape could be seen rolling down the hill toward the crowd of enemies. It stuck them with the same force as Scorpia, knocking the troops who had just regained their footing right back into the dirt. Once among the group, the rolling

object unfolded into an upside-down dome-shaped body with two large front arms ending in large fists and two smaller legs. A purple cockpit was in the flat top of the dome-shaped body, and Catra could see a ponytailed figure waving and smiling at her.

"Hey, Catra! Linda came as fast as she could!" Entrapta called to her friend through the outside vocalizer.

True to her word, Entrapta did come back for her mechanical invention and friend she left on Beast Island, transporting it back to Dryl and naming her "Linda". It was Linda in her storage container that Adora had seen being loaded into the ship by Entrapta and Emily.

Linda grabbed two approaching soldiers and slammed them together, dropping them, unconscious, to the ground. The rest of the soldiers who weren't wounded or unconscious, ran back toward the city. However, the fight was not over.

"AHHHHHHH!!!! Here come the Szi'th! They're so gross!" Entrapped cried as the shambling group finally reached them.

Catra smiled menacingly. She held her hand out to Melog asking them to stay put, and turned toward the Szi'th, dropping to all fours and running toward the foe.

Scorpia reached out toward her. "Oh, come on! Wait for me to catch my breath!" She yelled after Catra.

Catra ignored her and charged the group of undead; she didn't need any help for this. Just as she came within striking distance, the Szi'th in the front suddenly howled and reared back from the charging Catra. She ran full speed into the group, as she passed them and they fell limp to the ground, the foul magic animating them seeming to flee their bodies. Once Catra exited the back of the group, she turned for another pass, continuing her tactic until all the Szi'th lay in a pile, defeated.

Scorpia, Entrapta and Melog finally caught up and Catra stood to meet them, hands on her hips, laughing.

“Wow, you’re so amazing, Wildcat,” Scorpia whispered, in awe of her friend.

Catra smiled and tapped the crown of her gold headpiece with a clawed finger, the Heart Thorn gleaming from where it was inlaid. Adora had given Shen’s gift to Catra, and it was her secret weapon against the Szi’th.

“Catra, any chance I could—” began Entrapta.

“Not a chance.” Catra cut her off, already knowing what the woman would ask.

It was then the group of civilians tentatively approached them, a man and a small girl in the front.

Like all Omirosians, the man was tall with dark orange skin and had four arms, each ending in three digits. His head was hairless, the face broad and open, two eyes colored like opals with no pupils. The young girl was similarly featured but had long bright pink hair. The man approached Catra, sensing she was their leader.

“Did you come here to save us? Who are you?” he asked, in an awed whisper.

Catra stood up straight and pointed a clawed thumb to herself. “Catra, the name’s Catra. This is Scorpia, Entrapta and Melog, we’re *the good guys*.” She said smugly.

The little girl ran up to Catra and wrapped all four of her little arms around her leg. Catra looked down in shock to see the child beaming back up at her, and a lump formed in Catra’s throat.

“You saved us. You’re a *hero*!” the little one exclaimed.

Catra’s heart swelled and she had to suppress a purr that was about to form in her chest. She felt a weight on her shoulder, and she looked to see Scorpia’s claw there, the larger woman beaming down at her.

“Feels good, huh Catra? Doing good.” Scorpia whispered, warmth in her voice.

Catra beamed back at her, it was one of the most genuine and joy-filled smiles Scorpia had ever seen the other woman give her.

Just then, Catra’s contingent of Star Force ground troops crested the hill and jogged down toward them, finally catching up to their leaders. The troopers wore a variation of the armor the old Etherian Horde wore; the armor plating was blue with purple trim, the bodysuit underneath white. The purple faceplate of the helmet was no longer a sharp-angled butterfly shape, but more open, encompassing the entire face. Replacing the Horde symbol on the chest plate was the shining star of the Etherian Star Force.

Just like the people of Etheria, the troopers were a mixed band of races, and the armor fit their varied bodies in different configurations. The weapons they each carried were the same batons the Horde troopers were once equipped with, a mixed blaster and stun weapon.

“Sergeant, how good of you to show up!” Catra called out playfully.

“I’d really wish you would wait for us; the Queen would have my head if anything happened to you.” the Sergeant complained.

“Oh please, nothing is going to happen to me,” Catra said, still riding the high of her victories. “I promise I’ll let you keep up for this next part. We’re heading into the city to meet up with Glimmer. Leave a small squad behind to protect these civilians. Let’s move out!”

Catra, Melog, Scorpia and Entrapta led the troops toward the break in the city wall, and for once, Catra did not run ahead.

* * *

She-Ra/Adora, Glimmer and Bow fought through the streets of the city, driving the Shen’Aan-war’s troops back through the spiral and

toward the city center. Up until now, the fighting had been slow going, the spiral design of the city beginning to frustrate them.

The enemy they fought thus far was a mass of mixed enemies, the black uniformed troops and Szi'th relying on close-quarters combat, counting on the few Death-Binders in the field to magically shield them from the ranged weapons of Etherian forces. Try as she might, Glimmer was unable to break through the barriers with her Star Fire blasts; the enemy sorcerers were able to combine their powers to enhance the barriers. The Etherians were forced to fight the Shen'Aan-war's troops on their terms, up close and personal.

"Ugh, I'm getting sick of this." She-Ra/Adora grunted while blocking a sword strike from a black-clad trooper. She deftly disarmed him and punched him back into a crowd of his fellows, all of them ending up in a tangled pile.

"I'm up for any suggestions." Glimmer replied, blasting Star-fire into another group of enemies. Being the Queen had given Glimmer authority over this task force, so any change in tactics would come from her.

Adora looked at the smooth white inner wall of this section of the spiral, her face brightening. "Here is the idea *and* the application of it!" she yelled and rushed to the wall. With three mighty sword blows, she created a hole big enough for them to fit, one-by-one.

"Adora! We are here to liberate this city, not tear it to pieces!" Glimmer yelled.

"At the rate we're going and the destruction we've caused so far, I think this is the least destructive way!" she retorted.

"If we keep breaking through the walls in this way, we can head straight to the center, taking the enemy leader and ending this now!" Bow spoke up.

Glimmer scowled, remembering the last time Adora and Bow had ganged up on her. They had ended up being right, too.

“Fine. Sergeant, keep pushing with your troops and keep them distracted here. We are going to spit up and go straight for the enemy’s head!” she yelled to her ground force commander.

Just as they were about to head into the hole Adora created, Catra, Scorpia, Entrapta, Melog and their forces arrived, bolstering the Etherian liberators.

“Catra! You were supposed to take the Star Port! What are you doing here?” Glimmer yelled.

Catra put her hands on her hips and gave Glimmer her cockiest smile. “The Star Port is ours, courtesy of the Super Pal Trio. You’re welcome, by the way.”

Scorpia beamed at Catra’s use of the name she invented for their little group; up until now, Catra had never referred to them by that title.

Glimmer was taken aback by the news. “Oh, well…okay. Good work, Catra. Scorpia, Entrapta, lead your troops here in support of mine, help them push into the city. Catra, since your tail seems to be on fire today, maybe you should come with us. We are going straight for Ackle Keep!”

Catra was excited by this news and grinned at She-Ra/Adora. “Count me in!” she said, all enthusiasm.

Catra then turned to Melog and subtly pointed in Entrapta’s direction, pulsing an ask to her friend. Melog nodded their head and bounded off after Entrapta to guard her and keep her out of trouble to the best of their abilities.

The four friends headed through the hole created by She-Ra/Adora, while Scorpia and Entrapta directed the Etherian forces forward.

As they entered the next section of the city, they could see it was empty. All enemy forces were concentrating on the engagement further out of the spiral.

“See, told ya.” She-Ra/Adora said to Glimmer, smirking.

Glimmered glowered at her but said nothing as She-Ra/Adora ran to the next inner wall, striking it with crushing blows from her sword.

Catra crossed her arms and watched in appreciation. “I really love watching you break stuff, Adora.” She purred.

She-Ra/Adora smashed through the wall and they continued their journey to the center of the city, the area they entered smaller than the last.

“We there yet?” asked Glimmer.

“According to the maps and diagrams I studied, the spiral should end after this wall. Ackle Keep should be on the other side.” She-Ra/Adora said, running to the next wall. She smashed through it with one blow, revealing a small courtyard and the lower portion of Ackle Keep.

The keep was composed of smooth white stone, much like the wall surrounding it, but the white of this stone seemed to radiate darkness. As they progressed further and further into the spiral, She-Ra/Adora could feel a slow creep of dread and evil as they got closer to the keep. She hesitated as she inspected the tower, trying to pinpoint the source of the evil.

Glimmer noticed her friend stopping. She walked up to Adora and placed her hand on the other woman’s arm. “You can feel it too, can you? The Evil.” She said, almost whispering.

She-Ra/Adora looked down at Glimmer. “Yes, I think it’s coming from the top of the keep. That is where we will find what we came for.”

She-Ra/Adora looked over at Bow and Catra, trying to see if they were similarly affected. As usual, Bow’s positive outlook was not shaken and he glanced back at her, giving her a thumbs up and a winning smile. She could tell Catra could sense it though, for her

ears were down and her tail was twice its normal size. She seemed to be crouching a little as well.

"Okay guys, let's get in there and get this over with. Be on your guard. We've had it easy so far and I think we're going to find our true test at the top of this tower." Glimmer said to her friends.

They all ran toward the tower base, looking for the entrance, but as they walked around the base and came full circle, they could not locate it.

"Ugh, it must be some sort of illusion spell. I got this." Glimmer said, holding her black star topped staff out.

Glimmer pulled her star-covered robe around her and lifted the staff up, closing her eyes. Rainbow beams of light shot down from the sky, alighting on the top of the staff as it grew brighter. Glimmer held the staff out, directing the light at the tower base. She walked around, waving the staff and directing the starlight to different portions of the white wall. Finally, she found it— two white double doors, the seams so fine that the door was almost indistinguishable from the wall.

"Found it!" Glimmer called brightly.

"Let's get in there!" Catra yelled, running toward the door with her hands held out to her sides, claws out.

"Catra, wait!" yelled She-Ra/Adora, just as the doors exploded outward.

Two large, black-armored figures strode out, weapons in hand, it was the Shen'Sho-heim. They were tall, perhaps as tall as She-Ra, and covered in segmented black plates that seemed to absorb the light. Their armor styles were varied in subtle ways from each other, like two individual warriors. Their helms completely encompassed their faces except for a visor slit, two deathly white lights peered out from within. Like their armor, their weapons were also not the same; the one facing them on the left had a

massive black sword held in both hands, while the other held a gigantic black maul.

The one with the maul went for Catra, smashing it down at the opponent that dared charge the tower they guarded. The maul slammed into empty ground as Catra did a backflip away from harm.

Glimmer raised her charged staff and blasted the maul-toting giant in the face, staggering it but not bringing it down. She-Ra/Adora charged the sword-wielding one and engaged it, sword to sword. They traded gigantic blows, both bringing forth massive strength to their strikes.

The maul-toting Shen'Sho-heim strode forth, intent on smiting the small sorcerer who hurt it. It was struck by three arrow strikes, one to each leg and one to the face, each hit leaving a thick green substance behind, hindering its movement. It emitted a strange scream while it fought to free itself from its green bindings.

"Ha, got ya! Stay away from my Vow-Promised!" Bow yelled, pumping a fist in the air.

She-Ra/Adora was immediately taken aback by Bow's proclamation and hesitated, causing her to be knocked back on her rear. She stood up, confusion and surprise on her face.

"Wait...you and Glimmer are taking the Vow? When were you going to tell us?" she yelled accusingly at her friend.

"Sorry, Adora... it was a recent decision. We were going to tell you soon, I promise!" Bow called back while shooting more arrows into the struggling Shen'Sho-heim.

"Oh boy, I was looking for a reason to wear my purple tuxedo again!" Catra yelled as she leaped on the shoulder of the maul-toting enemy, striking at its helmet with her claws. Sparks flew, but the armor was impervious to her strikes.

“Who said you were invited, Catra? We don’t need Vow crashers!” Glimmer yelled, teasing her friend while absorbing more energy for another Star Fire blast.

Catra leapt as the giant foolishly tried to strike backwards at her with its own weapon; it only succeeded in smashing its own head, finally denting the armor. Catra backflipped and landed next to Glimmer.

“Uh, I’m totally going to be there… you’re just kidding, right?” Catra asked Glimmer, worriedly.

Glimmer laughed at her friend and blasted the Shen’Sho-heim directly where the dent was, taking the head clean off. It dropped the maul and clutched at its empty neck socket, white deathly vapors blasting out the top like a steam kettle. As the vapors finally stopped, its entire armored body fell to pieces; it was completely empty within.

Glimmer smiled at Catra and put her hand on the woman’s shoulder. “Yes, Catra, of course. I’m asking Adora to be my Vow Paranymph, Bow was going to ask you to be his.”

“Uh, wait, that was not a definite yet.” Bow said as he ran toward the fight between Adora and the sword-wielding Shen’Sho-heim.

“Well, it is now! If Adora gets to be a Paranymph, then I do too!” Catra pouted.

“Fine, fine. Maybe we should stop talking about Vow planning and go help Adora instead, though?” Glimmer said, exasperated.

She-Ra/Adora had just blocked a sword strike and kicked her opponent’s legs out, watching the armored warrior fall face-first to the ground. With a cry of fury, she spun her sword hilt around and plunged the blade into the Shen’Sho-heim’s back. The giant emitted the same strange scream as its sibling as she drew the sword back out. Ghostly vapors blasting out of the hole, leaving only an empty shell behind.

She-Ra/Adora walked over to her friends, a huge smile on her face. She gathered them all into a huge hug and squeezed them tight.

"Ohhh, my best friends are taking the Vow! I'm so happy!" she exclaimed into their groaning faces; she was squeezing a little too tightly.

"Unnnnn…Adora, you're killing us…" groaned Bow.

"Uggghhh…Adora…will you be my Vow Paranymph?… Uggggh…" Glimmer wheezed.

"Adora…my ribs…you're breaking them again…" gasped Catra.

She-Ra/Adora finally released them, still beaming down at them.

"Yes! Yes, Glimmer, I will stand by your side while you take the Vow. Yes, yes, yes!" She-Ra/Adora was almost crying now.

Bow and Glimmer looked at each other, with big smiles on their faces and love in their eyes for each other. She-Ra/Adora glanced at Catra; their eyes met, and they shared a knowing look. Catra smiled strangely at her and then looked away, still smiling, but also a little embarrassed.

"Okay guys, let's focus. Somehow, we just beat two of the Shen'Aan-war's best fighters all while talking about Vow ceremonies. I don't think our next fight will be so easy." Glimmer said, putting some force behind her words.

"Right! Best friends squad together, always!" Bow said, holding out his hand.

Glimmer and She-Ra/Adora smiled and placed their hands on top of his, looking over at Catra. She looked at this with her arms crossed, then rolled her eyes and finally put her hand in. They all raised their hands in the air at once.

“You guys should know I’m already part of the Super-pal Trio. That means that I’m the only one of you with dual membership in two friends’ clubs.” Catra said. It almost sounded like she was gloating.

“How in the name of Etheria did that happen?” Bow said in a fake whisper to Glimmer and She-Ra/Adora. Catra slapped him playfully on the chest.

They all turned and headed into the tower. It seemed as if all the lamps and sources of light were eliminated within, the darkness endless. Glimmer held her staff out and the light at the top pulsed brighter, pushing the darkness back. Looking around inside the chamber, they located a spiral staircase heading upwards.

She-Ra/Adora took the lead, with Bow and Glimmer in the center and Catra protecting them from the rear. They slowly made their way up the tower; once in a while, an empty chamber would open up. After a cursory inspection, the group would continue on their way up, up into the darkness. They finally came to the top to an entrance from which they saw the same ghostly light that emanated from the Shen’Sho-heim’s eyes.

They entered into a large chamber. At the center was what looked like a large metallic pot, and above it, was a ghostly shimmering orb; the source of the light. It was terrible to look upon, like looking at the sun; one couldn’t make direct eye contact with it without something terrible happening to them.

All around the metallic pot were discarded clothes. The implications too horrible to mention, for here and there were the four-armed shirts typically worn by the locals.

Behind the orb was a black-robed, hooded figure, their hands raised as if they were basking in the orb’s power. They lowered their hood, revealing a man’s face. It was a horrible face, bald and pallid, the eyes cruelly sutured closed, but the worst part was that the face was smiling kindly at them.

“Greetings, friends, welcome! Come, stand by my side and bask in the light I have created! Let it warm you…” he greeted in a melodious but raspy voice.

“No thanks,” She-Ra/Adora dryly replied. “We’re not here for your creepy light or your even more creepy company. We’re here for your surrender. We are here to liberate Omiros.”

The robed man, who must have been the Death-Binder, looked disappointed at this pronouncement and tsked at them.

“What are you *doing* here? What have you done to the people here?” Glimmer asked, horror in her voice.

“Ahhh…my child, it is *wonderous.* I could teach you, you know. I can sense that you too have power, although it is a foul power. As a Coven Master, I can bring you into our fold, teach you the right way. Would you like that, my child?” the Coven Master asked Glimmer.

Glimmer wanted to spit in his face, but instead, she raised her staff, ready to teach this man *her way*.

“If you are the leader of the forces here, I am formally asking for your surrender. Do you accept?” Glimmer asked, using her most formal voice.

The Death Binder laughed loudly. “My child, there is no surrender for me, no turning. My soul is bound to the Set’Heth-un’dar and I would have it no other way!”

The Death Binder raised his hands, placing them against the orb and screamed. The orb seemed to grow in intensity and horror.

Glimmer immediately raised her staff, creating a barrier against whatever foul magic this insane enemy was about to release. She-Ra/Adora, Bow and Catra were huddled together behind the barrier in front of her, hoping Glimmer’s magic would hold.

The orb's intensity had reached a crescendo and exploded, screaming like a hundred souls crying all at once. It blasted outward with such force the entire roof and surrounding wall of the tower were vaporized. Screaming vapors seemed to zip back and forth through the empty space, like gleeful, howling ghosts, and then, they too were gone.

She-Ra/Adora raised herself up, looking at Bow and Catra; they were unhurt.

"Glimmer!" cried Catra. She-Ra/Adora turned to see Glimmer lifeless on the ground, eyes wide open, the black star-topped staff at her side.

"NOOOOO!!!" Bow screamed as he ran to her side and lifted her in his arms, cradling her against his body.

She-Ra/Adora ran next to him, Catra was already feeling Glimmer's neck for a pulse. She turned to She-Ra/Adora with tears in her eyes. "Adora, I can't find her pulse. Please do something! Use your power!" Catra cried.

She-Ra/Adora closed her eyes and concentrated, summoning her healing ability. When she opened her eyes, they were shining with gold-yellow light. The light spread over her body and all the way to her hands, which seemed to glow the brightest. She placed her hands on Glimmer's chest and closed her eyes again.

She reached inside Glimmer, feeling for her heart; it was stilled. She focused there, using her power to massage the heart and impart her healing force to it. It came to life, beating hard to catch up for lost time, pumping life-giving blood once again through Glimmer's veins. She-Ra/Adora stayed, searching for other injuries, reaching into Glimmer's consciousness, searching for signs of her friend. It was hard, for she was there but not, like walking into her room at Bright Moon and seeing signs that she lived there, but not finding Glimmer.

She-Ra/Adora opened her eyes, reverting her form to just Adora.

“Adora, I have a pulse, but she’s not opening her eyes. Why won’t she wake up?” Catra asked, trepidation in her voice. Bow was inconsolable, weeping over Glimmer.

“I don’t know, Catra. All I know is that we need to get out of here.” Adora said, looking around at the empty space where the tower walls and ceiling used to be. A strong wind had started blowing in and whipped around the tower, creating eerie, lonely sounds.

Adora gently reached toward Bow, into his pockets, removing his data-pad, he didn’t even notice.

Adora pressed a command into the data-pad; it beeped as it made contact.

“Adora! You won’t believe it! We—” Entrapta began.

“Entrapta, not now! Glimmer is hurt badly. We need you to bring Darla to the top of Ackle Keep, we need an evacuation, now!” Adora yelled into the data-pad.

“Right, Adora, don’t worry, we’re on our way,” Entrapta said as she signed off.

They stayed at the top of the empty tower in a protective circle around Glimmer, the lonely wind blowing over them, listening to the roar of Darla’s engines rising in the distance as Entrapta brought her in.

Things Fall Apart

Glimmer wakes; she is alone and it's cold, very cold. She looks around and sees that she's in some sort of hall. The walls seem to be made of smooth blue and purple crystal. The shape of the hall is not straight; the walls rise at an angle outward from the floor, then turn back in at the middle, peaking at the top. Looking closely at the wall, Glimmer can recognize First One's writing. She suddenly recognizes the place. She is inside a First One's Temple, although this temple seems different, somehow newer than the Crystal Castle she remembers visiting on Etheria.

She hears voices emanating from down the hall, they seem to be chanting. She follows the sound down through the corridors. As she walks down the halls, she sees them change somehow, the purple and blue hues becoming duller, more dead. The runes suddenly become more jagged, more sinister. It was as if the place was corrupting before her very eyes.

Glimmer finally finds the source of the chanting in a large chamber. Looking around, she finds that the place seems familiar to her somehow. There is a large crystalline portal in the back of the chamber; it is already activated, and a shimmering energy field with ripple-like waves could be seen under the arch. There are long side-by-side cylindrical pillars running down the center of the chamber, but they are not pillars. They are bright, like they somehow contain sunlight, and Glimmer realizes that they must be some form of solar light collectors. It was when she saw the altar before the shimmering portal that she finally realized where she was. She was on the planet Twilight, in the strange First One's temple there.

Somehow, she was seeing the temple in the past, before it was corrupted.

Glimmer looks around and sees hooded, robed figures spaced about the place. They are the ones chanting. No one turns as Glimmer enters the chamber; it is as if she is invisible. She catches sight of a figure she recognizes, a figure that seems to be orchestrating the events in the chamber. A blonde-haired woman dressed in a black jacket, black pants and knee-high, high-heeled boots. She is carrying a white staff topped with a gleaming yellow gem.

Zzar is her name. She is the woman from her vision in Razz's cottage. She is approaching the altar when a figure comes through the portal. As soon as they appear, they run toward Zzar.

"Zzar! Stop this at once, you've gone too far this time! I don't care if you are the Castle Sorcerer, I'm here to stop you." the figure cries. It is an older woman. She is also dressed in robes and carries a staff.

Zzar slowly turns toward her, laughing maliciously. "You're an old fool, Kuduk, a fool for doubting me and a fool to come here to stop me."

"How can you do this? Adam is an idiot. He doesn't truly know what you intend. There is no way he would agree to this madness!" Kuduk cries.

Zzar laughs. "Three times the fool, Kuduk. Adam gave his blessing to this ceremony. He knows that we must make sacrifices for the greater good, for Eternia, for the Empire!"

The older woman raises her staff toward Zzar. "No!" she screams as a bolt of fire issues forth from the end of her staff.

Zzar raises her own staff and deflects the firebolt away from her, it lands against the ceiling. Zzar then points her own staff at Kuduk. The beautiful yellow light at the top changes, becoming a white deathly light. A screaming orb issues forth from the end. The

white orb moves slowly, but somehow with a purpose, as if it was searching for something. Kuduk screams and attempts to move out of the orb's way, but it follows her like a hungry animal seeking its prey. It finally catches Kuduk right as she is about to enter the portal, and she screams in pain and horror. It consumes her slowly, like it was enjoying her torment. Finally, the screaming ceases. Kuduk is gone.

"Old fool," Zzar mutters as she turns, resuming her course to the altar.

She raises her staff and inserts it into an alcove in the top of the altar; its light has returned to its beautiful yellow color and it pulses as it is set into place.

"Let us begin!" Zzar calls to her acolytes.

The robed figures approach the pillars of light. Glimmer notices that there is an acolyte for each pillar, and they place both hands on their appointed container of light and close their eyes.

Zzar wraps both of her hands on the white staff and closes her eyes. She begins chanting, like the one her acolytes spoke earlier, but it changes into a new language, one with a lot of hissing sounds. Glimmer recognizes the language; it is the one that was briefly spoken by Shen before he used magic to speak to her in her language.

A low hum can be heard now, coming from everywhere and nowhere at once, building as Zzar chants. Suddenly, the top of the white staff explodes in a cloud of spreading darkness and the gem at the top becomes its deathly white color again. The columns of bright sunlight suddenly turn pitch black, consuming the light in the room now. From the very top of the staff, a beam of the same blackness shoots up, toward the ceiling. It passes through the ceiling to some unknown destination.

One by one, the acolytes are silently absorbed into the pillars of darkness. Zzar, her eyes open wide now, looks side by side

without moving her head, at the fate befalling her followers. She seems rigid, set in place, as if she cannot move.

“Noooooo...” She moans through clenched teeth.

She fights against it, but slowly, she begins to be absorbed into the staff until she is gone... Only the staff remains until it shoots up, following the beam of pure blackness.

Then... nothing.

* * *

Adora, Bow, Catra, Scorpia, Entrapta and Melog were all in the medical ward, hovering near Glimmer who was laying on a cot. She was still unconscious, although they managed to close her staring eyes. There were monitors and medical devices hooked up to her and reading normal signs, but there was nothing normal about the state Glimmer was in.

“We should bring her back to Etheria, to Bright Moon, as soon as possible. Her Father will know what to do.” Bow told the group, his voice strained.

“Bow, we can’t just turn ships around right now, we are in a war. We need everyone here keeping the Shen’Aan-war’s fleet from gaining more ground and getting to Etheria.” Adora replied, trying to speak in a calm, convincing manner.

“Then we take Darla and take her ourselves! I’ll do it myself if I have to!” Bow yelled.

“Bow, please calm down. This isn’t helping. I care about Glimmer a lot, but we can’t just rush off and do anything rash.” Adora soothed, trying to placate her friend.

“Rash!? How’s this for rash!?” Bow screamed as he picked up a cart and threw it into the monitors by an empty cot. It exploded in sparks.

He was just about to grab a monitor when Adora leapt up and wrapped her arms around him from behind, pinning his arms. He struggled in her grip, but sagged and started to cry. Adora continued to hold him, placing her cheek against the back of his head.

"Shhhh…Bow it's going to be alright..." She whispered to her grieving friend.

Scorpia joined Adora and Bow, wrapping her arms around him from the front, her claws meeting at Adora's back. He buried his face in her chest and she placed her cheek on the top of his head.

"It's okay, buddy, we're here for you," Scorpia whispered down to him.

They broke apart and Adora led Bow to a chair next to Entrapta. He sat there weeping as Entrapta wrapped her arms and ponytails around him. It seemed like the right thing to do at the moment for the usually emotionally oblivious Entrapta. Catra and Melog sat next to Bow on his other side, worriedly staring at him and laid a hand and paw on his shoulder and knee in support.

"We were going to take the Vow…" Bow whispered brokenly.

Catra stood up and walked over to Adora.

"Maybe he is right... maybe we should take her to Bright Moon. I can go with him." Catra told Adora.

Adora was touched by Catra's altruism; she had come a long way from Horde Force Captain Catra.

"Okay, maybe it is the best—" Adora was cut off as the room was bathed in red flashing lights, and the ship's red alert sounded.

"All ship's personnel, report to your battle stations. This is not a drill, I repeat, all ship's personnel, report to your battle stations." The computer voice stated over the ship's loudspeaker system.

“I’ll head to the bridge and see what’s going on, you guys stay here with Bow and Glimmer.” Adora told her friends.

Adora exited the medical ward, walking through the corridors toward the nearest lift tube. She walked into the glass tube and entered the commands for it to take her to the bridge. The platform below her lit up and lifted her toward her destination.

She was still thinking of Glimmer and Bow, her friends, who just a short while ago, told her they wanted to take the Vow together. They wanted her to be there, of course, to be Glimmer’s Vow Paranymph. Now, Glimmer was in a coma-like state and Bow was in complete shambles. Adora was close to breaking down into tears, but she forced herself to suppress her emotion. She was heading to the bridge now. Something was going on with the fleet and it was bad enough for a red alert, so she needed to be strong.

Soon after the planet was made secure, the fleet had exited Omiros’s orbit They were now headed toward the Omiros bridge, which was not far from its namesake planet. They must have encountered the enemy fleet.

Adora entered the bridge. Admiral Octavia, Captain Keylon and Commander Longshot were all standing around the holographic projector; the tension was obvious. Adora quickly approached them.

“They’re grouped at the Omiros Bridge neck here, in a loose formation and holding position.” Captain Keylon was saying, pointing to the center of the holographic representation of the Omiros Bridge. Adora could see a mass of enemy ships indicated by red runes.

“I got here as fast as I could, Admiral.” Adora greeted.

The Admiral turned to Adora, concern on her face. “How is the Queen? How is Glimmer?” she asked.

Adora looked down, suppressing her grief. “Still the same. No change, for better or worse. We were discussing taking Darla and bringing her back to Etheria right as the ship’s red alert went off.”

Octavia smiled thinly. “Yes, it’s probably not a good time to leave right now. As you can see, we’re approaching the Bridge and have encountered the enemy. They’re blocking passage through the Bridge in a loose line formation. We’re moving in to engage them now.”

“All Star Wings…launch.” Commander Longshot murmured into a communicator.

Adora watched as squadron after squadron launched from the ship’s bays, the single person fighters blasting forward to engage the enemy.

Adora looked at the tactical representation of the enemy fleet and the designation number indicating how many ships they had— eighty-seven. There were one hundred and forty-seven green indicators heading toward the red, even without the fighters, the Etherians had the enemy outnumbered once again.

A creeping sense of dread started to fill Adora, just like in the city of Ackle. She could feel it then— the cold, the evil... there were Death-Binders on those ships, a *lot* of Death-Binders.

The fighters had just reached the enemy ships and were engaging them, zipping around them and firing at known weak points. The Etherian fleet was getting closer to engagement range and the black ships of the enemy were becoming clearer, more defined. Dread continued to build inside Adora; She-Ra was trying to warn her.

“Admiral, there are enemy sorcerers on those ships, I can feel them. Perhaps we should disengage and reassess?” Adora asked, trying to stem the panic in her voice.

“What?! Nonsense, Adora, you’re just on edge because of what happened to the Queen. We have them outnumbered and we’re

going to crush them!" Admiral Octavia said, offhandedly.

"What are you talking about? Do you feel them? Are you a sorcerer?" asked Captain Keylon, suspiciously.

"No, it's She-Ra. She is trying to warn me!" Adora said, starting to panic; they were running out of time.

"Adora, even if there are enemy sorcerers on those ships, we're heavily shielded. No magic will break through our technology. Horde Prime built these ships specifically to defend against magic." Commander Longshot said to her, a little pompously.

Adora looked at the three senior Star Force officers and felt completely outnumbered. "I hope you're right, I really do," Adora whispered.

They had just come into firing range when it happened— a strange buzzing could be heard on the bridge, seeming to come from the very air.

Suddenly, two of the crew members sitting at their stations stood up and screamed, holding their ears.

"What are you doing? Get back to your stations!" Captain Keylon screamed at them.

"Captain, they're being attacked. It's the Death-Binders!" Adora shouted.

"You are not in command here, Adora. One more outburst and I will have you escorted off the bridge!" Captain Keylon shouted back. She then turned to the troopers standing guard over the bridge. "She says one more word, I want Adora off this bridge!"

Admiral Octavia held her hand up as she looked out the window. "Wait, Adora may be right." She then turned to the troopers. "Get those crew members to the medical bay, they may need sedation." She ordered.

Octavia then stood near Adora and pointed out the viewport, directing Adora's attention there. There, out in space before the Etherian fleet, three bright points of white, eerie lights were forming. They blossomed, getting bigger and seemed to swirl like a vortex. Before each swirling vortex was an Etherian ship, they started to be pulled forward, dragged into the swirling cloud of deathly light.

"No! Tell those ships to pull back, full reverse thrust!" Octavia screamed.

While this was happening, the buzzing on the bridge had continued, now reaching a crescendo. Then there was a series of ten dark explosions throughout the bridge, each sounding with a single *pop,* and ten Szi'th appeared, immediately going for the closest warm bodies.

Captain Keylon screamed, drawing her weapon baton and firing at the walking dead; Commander Longshot and the Admiral followed suit. Three Szi'th were vaporized before they could reach the crew members, who by then, had fled their stations. Some of the fired shots had missed the creatures and instead hit the read-outs and monitors behind, destroying critical crew stations. The bridge was in complete disarray.

Six of the Szi'th were headed for the three senior officers when Adora held out her hand.

"For the honor of Grayskull!" she shouted, summoning the sword and then She-Ra, putting herself between them and the monsters.

Not wanting them to get any closer, She-Ra/Adora blasted them from the gem in the pommel of her sword, destroying all six in a sweep with the beam.

Unfortunately, the sweep of the beam not only vaporized the enemy, but the control stations behind them as well; they were now flaming ruins. Crew members were rushing about, using their training and equipment to put the flames out.

“Errr, sorry.” She-Ra/Adora apologized, looking at an obviously angry Octavia.

“Just stop that last one with your sword and please, *please* be careful!” Octavia screamed at her.

The last Szi’th had a crew member pinned to the ground. The poor man was struggling, trying to keep the monster from biting him.

She-Ra/Adora ran to his side and pulled the Szi’th off him by the waist, not wanting to cause more damage with her sword. She held it up before her, facing it away from her as it struggled in her grip to turn around and bite her.

She-Ra/Adora closed her eyes as she thought of an idea. She summoned her healing powers, the yellow aura surrounding her and through her touch, the Szi’th. It squirmed furiously as if it was being burned, then fell apart in a heap of dust.

“Good work, Adora!” Admiral Octavia said, then asked the closest crew member, “Bridge status, report!”

“Sir, the bridge is only partially functional. We have some maneuverability, but weapon systems and shields are offline.” A crew member reported.

“And the rest of the fleet?” Captain Keylon prompted.

“In similar states. All were boarded by the enemy, some are still repelling the boarders. The *Bright Star*, *Rainbow Sword* and *Salineas* were all consumed by the vortex anomalies. We are in the process of recovering life-pods.” the crew member continued.

“Blast! Everything is falling apart! I want all ships that are able to pull back, out of the Bridge. We will regroup at Omiros!” Admiral Octavia yelled. “If any ship cannot retreat then evacuate the ship, abandon it!”

She-Ra/Adora looked out the window. The Etherian fleet was in chaos; some ships were aflame from the battles being fought within, the three deathly whirls of white light were slowly consuming three whole ships of the fleet, and the rest of the ships were turning around.

She felt a hand on her shoulder and turned to see Octavia's pained face. "Curse me, Adora, I should have listened to you. I am a fool!" Octavia said.

"You did what you thought was right Admiral. We have no time for recriminations," Adora said quietly, who seemed to be in a state of shock.

Adora and Octavia stood side by side watching from the viewport as the *Etheria's Light* turned ponderously in the same direction of the rest of the fleet, then burned full throttle away from their defeat.

* * *

Glimmer wakes, she is alone and it's cold, very cold. She looks around, it is dark and gloomy, she can barely see, but she can tell that she is in some sort of hall. The walls are rough, all a uniform moss green color. They seem to be made of hewn stone blocks that were expertly fitted together. The shape of the hall is straight, like the halls in her home at Bright Moon. Looking around, she realizes she has no idea where she is. The place is completely alien to her.

She decides to explore her surroundings and follows the hall to an opening. There is a weak light coming from the other side. Through the opening is a large hall; in the center, seven statues stand in a circle facing in. Next to each statue is a torch held by a sconce. Glimmer removes a torch to inspect the statues. They gaze down at her with stern visages. They look like important lords or scholars and she does not recognize any of them.

She feels it then, like a tug or pulse from below the floor. It is power, magic, a wealth of it. It beckons to her. Glimmer keeps moving forward to the opening in the chamber opposite from where she came from.

She goes through the opening to find herself in another large chamber. As she walks in, she sees raised platforms on either side of her. Massive pillars sit on top of these platforms. Past these platforms, at the back of the chamber, is a series of raised daises; at the top sits a throne. Behind the throne is a mural consisting of expanding circles emanating from behind the throne with lines passing out through them. The effect gives the impression of a sunrise... or sunset. The mural seems to be made of yellow transparent material and is filthy with age.

As Glimmer walks closer to the throne, she sees a figure sitting there. It is an extremely old and frail man. He seems ancient, as if he has lived beyond the natural lifespan that was afforded him. His head is bald with a few wisps of white hair, his eyes are white and blind, his skin so old, it is almost translucent. He is wearing clothing that is worn so thin that they are basically rags hanging atop his thin frame.

He turns his head when he hears her enter, his blind eyes searching for the source of footsteps. Unlike the people in the last vision, this person seems to be aware of her presence.

"Who is there?" he calls out.

Glimmer gets closer to the man before she speaks. "My name is Glimmer. I am Queen of Etheria."

"Etheria? Bah, a backwater planet. What do you want in Eternos?" he responds, annoyance in his tone.

Back-water? Did this old man just call Etheria back-water? Glimmer thinks scornfully.

"I don't want anything, I'm not sure what I am doing here. I've never heard of Eternos. Is it a planet?" She asks.

The old man shakes, like he is having a minor seizure, but then Glimmer quickly realizes he is laughing.

“Yes, you are definitely from Etheria. Everyone in the Empire knows of Eternos, the capital of Eternia. The seat of our mighty Empire.” The old man states condescendingly.

Glimmer was sick of this man’s tone. “Looking around at the state of this place, I would say this isn’t much of an Empire if this is its castle and you are its king. You look like a pathetic ruin of a man.” She spits angrily.

The old man sags into the throne, as if deflating, and Glimmer immediately feels ashamed by her rash tone. He places his hand over his eyes, as if he is coming to some realization.

“The Empire…my Empire is a ruin…I am a ruin. I cannot see, I can barely remember... I know I am not a king though.” The old man whispers.

“Who are you?” Glimmer asks the old man, putting a little bit of compassion into her voice.

“Who am I? I was…was…a hero…once. Then I became…I don’t know. My name was…” The old man continues the rest of the sentence soundlessly, just mouthing a word. Glimmer cannot make it out.

“I’m sorry, I didn’t get that... can you repeat your name?” Glimmer asks.

“My name is lost. I lost it with my honor... I lost it when I became a monster. You must help me, Queen Glimmer. Please take pity on me…” The old man was almost crying now.

Glimmer walked up to the throne, kneeling before the old man. He smelled terrible, but Glimmer kept herself from making a face, even though she knew he was blind and could not see her face. He was so sad, so pathetic, and even though he was cruel to her in the beginning, she feels great pity for him.

“I’m here, I can help you. Tell me how.” Glimmer asks.

The old man looks at her, suddenly gripping her hand tightly, belying his old frail state. He seems to be looking intensely at her with his blind eyes. Glimmer tries to pull back, but he holds her tight.

“You will meet me soon and when you do, please, you must free me! I cannot take what I have become. It has been so long, please... promise me!” he rasps at her, then lets her hand go. She falls back on the ground.

Then... nothing.

* * *

Glimmer woke, she was warm… and not alone. She looked around.

“Bow?” she stammered.

Bow, who had been asleep out in a chair next to Glimmer snapped awake, surprise and joy written on his face at seeing Glimmer awake.

“Glimmer!” he shrieked as he jumped forward, wrapping his arms around her; he was crying.

“Bow, Bow... what’s the matter? You’re acting like I was dead.” Glimmer said, confusion in her voice.

Bow placed his hands on her cheeks and looked deep into her eyes. “Glimmer... you have been…gone…for the past five days, ever since the Ackle Keep on Omiros. The magical explosion… do you remember anything?”

Glimmer concentrated, though she was still groggy from sleep. “Yes, I remember fighting in Ackle, then there was the Death Binder at the top of the tower, the explosion and trying to block the blast… wait, are Catra and Adora alright?”

Bow smiled at his love; even after being hurt, she was always thinking of her friends' safety over her own.

"Yes, they're fine. We found you unconscious after the explosion and feared the worst. We couldn't wake you up. We were thinking of bringing you back to Etheria when…" Bow started, then broke off.

"What? What happened?" Glimmer asked.

Bow filled her in on the fleet's approach to the Omiros Bridge and how they found the enemy there. How the enemy ship numbers were small in comparison to the Etherian fleet and victory seemed imminent. Then, the magical attack; the vortexes, the mind attack on the crew and the boarding of the Etherian ships by the horrible Szi'th. The retreat to Omiros and holding there, holding for the past four days.

"I should have been there to use my magic to help protect the fleet." Glimmer said miserably.

"No, Glimmer. Even if you were there, we still would have been outclassed. It's not on you, especially since you were in here *because* you saved the three of us." Bow said placatingly.

Just then, the door to the medical ward opened and Entrapta, Scorpia, Adora, Catra and Melog entered.

"Yayyyyy!!! Glimmer's awake!" Entrapta said joyously, running over on her ponytails to hug her friend.

The others ran over to Glimmer's bedside as well, Scorpia and Adora almost crushing Glimmer back into unconsciousness; they were overjoyed to see her awake. Melog was licking her face.

"Ughhhh… guys you're crushing me." Glimmer wheezed.

Adora, Melog, Scorpia and Entrapta finally stepped back from Glimmer, gazing at her in happiness. Looking between Adora and

Scorpia, Glimmer could see Catra hanging back, arms crossed and smiling at Glimmer.

Glimmer looked at Catra and beckoned for her to come over. “Come on, Catra, get over here, bring it in!” She called to her friend.

Catra suddenly rushed over and wrapped her arms around Glimmer, putting her cheek against the top of Glimmer’s head. Her shoulders were shaking; she was crying.

“Ohhh, Catra, it's okay, I’m okay.” Glimmer said, rubbing her friend on the back. She always knew Catra had a soft core inside her hard exterior.

“I was so scared we were going to lose you...” Catra whispered to Glimmer.

Glimmer continued to rub her back, knowing Catra’s fear of losing people all too well, people she had grown close to.

“I’m not going anywhere, Catra.” Glimmer whispered to her friend.

Catra broke the embrace and stood up, wiping her eyes. Everyone was staring at her, not used to this side of Catra.

“What are you all looking at?” she snapped at them, walking to Adora’s side.

Glimmer chuckled; some things would never change.

“So, what’s happening now, with the fleet, our push into the Bridge? Are we going to continue?” Glimmer asked Adora.

Adora frowned, not really wanting to burden her newly-awoken friend with bad news.

“With our defeat and withdrawal from the Omiros Bridge, we have been just holding here, trying to decide the next best course of action is. The enemy seems to be holding for now. We don’t know

why they have not pushed their advantage... Perhaps they are holding out for more reinforcements. With their magic offensive capabilities, the Admiral has been afraid to engage them and lose more ships. We lost nine ships in the last engagement within a matter of moments. The enemy lost none— and that is terrifying." Adora said, sadly.

"You have me now. I can use magic against them, powerful magic. We can send a message back to Etheria, to my father and Castaspella. They can bring their most powerful sorcerers here and we can even the battlefield and crush these invaders!" Glimmer said, emphatically.

Everyone was emboldened by Glimmer's words; she was a great leader and her presence had been missed immensely.

"That's a good plan Glimmer, but what do we do in the meantime?" Bow said.

She looked at them all in turn before she spoke. "Hold them back. Don't let them gain any ground and look into other ways to beat them." She said quietly, but forcefully.

Space Is No Place for Stuffed Animals

Bow walked down the corridor of *Etheria's Light.* He was barefoot and dressed in a white, waist-long robe and baggy white pants; a white cloth belt held the robe closed. He was still sweating profusely from his sparring session with Catra, and still tasted a little blood in his mouth.

Catra and her dirty tricks... I swear she is getting meaner the longer we have to wait out here in space, Bow thought darkly to himself.

They had surreptitiously sent a small courier ship back to Etheria to deliver the message asking for aid. It was expected to take almost two weeks before they could see reinforcements. They had been waiting a week now already, and everyone was getting agitated, not just from the waiting but from not knowing what their enemy was up to, for, the enemy ships hadn't moved from their positions within the Omiros Bridge.

Bow and Catra had decided to continue their martial arts sessions to try and blow off steam, although Bow was wondering if Catra saw him as a student or just the punching bag.

Oh, well... I'm learning a lot from her, even if it's how to take a punch, Bow thought, looking on the bright side.

He was just about to enter the cabin he shared with Glimmer when he felt something like electricity in the air, tense and powerful.

Uh oh... better knock first, remember what happened last time Bow? He thought as he knocked on the door.

“Ughh…okay…come in.” he heard from within.

Bow opened the door to see Glimmer standing inside, her black star-studded robe on, hood over her head and holding the black star-topped staff out. Before her on a table was a stuffed animal; a bear.

“No, not Beary!” squeaked Bow, horrified.

“Bow, it's okay, relax, I got this. Beary will be fine.” Glimmer said with a confident smile.

Bow watched, biting his fingernails as Glimmer pointed her staff at the stuffed animal, ribbons of starlight projecting from the end. The ribbons wrapped around the stuffed animal, then they suddenly squeezed tight, so tight Beary’s head shot off and hit the ceiling, stuffing flying everywhere.

“BEEAARRRRYYY!!!” Bow screamed as he ran forward to cradle his precious stuffed toy.

Glimmer only looked mildly annoyed. “Darn it! I thought I had it that time! Sorry, Bow, I’ll get you another one.”

“I knew space was no place for stuffed animals!” Bow cried.

“Oh, stop being a baby, Bow, I’m running out of test subjects for my Cosmic Binding spell. Beary died for a good cause.” She said, trying to placate him. “I promise I will make it up to you…” she continued, giving him a devious look.

“Okay!” Bow said, throwing Beary over his shoulder as he walked to her.

Before they could touch, there was a chime at the door.

“Ugh…enter.” Glimmer said, annoyed again.

The door opened and a grinning Catra stood there, in her usual maroon and black outfit, arms crossed.

“Somehow I have the sense that I’m interrupting something.” She smirked slyly.

“How did you get changed so fast!? I just got back to my room!” Bow exclaimed.

“Punchy, you should know from experience by now that I’m lightning fast. How’s your mouth?” Catra asked.

“Fine.” He said, petulantly. “I owe you for that last dirty trick you pulled, slapping me in the eyes with your tail— totally unfair!”

“Hey, I’m always here when you’re ready to take a shot at the title,” Catra said, cocky as usual.

“So Catra, did you come here for a reason or are you just wandering the ship bugging everyone?” Glimmer asked coolly.

Catra chuckled. “No, Adora wants us in the ship’s briefing room. Those Star-whatevers are here, they have news.”

“The Star-Siblings?” Glimmer said, giving Catra another dirty look. “You should be nice to them Catra, they’re a big help and they are good people.”

“Yeah, yeah, okay, are you guys coming?” Catra said, trying to stop Glimmer from delivering another lecture.

Bow looked down at himself. “Yeah, sure, let’s go, I’ll change later.”

Catra patted Bow on the back as they all walked down the hall together. “You look good like that, Punchy, like a person who could actually put up some kind of proper fight.” She teased, gleefully.

* * *

Adora was sitting in the conference room. It was a circular room with a circular table in the center, chairs placed around the

outside of the table. In the center was a holographic projector, much like the one on the bridge, but larger. It was currently showing an image of the Rainbow Arm, the lower swirl where Twilight was, the Maelstrom Gulf in between, and the Omiros bridge connecting the upper arm to the lower swirl. Fleet positions were shown in reds and blues.

Seated at the table were Entrapta, Scorpia, Admiral Octavia, Captain Keylon, Commander Longshot and the Star-Siblings; Tallstar, Jewelstar and Starla with Glory perched on her shoulder. Melog was in the back, staring at Glory with a quizzical look.

Just then, Catra, Glimmer and Bow entered. Bow was still in his sparring outfit and looked disheveled. He also looked like he had a fat lip.

Adora saw that Catra was dressed in her usual outfit and groomed as much as she normally was.

"Sorry, did I interrupt a solo sparring match? Did you give yourself a fat lip, Bow?" Adora laughed at him.

Bow only glowered at Catra who gave everyone an innocent look.

"Okay, you guys interrupted me from my training, let's get to it. What's this about?" Glimmer said, trying to divert everyone's attention from abusing her poor Bow.

"Yes, the Star-Siblings recently arrived and they had urgent news. I thought we should address it immediately." Admiral Octavia said, waving to the trio to begin.

"Yes, it is good to see you all again. The universe has once again become a dark and dangerous place and I am glad you are well. We heard news of the battle at the Bridge and the impasse that has followed. Unfortunately, we come with more bad news." Jewelstar began.

He pressed commands in the control panel before him and the holographic display zoomed in on the lower swirl showing Twilight,

Makkina, Rham and Karthis. There were two groups of red indicators moving between Makkina and the Omiros Bridge.

"We have received this intelligence from the few agents we still have in the enemy sector. As you can see, there are reinforcement fleets moving toward the Omiros Bridge. We project that they will arrive in a couple of days' time and reinforce the enemy there." Tallstar finished.

A murmur spread through the group, as everyone looked at each other with worry and dread.

"They could be carrying more of those Death-Binders." Captain Keylon said, not even trying to disguise her fear.

"How much longer before we expect to receive reinforcement from Etheria?" Commander Longshot asked.

"They are a week out, at best, *if* it's even coming." Captain Keylon responded, the fear rising in her voice.

"Be calm Captain, be calm. We will work out a solution, all is not lost. We still have them outnumbered. From these numbers, even with reinforcements, the enemy will still only have one hundred and three ships. We have one hundred and thirty-eight, plus our Star Wings. We know their tricks now, so we won't be caught off guard." Admiral Octavia said, trying to placate her subordinate.

"Even if we did come out on top it would be a slaughter. We would lose too many ships; the loss of life would be high!" The Captain responded, on the edge of hysteria.

"Is there any way we could go around the bridge, around the outside of the spiral?" Bow asked.

"No, my friend. There are many anomalies there, anomalies that bend space and time. It could end up taking mere minutes or a hundred years to pass through there. I would not recommend it." Tallstar shook his head sadly.

“We could pull back to Spira, meet the reinforcements halfway?” Commander Longshot suggested.

“And give up the ground we took? Give up Omiros and its people to be captured again? We can’t! The enemy was doing terrible things to those people. There has to be another way!” Adora said, emphatically.

“Adora, sometimes there is no other way, just two bad choices. I’m sorry, but I’m leaning toward Commander Longshot’s idea. It seems the soundest.” Admiral Octavia said, sorrowfully.

Suddenly Starla brightened. “White Claw! What about White Claw?” she said, looking at her siblings.

Tallstar and Jewelstar looked at each other. “White Claw is an unknown, they are not one of our official contacts. They are risky.” Tallstar said to her sister.

“Who’s this ‘White Claw’?” Glimmer asked of the Star Siblings.

“They are a recent contact. They wished desperately for us to get them into contact with the She-Ra, they supposedly have a way across the Maelstrom Gulf. We have not verified them yet, so we have not brought this to your attention.” Jewelstar said.

“If we could get across the Maelstrom and the Omiros Bridge, that would be huge. We could hit them wherever their leaders are, where this Shen’Aan-war is. We could send a strike force, our best fighters with She-Ra in the lead, leaving the fleet to hold the bridge.” Adora said, hope in her voice.

“Risky, very risky. That is only *if* this White Claw contact really has this route and *if* we can pinpoint the location of the enemy leaders.” Octavia looked at Glimmer, “This would be your call, your Majesty. You have overall command over this operation.”

Glimmer looked at Adora; her friend had that look on her face, that confident, assured look that had gotten them through so many other dire situations. She made up her mind.

"We do it. We meet this contact and try to find a way across the Maelstrom. How do we make contact with this 'White Claw'?" Glimmer asked the Star Siblings.

"They will only meet in person, and on the planet Thenlor. We can set up a meeting location and let you know." Tallstar said.

* * *

Adora and Catra walked through the streets of Thenlor. Both were wearing hooded robes to disguise their appearance. They had landed Darla close by, on an empty platform; Melog had stayed behind to mask the ship in their invisibility field. There were too many people walking around in this city bumping into each other for Melog's invisibility to work on Adora and Catra.

They walked between tall, rectangular towers, so tall that the sky was barely perceptible far above. It was day, but the sky was dark and gray and it was raining; Adora and Catra did not know whether or not this was everyday weather. Water dripped down on them from high above, and foul-smelling steam rose from grates in the street. Here and there, black uniformed soldiers of the Shen'Aan-war could be seen standing watch over the subjugated populace. Black hooded figures were nearby in overwatch, their faces hidden from view; Death-Binders.

Adora and Catra steered clear from the Death-Binders, just in case they could sense them somehow. They wanted to infiltrate this planet without being seen, they especially did not want She-Ra to be seen. This would bring attention to Thenlor, perhaps even tip their hand to their enemy. Adora and Catra were picked for the mission because they were excellent fighters and could keep a low profile. They didn't need brawn or magic if they ran into trouble, and if they were in a bind and had no choice, Adora could just summon She-Ra.

"Are we close yet, Adora? This water is dripping through my robe and my fur is starting to get wet," complained Catra.

Adora held up her data pad, trying to be inconspicuous. It showed a map of the city blocks; the coordinates for the meet location were close, a couple of blocks away.

"We're almost there, Catra. Just hold it together a little while longer." Adora said, smiling at her love. There was something extra cute about a wet and whiny Catra.

Adora looked around at the various people that composed the planet-wide city of Thenlor. She thought she was used to variety since she grew up on a planet like Etheria, but the diversity she saw before her was on another level. She saw no two the same- there was a light blue-skinned humanoid with two blue antennae sticking up through its white hair. There was a brown, mottled-skinned humanoid with a fish head, two yellow eyes on short stalks sticking up from either side of the head. There were many others; they walked, crawled or slid along the ground. They wore a wide variety of outfits; some wore no outfits at all.

Adora laughed at Catra's face, her eyes wide and mouth opened as two silver-skinned beings, obviously male, walked naked, hand-in-hand, past them. They had piercings on various places on their bodies, with small glittering chains connecting the piercings to each other in a statement of bonding.

Adora elbowed Catra. "Must be like a Vow thing, huh? Maybe we should suggest it to Bow and Glimmer?" Adora grinned.

Catra laughed and grinned back. "The image in my mind right now? *Priceless.*" She said, chuckling to Adora.

Something shiny caught Adora's eye in a nearby store window. Looking in, she saw a pair of gray, knee-high boots with a gold heel and solid buckle over the top of the foot. They looked like they could fit her or Catra.

"Hey, Catra, look at these boots. They're cute, right?" Adora said.

Catra strode over and peered into the glass. "Eh, yeah, if you're into footwear, I guess."

“You know, the color kind of matches those pants Scorpia got you, don’t you think? And the gold. I bet these would look perfect on that outfit.” Adora continued, trying to press the point.

“Oh, I don’t know, Adora... you know how I feel about footwear. Well…maybe, but I mean, this isn’t exactly a shopping trip mission.” Catra replied.

“On the way back, after we beat these guys, I’m coming back and getting these for you. Promise.” Adora said, pressing a button in her data pad to mark the location for the future.

Catra shrugged and continued on through another billowing cloud of stinky steam, Adora following behind her.

Catra scrunched her nose up at the smell, the hot moisture making her fur crawl; she wasn’t really sure how she felt about cities. Sure, the buildings looked fun to climb and leap across, but there were many detractors. So many people, constantly walking past her, whether they looked at her or not; there were just too many people, she felt claustrophobic, it was worse than being on the ship. Then there was the *noise*. Her ears felt numb from constantly turning and straining to the sounds. Then there were the *smells*. There were so many smells, most of them bad too, they assaulted her senses. Wait, speaking of smells…

Catra stood still, crouching slightly as she sniffed the air, her ears down. Adora stopped, watching her.

“Whatcha got, girl?” Adora teased.

Catra ignored her, following the scent, she went on all fours, heading over to the building wall. She placed her hands against the stone there and stood up; it almost seemed like she was going to start climbing.

“Uh, Catra, where do you think you are going? You’re kinda acting suspicious, even for this place.” Adora said, running over and placing her hand on Catra’s shoulder.

Catra suddenly turned to her, as if she was snapping out of a trance. “Hmmm? Sorry, Adora, it’s just this smell, it’s like... it smells like me but…not. It’s weird.”

Adora shook her shoulder and smiled. “Ignore it. Come on, we have a meeting to go to.”

They both walked together down the street toward the meeting location, steam billowing around them and gray water dripping down from above.

* * *

The hunter stood on the building edge, looking down at her prey. She had watched as one of them seemed like they sensed her presence above and was about to climb the building toward her. Luckily, the other had pulled them away; the hunter was not ready to make herself known.

She watched them with yellow eyes under a gray hood, ears sticking up through cut holes. She was soaked. She hated this planet and its rain, but she had work to do here for the greater good.

They were getting out of sight now, and she crouched and leaped to the next building, running and balancing along a ledge, wet tail swishing behind her. She repeated this until they were in sight again, they were close now, close to the location. She gripped the stone walls with her claws; she hated these hard surfaces, her claws could barely find purchase, not like the softwood trees of her home.

The two figures were there now, in the alleyway, tucked between two buildings and out of sight. She saw it then, two groups of thugs at both ends of the alley moving in and trapping the two figures, her quarry.

Her ear twitched and she growled low, leaping into the air.

* * *

Catra and Adora backed up into each other, facing outward, toward the approaching enemies. They were a motley assortment of thugs; some were huge with muscles and leering faces, some lean, looking like speed and agility were their specialty. Some had metallic limbs, like the ones Hordak manufactured for prosthetics, but these looked like they were made for fighting, for they were bulked out and bladed. They had a mixture of swords, clubs, and other weapons Adora and Catra had never seen before. The only thing these thugs had in common were that they were focused on Adora and Catra, approaching them slowly and menacingly.

"Great, Adora, good plan. Let's go to an enemy-held planet and meet some mysterious person that calls themselves 'White Claw'. Didn't see this coming." Catra said, dryly.

"You're not helping, Catra," Adora responded as a particularly huge and scaly specimen neared her.

"So much for subtlety, maybe it's time for She-Ra?" Catra prompted.

Adora nodded and was about to raise her hand and speak the words of summoning when a robed figure leaped down from above.

The robed figure landed on the scaly thug nearest Adora and swiped at its head, eliciting a scream from the creature. It raised its clawed hands to its wounded head and the robed figure did a backflip off its shoulders. They twisted in the air to perform a downwards kick into the next charging thug's cybernetic face. The metallic mouth, eyes and nose came off completely as a single piece, and the owner went on its hands and feet, desperately searching for it. As the robed figure continued its attack, Adora could see a striped cream-colored tail whipping behind it.

"Come on Catra, looks like we have help. Let's not waste it!" Adora yelled.

Adora and Catra leaped into the fray, delivering hand-chops, slashes, punches and kicks.

A slight, six-armed female with bug eyes attempted to grab Catra; she was rewarded with a leaping kick to the face.

A genderless ogre with one eye tried to slap down on Adora from above; they received a kick to the kneecap and doubled over in pain.

Catra leaped and delivered a downward slash on a snake-like body; its owner screamed and slithered away.

Adora had just delivered a knockout blow into a furry muzzle when she noticed their attackers were fleeing, probably deciding to find easier quarry tonight.

"Yeah? That's what you get for messing with a couple of Etherians!" Catra yelled at their fleeing backs.

Adora and Catra turned to the robed figure who was striding over to them now, not a mark on them.

"So... you're the smell I smelled." Catra scrunched up her nose.

"Greetings to you too, sister." the figure replied in a female voice, she had a pleasant, lilting accent.

She reached up and drew the hood back revealing a face that, up until now, Adora had only seen on her soulmate, Catra.

Although the shape was different and the chin not as pointed, she had the same furry face as Catra, the same slit eyes, although hers were both yellow. Her coloring was different too; where Catra's face was a cinnamon color, hers was a light orange with the exception of an oval cream-colored patch over her left eye. Her hair was long, swept back from her face and held together with metal rings and beads, dark brown except for two white tufts under each ear. Her ears and long tail were both cream-colored

with dark brown stripes. She smiled at them, revealing small upper and lower fangs.

Her robe opened to reveal a one-piece bodysuit. It seemed to be composed of different shapes stitched together, made of green and black material. She was completely barefoot, just like Catra.

"I thought it would be polite to let you know I was near, so I let you catch my scent. The name is Panga, I am your contact." She said to them.

"White Claw, huh?" Adora asked.

Panga held up her light orange hand, extending five sharp white claws.

Catra looked this newcomer up and down, sizing her up.

"I am Adora, and this is Catra," Adora said pointing to herself, then at Catra.

Panga scrunched up her nose at this. "Cat-tra?" She asked incredulously.

"What? What about it? It's my name, *Panga*." Catra retorted, scornfully.

"My sister, you let them name you Cat-tra?" Panga repeated, as she shook her head.

"What's wrong with Catra? I love that name." Adora replied defensively.

"Yes, yes, such a nice name. How about I call you Ape-tra?" Panga said to Adora, her tail twitching.

"Hey, I'm sorry if we offended you, but there is no need for names," Adora said, a little angry.

Panga put her hand on her hips as she studied Adora.

“You’re the bearer of the She-Ra, aren’t you? They said you were beautiful, but that description does not do you justice, you are simply *radiant*.” Panga purred.

“Huh, huh, well if you’re going to call me radiant, huh... I don’t know…” she stuttered, embarrassed.

“Hey, weird cat lady, back off! Adora is mine!” Catra bristled, practically hissing.

Panga walked up to Catra. Her teeth were exposed and a low growl emanated from both women. Adora looked back and forth between them nervously; she did not want to be in the middle of this catfight.

Suddenly Panga laughed, brightly and loud and stepped back. “I am only playing with you, my sister; I can sense your essence on her; I know she is yours. I tease. I’m sorry.”

Catra was suddenly wrong-footed. “Uh... what? My essence? What are you talking about, you nut?” Catra asked.

Panga looked shocked. “Yes, it’s true, isn’t it? I have heard that the bearer of the She-Ra’s consort was of our people, lost to us as a child, so your ignorance makes sense. When I say essence, I am speaking of smell, your scent-mark.” Panga said this last part waving her hand up toward her nose, opening her mouth like she was going to bite the air.

Adora started trying to smell herself. “Catra, you scent-marked me?” she asked, incredulous.

“WHAT? No, I didn’t, I swear, Adora!” Catra said, a high-pitched quality to her voice.

“Oh yes, she did, Adora. Actually, more than what is customary, she must really like you.” Panga said, grinning at Adora.

“I don’t smell anything; how did you scent-mark me Catra?” Adora said, looking at Catra suspiciously.

Catra looked panicked, not knowing what to say. Adora looked at Panga, who only smiled knowingly back at her.

"I'm sorry to embarrass you, my sister. It is not why I am here." Panga said sorrowfully.

"Why exactly are you here... and stop calling me *sister*!" Catra said angrily.

Panga smiled at this. "Sorry again. We are, of course not siblings, but you come from the same planet as I. You must have, for our people are found nowhere else in this universe. We would know—we have traveled far." Panga said.

"I have never seen anyone like Catra on Etheria, so I believe you. Where is this planet?" Adora asked.

"It is far from here, on the other side of the galaxy, in the other arm. It is a beautiful world, full of magic like your Etheria." Panga said, full of wonder.

"You didn't answer Catra's other question... why are you here?" Adora asked.

Panga cocked her head at Adora. "To help these people, of course. To fight against these intruders in our universe, invaders who want to only cause pain and destruction. Our people are strong and filled with empathy for others, it is our way to help those in need. Surely you must understand sis…Cat-tra?"

Catra suddenly looked ashamed, eyes wide and ears down. Adora put her hand on her shoulder knowing what she was thinking at that moment.

"I was sent here to fight in any way I could, but also to give you this," Panga said, reaching into the folds of her robe and pulling out a shiny data disc.

Adora took the disc. It was a copper color and had multiple concentric half-rings interspersed throughout it. It looked very old.

“We have kept many secrets safe; this is one of them. It will take you to a path across the Maelstrom, a safe path that completely bypasses this reality. You cannot see this path and it is in space, not far from this planet. The disc has exact coordinates to it. The other end of the path will deposit you near the planet Rham.” Panga said.

“How do you know this path will work? And even better, how do we know we can trust you?” Catra asked, suspiciously.

Panga returned Catra’s suspicion with a smile. “I know it works because I used it to get here. As for trusting me, use your senses. My intentions will be obvious.” Panga said, holding her arms out.

Catra squinted at Panga with her ears down, nose twitching, smelling. Then, suddenly, Catra’s ears perked up and her eyes softened, a small smile appearing on her face. Panga blinked at her slowly, and Catra returned the blink; mutual trust was established.

“Uh..., what’s happening?” asked Adora, oblivious to what was going on between the two feline women.

“What’s going on is we got what we came for, Adora. We should get back to the fleet.” Catra said. She then looked at Panga. “What about you? Without this, you won’t know how to get back. You should come with us.” Catra offered.

“I am not leaving until these people are safe. Besides, I am confident you and your Adora will end this soon. Once that happens, I won’t need a secret path to get home. You need not worry about me.” Panga reassured me.

The women said their goodbyes to each other, Catra and Panga actually embracing, to Adora's surprise. When they parted, Panga held Catra by the shoulders and looked into her eyes.

“Cat-tra, when this is over and the galaxy is free of this evil, seek us out. Come to our homeworld, the coordinates are also on that disc. There, we will greet you as a sister returned and we shall

treasure you. I sense much anger in you, Cat-tra. This is not the way of our people; you will see that we are filled with love and laughter." Panga said, then placed a clawed hand on Catra's cheek. "You have such beautiful eyes. This is rare among us. It would not be hard to find where you came from or who your people are. Goodbye, for now, Cat-tra"

Catra smiled back at Panga and watched as Panga turned and leaped up and into a swirling steam cloud, disappearing out of sight.

Adora placed a hand on Catra's shoulder and looked into her eyes; she did not see sadness, but happiness. Catra smiled at her.

"Hey, we should do it, like she said. When this is all over, we should take Darla, just you and me, and find this planet." Adora said, squeezing Catra's shoulder.

"I would like that." Catra looked back at her, still smiling.

Adora and Catra turned, walking hand in hand back through the city streets, back to Darla and to the fleet.

An Old Friend, but Their Face has Darkened

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Darla shot through space toward the coordinates indicated on the data disc given to them by Panga. Abord the ship were some of the best warriors Etheria could muster; Adora, Catra, Glimmer, Bow, Scorpia, Entrapta, Melog, and two squads of Star Force ground troopers. They were ready to bring the fight to the enemy's doorstep and finish this; they were headed for the planet Twilight.

Adora sat in the ship's command chair, remembering the dream she had the night before; instead of the usual nightmares, it was a vision, a vision of Mara as She-Ra.

She was in her She-Ra form standing on the edge of a cliff next to She-Ra/Mara overlooking a beautiful vision of the Whispering Woods during sunset, just as she did before using the fail-safe to release the magic bound in Etheria's Heart.

She-Ra/Mara was standing at the edge looking out. She-Ra/Adora walks to stand by her. She-Ra/Mara turns toward her and smiles.

"Hello, Adora, it's good to see you again." She greets.

"I thought I wouldn't see you again, Mara, I'm glad that's not true." She-Ra/Adora responds, happiness in her voice.

"I am a part of She-Ra, and therefore, always with you Adora. I sense you are about to face a great obstacle again. I wanted to

reach out and provide any guidance I may impart before you do." She says to Adora.

"Yes. We are in the middle of another fight with a terrible enemy, one that wants to control the universe. He calls himself the Shen'Aan-war. I was told he used to be called someone named He-Man." says She-Ra/Adora.

She-Ra/Mara's expression turns sorrowful and she turns, looking at the view again. "Yes, He-Man… his name was Adam. He was my trusted friend once, long ago. Now, he is something else, something twisted and horrible. I fear I would not recognize my friend's face now." She-Ra/Mara sadly replies.

Adora's viewpoint changes suddenly. She is out of body, watching a scene unfold. It is Mara in her She-Ra form, fighting alongside an almost naked, heavily muscled man. His hair is blonde and chin-length with bangs, his face is strong and handsome. He wears a harness over his chest; there is a cross symbol where the two straps met. On his feet are red fur-topped boots and he wears a furred red loincloth with an orange belt holding it in place. He holds a sword in his hands, much like Mara's but different in style. The foe he faces is out of sight, and he is fighting back to back with She-Ra/Mara; they are two warriors guarding each other.

"Since I was a senior member of our order, and thus had much to teach, I was assigned to help guide Adam when he was chosen to bear the He-Man. I did my best but found a difficult student in Adam; he was proud and headstrong. He was of royal lineage, so he expected much of those around him. His ideals of what made a true warrior were antiquated, but he had a good heart." She-Ra/Mara's disembodied voice continues.

Enemies suddenly appear on both sides, and Adora recognizes them— they are Horde Prime's robot soldiers.

"Over time, we became close. Adam became a brother and true friend to me. In turn, I was also dear to Adam, although I began to believe he was falling in love with me. Looking back now, in

hindsight, perhaps it was not love, just lust." She/Ra-Mara continues as the point of view changes. It is now of Mara sitting at a view screen aboard her ship. On the screen is Adam, his face screwed up in anger as he yells.

"How can you do this Mara, have you lost your mind? Don't you know we are losing this war? I won't let you do it, I won't let you throw it all away based on your weakness! I have alerted the council to your treachery. Soon they will send me to bring you back!" Adam screams, berating her.

Mara suddenly looks very angry. "You will bring me back? *I think you forget who you are talking to, Adam. You may want to rethink that course of action." Mara says, voice low and full of threat.*

"We will see," Adam replies as he cuts the communication.

Mara stood and turned then, fists and teeth clenched, eyes hot with anger. She closes her eyes and a single tear falls.

She-Ra/Mara's voice continues. "When I decided to hide Etheria instead of letting it be used as a weapon, Adam turned on me, thinking me weak-hearted. I was so hurt by his betrayal. How could someone who I thought I knew so well do this to me? How could he be so surprised by my actions? Didn't he fight by my side as my brother? How could he not see me, see who I was and know that I would have taken this course of action? What did Adam see when he looked at Mara, bearer of the She-Ra? Did he see me as Mara the strong and compassionate woman, or did he just see She-Ra, the beautiful representation of some skewed ideal of his? I believe it was the latter."

Adora was suddenly back on the cliff edge with Mara, both as She-Ra. The other woman turns to her.

"The man I knew, Adam, is long lost, for he has corrupted himself beyond all redemption, but he is holding back a piece of a whole that yearns to be freed. I can feel it, and so can you though She-Ra. The essence of He-Man calls to be released. You must destroy

what Adam has become, you must, my sister." She-Ra/Mara implores.

"You say this He-Man essence is part of a whole... So She-Ra and He-Man make up this whole?" She-Ra/Adora asks.

She-Ra/Mara smiles. "By themselves, no, there are others." She says, pointing up to another vision in the sky. Figures appear above them.

A man, kind-eyed and smiling, holding aloft a sword. "To the Glory of Grayskull!" he shouts.

A short-statured, bespectacled woman, also holding aloft a sword. "By the Wisdom of Grayskull!" she yells.

There are others, figures holding aloft swords and shouting their own words of activation. The vision ends with one last figure.

They are genderless, light purple-skinned with long black hair; they are beautiful. They hold up a sword. "By the Light of Grayskull!" they shout.

The vision ends, and She-Ra/Mara looks at where the vision was with sadness. "My comrades, my friends, we all fought side by side to hold back the darkness and hold up the light." she finishes.

She-Ra/Adora looks at She-Ra/Mara with confusion. "Mara, thank you for showing me all that... but how does this help me? I need to know where this Shen'Aan-war is, to stop him."

She-Ra/Mara nods to her. "Since the She-Ra and He-Man essence are part of the same whole, you are still connected in a way. This connection was reinforced when you entered the temple on Dark Moon and attempted to open the portal. Adam was able to reach out to you and latch on, drawing energy from you and creating a tether to this universe. It is also why you have been having dark dreams ever since you returned from Dark Moon."

"Dark Moon? You mean Twilight?" She-Ra/Adora asks.

She-Ra/Mara nods. "Use that connection against him to see him, to see through his eyes. Perhaps you will learn of his location. I will help you. Close your eyes, concentrate and feel for the connection."

She-Ra/Adora does as she is told, closing her eyes and feeling for the connection She can feel She-Ra/Mara boosting her sensitivity. She feels out, like a blind person reaching for something to guide them.

Then, she feels it. Like the end of a loose string, she follows it to —

"No, my sister, that one leads to someone you left on Etheria. Look for another connection." She-Ra/Mara instructs.

She-Ra/Adora lets go of the string and searches for another. She finds it, but it is different from the other string. It was dark, dirty, like it was dipped in black mud. It disgusts her to concentrate on it.

"Yes…you have it now, Adora. Follow it." She-Ra/Mara implores.

She-Ra/Adora follows the dark string. As she gets farther along, she speeds up, faster and faster until it is a blur, then—

She is sitting in a gloomy chamber. Looking down, she sees she is sitting on a throne, her huge armored arms ending in clawed gauntlets on the armrests. Looking out she sees pillars side by side, extending to the other side of the room, ghostly lamps hang from the ceiling casting hideous light. Between the pillars is an altar... wait, she recognizes this altar.

She-Ra/Adora suddenly opens her eyes in her vision. "Twilight! He is on Twilight!" she exclaims to She-Ra/Mara.

The other woman only smiles and nods, as Adora wakes from her dream.

Adora shook herself from her reveries, concentrating on the task at hand.

"We are approaching the coordinates from the data disc; we should be entering the pathway soon." Bow said from the front console.

"Ohhhhhh, I'm so EXCITED! Up until now, wormholes have only been theoretical. Hordak and I have spent NIGHTS staying up late talking about them! I can't wait to bring this data back to him!" Entrapta bounced, brimming with excitement.

"I hope we make it through to tell him about it, little buddy," Scorpia said, putting her claw on Entrapta's shoulder.

"It will be okay, Big Gal, you'll see," Catra said, placing a hand on Scorpia's claw. The larger woman smiled down thankfully at Catra.

"Entering the pathway…NOW!" Bow exclaimed.

Where once they had only seen stars ahead, they now see a swirling tube of chaotic lights, so bright they had to squint.

"Darla, dim viewport," Bow commanded, and it dimmed enough to be tolerable to look at.

They stayed like that for what seemed like minutes then, they were out of the pathway back into real space. In the distance, they could see what must be the planet Rham, with two large dark ships in orbit.

"Melog, can you cloak us please?" Adora said to Melog. They complied, using their magic to render the ship invisible. "Bow, try and steer us away from that planet. There may be Death-Binders on those ships who could sense us."

Bow nodded, directing them away from the enemy planet, far enough away from the gravity well to engage the hyperdrive. Then, they jumped into hyperspace, on their way to Twilight.

* * *

Darla appeared out of hyperspace in low orbit, still invisible. She decelerated down toward the planet Twilight. The dull gray planet opened up before them. As they dropped through the clouds, Adora recognized the dead empty landscape from her last visit; flat dirt plains with scrubby, ugly, gray plants dotting the landscape here and there.

"I didn't miss this place," Bow muttered as he directed the ship toward their target. It doesn't take long for them to find it; among the empty plains, they could see the twisted temple on the horizon. It appeared that temporary structures and tents had been set up around the temple since their last visit; it had become the invader's base of operations.

"Okay, everyone, get ready. Sergeant, I want your ground forces to engage the enemy on the outside, holding them off while we enter the temple and take out the enemy leaders. From what Adora says, the Shen'Aan-war is in the main chamber." Glimmer took charge.

As Darla accelerated in, figures could be seen running around in a panic around the tents, some were in black uniforms, while others wore gray, drab garb. The black uniformed figures ran toward the approaching ship; the gray uniformed figures ran away. Thankfully, there were no signs of robed or shambling figures, no Death-Binders or Szi'th among the gathering enemies.

Darla landed quickly and extended the ramp, and the Etherian Star Force ground troops rushed out to engage the enemies. The fight was immediately one-sided as the Etherians used their ranged weapons on the melee-based black uniformed troopers.

She-Ra/Adora, Catra, Bow, Glimmer, Scorpia, and Linda with Entrapta inside rushed down the ramp. Since they could not enter the temple last time, Melog stayed behind to guard the ship. The team ran past the battling troops and toward the temple entrance. The temple was just as they remembered, twisted like a large

thorn bush, but this time, the inner light it projected is somehow more intense. It's as if the owner had returned to an empty dwelling and lit all the lights, letting everyone know they had returned.

As they neared, they saw the entrance was closed. She-Ra/Adora did not even bother opening it with a command this time; she simply bashed the door down with her sword.

"I like your style, Adora," Scorpia said appreciatively, as they all headed in.

Linda, with Entrapta within, approached the door and halted, seeing it was too small for the robot's frame. Using her two huge arms, Linda pried the doorway wider, making space for her bulk, then continued down the hallway. It was big enough for the large machine and it continued down with the rest of the team, turning on its forward lights to illuminate the gloomy hallway.

"This place hasn't changed much since last time, it's still a huge downer." muttered Glimmer as they raced ahead.

By memory, they followed the twists and turns down into the depths of the temple. Soon, they made their way to the entrance of the main chamber. They came up short as soon as they entered.

Before them, on the other side of the chamber and between the pillars, was the huge form of the Shen'Aan-war sitting on his throne. Behind and around him, armored figures could be seen, the Shen'Sho-heim, with two Death-Binders among them. The two groups stood motionless, watching each other, trying to see who would make the first move.

"Welcome, your visit is an unexpected, but not a troublesome surprise." The Shen'Aan-war called to them.

The seated giant rose and strode forward. He was dressed just as Adora remembered him from her dreams; armored shoulders and arms, cloaked in a black robe, a huge sword mounted on his back.

His head was bare save his jagged crown, his long gray hair flowing freely. He was grinning maliciously as he reached two clawed hands down toward his robe, and with one abrupt tear, ripped the black robe completely apart and off him, revealing the form below.

A barely clothed, heavily bloated and muscular body could be seen, much bigger than the He-Man Adora had seen in Mara's vision. Grotesque muscles bulged past the harness that crisscrossed his torso, the same harness with the cross symbol on the front. He was wearing black fur-topped boots and a black fur loincloth held in place with a black belt.

He was a completely dark and twisted version of the heroic He-Man Adora had seen in the vision. She was filled with dread looking at him and she could feel the essence of She-Ra cry out in dismay.

"Uh, Adora, is that guy wearing furry underwear?" Catra asked lowly, chuckling.

She-Ra/Adora was immediately pulled out of her spiraling dark thoughts by Catra's blunt words and started to laugh.

"I think you're right Catra, he is wearing fur underwear. Or is it furry underwear?" She-Ra/Adora replied, still laughing.

The Shen'Aan-war's smiling face suddenly became much crueler and he began to walk forward, drawing the huge sword from his back.

"You mock me, creature? Perhaps I shall make a new loincloth from your pelt after I kill you." He said to Catra, menacingly.

Catra hissed and She-Ra/Adora raised her sword. "*You stay away from her you bastard*!" She-Ra/Adora screamed.

The Shen'Aan-war stopped a few paces from She-Ra/Adora and her friends. His minions, who up until that point were moving in, stopped as well.

“My, my, She-Ra, you are just as beautiful as I remember.” The Shen’Aan-war said, hungrily.

“Uh, same She-Ra, different person, didn’t you notice?” She-Ra/Adora replied in disgust.

He shrugged at this. “It matters not. So, you have come to face me. Shall we see who will be master of the universe?” the Shen’Aan-War asked.

“Master? I have no intention of being the universe’s master, you tyrant.” She-Ra/Adora answered.

“Then what is the point? Why fight me? Who is She-Ra if not a master of the universe?” the Shen’Aan-war asked incredulously.

She-Ra/Adora looked as if she was seriously pondering this. “I dunno…protector of the universe? Guardian of the universe?” she said, uncertainly.

“*Weak.*” the Shen'Aan-war spat scornfully. “I see She-Ra has found another *weak* host. Mara was *weak,* too.”

“Mara was stronger than you’ll ever be. Mara chose the hard route, the route to protect innocents. You chose the easy route, a route to damnation.” She-Ra/Adora was angry now.

“I’LL SHOW YOU DAMNATION!!” the Shen’Aan-war screamed as he charged She-Ra/Adora.

His descending sword was blocked by She-Ra/Adora’s; she had to bend a knee for his strength was immense and unnatural. He towered over her by a full head, his ugly and cruel face leering down at her. Looking at the sword in front of her, She-Ra/Adora saw that it was the same one from her vision with Mara, only larger, as if bloated by dark power like its owner. It had the same inlaid circuity on its surface as her old sword of protection; it glowed with a dark light.



Taking the lead from the dueling pair, the two opposing sides engaged.

Chaos ensued.

Catra leaped into the air, intent on hunting one of the Death Binders who ran, turning to shoot white ghostly fire back at her. Catra dodged these blasts easily, laughing with glee.

Glimmer raised her staff to summon power from above, then lowered it to shoot Star Fire at two charging Shen'Sho-heim; they stumbled back from the searing blasts.

Scorpia engaged one of the black armored giants, catching a descending sword blow in her claw. With her other claw, she cleanly decapitated the giant, and hissing vapors blasted from the spot its head used to be.

Bow drew an arrow back and fired, striking a fleeing Death Binder; green goo exploded everywhere. He was trying to slow the fleeing sorcerer long enough for Catra to get her claws on him, and the green goo barely missed the leaping Catra.

"Hey, Punchy, watch it! Try to actually hit the bad guys!" Catra yelled, accusingly.

"Sorry..." Bow said, shamefaced. He then directed his arrows toward the Shen'Sho-heim Glimmer was currently engaging, trying to slow them down enough for her to charge her powers and blast them repeatedly.

Linda and Entrapta were charging around the room, grabbing two of the armored Shen'Sho-heim in both large hands and holding them aloft. Just as they raised their weapons to strike down on Linda, they were smashed together. Holding them by their legs or arms, Linda repeatedly smashed them into the ground, like a child mistreating two toys. They finally broke apart, falling to pieces as two large mist clouds billowed up.

She-Ra/Adora and the Shen'Aan-war continued to trade blows, She-Ra/Adora being put on the defensive by his strength. They broke and the Shen'Aan-war gazed at his panting nemesis.

"I expected a better fight than this. How did someone so weak as you defeat my assassin, the Demon-Heart? How did you manage to destroy it?" he asked, incredulously.

"By freeing your son from it from its grip, freeing him from the torment you've inflicted on him." She-Ra/Adora accused.

"Ah, yes, my 'son', the Outcast... so you destroyed him, then?" he asked nonchalantly.

"No, he did not need to die. He is alive and back on Etheria, out of your reach." She-Ra/Adora taunted the Shen'Aan-war.

There was a burst of fury on his horrible cruel face. "He is not yours to take." he snarled, swiping his sword downward at her.

She blocked his strike, kicking out at his knee, and was rewarded with a grunt of pain. "He is not mine. He is his own person, and I will protect him from you," she said emphatically, jumping back from a horizontal swipe of his sword.

The Shen'Aan-war was now incandescent in his fury, and he lunged at her with furious, alternating diagonal slashes. She-Ra/Adora was barely able to block this assault and screamed in pain as she received deep slashes on her upper right arm and left forearm

"Adora!" Catra screamed as she leaped on the Shen'Aan-war's shoulders, furiously slashing at his head with her claws, knocking his crown off.

He bellowed in pain and shook his upper body in one powerful movement, flinging his attacker off him. Catra is not done though, flying through the air she rebounded off one of the pillars, directly back at her foe, passing by his face and delivering a slash across it.

The Shen'Aan-war screamed again and swung a backward slash at Catra, just missing her as she leaped away. He pointed one of his gauntleted claws in her direction, fingers splayed open, and a screaming ghostly orb issued forth. It moved slowly but steadily toward Catra, who ran as fast as she could to elude it. It sought her out, turning toward any direction Catra tried to flee in.

"Catra! To me!" yelled Glimmer, holding her staff out.

Catra ran to Glimmer on all fours as fast as she could muster, and as soon as she was close to her friend, Glimmer summoned a magical barrier. The screaming orb hit the barrier and splashed over it like water, emitting one last shriek before completely dissipating.

"Thanks, Sparkles," Catra said, panting and hunched over, holding her knees.

"Anytime." Glimmer replied with a smile.

The Shen'Aan-war had turned back to his duel with She-Ra/Adora, when Linda with Entrapta inside stepped in between them, fists up.

"Foolish toy." The Shen'Aan-war growled, putting his sword back in its scabbard behind his back as he raised his clawed gauntlets. "I will tear you apart with my bare hands."

Linda leaped high in the air, both fists raised to smite their enemy. As she came down, the Shen'Aan-war caught both larger hands in his smaller clawed ones, holding them fast.

"Ohhhh, come on girl…" Entrapta coaxed, trying to summon more power to the arms.

The Shen'Aan-war grinned maliciously as ghostly white light transferred from his hands to the mechanical fists, wrapping them in the dread light, which spread to the rest of Linda's body.

“Oh boy, this isn’t gooooood. *Fascinating*…” Entrapta said, distracted.

“Entrapta, look out!” screamed She-Ra/Adora.

The Shen’Aan-war had released his physical hold on his enemy; for now, it was held fast by his magical power. He delivered powerful swipes with his claws, tearing huge gouges into Linda. Entrapta’s mount and friend seemed to moan in pain at the egregious damage being done to her, and she toppled over.

“AAGGGGHHHH, eject, eject!” Entrapta screamed, trying to get the controls to do as she asked, but they weren’t working- she was trapped.

The Shen’Aan-war drew his sword, grinning like a mad man, and strode to the purple dome on Linda’s prone body, Entrapta struggling within. As he raised his sword to bury it point first into his downed enemy, he was tackled bodily from behind; She-Ra/Adora was just in time to save her friend. Both warriors rolled, struggling against each other, then parted, standing and raising their swords to resume their duel.

“Entrapta, I’m coming!” screamed Catra, running to the glass dome.

Catra swiped furiously at the purple glass, gouging it with scratches, but she did no damage. Desperate now, Catra removed her gold headpiece, and holding it by one of the flaring wings, proceeded to smash it into the dome. Catra put all of her considerable strength into the blows, finally being rewarded with a crack; then the glass shattered. Entrapa closed her eyes and covered herself with her ponytails, flinching from the glass pieces. Catra reached inside, slicing the harnesses with her claws and gently wiping the glass pieces from her friend.

“Aw thanks, Catra, I’ve got it from here—ack!” Entrapta yelped as Catra scooped the smaller woman up in her arms, leaping away to safety.

As they escaped, Linda emitted one final moan then exploded, metal pieces flying everywhere. Catra stood at a safe distance with Entrapta still in her arms, watching the demise of the faithful robot.

Entrapa put a gloved hand on Catra's face. "Catra, you saved me! But you lost that nice shiny headpiece... I'm sorry." She said sorrowfully.

Catra rolled her eyes and put Entrapta down. "You need to stay back now, Entrapta, okay? Please?" Catra pleaded.

"Okay." Entrapta conceded, patting her friend on the head with one of her ponytails. "My poor Linda..." She said mournfully at the smoking ruin of her friend as Catra leaped to assist Bow.

The duel continued to be one-sided between She-Ra/Adora and the Shen'Aan-war; She-Ra/Adora had since changed her sword into a shield, blocking his relentless strikes.

I really hope this guy wears down before I do. His power is incredible, but unnatural! she thought to herself, blocking another blow.

"Perhaps after I defeat you, I will take you back with me, to Shen'Dar-oom. There, I will offer you to the Set'Heth-un'dar to become like me. Would you like that?" he asked, mockingly.

"No, not really." She-Ra/Adora panted, lunging and smashing him in his leering face with her shield.

"GAHHHH!" he hissed, dropping his sword and clutching She-Ra/Adora by the arms, pinning them to her sides. She struggled in his grip but was frozen, seized by his dark power.

She-Ra/Adora felt only coldness spreading from his touch to the rest of her body. It was as if her life force, both hers and She-Ra's, was being sucked out of her. She felt herself slipping away, her consciousness fading, as if she was slowly going to sleep.

“Adora!” Glimmer cried, directing a bolt of hot Star Fire into the Shen’Aan-war’s face.

“RAHHGGGHH…” he screamed, dropping She-Ra/Adora to the ground, holding his face in pain.

She-Ra/Adora reverted form back to Adora and lay there, dazed, as Glimmer ran to her side.

“Adora? Can you change back? We need She-Ra!” Glimmer exclaimed.

“Uh…don’t think so…he is too strong…” Adora replied, weakly.

Glimmer looked up; the Shen’Aan-war had since regained his composure and was leering at them in his perceived triumph.

Glimmer saw something then, looking at this huge hulking monster that was once a man, and saw inside him to his true self. She saw the weak, twisted old man from her vision, the one begging her to free him. An overwhelming sense of compassion and pity hit her then, and she realized what she needed to do.

Glimmer stood and raised her staff, the Starstone at the top shining brightly as beams of rainbow light shot down from the sky, alighting there. Then, she pointed it at the Shen’Aan-war, and ribbons of bright starlight emanated from the end toward him wrapping around him and pinning his arms to his side.

“GAHHHH! WHAT IS THIS? NOOOOO!” he screamed, piteously.

The ribbons covered his torso, legs and face, forming a cocoon of starlight. Then the bindings squeezed the Shen’Aan-war... There was a sound like metal being crushed followed by a long deep sigh, the bound form within shrinking. A large cloud of screaming vapor shot forth from the bindings, much like when the Shen’Sho-heim perished. The starlight binding burst open, revealing the form within.

It was a withered and naked old man. He was gasping in alarm and pain, clawing and kicking weakly with his arms and legs.

“MASTER!” one of the Death-Binders screamed, rushing to his side. The surviving Shen’Sho-heim screeched in unison and they retreated to their fallen master, one of them lifting his shriveled form into its arms while the others formed a protective circle around him.

“No, don’t them escape! This is our chance!” yelled Glimmer.

Before her friends could act, the two Death-Binders rushed forward and grasped the two nearest ghostly orbs mounted on the pillars. They held the orbs and screamed, and a sense of déjà vu overcame Glimmer.

“NO! Everyone get out of here, now!” she screamed, helping Adora to her feet.

The friends rushed out of the chamber, toward the exit as the two activated orbs grew in intensity. Adora turned as she left, looking back to see one of the Shen’Sho-heim carrying her weakened nemesis through the activated portal to safety.

“Next time,” she murmured.

They scrambled madly through the dark hallways as an explosion could be heard behind them. The entire structure around them began to shake; it was coming apart.

They burst through the smashed entrance in a cloud of debris smoke, and once they were a safe distance away, turned around.

They watched as the entire twisted temple folded in on itself in abrupt, jerky motions. Beams of ghostly light shone out like searchlights through the seams and cracks of the folding structure. It folded smaller and smaller until it simply disappeared out of existence with a small “pop”. Where once there was an immense structure, there was now only a huge open empty pit.

“That. Was. So. FAAASCCCINNNATING!!” exclaimed Entrapta.

“Not the way I’d put it, but I agree with the sentiment,” said Scorpia, laying a claw on Entrapta’s shoulder.

With the temple’s destruction complete, it was completely quiet outside; the outside battle appeared to be over. While the battle had raged inside, the Etherian Star Force ground troops had soundly defeated the Shen’Aan-war’s guarding forces outside of the temple. Groups of black uniformed soldiers that surrendered could be seen here and there under guard.

“So, is that it? Did we beat them? Is it over?” Bow asked, looking at his friends. Everyone looked at each other, not saying anything for a while, until Adora spoke up.

“We have driven the Shen’Aan-war out of our universe and back into darkness, but we still have his fleet to deal with. Hopefully, without his leadership, they will be in disarray and it will be a quick fight. Unfortunately, I don’t think that this is the last we have seen of him...” Adora said sadly.

Catra walked up to Adora from behind, wrapping her arms under Adora’s, and hugged her tight.

“We’ll be waiting for him when he does,” Catra stated quietly, purring in Adora’s ear.

Glimmer, Bow, and Scorpia walked up on either side of Adora to join in the group hug. Entrapta turned from her admiration of the large open pit and stared at her friends for a moment, then she too joined in, wrapping the entire group in her ponytails, happiness written on her face.

Chapter End Notes

Illustration of Shen'Aan-war and She-Ra done by @Yoritomito.

Home

Part III

…we helped each other learn how to heal ourselves, and through this…

Adora was back where she had been almost two months ago; she was at the small landing pad by Bright Moon Bay, helping to unload Darla. It was one of those rare cloudy Etherian days, dark and brooding. Adora didn't mind though. She was just happy to be home and there was no way a bunch of clouds would dampen that.

* HOME AT LAST *

After the defeat of the Shen'Aan-war, they raced back to the fleet at Omiros, arriving in time to see the end of a space battle. With the Shen'Aan-war's departure from this reality, the magical offensive capabilities of the enemy fleet had diminished. No teleportation of Szi'th or mental attacks on the crew occurred, only weak versions of the vortexes they summoned earlier. Instead of swallowing the ship whole, the vortex was only able to drain shields marginally and disrupt the ship's power distribution systems.

The ensuing battle was short, with much of the Shen'Aan-war's fleet surrendering to the Etherian Star Force. However, some of the enemy ships escaped, entering hyperspace in different

directions to throw off their pursuers. When Star Force ground forces boarded the black ships, they could find no sign of any of the Death-Binders, and the escape of the few enemy ships took on a whole darker aspect with that discovery.

The captured enemy ships were manned by clones and the entirety of the Star Force Ground trooper contingent for the trip back to Etheria. The trip was uneventful, for they found a mostly compliant crew in the Shen'Aan-war's people, or as they called themselves, the Set'Heth-un'dar Sho-heim. They were mostly fearful and bewildered, not used to the kind treatment afforded to them by the Etherians. The only issue was communication; the newcomers only spoke that strange whispery language of She-Thar. This was quickly overcome, for Entrapta had quickly devised a translator device that was copied and distributed among the fleet.

The captured Set'Heth-un'dar Sho-heim were to be brought back to Etheria and set up in camps to learn how to be integrated into Etherian society, much like the Horde soldiers before them. This was not expected to be a problem, for the people of Etheria were experienced by now with healing, forgiveness, helping others through their trauma and learning from their mistakes.

Adora looked up as she heard her name called, and saw the rest of the princesses, Micah, Castaspella, Juliet, Lance and George approaching, smiles on their faces. Glimmer, Bow, Catra and the rest of the returning party rushed to meet them, letting loose cries of joy at the reunion.

Scorpia lifted Perfuma in the air before lowering her into an embrace and kiss; the flower Perfuma gave her was still fresh and in Scorpia's white hair.

Glimmer ran into her father's arms. Micah gathered up his daughter in a huge hug, as Castaspella stood behind clutching her hands together, tears in her eyes. Bow similarly ran into both his father's waiting embraces; all three men were crying.

Adora, Catra and Entrapta greeted Mermista, Spinnerella, Netossa and Frosta; Catra and Mermista exchanged secret handshakes like the cool girls that they were and Frosta gave Adora a hug. Frosta was now fourteen years old, a teenager, and almost as tall as Adora. Entrapta stood back smiling at everyone until Mermista beckoned to her.

"Oh, come here you weirdo, give me a hug," Mermista said, pulling Entrapta in a big hug.

Adora beamed at her friends, overjoyed to be home, then it hit her.

"Hey, guys... where's Shen?" Adora asked the princesses.

Netossa, Spinnerella, Mermista and Frosta exchanged guilty looks, and Perfuma walked up.

"Last time I saw him, he was leaving Plumeria to go stay with Mermista." She said, brightly.

Adora looked at Mermista who only shrugged.

"Guys, I asked you to take turns looking after him. What gives?" Adora exclaimed, frustration seeping into her voice.

"Like, I mean we were taking turns just like you said. We would have him for a week, then he would go to the next princess. It was working out fine, and, I mean, he wasn't bad to have around. Like, once he warmed up to you, he was actually pretty funny! We had lots of fun at Sea-Hawk's expense, for sure." Mermista smirked.

"I was working with him on his issues, like you asked Adora, but he kept deflecting my attempts by making jokes. Much like someone else I know." Perfuma said, turning to look at Catra.

"I liked having him around too. When I was going through some… relationship rejection issues…he was the only person who seemed to notice I was hurting. He came up to me one day with a bunch

of Ice Roses and asked if I was okay, if I wanted to talk about anything. He spent the next hour with me while I bawled my eyes out. I got over the rejection the next day, but what he did meant a lot to me." Frosta stated shyly.

"He hung out with Spinnerella and me for a while. I mean, we move around a lot, so it's hard for us to keep track of someone else. He was pretty easy going. He seemed to absolutely love camping with us in the Whispering Woods." Netossa added.

"I think he was tired of being shuffled around and felt like a burden. He must have gone off to do his own thing." Perfuma added, trying to be helpful.

General Juliet stepped into the conversation. "Maim, Adora, if I may? I've been keeping an eye on this Shen since he was in Bright Moon. I know, I know, we're supposed to trust him…" Juliet said after Adora glared at her. "But security is my job and he was once the biggest security threat we've had in a while. Anyway, the last report I've had of Shen's whereabouts was in the company of a known troublemaker, aptly named 'Double Trouble'".

Catra immediately burst out laughing. "He's with Double Trouble? HA! Oh boy, Adora, you were right, that guy definitely needed looking after!" Catra continued guffawing while Adora scowled at her.

Adora closed her eyes while holding the bridge of her nose. "Ughhhh…well, I just want to settle in and relax. I can deal with this later." she sighed.

* * *

Glimmer teleported outside of Madame Razz's cottage. She was there to return the staff and robe she borrowed. She wasn't really thrilled about the idea of handing back the items which gave her so much power, but promises were promises.

It was the day after their return from space. Bow was spending time with his dads, and Micah and Castaspella had important

duties to attend to, namely, planning the Vow ceremony for Glimmer and Bow. It was planned to take place tomorrow; the two young lovers were in a rush to take their Vow to each other, especially after what they went through in space.

Glimmer thought her father was going to faint when he was told of his daughter's plans to take the Vow, but once the idea had a chance to sink in, he was overjoyed and even started crying. Castaspella was completely head over heels at the news and had begun planning the whole ceremony in her head. They actually had most of it planned by now, they just needed a Vow Celebrant to lead the ceremony.

Glimmer looked around the outside of the cottage and saw what appeared to be a small tent not far away. Swift Wind was nearby too, eating apples. He waved a rainbow wing at her.

"Hey Grimmer, goob to smee you bac!" he shouted around a mouthful of apples.

"Hey Swifty, it's good to see you, too. Is Madame Razz getting ready for a camping trip?" she asked him.

Swift Wind only laughed and went back to eating, Glimmer walked up to the cottage entrance.

She stood in front of the cloth that served as Madam Razz's door. Glimmer was always unsure how to announce her presence, since she couldn't knock on cloth.

"Hellooooo, Madame Razz?" Glimmer called.

"Yes, yes, come in, come in, Adora," Razz called out to her.

Glimmer rolled her eyes at being called "Adora" and began to walk inside, immediately smelling baked goods, but came up short.

"Shen?" Glimmer asked, incredulously.

Shen was sitting at the table, sipping on tea and eating freshly-baked cookies. Where the new furniture came from, Glimmer had no idea. The old woman seemed to have some secret storage space for miscellaneous furniture. The old woman was fussing about, but turned and smiled at Glimmer when she entered.

"Glimmer!" Shen cried, jumping up and drawing her in a hug.

They parted, gazing at each other. "I didn't know you returned, but I'm so glad you made it back safely! Glimmer, are Adora and Bow okay? Tell me everything!" Shen asked.

"Yes, yes, everyone is okay." Glimmer said, then began recounting what occurred out in space during the past two months. The battles, the magic they encountered at the Omiros Bridge, the standoff, and how both sides sent for reinforcements. Glimmer skipped the part about her injuries, not wishing to upset her friend. Then, their contact "White-Claw" on Thenlor, and the desperate strike at the heart of the enemy on the planet Twilight. Shen was visibly upset at the description of the battle that took place, the Shen'Aan-war and She-Ra's fight, and how his father was close to killing Adora, or worse. He clenched his teeth and fists in rage.

"I wish I was there. I would have made him *pay*." He hissed.

Glimmer didn't like seeing him so upset and rubbed his arm in reassurance. "It's okay, your buddy Glimmer was there to save the day!" She said with a grin, then described using her newfound magic to finally cast the Cosmic Binding on the Shen'Aan-war, changing him back to his original form— a pitiful old man.

"You defeated the Shen'Aan-war?" Shen said in awe. "This is something that hasn't happened in the whole history of our people."

Glimmer blew on her fingers and rubbed them on her chest. "Hey, no tyrant is too big for Queen Glimmer to take down," she said smugly.

Madame Razz walked up then. “Yes, yes, Madame Razz is glad you finally found out how to use the Cosmic Binding dearie, but don’t get overconfident. Did you capture or kill your enemy?”

“Ugh, no. He escaped through a portal and back to his dimension.” Glimmer said, exasperated.

Shen and Madame Razz looked disappointed at this news, but said nothing.

“Anyway, Shen, what are you doing here? Adora was looking for you yesterday. She thought you would be with the princesses.” Glimmer asked.

He looked sheepish at this. “Yeah, I don’t know...I just felt like a drag on everyone, having to be passed around like baggage. I decided to give the princesses a break and left. I got caught up in some stuff for a while, but then I ended up out in the Whispering Woods. It’s so beautiful out here. I could stay here forever. Madame Razz let me set up camp near her cottage and I come over once in a while for company. She makes some great tea.” Shen added.

Madame Razz came over to him and pinched Shen’s cheek. “Such a good boy,” she said to him.

“I’m sure it’s great out here Shen, but you should come back to Bright Moon. We miss you, plus I put all that effort into getting you that room.” Glimmer said with a grin.

“Well, I guess, but what about you, Madame Razz? I mean, that horse of yours is good company, but he isn’t exactly reliable.” Shen said in concern.

“I’M NOBODY’S HORSE!” Swift Wind yelled from outside.

“SHUDDUP!” Madame Razz yelled back. “No, my boy, Madame Razz has been here by herself for a long time and can take care of herself. You go back, be with your friends. Go pack now. Madame

Razz must speak with your friend here." Madame Razz said kindly to Shen.

Shen smiled and nodded, walking out the door.

"I'll be out in a bit. Wait for me, I can teleport us to Bright Moon." Glimmer called to him.

Glimmer held out the robe and staff to Razz. "I brought these back, as promised," she said to the old woman.

Madame Razz took the staff and the robe, smiling back at Glimmer in appreciation.

"Now, tell Madame Razz about the Cosmic Binding spell. How were you finally able to summon it?" Madame Razz asked.

During the tale she told Shen, Glimmer did not mention the vision-dreams that she had. She went into detail about them with Madame Razz. She told Razz about both the vision with Zzar and the vision of the old man. Madame Razz was visibly disturbed when Glimmer told her of Zzar, the dark ritual she conducted and her fate.

"Yes, yes, these visions were fortuitous for they enabled you to access your pity and empathy. Both are important for Cosmic Binding." Madame Razz said, softly.

Glimmer looked at Madame Razz as if trying to make up her mind about something, then finally spoke up. "Madame Razz, who was Zzar? I'm sorry if it's a difficult question, but I keep having visions of her. I feel like she is important to what is going on."

Madame Razz looked at her strangely for a moment, then looked away and sighed. "Yes, I will tell you," she said, not speaking of herself in the third person anymore.

"Zzar was my sister. We were both part of an ancient order, an order whose job it was to protect powerful forces. We were each tasked with guarding a specific force; I was tasked with guarding

the Starstone and Zzar, the Life Gem. There were other guardians too. They were all our siblings, and together we held back the darkness." Madame Razz said.

Just then, Glimmer remembered Adora mentioned the same phrase when she told Glimmer about her vision with Mara, and how Mara said it was her order's job to do the same.

"Was this order somehow related to She-Ra and He-Man?" Glimmer asked.

Madame Razz nodded. "Yes, we all worked together— two orders that were part of the same universal force, the force for good, at least on this plane of existence anyway."

Glimmer didn't even know how to respond to that statement and kept her mouth shut, letting the old woman continue.

"We worked together in harmony for countless eons, all content in our specific roles. But over time, my sister, Zzar, became curious, greedy. She was tired of her ward, the Life Gem, and started becoming interested in its opposite, which is of course, Death."

"We all became worried by this, and tried to help guide her away from her dark course. Eventually, we thought we cured Zzar of her curiosity for she no longer openly sought death. Little did we know that she continued in secret."

"By this time, she had become the 'Castle Sorcerer' for the Empire and resided in Eternos. This Castle was special, for it resided over great power and many secrets were kept within it. Zzar had access to all of these secrets and she delved long and deep, finally finding the one secret she desired most of all."

"She began twisting the Life Gem to her new desires, and we, her siblings, could hear the screams of the Life Gem every time she did so. Eventually, they sent me to bring her back, for judgment. You know the rest of that particular story." Madame Razz finished, giving Glimmer a knowing look.

Glimmer looked sheepish at this, remembering the time she pried into Madame Razz's secrets and getting caught.

"So, what I saw in the vision was Zzar conducting the ritual she learned from this castle's secrets? But what was its intent? It looked like whatever she was doing ended up killing her." Glimmer said.

Madame Razz shook her head at this. "No, what happened to my sister was worse than death. She was using that ritual to create a new source of power, the power of Death. The ritual worked and she and the Life Gem were absorbed into the new power; the Life Gem was twisted, allowing Death to take form through the power of life and Zzar's life force created consciousness for this new power. I can sometimes hear my sister, screaming in torment, screaming to be released…" Madame Razz said, tears in her eyes.

Glimmer wrapped her arms around the crying old woman. "I'm so sorry." Glimmer whispered to her mentor.

Glimmer held Madame Razz like that for a while until her crying subsided, then the old woman patted Glimmer's back.

"Thank you, dearie, Madame Razz appreciates it, you are such a good girl. Now, why don't we talk about something else, eh? You want a cookie?" Madame Razz asked, presenting the tray to Glimmer.

"Don't mind if I do!" Glimmer said with a smile, popping a cookie in her mouth. "Mmm…smo good. Eh-uh…anyway, besides giving your staff back, I wanted to ask you for a favor."

"Yes dearie?" the old woman asked.

"You remember that handsome guy Bow I'm always bringing around? He and I decided to take the Vow together!" Glimmer said excitedly.

Razz looked confused at this. "Vow? Like what Madame Razz had to say when she accepted the Starstone?"

Glimmer laughed. "Noooo…we are taking the Vow, as in a Vow to each other. We are in love and want to be together forever. We want to make a sacred Vow to each other in front of the Moonstone. I wanted to ask you to preside over it as the Vow Celebrant!"

Madame Razz shrugged at this. "Oh whatever, okay. Madame Razz doesn't understand why you must do this 'Vow' if you are already in love, but what does Madame Razz know? She has only been alive for over ten thousand years."

Glimmer was completely awestruck by Madame Razz's lifespan, but said nothing, simply popping another cookie in her mouth.

* * *

Glimmer and Shen teleported directly into the hallway their rooms shared, back in Bright Moon.

"Home sweet home!" Glimmer said happily to her friend.

Shen smiled as he looked up and down the hall, holding the small bag of personal belongings he had acquired during his time on Etheria.

"Now that you guys are back, it does feel like home again," Shen told Glimmer.

"Aww…well, you remember where your room is, right? I have to go see my Father and Aunt and let them know we have a Vow Celebrant, plus I should kind of be involved in planning my own Vow Ceremony. Don't forget, you better be there tomorrow!" Glimmer said to Shen.

"I wouldn't miss it," he replied as she vanished.

As he walked back to his room, Shen heard voices behind him. Turning around, he saw Adora and Catra approaching their room. There were carrying what appeared to be clothes draped from hangers; Adora had a pink and purple dress while Catra had a

dark purple jacket and pants, along with a pink shirt. They were laughing happily when Adora noticed Shen down the hall.

"Hey, you! There you are!" she yelled to him, then she said something to Catra who took her gown for her. Catra glanced at Shen, giving him a completely unreadable look, before going into the room she shared with Adora.

Adora ran down the hall, embracing Shen in a firm hug when she reached him. He returned the hug, although not as firmly; Adora's grip was strong and it was hard to move his arms.

They parted, smiling at each other. "It's good to see you safe and sound back home, Adora," Shen stated happily.

"It's good to be home. I was a little worried when I didn't see you, though. Where were you?" Adora asked.

"Oh, I've been around…" He said vaguely, then motioned his head toward his room. He and Adora walked in. Shen tossed his bag of possessions in the corner and took a seat at his table. He motioned for Adora to take the seat across from him.

"The last thing I heard was that you were with Double Trouble, what was that about?" Adora said, pulling out a chair.

Shen laughed. "Oh, that. They pulled me out of some trouble I was getting into. We were hanging out for a while after that, but then went our separate ways. I headed out to the Whispering Woods afterwards. It was good to be out there in the peace and quiet. I really haven't been up to much, Adora, just waiting for you guys to return like a lonely pet." he said the last part with a laugh. "Anyway, I got some of the story from Glimmer, but I'd like to hear it from you too. What happened out there?"

Adora went into the tale from her perspective, adding the bit about Glimmer being hurt, waiting for her to wake up, and almost having to take Darla back to Etheria.

“Glimmer kind of skipped over that part,” Shen said, shaking his head.

“Yeah... you know how she is, doesn’t want to worry people,” Adora said, also shaking her head.

Adora finished her tale with the trip to Thenlor, meeting their contact Panga, the journey to Twilight, facing the Shen’Aan-war and his defeat.

“I wish I could’ve seen him crawling powerless around the ground,” Shen said when she was finished. “It’s too bad he escaped though, he is still out there, plotting.”

“Yeah, well you don’t have to worry about him, Shen. I won’t let him hurt you or anyone else again.” Adora declared.

Shen was touched by the thought that anyone would care enough about him to protect him from someone as powerful as the Shen’Aan-war. He also felt guilty, for he did not want to be a burden that needed protection; he wanted to do the protecting, especially when it came to his friends.

“Adora, I don’t want to just sit around here on Etheria, being protected. When I said I would be there for you, I didn’t mean just helping you with your dreams. I’ve been trained as a warrior. I want to fight, to help protect *you* in return.” he said emphatically.

Adora had known this was coming.

“Yes, I know you do, Shen, but we need to work some things out before that. I want you to continue working with Perfuma... and this time, you need to take it seriously. Please, for me? I also want to see what your capabilities are, fighting-wise. I have someone in mind for you to work with, it’ll be a good exercise for you both. After that, well... we’ll see.” Adora explained.

Shen nodded. “Yes, of course, I must prove myself. I have no problem with that.”

Adora raised her hands placatingly. “No, not prove yourself, Shen, that’s not what I mean. It’s just, you have to…”

“…Prove myself to you?” Shen finished for her, smiling.

Adora looked sheepish, not saying anything.

“Well, anyway Adora, tell me about the nightmares? Anything new you want to discuss?” Shen asked.

“I have not had a single new nightmare since we defeated the Shen’Aan-war, nothing.” Adora said, smiling.

“That’s great!” Shen replied.

“I did want to ask you a few questions about your world, Shen’Dar-oom. Stuff that has been bugging me.” Adora said.

Shen beckoned for her to continue. “That first dream I had of the Set’Heth-un’dar, when I was in the water. I remember the water was warm, and the light being projected above was cold, this just doesn’t make sense. Also, there are trees and life on your world, how is this possible? How does anything live on your planet?” Adora asked dumbfounded.

Shen looked very thoughtful. “Yes, this is something not really discussed among my people, except for those in the rebellion. Shen’Dara was the one to speak to me about this, it is a story, an idea, called the Shea’Har-the, the Heart of Light. It is the idea that there is magic inside our world, buried deep in its heart, where it has been pushed down and suppressed by the power of the Set’Heth-un’dar. It is the belief that this magic has a sentience of its own, and it loves us, loves the people and life of the planet. It finds ways to seep up, pushing back the dark power above, to help keep us alive. Keeping the plant life alive without true light, giving just enough warmth to the planet from freezing. This warmth comes up from deep in the ocean, that is why it is so warm.”

“That is beautiful, Shen. Come to think of it, when Etheria was in Despondos, we didn’t exactly have anything like a sun to keep us warm either, it must have been the magic which kept us alive.” Adora said, with wonder in her voice.

“Yes, I believe it, Etheria is truly magical and wonderous. I feel a similar sensation here as I do back on my home planet, although here it is stronger, it must be the magic I am feeling.” Shen said.

They were silent for a moment, letting the implications of the mutual magical nature of their planets sink in.

“So, did the Heart Thorn help you at all? Hopefully you didn’t have to deal with the Szi’th but I’m sure that is unlikely.” Shen asked.

Adora looked a little guilty at this. “Well, since I have She-Ra, I gave it to Catra, and she lost it. It did help protect her though, so I thank you for that.”

Shen laughed. “Yes, I should have known you would have given it to her, it was yours to give anyway, to protect your love. I’m glad it helped her, although did you tell her it was from me?”

“Yeah, Catra didn’t care, I think she will come around to you Shen, don’t worry about her. It just takes her a while to get used to someone new.” Adora said confidently.

Shen remembered the shock on her face when she looked into his eyes the day he slipped. The horror in her eyes when suggested she could rip his throat out. He did not feel confident this would be the case.

“I hope your right.” was all he said.

A Day of Vows and Horrible Shanties

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"BONG! BONG!"

Catra opened one bleary blue eye and moaned.

"BONG! BONG! BONG!"

"Adoraaaa…make it stop…" Catra groaned to her bedmate.

Adora's eyes opened wide with shock, and she leaped out of bed in a panic.

"Catra! Those are the Vow ceremony chimes, it's starting soon. We're going to be late!" she gasped.

Catra leaped out of the bed with a shriek and landed on all fours, tail bushy.

"Hurry! Glimmer will *literally kill us* if we're late to her Vow ceremony!" she screeched.

The two women frantically took turns trying to brush each other's hair; they were both a complete mess.

For the past two nights, they had been living it up, so happy to be home again. Last night's adventures had taken place in

Seaworthy. They had been invited there by Seahawk and stayed up far too late.

Adora was trying to brush out the mass of tangles that was Catra's hair, eliciting yelps of pain here and there.

"Hurry up. Adora, what's the problem?" Catra whined.

"Catra, I don't know how you keep this mop under control. I mean, your little brown hair tuft is stuck to your ear. How did that happen?" Adora asked.

"Uh, because someone spilled sugary drinks in my hair, *Adora*…" Catra said, accusingly.

"Oh yeah, I forgot." Adora sniggered, finally pulling the tuft off of Catra's ear and brushing it down.

They both scrambled into their outfits, laughing and giggling now. Catra helped Adora with the clasps in the back of her gown while Adora tied the knot in Catra's bow tie. As this was such an important occasion, Catra decided to go with the full tuxedo look. Finally, they were ready to go.

"Race you there, slowpoke!" Catra teased, going for the door.

"Nope!" Adora said, shoving Catra back on the bed and running out the door, slamming it behind her.

There was a loud BANG and a whine against the door, but Adora kept running; she knew Catra's tricks.

Adora was almost to the stairs when the door flung open and Catra came running out, grinning wildly.

"Hey Adora, I'm gonna *geeeet* you!" Catra called creepily, then proceeded to run after her on all fours.

Adora screamed in excitement and ran down the stairs, almost losing her shoes in her attempt to escape her pursuer. She burst

out of the doors and onto the grounds, running as fast as her legs could take her. It was an absolutely beautiful Etherian day, the perfect day for Glimmer and Bow to take their Vow.

Adora looked to her left while she ran, seeing nothing. Then she looked to the right and yelped when she saw Catra running on all fours next to her, grinning up at her. Catra stood up and continued to run next to her. She was starting to gain ground and pull ahead of her.

Adora reached forward and yanked on Catra's tail, pulling her back.

"Yeow! No cheating!" Catra complained.

The two continued to jostle each other while running to their destination, laughing and yelling the whole way up the stairs to Bright Moon Castle.

* * *

Glimmer was on the castle terrace, the Moonstone behind her, sweating and staring at all the people staring back at her.

She was in front of everyone in her life; the Princesses, her Father, her Aunt, friends, and her subjects before her, staring. Staring beside her was Bow and staring at her from behind was Madame Razz. *Staring, staring, staring*. Everyone in her life, that was... everyone except Adora and Catra.

"*Where are they*?" Bow said between clenched teeth.

"*I don't know, but I'm going to kill them*." Glimmer replied behind a sweet smile.

Taking the lead from Catra's choice to wear her purple and pink tux, Glimmer and Bow wore outfits of the same colors. Glimmer's long, billowing dress was a light purple with pink gems woven into the embroidery that encompassed the bust and waist. It was strapless and open-backed, the front plunging into a "V". Bow was

wearing a purple tuxedo, almost exactly the same as Catra's, except his was open to expose his midriff, as was his style.

Madame Razz had just yawned loudly when a commotion could be heard in the watching crowd. Adora and Catra were pushing and barging through.

"Excuse me, pardon me, sorry, whoops. Hey! Don't touch the tail!" Catra said as she broke through the crowd, leading Adora. Adora and Catra both saw Glimmer staring at them, and they smiled and waved.

If I still had Madame Razz's staff, I would blast them with Star Fire! Glimmer thought as she smiled sweetly at them.

Adora took her place beside Glimmer and Catra beside Bow. With their Vow Paranymphs finally in place, it was time to start the ceremony.

"Ahem…Madame Razz?" Glimmer prompted the old woman.

"Oh, yes! Dearie me, Madame Razz must conduct the ceremony, right." The old woman said. "We are gathered here today, before the…" Madame Razz turned around to look at the Moonstone. "… before the large glowing rock, oh pretty! We are here today to watch these two beautiful young people take their Vow to each other. Now I, Madame Razz, Keeper of the Starstone, Member of the Council of Corporeality, Protector of the one hundred and eight Cosmic Chambers, and Daughter of Azzr will stand in witness of the Vow. Commence now!" Madame Razz said pompously.

Bow and Glimmer, who up until now were watching Razz with wide eyes and rictus grins, suddenly turned to each other. When their eyes finally met, their eyes softened with love and their grins became genuine and pure. In unison, they spoke their Vow.

"I take you to be my partner for life, my constant friend, and my true love.

I promise above all else to live in truth with you, and to communicate fully and fearlessly.

I give you my hand and my heart, as a sanctuary of warmth and peace.

I pledge my love, devotion and honor as I join my life to yours, forever." they said as one.

"Very good. Now I, Madame Razz, pronounce this Vow true and binding!" Madame Razz lifted her star-topped staff and slammed it down. Bright points of starlight shot up from the top, raining down harmlessly on everyone.

"Now you must kiss!" the old woman commanded.

Glimmer and Bow drew each other in a long and passionate kiss as everyone in attendance exploded in cheers and applause. The newly-joined couple then parted and turned toward the crowd, holding their joined hands aloft to more cheers and applause. It seemed that even the Moonstone approved, for it glowed brighter and more radiantly.

Adora and Catra then hugged their friends. They all had tears in their eyes, even Catra, who patted Bow on the back.

"Congratulations, Punchy, how does it feel to be King now?" she said to him.

Bow looked stunned. "What? King? Me?" he stammered.

"Yeah, dummy! You just took a Vow with a Queen, that makes you King, duh." Catra said, rolling her eyes.

Bow's eyes went wide. "I'm a King." He whispered, then in various pompous and commanding voices; "I'M A KING! Kiiiing Bow! Bow *the* King!"

Glimmer rubbed him on the shoulder. "Take it easy, my love." She then whispered to Catra. "*I was going to tell him later!*"

Catra just smiled and shrugged.

* * *

Later in the day, the Vow ceremony members all gathered for image taking and the flower throwing ceremony in the reception hall. The Best Friend's squad formed up together; Glimmer and Bow stood in the middle, both holding a huge bouquet of flowers. On either side stood Adora and Catra, with Madame Razz in the front, holding her staff and looking bewildered.

"Okay, everyone please hold still." The image technician asked. "Uh, hey you, can you stop sticking your tongue out?"

Glimmered elbowed Catra, who drew her tongue back in and smiled, showing all her teeth.

"Um... okay, I guess." the technician said with a sigh, capturing the image.

The technician walked away shaking his head while the group got ready for the flower throwing ceremony. The plan was that Bow and Glimmer would simultaneously throw their flowers into the waiting crowd, and whoever caught the bouquet would be the next to take the Vow.

A huge crowd gathered in front of them, eager to be the ones to catch this bouquet. Glimmer and Bow pushed their Vow Paranymphs in the crowd to join the others; everyone was laughing except for Catra, who looked grumpy.

"Okay, is everyone ready!?" shouted a smiling Glimmer.

"Yes!" was the screamed reply.

"One, two, three!" said Bow and Glimmer, throwing the bouquet on three.

The flowers flew through the air, then seemed to hover momentarily, and change direction. They were now moving

toward a single person in the crowd, one who looked horrified at its approach.

"Eeeek!" cried Catra as she turned to run.

"Oh no, you don't." a gleeful Glimmer murmured, holding her hand out to direct the flowers.

Catra got a few paces away before the huge bouquet smacked her on the back of the head, knocking her flat on her stomach. The bouquet had completely come apart on impact and she lay there growling, covered in flowers.

Glimmer stood over Catra with her hands on her hips, laughing. "Wow, Catra, you *really* wanted to catch that, didn't you? You practically leaped into it!"

Adora came over to help Catra out of the mess, "I don't know, Glimmer... I once tried to put a flower in Catra's hair and she said she was going to eat it. Maybe seeing all those flowers flying in the air made her hungry!" She giggled.

Catra stood up, wiping herself off. "Har, har, I totally know that was you Sparkles. You know that doesn't count, right? I didn't really catch it." Catra said, pulling a flower out of her hair and flicking it toward Glimmer.

"Oh, I don't know, Catra... no one said anything about having to catch the bouquet, I think the old saying is 'whomever receives the bouquet shalt be next to proclaim the Vow'," Adora said with a warm smile on her face as she looked at Catra.

Catra looked back at her then quickly looked away. She had that same strange, embarrassed smile on her face as she did on Omiros. Adora walked up to Catra and hugged her tight. Catra returned the hug, laying her head on Adora's shoulder.

"Oh, boy, here comes the cake!" Bow exclaimed as five caterers brought the huge cake out. Serving all the guests that were expected to attend the Vow ceremony was going to overtax the

Bright Moon kitchens, so Castaspella decided to employ the services of a caterer. Bids were sent out, and the winner of the bid was none other than Double Trouble's Enchanted Grotto.

The caterers placed the cake down and walked away quickly; Glimmer watched them go suspiciously.

Why are they in such a rush to leave? she thought to herself.

Bow and Glimmer approached the cake. As the ones taking the Vow, they were supposed to cut pieces and then hand feed each other. It was kind of a ridiculous ceremony, but it was fun.

As they were about to cut into the cake, the top exploded, showering both Glimmer and Bow in frosting. They both stood there shocked, gaping up at a figure that appeared where the top of the cake had been. Standing in a jaunty pose with their arms raised in a "V" was Double Trouble.

They were wearing a skin-tight dress of pink marquisette fabric covered in shimmering rhinestones. Double Trouble's blond hair was now wavy, chin-length and parted down the left side. Double Trouble put their hands down, gazing sultrily at Glimmer and raised a microphone to their lips.

"Happy Birthday to you, Happy Birthday to you, Happy Birthday, Queen Glimmer, Happy Birthday to youuuuu!" They sang in the most seductive voice anyone had heard; it was totally and completely inappropriate for the occasion. Everyone was staring at Double Trouble in horror.

"IT'S A VOW CEREMONY, NOT MY BIRTHDAY!!!" Glimmer screeched, her fists clenched at her sides.

Double Trouble looked confused and raised a limp hand to their chest. "Whaaat?? I put all that work into that performance for NOTHING!?" They leaped down, changing back to their normal green and black outfit and long blond hair with closely shaved sides, and performed an extravagant bow. They then squeezed

between Bow and Glimmer, wrapping two long green limbs around the two.

“Oh boy, you two precious little lambs took the Vow? My goodness, so brave, I can’t even hold a relationship for a week let alone Vow myself away to someone.” They cooed.

“That’s a big surprise!” said Catra, grinning at the green elfin scamp. She had long ago forgiven Double Trouble for their betrayal, seeing it as the important lesson that it was. It was the lesson that began her on her long road back to redemption.

“Oh, Kitten, when are you going to take the Vow? You and Adora were fighting like you were Vow-bonded for all that time before you finally admitted what we all knew already. Just take the plunge!” Double Trouble said, looking at Catra with a toothy grin.

Catra looked between Double Trouble and her friends, eyes wide and ears down. “What’s with all you guys? Is everyone ganging up on me today with this Vow stuff?”

Adora sidled up to Catra and wrapped her arm around her. “Yeah, you guys, leave her alone!” Adora said.

Catra looked at Adora with hooded eyes and shook her head.

“You know I’m not paying full price for this, Double Trouble; the cake was a disaster!” Glimmer said angrily.

“Oh, stop it, that performance alone was worth ten cakes, honey. I can’t be blamed for your Aunt’s mix-ups,” Double Trouble said, suddenly becoming distracted by something in the distance. “Anyway, I have important matters to attend to. The bill will be in the mail, sweetie!”

Adora watched as Double Trouble sauntered through the crowd, zeroing in on Shen who was talking to Netossa and Spinnerella. The lithe troublemaker put a green arm around Shen and whispered in his ear. Shen jumped in surprise and turned around, grinning.

What is going on with those two? I need to have a talk with Shen about his "friend" Adora thought.

Glimmer and Bow began to cut some slices out of their disaster of a cake, handing out messy slices to everyone.

"Who wants cake!?" Glimmer yelled.

The majority of the party guests looked at the cake slices and turned around, uninterested.

* * *

During the evening Vow reception, a lively band was playing and all the guests were dancing. The music was a mix of electronica, guitar, wind instruments and vocals.

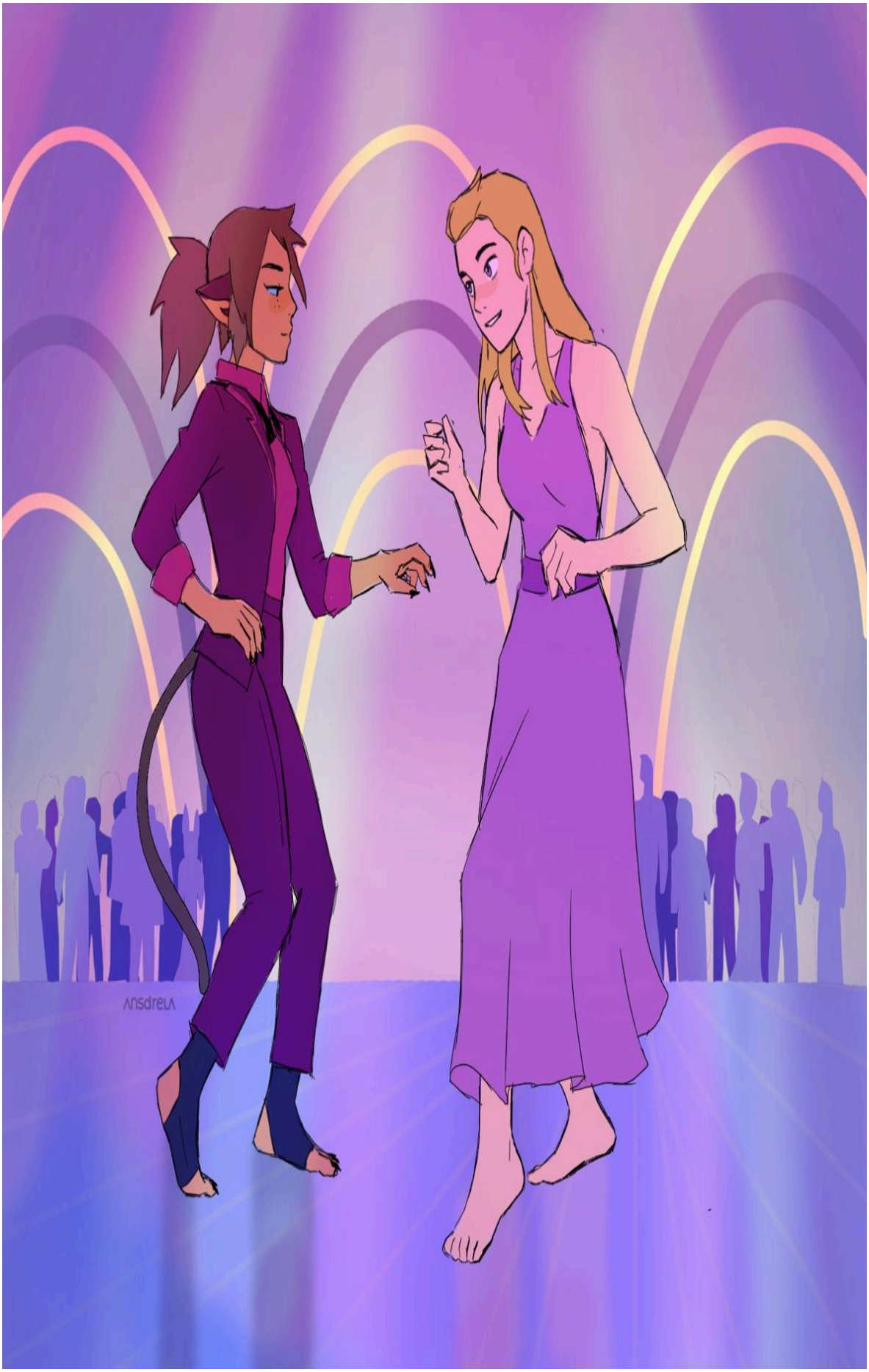
The band was currently playing a boogie, and everyone was moving to the rhythm. Scorpia jumped up on stage and was belting out a sultry number she planned on using at her ball.

Catra and Adora were facing each other, dancing in different styles, huge grins on their faces.

Catra was pivoting on the balls of her feet, hands held out limp before her, rear end wiggling back and forth, tail swishing to the rhythm. Adora was bouncing on her tiptoes, alternating placing one before the other while holding her hands by her sides, snapping her fingers.

They parted, getting distance, then came back toward each other while moving their arms up and down toward each other, like waves. Catra held her nose and gyrated down toward the floor with her other arm held above her, like she was plunging into water. Adora continued grooving, motioning sideways past her face with her fingers held in a sideways "V".

* IF YOU HAVE FIGURED OUT WHAT SCENE THIS IS, I'M SURE THIS SONG WILL GIVE IT AWAY *


ANSDREA

The music then transitioned into something slower and more romantic and everyone partnered up to slow dance.

Off to the side was Entrapta, dressed in a purple evening gown, her hair ponytails folded together elaborately over her head. She was dancing with a robot representation of Hordak which was dressed in a dark blue, long-tailed tuxedo. The robot was being controlled by the man himself back in the Crypto Castle.

Huntara was dressed in blue canvas pants, pointed shin-high leather boots, a gray formal jacket with a white collared shirt underneath, and a bolo tie. She was leading a light-teal skinned woman, who was dressed in blue canvas pants, pointed leather boots, and a crimson button-down shirt, the shoulders embroidered with the thorny pumpkin-shaped plants the Crimson Waste was known for.

The evening continued, the music shifting between styles and keeping everyone on their toes. At one point, Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle jumped up and hijacked the stage. They were all wearing the same outfits of thick hooded baggy shirts and baggy pants. Rogelio started supplying a tight baseline with grunts and growls while Kyle delivered poetry-based vocals in musical form.

"My name is Kyle and I'm here to say, I like droppin' beats in a major way…" He began.

While this went on, Lonnie began to breakdance, performing a series of backspins and handstands. The whole thing was very unique, and the Etherians were unsure what to make of it.

This was then interrupted by a loud commotion in the back. Everyone turned to see Sea Hawk standing on a table, knocking over glasses while trying to keep on his feet.

"Greetings, everyone! I, the famous Sea Hawk would like to propose a toast!" he began, raising his class.

Mermista stood below him, fists clenched at her sides and gazing up at him with fury. “Sea Hawk! GET DOWN! *You're embarrassing me*!” she hissed.

He ignored her and continued. “To the happy couple. May the seas be calm during your life journey together! To Glimmer and Bow!” he said jovially.

Everyone looked at each other, unsure what to do since most of them were dancing and didn’t have a glass to raise. Some scrambled to find a cup while others raised their hands like they were holding one.

“To Glimmer and Bow!” everyone shouted back.

Sea Hawk finished his drink and dropped it casually before him before he began a shanty. *“Ohhh…I’ve been roaming all my days and now I’ve found myself in a vow malaise...”*

“SEA HAWK!” Mermista shrieked, yanking his legs out. As he slammed down onto the table, the lights came on and Castaspella walked on stage.

“On that note, everyone please gather back on the terrace for the sending off!” she exclaimed happily, clapping her hands together.

Everyone moved back out on the terrace. Bow and Glimmer stood in the center, holding each other’s hands and gazing into each other’s eyes.

They were off to spend the next week on a little-known island called Mystic Isle, somewhere in the Sea of Sighs. A cozy cottage was set up for them, and some of the Bright Moon kitchen staff had been sent ahead to be on standby for anything the couple needed. Other than that, Bow and Glimmer would be completely alone together, undisturbed by any outside influences.

Everyone cheered or yelled out their farewells.

“Bye guys, I love you!” Adora yelled.

“Bye Sparkles, bye Punchy, we’ll miss you!” Catra called, waving goodbye.

Glimmer and Bow turned to everyone, holding hands and waving goodbye, then they teleported away.

Chapter End Notes

Illustration of Catra and Adora by @Ansdrela.

Class Clowns

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It was mid-morning as Catra walked across the Bright Moon castle grounds, heading to one of its many gardens for her sparring lessons. She was wearing a black waist-length robe and baggy black pants; a black cloth belt held the robe closed. Around her forehead was a wide black headband with an emblem of a black hand, its clawed fingers curled as if to tear someone to pieces.

She was not on her way to meet Bow though; he was halfway through his week away with Glimmer on the Mystic Isle. She had new students— or victims, depending on how you saw it. Her old friends and Horde comrades Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio had answered her flyer asking for students to learn her fighting style she named Catra Kai. Under her tutelage, the flyer had stated: "I'm not just going to teach you how to awaken the CAT within you, but you'll build strength, learn discipline and when the time is right, you'll STRIKE!"

Besides her three additional new students, there was one more, someone that she was basically forced to take on and 'evaluate'. She thought back to her conversation with Adora from the night before.

"Catra, can you please do this for me? I need your help. I need to know what his capabilities are, and whether or not we can depend

on him in a fight. You're the best hand-to-hand fighter we have." Adora pleaded, trying the flattery tactic.

"Yeah right, Adora. We both went through the same training—you're a great fighter too. You can evaluate him yourself, you don't need me; this is some attempt to make me work with him so we can ***bond****." Catra emphasized the last word.*

"Okay, yeah, maybe I am, Catra. I would be nice if you were able to be at least civil with him, especially if he's going to be working with us. You know, Catra... I love you so much and makes me so happy to see the way you've also bonded with Glimmer and Bow over the past year. You've really grown and come out of your shell. Maybe it's time to grow a little more, you know? You've worked past so many of your issues, maybe you're at the point where you could help someone with theirs? And maybe, by doing so, you can help yourself as well?" Adora said, trying to cajole her into submission.

"Blah!" Catra responded while sticking her tongue out.

"Pleaaaase, Catra?" Adora begged, holding her hands together and making doe eyes.

Catra hissed in irritation. "Okay, fine, I will 'evaluate' him, but I can't promise I won't rough him up a bit... or a lot. You can forget about that other stuff, though. There's no way." She said, annoyed.

"Okay, okay, I'll take what I can get. Promise me though, no claws." Adora said the last part a little sternly.

"Like I told him before, I don't need my claws to beat him," she smirked nastily.

She had the same nasty grin on her face as she approached the place the mat was set up in. She had chosen to set up in the garden; being stuck on a spaceship for the past two months had made her crave the outdoors.

Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio were standing together, laughing and joking around while Shen sat cross-legged nearby with his eyes closed. As she had instructed them, they were all wearing the white version of the outfit she now wore.

"The students will now form up," Catra said to them. The old hands stood in formation, Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio formed in a line, Shen following suit in imitation.

"Hey, Catra, when do we get to wear the black pajamas?" Kyle queried.

"Quiet! The student only speaks when spoken to, is that understood?" Catra snapped.

"Uh, okay, Catra." Kyle squeaked.

"Also, you will always address me as 'Sensei' or 'Sensei Catra', is that understood?" Catra asked sternly.

"Yes Cat…I mean, Sensei." Kyle stammered.

Catra nodded and proceeded to walk past them, inspecting her students. Seemingly satisfied, she nodded to herself and then stood ramrod straight before them, her hands clenched in fists at her side.

"I'm going to teach you the style of fighting that I basically taught myself. I call it Catra Kai. Catra Kai is a method of fighting you soft Etherians desperately need. Catra Kai is not just about fighting, it's a way of life." Catra said.

"Didn't Sergeant Cobalt say the same thing during our training? 'The Horde is a way of life'?" Kyle interjected.

"QUIET!" Catra screeched. "Kyle, give me fifty push-ups on your knuckles!" she commanded.

"Oh, man…" Kyle whined as he did as he was told. "One, two, three, uhhh…four, ow! This really hurts!" he complained, sitting

and rubbing his knuckles.

Shen kneeled by Kyle. “Try alternating putting pressure on one fist over the other. It will relieve the pain a bit and allow you to keep performing the exercise. Catra is only trying to toughen up your hands for the fighting exercises we will learn.” he stated.

Kyle smiled at Shen and tried it again. “One, two, three, four, five... hey it’s working! Six, seven, eight, owwww…”

“Keep trying, you will get it.” Shen smiled at the struggling Kyle.

Catra walked up to Shen and glared at him. “I don’t remember anyone calling you Sensei, you’re not the teacher here, I am,” she said to him coldly.

“Sorry, Sensei Catra,” Shen replied mildly.

Catra pursed her lips. “I think we should just jump right into this. Let’s move into some combat. I pretty much know what Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio can do, but not you, buddy. Everyone except Shen, off the mat!” Catra commanded.

Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio walked off the mat and watched as Catra and Shen walked to the middle and stopped, facing each other. Shen stood loosely, hands at his sides while Catra stood with her arms crossed, hips cocked, tail twitching. She had her usual cocky grin on her face while she studied him.

“I want you to come at me. Use everything you’ve got and try to hit me in the face,” she said to him, smoothly.

Shen shrugged, then moved into action. Catra saw his foot rising for what it was, a lame attempt at a feint. She also saw what she knew was his dominant arm pull back for a swing; this turned out to be another feint intended to conceal his non-dominant hand lashing out at her face.

She just barely broke her arms apart to raise them in a deflection and pull her head back, but still received a grazing blow to her

chin for her troubles.

“Yeow!” she yelped, turning around and rubbing at her bruised jaw. He was actually fast, and he hit her hard. She turned around and eyed him with just a hint of respect.

“I’m sorry, I really thought you would block that,” he said earnestly.

“Yeah, I was expecting to fight the guy who showed up in my room in the middle of the night to kill my girlfriend. The guy who I could have beat blindfolded. You got lucky.” Catra replied coldly.

Shen looked down in shame at the mention of their first meeting and Catra felt a slight hint of remorse, but it didn’t last long.

“Like I said before, my heart wasn’t in that. I truly never really wanted to kill Adora.” Shen whispered sadly.

Catra looked at him with hooded eyes. “So, what you’re saying is your heart is in this? I bet it is... I’m sure you would like to get your revenge on me for that knock on the head.” she accused.

Shen shook his head again. “No, Catra. I don’t want to try and hurt you, and I’m pretty sure I can’t. All I want to do is prove myself to you, prove my worth.”

Catra was taken aback by this admission and unsure how to respond. Thankfully, Lonnie stepped in for her.

“Hey buddy, it’s okay. You don’t have to prove your worth to anyone. Everyone here spent years trying to prove themselves to the Horde, and it got us nowhere. We had to learn the hard way that self-worth comes from within ourselves, not from the outside.” she said, holding her hand over her heart.

Shen looked down at the ground at this statement, a strange far-off look in his eyes. Catra was similarly struck by Lonnie’s words; they hit very close to home, and she could feel her bluster start to fade away.

"Okay, okay, enough of that, this is Catra Kai, not 'feel-good sessions' with Perfuma, which, by the way, I already have to attend later today," Catra said, trying to put some bite behind her words.

She looked at her old friends and could feel the bite leaving her words. They were each looking back at her; Lonnie with that grin that seemed to read your mind, Rogelio with a steadfast look that told you he could always be counted on Then there was Kyle, staring back at her with his hopeful, puppy dog eyes. He was always so sensitive and soft, looking to her for support as his leader, which she never gave while in the Horde.

So much for awakening your inner cat, She thought to herself as she let out a long sigh.

"Okay, why don't I just go through some moves and you all imitate them as best as you can?" She said, dropping her formal tone. Everyone nodded and grinned back at her.

She went through some basic moves, trying to go as slow as possible and explain the intent behind each one. It was hard to know where to begin when this was second nature for her, but she tried her best.

As usual, Kyle was having a hard time with it because he was so clumsy, and Catra had to step in. She stood behind him and gently moved his arms and torso, placing him in the beginning stances, then helped him slowly execute the moves.

After a while, he got it and she stood back, watching him perform the sequences that she had just taught him. A strange sensation started to well up inside her. It was a warm sensation, one that she never felt while in the Horde; it was pride. Through patience, she had just taught someone something that they would have never known without guidance, and they were stronger for it.

She watched Kyle perform the moves with confidence now, he was grinning at Lonnie and Rogelio and Catra caught herself

grinning as well. She tried to stifle it when she saw Lonnie looking at her with a knowing smile on her face, but ended up smirking, sheepishly.

"Okay, why don't we split up into groups of two and try out what we've just learned on each other? Remember, this is just practice. We're not trying to kill each other." Catra said, standing back and crossing her arms.

Rogelio and Lonnie paired up while Shen and Kyle did the same. She watched Kyle perform the moves he had just learned on Shen; Kyle launched into attacks while Shen clumsily tried to block them, a few landing on their target. Catra saw Shen's blocks for what they were- half-hearted attempts. He was letting the slight, blond-haired youth land blows on him, yet he seemed completely unaffected.

It is *Kyle, after all, it's probably like butterfly wings brushing your face.* Catra thought to herself.

Shen then went on the offensive, Kyle blocking all the strikes which were just as halfhearted as the blocks, but Kyle didn't notice.

"Okay, that's enough," Catra commanded.

Kyle walked up to Shen with concern on his face. "I'm sorry about hitting you... are you okay?" he asked.

"Oh, I think I'll be okay. Those were some pretty solid blows, Kyle." Shen rubbed at his chin.

Kyle beamed as Catra scrutinized Shen. She was supposed to be evaluating him and so far she'd just seen him land a lucky blow on her and humor Kyle. She needed to bring things up a notch if she was going to have anything meaningful to tell Adora.

"Okay, Lonnie and Rogelio, I want you to team up and attack Shen. I want you to forget what I just showed you. Use all the

hand-to-hand combat techniques we learned in the Horde. I don't want anyone to hold back." She instructed them.

"Catra, really? Come on, I don't know what your problem with this guy is, but I didn't sign up for your lessons just to team up and beat people up. I had enough of that in the Horde." Lonnie complained. Rogelio added his own reservations in his growling language.

Catra held up her hands. "Just humor me, please? I have a feeling he can handle it. Do you have anything against this, Shen? Speak up."

Shen just shrugged. "Let's do it," he stated.

"Yeah, he just said he wanted to 'prove himself' to you, Catra. Okay buddy, get ready." Lonnie warned.

Kyle stood next to Catra off the mat and watched as Lonnie and Rogelio assumed fighting stances, circling in opposite directions around Shen, who crouched down slightly, arms lose at his sides. As soon as Rogelio was behind him and Lonnie was in front, they both attacked simultaneously. Lonnie came running in low while Rogelio came in high, using their natural stature to their advantage to overwhelm their opponent from every direction.

Just as Lonnie was about to sweep Shen's legs, he deftly sidestepped her and shoved her toward the charging Rogelio. She dove forward and rolled while Rogelio leaped over her with a roar, diving toward Shen with his reptilian claws outstretched.

Shen reached out and grabbed Rogelio's wrists, moving backwards with the momentum until he was on his back, then pushing up with his legs, Shen directed the larger opponent away from him while doing a backwards roll. Catra and Kyle barely leaped out of the way as Rogelio crashed between them with a moan.

By then, Lonnie had regained her feet and was rushing back at Shen who had just finished his backwards roll and stood up. She

delivered a series of low kicks and high punches, all deflected or blocked by her opponent. She spun and tried to do a roundhouse kick, but Shen seized her leg between his hands, holding her foot below his chin. Then, stepping in and placing his foot behind her standing leg, he swept her down on her back, pinning her there with his knee. He raised his fist over her face and held it there. All of this happened within mere moments.

"Do you yield?" he asked.

Lonnie gave him a lopsided grin. "Yeah, I guess," she replied.

Shen held his hand out to her which Lonnie took gratefully, and he raised her to her feet. Rogelio joined them and growled something to Lonnie.

"Yeah, he's not bad, Rogelio. Why don't we see what happens when he faces our 'Sensei' again? What do you say, Catra?" Lonnie asked.

Catra strode up. "Okay, everyone off the mat except for Shen." She said. "You ready? I'm not going to stand still this time. I'm going to come at you with everything I have." Catra told Shen.

"I guess it's only fair, especially after the knock on your chin I gave you," Shen replied mildly.

Catra squinted at him, trying to determine if he was taunting her, but saw no malice in his eyes, only good humor.

Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio walked off the mat, as Shen and Catra walked to the opposite ends and then faced each other. Catra was not standing with her arms crossed this time, she was crouched and tense, ready for action. Shen was in his usual position.

"Lonnie, since this was your suggestion, why don't you do the honors? Say when." Catra asked.

"Okay on three. One, two, THREE!" yelled Lonnie.

Catra was the first to spring forward, running on all fours, intensity written on her face. Shen had just stepped forward from his side, throwing his arm forward in a reactionary strike when Catra leaped. She reached forward and grabbed his outstretched arm, pulling her lower half-forward and wrapping her legs loosely around his waist. Using her momentum, she spun around his torso, and once she was directly behind him, she leaned back into a handstand and flipped Shen backwards off his feet. As he flew away from her, Catra managed to pivot in midair, landing and facing his falling body in a crouch.

Shen landed flat on his back with a groan and lay there, stunned. Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio ran over to him, kneeling by his supine form.

"You okay?" asked Lonnie.

"That was amazing!" Kyle exclaimed.

Rogelio said something in a series of high and low pitched growls.

Shen was coming around now. "I'm so glad I could provide such great entertainment," Shen stated sarcastically.

Catra strode over and stood over Shen, and with an impassive face, reached down and held out her hand. Shen took her hand as she lifted him to his feet in one swift motion. Catra patted the dust and dirt off of his upper body and slapped him on the arm.

"Not bad today! You need some work, but I'm up for it if you are," she said nonchalantly.

Shen nodded slowly, still dazed. "Yeah, definitely, but how about we take a break for today? I think I might be bleeding inside somewhere."

Catra shrugged. "Yeah sure. Class dismissed. I'll catch you guys next time." Catra said, waving as she walked away. As she strode away, she heard Lonnie call out to Shen.

"Hey, Shen, help us put this mat away and I'll buy you lunch, what do you say?" Lonnie asked.

"Deal!" he replied.

Catra turned and watched Shen walk over to the mat with his new friends, helping to fold it up. Catra realized the warm feeling had returned once again and she was smiling. She pulled off her Catra Kai headband and tossed it in the nearby bushes.

* * *

It was later in the day as Catra was heading to her next appointment, her dreaded "sessions" with Perfuma. Once a week, Perfuma would come to Bright Moon and host "group therapy" meetings in one of the few empty rooms in one of the towers. These sessions were meant to help people with trauma, and according to others who attended her sessions, they were very helpful.

It had been two months since her last meeting and Catra felt she should show up, not just because she would face Adora's nagging if she didn't, but because deep down inside, Catra knew they were helping her.

Why do they have to be so painful though? Catra thought, as she practically dragged her clawed feet down the hallway to the open room. Next to the open door was a hand-painted sign which stated the following in flowery script:

I choose peace

I choose love

I choose respect

I choose acceptance

I choose warmth

I choose freedom

I choose light

Catra always frowned when she saw this sign, and always caught herself whining a little.

"Blah!" was Catra's idea of a statement of intent.

"I hear Catra out there!" a bright voice called from within, and Perfuma glided out to greet her grumpy friend. "Greetings, Catra, I look upon you with a glad heart!"

This was the formal greeting that everyone was expected to use when meeting each other during these sessions.

"Greetings, Perfuma, I look upon you with a glad heart," Catra responded flatly, ears down and frumpy looking.

As Perfuma led her in, Catra saw more signs placed around the room, and eyed one she didn't recognize.

"*I will not let anyone walk through my mind with their dirty feet.*" Catra read aloud. "Hey, that one's not bad Perfuma."

Perfuma beamed at her. "Yes, spoken by my favorite venerable. I am *overjoyed* that you appreciate it, Catra."

Catra rolled her eyes. "Let's just take it easy. We're just starting today's session and I only have so much energy."

Perfuma laughed and guided Catra to her seat, it was one of ten placed in a circle, all facing each other. Sessions always started with the "sharing" segment; someone shared their personal story, or something that had happened to them recently that stirred up feelings of hurt or pain. Perfuma would usually coax or guide them through it when necessary, while others shared their support as well. Catra nicknamed this part "torture time", but never spoke this aloud. This talk therapy was usually followed up by little

workshops, each different and unique; Catra nicknamed these "mini-tortures".

Catra sat and looked around, seeing familiar faces smiling at her. She tried her best to give them one in return, but it usually looked like a grimace. She saw one new face, one she was starting to see a lot of.

Shen is here? Man, I can't get rid of this guy today. Catra thought with an inward groan. He nodded to her as she nodded back; he also had an uncomfortable and pained look on his face.

Perfuma stood in the middle with her hands clasped, beaming at everyone in turn. "I am so happy to be here today, to see all your smiling faces looking back at me and to help guide you through your struggles. I am especially happy to see two faces which have been long absent- everyone, welcome back Catra and Shen!" She said, clapping happily.

Everyone clapped while Shen and Catra waved back sheepishly, both looking like they wanted to melt into their chairs.

"So, let's begin our sharing, since we have not seen them in so long, I think it's only fair that Catra or Shen be the ones to share today. Hmmm…which one though…" Perfuma said, one finger to her lips, her other hand on hip.

She pivoted back and forth between the two, humming to herself while trying to make up her mind.

Please don't pick me, please don't pick me, please don't pick me, please don't pick me… Catra chanted inwardly.

Perfuma stopped pivoting and stared at Catra, seeming like she had made a decision. Catra's eyes were wide in terror, her ears pointed down.

"Let's hear froommmm…" She started, raising her hand to point, then suddenly turned to Shen, pointing at him. "Shen!" she said brightly.

Catra almost leaped out of her seat in joy while Shen seemed to deflate, moaning.

I feel your pain buddy, but better you than me. Catra thought.

Perfuma glided over and behind him, placing her hands on his shoulders in support.

"Come, come now, I almost got it out of you last time, and no jokes today!" Perfuma scolded. "Just tell the group the moment or moments in your life you felt were the most hurtful or disappointing to you. Don't hold back, you are in the presence of others who are also dealing with their own trauma. No one judges anyone here."

Shen looked at her dubiously. "Everything?" he asked. "Are you sure we have enough time? How about I do just the highlights?" He laughed while Perfuma looked at him sternly.

"Okay, okay…" he said, placatingly. "I guess I'll start at the beginning…"

Catra listened as Shen told about his early life, being taken from his mother, who he never saw again and being raised by a cold and cruel father.

Big deal, cry me a river. Catra thought to herself. *At least you didn't have Shadow Weaver breathing down your neck all the time, being told you will never be good enough. Oh, and I'm sure you never had to endure being tortured with magic and being threatened with "disposal*".

Shen then went into how he was expected to fit a certain mold, how he was told life was supposed to be cruel and that love was not real. That he was supposed to take the darkness that surrounded him on a daily basis and place it in his heart, so that by doing so, he would become the man he was supposed to be. Shen told the group that he rebelled against this notion down to the very fiber of his being, and that when the opportunity presented itself, he joined the rebellion against his father's rule.

Oh boy, we have another goodie two shoes, no wonder Adora likes him. Yeah, yeah, sorry, but not all of us are born with a perfect moral compass like you. Catra thought glumly, emitting an audible "Humph!"

Shen stopped talking and everyone looked at Catra. "Now, Catra, you know the rules, please wait until Shen is done speaking before making your comments." Perfuma scolded. "Shen, please continue."

"I mean maybe I should just stop here, especially if people are getting bored listening to me. I know I'm bored listening to myself," he said, grinning.

"Nope, no way mister, we got this far with you last time and I feel we are just getting to something important. Please, go on." Perfuma coaxed.

Shen's smile suddenly disappeared and he had an empty look in his eyes.

Well, don't keep us waiting, let's get this over with. Catra thought impatiently.

Shen continued his tale, how he met someone in the resistance, someone who showed him that there was another way besides the way of darkness, someone he fell in love with. How he met others as well, good friends, and together they stood against the darkness, and that for once in his life, he knew what happiness felt like.

How that happiness all fell apart when the rebellion was betrayed, and Shen was captured. He was brought before his father, the supreme ruler of his world, the Shen'Aan-war.

Wait, Adora never mentioned that part to me. That guy we fought was Shen's Father? Geez, I guess that has Shadow Weaver beat — that guy was a complete monster. Catra thought to herself.

Shen went on, and as he spoke, Catra's eyes slowly widened more and more, her ears dropping in horror.

Shen described being taken to a dungeon by the horrible Death-Binders, being opened and having his heart replaced by the dreaded Demon-Heart, then awakening to his new existence, being spoken to in his own mind by a demon, a demon he couldn't escape. Having that same demon take over his body and watching through his own eyes as he hunted down and killed his own friends, one by one. Then, finally, having to watch as his own hands ended the life of the one person he cherished and loved more than anything in this existence.

Catra felt like the ground was going to open up beneath her. Listening to Shen's tale had triggered something that she had long struggled with. She suddenly remembered all those times she had tried and almost killed Adora, when the hurt and pain inside her was so intense that the only way to get through it was to imagine a world where Adora didn't exist.

She thought at the time that it was the only answer, not understanding that it would have just made things so much worse. She knew now that there were things worse than the emotional pain of rejection, there was the "freedom" granted to her by Horde Prime, freedom where her personality and soul were crushed under the oppressive heel of mind control.

How would she feel if Adora's blood was on her hands? Where would she be now if she had killed Adora, knowing that there was no going back, having to face the rest of her life with the knowledge that she killed her one and only true love?

Catra's heart started pounding hard and she felt like leaping from her chair and running, running to find Adora. Find Adora and hold her, tell her she loved her, that she was sorry, so sorry, over and over and over…

"Catra?" Perfuma asked, pulling Catra out of her downward spiral.

“Huh?” Catra said, startled. She looked down and saw that she had drawn her legs up, her arms and tail around them, clutching them to her body.

Perfuma was standing behind Shen with her hands still on his shoulders. They were both looking at her in concern. Catra looked back at Shen, incredulous that he had just finished that tale and was now looking at *her* with concern.

She suddenly saw the strength in him, a strength that went beyond just the physical, to push past your own pain just far enough to reach out in compassion to another who is hurting. It was a greater strength than the one she used to toss him on his back, and the respect Catra held for him increased; she also envied him a little.

“Is there something you want to say in response to what Shen shared with the group?” Perfuma asked her kindly.

Catra was speechless but stammered her way through an answer. “Um…I don’t know…I’m sorry that happened to you…” she stuttered lamely.

Shen smiled back at her and shrugged, then looked down, the empty look back in his eyes.

“Okay, does anyone else have anything they would like to say?” Perfuma asked.

No one said anything.

“Then let’s move on to the workshops. I would like to start with something a little lighthearted and easy. Let’s use our creative sides and create art based on the emotions we are feeling at this moment. We are not thinking, but feeling our way through this, so make whatever comes to your mind first!” Perfuma said, the image of pure happiness.

Catra groaned inwardly as she walked over to the table with the various creative media. She grabbed the paper and colored

pencils; drawing was the only art she was "good" at, and she started making a rough sketch of this morning's sparring lesson.

She drew herself as a red stick figure representation with a round head on top, spiky hair and her face smiling, complete with pointed fangs poking out of the lips. She drew all her students around her, smiling and making kicking or chopping motions. She smiled and laughed to herself when she was done.

She looked up to see Shen sitting nearby, a wad of untouched clay before him; he was staring at it with his arms crossed.

Perfuma walked over to him then. "Are you still thinking of something to make Shen? It doesn't have to be anything complicated. Tell me, what is the first thing that is popping into your mind right now?"

He frowned and nodded as if seriously contemplating this. "I guess that would be a knife. I would make a knife so I could stab myself and escape this situation." Shen replied flatly.

Everyone stopped what they were doing and looked at him, horror written on their faces while Catra immediately burst out laughing. Everyone turned to look at her, shocked.

"Oh, come on, he's kidding. It's a joke guys, lighten up," she said to them, then turned to Shen. "You are kidding, right?" She asked hesitantly.

He gave her a little grin and winked at her.

This guy has a horrible and dark sense of humor… right up my alley! Catra thought to herself, grinning back at him.

"Shen!" Perfuma practically screeched at him. "We do not joke about *that* here!"

Shen immediately looked contrite and held up his hands. "Sorry, sorry, everyone. That was really insensitive of me. I am not going to stab myself." As he said the last part, there was a gleam in his

eye, as if he was going to say something else, something funny, but then shook his head and continued. "I'm really trying to work on not using deflection as a coping mechanism. Sorry, Perfuma."

Perfuma stared at him for a moment, then placed both her hands together before her chest and breathed out.

"So, let's try this again. What are you thinking of making?" Perfuma asked sweetly.

"I will let my hands speak for me," Shen said as he started breaking the clay apart into pieces, then rolling them into fat strings of various lengths. He was moving quickly, and they didn't have to wait long. Everyone watched as he put all the pieces together into a larger form, which he kneaded and teased into its final shape. When he was finished, Catra immediately recognized what he made.

It was the wing symbol that had adorned Adora's belt, the symbol for She-Ra.

"Oh, very nice Shen. We all recognize the She-Ra symbol, which is very positive. Why did you choose that?" asked Perfuma.

Shen looked down at his art, staring at it intently. "It's like this. I understand that my life has not been great so far— it's been downright horrible actually— but the one thing I have going for me is my resilience. I keep going, trying to not give up no matter what is thrown at me. It gets hard though, especially when all the people who cared about me are gone…" he said, the empty look returned, and he started clenching his fists. "Recently, I had thought I had come to the end of my path and I was finally ready to give up. But if it wasn't for the belief and strength of one person, I would have given into a fate worse than death."

Shen now turned his head and gazed into Catra's eyes; she stared back, transfixed.

"Adora believed in me; when everyone had given up on me and wanted to just shove me off to another dimension, Adora refused

to give up on me. She helped me. *She helped me save myself*."

Catra saw strong emotions in his eyes, the sincerity and pure intent behind his feelings for Adora, and she realized she was a fool for being jealous of him. She then felt it, a kinship to this person, one of mutually shared pain, the constant struggle to free yourself, and the shared love and admiration for the person in their lives that they strive to emulate... Adora.

Adora, who always seemed to have a single-minded drive to do good and never falter. To always have a helping hand for those in need, no matter who they are. To somehow see past a person's outer shell, to see the goodness inside them and help them pull it out.

Catra saw that Shen was smiling at her, and she returned it; she didn't stop herself, only nodded to him.

"That was amazing, Shen, thank you. See everyone, that is what I am talking about. Shen here has demonstrated perfectly the purpose of this exercise. Everyone, give him a hand." Perfuma exclaimed, clapping furiously.

Everyone, including Catra, clapped for him. Shen looked around and smiled weakly, then looked at Catra and rolled his eyes, causing Catra to laugh.

When the clapping slowed down, Perfuma put her hands together and beamed at them. "Now, let's move on to the next exercise, Traumatic Re-enactment. I want you to group up in pairs for this, and pretend the other person is the one who hurt you. I want you to tell them how what they did made you feel. The other person's job is to apologize, try to make it sound meaningful."

Ugggggghhhh…I hate role-playing. Catra thought inwardly. *I like to leave the acting to Double Trouble.*

She sat there, not moving and saw Shen doing the same. Perfuma zeroed in on him.

“Come, come now, don’t be shy. What situation would you like to work on? Maybe something recent?” Perfuma asked.

Shen looked thoughtful. “Well, not too long ago, Catra here punched me in the face pretty good.” He said mischievously.

Catra grinned at him, her arms crossed and tail twitching. “Uh... you totally deserved it, too!” she said, stifling a laugh.

“That’s perfect then, there will be no acting involved, this will be natural. You two partner up.” Perfuma pronounced, walking away.

Shen and Catra stood across from each other for the third time today, although now they were about to do something more painful than try and punch and kick each other. They were going to work through their feelings.

Shen frowned at her. “So... what do I do?” he asked.

Catra crossed her arms again. “Tell me how me almost knocking your head clean off made you feel.”

Shen nodded as if that was a fantastic idea. “Catra, when you punched me in the face it made me feel really, really bad.” He said with overexaggerated sadness and a big frown on his face.

Catra grinned at this. “Yeah, well, I didn’t exactly appreciate you busting into my room in the middle of the night. Plus, on top of that, *you threw water in my face!*” she finished, laughing.

Shen nodded at this with a small frown. “Yeah, I guess I had more than a blow to the head coming to me.”

Catra looked at him with a grin. “You think?” she said.

“I guess I have one last thing to say to you for that knock on the head, Catra,” Shen said, not joking around now.

Catra looked back at him dubiously and her tail started twitching. “And that is?”

He looked at her, completely serious. “Thank you.”

Catra balked a little, taken aback. “Thank me? Did I do some damage to that brain of yours today?”

Shen shook his head and laughed. “No, I wanted to thank you because if you hadn’t dragged me back through that window and knocked me out, I would have jumped and gone straight back to my father. I would have never stayed here and found freedom from the nightmare my life had become. That was the first of many turning points for me on the road back to redemption. Thank you, Catra. You saved me, you saved my soul.” Shen declared warmly.

Catra smiled and felt that warm feeling again; it was becoming a habit.

“I guess you're welcome. Anytime you want another one, just let me know,” she said slyly.

The two acting partners continued their role-playing, taking turns with made-up situations they came up with on the fly. They were starting to get into it and having fun.

“Catra, all I do all day is stay home with our kid all day, cooking and cleaning. When you come home, I expect a little attention and appreciation!” Shen said, hands on hips.

“Geez, this again? Look, I work hard all day and the last thing I need is to come home to your nagging! Get off my case!” Catra shouted back.

They stared at each other with their mock angry faces for a moment, then burst out laughing, drawing everyone’s attention. Perfuma glided over to see what the fuss was about.

“I see that we are just clowning around now. Maybe pairing the two of you up wasn’t such a good idea.” Perfuma said, her sweet tone just barely masking the annoyance in her tone.

“No, Perfuma, I think we are the perfect match. The first re-enactment we did was so successful we decided to just have fun with the rest.” Shen said in reply. Catra nodded in agreement.

Perfuma put her hands together in front of her face for another sigh. “You two are my most difficult participants, but you are also the two who need my help the most. I wish you would take this more seriously. I am only trying to help.” Perfuma sighed.

“Perfuma, we *are* taking it seriously and I think we both appreciate what you're trying to do, really,” Catra said, trying to placate her friend.

Perfuma looked at Catra, her gaze was piercing. “Catra, you have such a kind and tender heart buried deep within your hard exterior. Your past trauma and issues with abandonment are really hindering you from becoming the person I really believe deep in my heart that you are capable of becoming.”

Catra felt like she was hit by a hammer. She backed away, her ears down, a shocked expression on her face.

Perfuma turned her gaze to Shen now. “Shen, you are such a good person, and your soul shines so brightly. But I worry about you. You try so hard to be there for others, but deep down inside, you're not there for yourself. I feel like you don’t really care or love yourself, Shen, and it makes my heart hurt. I am opening my heart to you, can you please do the same for me? Can you open your heart to me?”

Catra looked at Shen and the reaction she saw there was intense. His whole body was rigid, his eyes were wide and he clenched his hands into fists.

“I’m really… sorry Perfuma… ummmm…” he said, voice strained.

Catra saw that he was on the verge of falling apart and was barely holding himself together. He then turned and moved hurriedly for the door.

“NO! Not again, don’t run away from me!” Perfuma cried, lunging to grab him.

Catra interceded by grabbing Perfuma by the arm, stopping her from chasing after Shen.

“Catra, get your hand off of me!” Perfuma yelled.

Catra let her go and held her hands up. “How about we just give him a break, huh? It looks like you hit a pretty big nerve and you will probably do more harm than good if you push it now.” Catra said, placatingly.

Perfuma suddenly looked into Catra’s eyes; it was as if she was seeing her for the first time and her expression softened. “You’ve changed Catra... I’m not sure if I’ve ever seen you try to help someone who wasn’t Adora. Okay, I will give him a break, *but only if* you go see if he is okay, and also tell him I want to see him tomorrow for a private session.”

Catra groaned inwardly. *Catra and your big stupid mouth…* she thought.

“Fine.” She tersely replied, walking out the door.

Catra looked up and down the hall and started sniffing. She caught his scent and followed. Turning a corner, she saw him at a dead end with an open window, he was turning around when he saw her. He then turned back around, trying to hide his face. Catra walked up behind him and stopped at a distance. She looked at the open window and grinned.

“Hey, I’m not going to have to pull you back through another window, am I?” she joked.

Shen laughed, it was a stifled, choked sound. “No…nothing like that… just need some time alone I think…” he said.

“That was some doozy Perfuma laid on us both, huh? She is good at that, pulling or yanking on those heartstrings.” Catra continued.

“Yeah… Catra, I just need some time…I just don’t want you to see… me like this…” he said, pleading now.

“What, see you cry? It's not a big deal, you should just let it out. I mean, when people look at me, they see ‘Big Bad Catra’, but little do they know that after Adora left the Horde, I cried myself to sleep every night. I’m a big-time crier, it feels good to get it out.” She said with a laugh.

Shen turned to her, looking at Catra sideways, still holding it in but a single tear had sneaked down his face. “Thanks, Catra…it means a lot…I just don’t want you…to think worse of me…especially after that time… in the hall…when I told you…could…” he said, his voice cracking. Shen closed his eyes tight and clenched his teeth, standing rigid.

“Oh, that? Don’t worry about that. I was being a stupid jerk and you made me see I was making a big mistake. As for what you said…well it’s not a competition or anything but I’m no stranger to…that. I mean, when Adora and I were on the opposite sides fighting each other, there were a few times I almost…you know… there was even one time I almost took all of Etheria with me. I mean, at least you weren’t being selfish like me, trying to hurt others while also trying to hurt yourself.” Catra said, saying the last part softly.

Shen breathed in deeply then let it out and looked up at the ceiling. “Okay, thank you Catra. I think I will be alright now.” He said, calmly but not turning around.

“One last thing. Perfuma wanted me to tell you she wants to see you tomorrow for a private session. If you want, I’ll go too, so you don’t have to endure the pain and suffering alone.” Catra said with a small laugh.

“Thank you, I will see you tomorrow.” She turned to her again and smiled.

Catra nodded and walked off down the halls and to the stairwell. As she was about to enter, her keen hearing could hear deep and uncontrolled sobbing back down the hall. Her ear twitched as she walked down the stairs.

* * *

Catra walked into her room, seeing Adora standing and reading a report; she looked up and smiled when she saw Catra striding in.

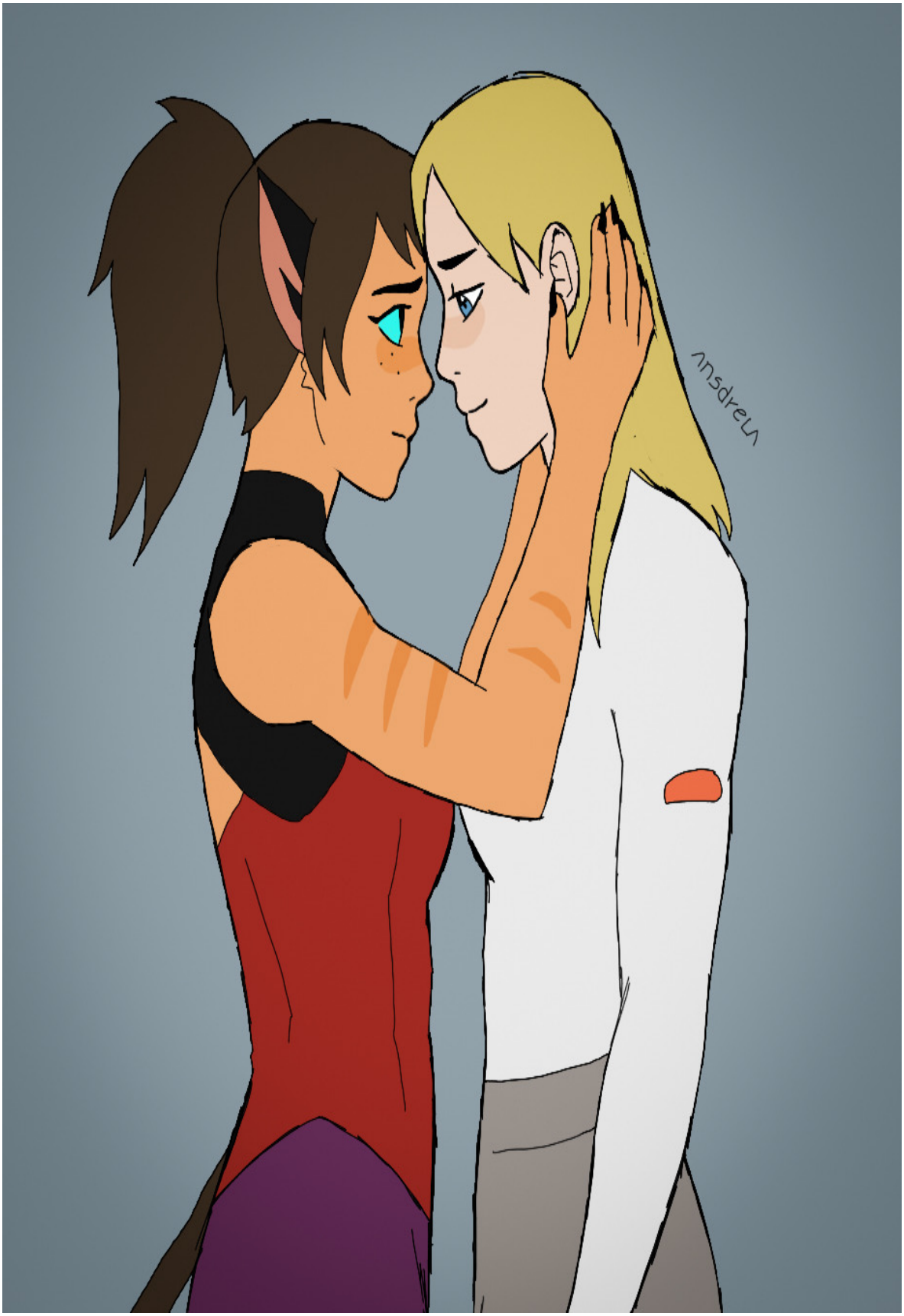
"Hey, Catra, how was your—" Adora began and stopped as she saw the look on Catra's face as she strode toward her.

It was the same look she had seen before, more than a year ago, when she, Glimmer and Bow were on their way to the Heart of Etheria, when she saw the vision of Catra... except this was real this time.

There was complete and total love for Adora on Catra's face, the love that had always been between them all those years.

Catra walked up to her while holding her gaze. She lovingly placed both her hands on either side of Adora's face, pulling her head gently forward into a gentle nuzzle as their foreheads touched. They both closed their eyes and opened them at the same time, gazing at each other.

* UNION *



"I know I might not say this enough, Adora, but I love you so, so much. I would be totally and utterly lost without you, you *know*

that, right? My heart was so broken when you left the Horde, when you left me. All those times we fought each other, I thought the only way to deal with that was to try and remove you from my existence—" Catra said, then let out a gasp of grief as she started to cry.

"Catra, shhhh…" Adora soothed.

"No…let me continue…" she replied, between sobs; she had started to caress Adora's face with the tips of her claws. "I am sooo sorry for that, Adora! You *know* that right? If I had ever actually done it, Adora, I would be so completely and utterly crushed, my soul would be torn apart, just thinking about it now…" Catra pressed her face into Adora's neck, sobbing.

Adora felt like her heart would break from the raw pain in Catra's voice. She walked Catra over to a large soft cushioned chair and pulled her there, holding Catra in her lap while she wept. Catra pulled her head back to gaze at Adora again, her eyes bleary with tears. Adora saw a deep need welling up in those eyes.

"Adora, I love you, you *know* that right? Please tell me that you do…" she cried desperately.

Adora placed both of her hands on either side of Catra's face and locked eyes with her.

"Yes, Catra, yes I do! I know you love me so much, I can feel it every day from the moment I wake up next to you, all throughout the day, to the moment I go to sleep at night, I can even feel it in my dreams, all night long. So basically, there is not a single moment I can escape your love!" Adora said with a laugh.

Catra laughed at this as well, lifting her head back smiling and wiping tears from her eyes.

"Catra, I may not have realized it at the time, but somehow, I always felt your love for me, even during those times we were fighting. I felt your love because I was in love with you as well. Those times when you tried to kill me? It was my love that always

helped me forgive you. I have forgiven you for that, Catra, I forgave you a long time ago, do *you* know that?" Adora said, emphatically.

"*Yes*!" Catra said, drawing Adora into a simple, sweet kiss. They held it for mere heartbeats but the meaning behind it would last a lifetime.

Catra pushed her face into Adora's neck, nuzzling there as she started to purr. Adora laid her head on top of Catra's and continued to hold her, caressing her hair and stroking the brown tuft behind her ears. They stayed like that for a while, holding each other in comfort and love, enjoying the fact that they were with each other at that moment. After a while, Catra let out a huge sigh of contentment and Adora could feel that Catra was at peace.

"So, to continue my earlier question, how was your day, Catra? What happened?" Adora asked, continuing to stroke Catra's hair.

Catra smiled a strange, sad smile. "It was good, mostly... I'm starting to get into teaching and I think I might be good at it. Your guy isn't bad by the way. He needs some work, but he's a better fighter than any of my other students."

Adora looked startled at this admission. "That so, huh? How about your appointment later with Perfuma?"

Catra made a face. "Yeah, that was okay. Your buddy Shen was there, it seemed like I couldn't escape him today. We all heard his story during the sharing torture session, it was pretty rough; how he killed his friends and the person he loved. It really hit me hard and made me start to think…think about us. It's why I was so upset tonight, actually." Catra said quietly.

Adora nodded. "Yeah, I got to see it firsthand, it wasn't pretty. We are very lucky, Catra."

"Yeah, and he and I were grouped together for some other torture sessions. He's not bad, once you get to know him. Turns out he

and I share the same messed up sense of humor and our own sad stories.” Catra said with a chuckle.

“Sounds like you two bonded.” Adora smiled.

Catra lifted her face from Adora’s neck and gave her a look. “*Please!* Anyway, we were kind of goofing around with the role-play nonsense and Perfuma was not happy. She laid her touchy-feely stuff on us both and it really rocked Shen. Like, I’ve never seen anyone fall apart like that. It made me feel…” Catra said, trying to search for words.

“The word you’re probably looking for is sad, Catra. You felt empathy for him.” Adora added.

Catra sighed. “Yeah, I guess so. I wasn’t sure what to do for him though.”

Adora hugged her. “I am proud of you Catra. Even admitting all this stuff is a huge step for you.”

Catra accepted the hug with an annoyed look, but slowly settled back into Adora’s neck with a small smile.

“You know what? I think I have an idea. I think I can help him out while also doing something I’ve been wanting to do for a while now.” Catra said, and Adora could hear the grin in her voice.

“And that would be?” Adora asked, eyebrows raised.

“It's better if you don’t know,” Catra said, mischievously.

Chapter End Notes

Illustration of Catra and Adora by @Ansdrela.

From Out of Nowhere

Shen woke to the sound of his door bursting open and someone striding in. He groaned and looked over to see Catra standing over him.

"Rise and shine, sleepyhead!" Catra cried, grinning down at him.

He looked at the window. The sun was just starting to come up and the first rays of morning light were peeking through the window.

"Catra, what are you doing in my room?" Shen asked, groggily.

"Oh, don't worry about it. I grew up in the Horde and we all shared the same locker room, you don't have anything I haven't seen before. Now get up, we've got a long day ahead of us!" Catra said, beaming.

"Did I miss something? Don't I have that session with Perfuma today? That's all I have scheduled." Shen sat up, confused.

Catra shook her head. "Nope, not anymore. You're coming with me, I've got something fun planned. I already told Perfuma you're not going to be seeing her today."

"Okay... I guess I'm up for anything. What are we doing?" Shen asked.

Catra shook her head again. "Not saying, it's a surprise. Just meet me down in the Bright Moon Motor Pool in half an hour, and don't

be late.” Catra said as she strode back out of his room.

Shen watched her go, groggy and confused.

* * *

Exactly half an hour later, Shen was down in the Motor Pool waiting for Catra. The Motor Pool, like the landing pad, was a new addition to Bright Moon with the addition of all the Horde technology. There, they kept various vehicles; large and small land transports, a few vehicles capable of air travel, and of course, Darla. There were no people this early in the morning and Shen was just wandering around, wondering what he was doing there.

He was tired this morning due to not sleeping very well last night. The impact of the session with Perfuma staying with him all through the night, her words repeating in his head.

I feel like you don’t really care or love yourself, Shen.

Can you open your heart to me?

Two lines spoken so effortlessly, two lines that drove deep into two different weak spots, but both ended up with the same result; pain.

The reason the last line caused him pain was obvious to Shen, it was the line Shen’Dara spoke during their first meeting.

The first though... he was confused about why it hurt him. *Did he love himself?* He knew he had love for Shen’Dara and that he felt love for Adora, Glimmer, Bow and the other friends he made during his time on Etheria, but was there love for himself? *Did it matter, really? Who cares?*

This argument had gone around and around in his head all night, and every time he came to that conclusion, he was left with a deep sadness.

He started feeling the darkness creeping in and began to worry that he was sinking into despair.

Maybe I should just go back to my room, he thought to himself.

Just as he thought this, Catra strode in, wearing what appeared to be a full-length robe and carrying a small bag; she was grinning ear to ear. She motioned for him to come to the back of the Motor Pool, and he followed her over to where a long object sat under a tarp. Grabbing one of the tarp ends, Catra yanked it off with one swift motion, and Shen gazed at what lay underneath.

It was all sharp lines and fins, it appeared to be some form of hover vehicle for it had no wheels, just large thrusters at one end. In front of the thrusters was a seat large enough for two people with two handlebars just ahead of the seat, presumably to control it.

"This," began Catra, "is an old Horde Viper Speeder. It's the fastest thing on Etheria. I smuggled it in here and hid it away from prying eyes. No one knows it's here, not even Adora. She would flip out if she knew I had this, so don't say anything about it!"

Shen shrugged. "So, we are going to ride on this thing?" Shen asked.

Catra nodded. "You bet we are." She said, then took off her robe and threw it to the side. Underneath, Shen saw that she was wearing an outfit he had never seen her wear before. It was a two-toned crimson sleeveless top with purple leggings that had open slashes at the front of her upper legs and knees. On her hips were two belts, one larger than the other, crisscrossed over each other.

She reached into her bag and pulled out a black leather jacket. She quickly put it on, leaving the front unzipped. On the back was an image of a silver serpent, in a circle, eating its own tail.

Catra then leaned over and whipped her claws through her hair, over and over. When she was done, she stood up and Shen saw that her hair had grown into a wild mane over her head.

She then opened a compartment in the speeder and removed what looked like a crescent-shaped, sharp-angled, maroon metal object. She turned her back to him and placed it on her face and as she turned back to him with a flourish, he saw that it was a headpiece like her gold one, except this one gave her a much fiercer aspect.

"Ta-da! How do I look?" she asked, hands on her hips.

Shen thought about it for a moment. "You look like we are headed for trouble." Shen stated, pursing his lips and nodding his head.

Catra's grin became wilder. "That's exactly what I'm going for!"

* * *

* WHEN YOU LEAST EXPECT IT *

They sped along the terrain of the Crimson Waste; two figures perched on top of a speeding vehicle, dust billowing behind them. The vehicle flew off an incline and soared through the air before bouncing back down on anti-gravity thrusters. A few predatory reptiles watched them pass, licking their lips and hoping the passing travelers would end up as an easy meal.

Shen sat behind Catra as she piloted the Viper Speeder. They were both wearing large goggles to protect their eyes against the dust. They had been traveling this way for a couple of hours now, but as soon as they entered the expanse of the Crimson Waste, Catra had opened up a little more of the thrusters. Shen had no idea how far they had traveled, but it seemed like a great distance.

"Hey, you awake back there?" Catra yelled. "I'm going to really let old Wildcat here loose soon, so you better hold on real tight!"

“Wildcat?” Shen asked, confused.

Catra patted the machine beneath them. “A nickname a friend gave me, it’s what I call this beast. Now hang on!” she exclaimed, twisting one of the handlebars and the speeder burst to new heights of speed. The increased thrust made the speeder swerve wildly back and forth for a moment, but Catra expertly regained control.

They were going so breathtakingly fast now that Shen felt giddiness come over him and he started laughing. He could not stop the laughter, for it felt as out of control as the speeder beneath him. It was a high joyful laugh; Catra started laughing with him, her hair flapping behind her and into Shen’s face, tickling his nose. He was acutely aware of the way Catra’s hair smelled; had a pleasant muskiness to it, spicy and seductive, he felt like he wanted to bury his face—

Whoa, thought Shen, stopping himself, *Wait a second, what was that?* He felt confused and a little nervous.

He had a sense of déjà vu, and as he clung to Catra, he suddenly remembered why. He remembered a high-speed ride like this, only on the back of a galloping Sekth. He remembered riding on its back as it ran at top speed, clinging to Shen’Dara the first time they met.

Ah, that’s where that came from... he thought to himself, satisfied. He suddenly chuckled, thinking of Catra’s reaction if he suddenly buried his face in her hair.

“What are you chuckling at back there?” Catra yelled back, suspiciously.

“Oh, nothing. I was just thinking about how a couple of months ago, you would probably have shredded me to pieces before letting me ride on a speeder with you. Now look at us!” he yelled back.

“Yeah, we’re a couple of real bosom buddies now.” Catra let out a bark of laughter as she gunned Wildcat in a tight turn, barely missing an outcropping of rock. Shen felt like he was going to be thrown from his seat, and he gripped Catra tightly as she gained speed and they pulled out of the turn.

Catra was howling with glee. She was a primal force of pure joy and Shen felt it infecting him, pushing back some of the darkness he had felt. He was suddenly very glad that he was there, and at that moment, he could think of nowhere else we would want to be.

Catra then directed them in a straight line, directly toward what looked like a large animal skeleton. It appeared it was being used as a form of shelter, for there were tarps and other additions covering it; it looked like an unappealing destination.

Catra sped toward the shelter at high speed. At the last possible moment, she braked the Wildcat sideways into a stop. The speeder howled in protest at such rough handling and Catra immediately shut the engines off. Shen had to wait a few moments to let his stomach settle before climbing off Wildcat.

“This is our destination? What is this place, a garbage dump?” Shen asked, incredulous.

Catra chuckled. “Yeah, something like that... It's kind of my old stomping grounds. Come on, I’ll buy you a drink.” she said as she sauntered through the piece of cloth that served as a door.

As he followed her in and let his eyes adjust to the dim lighting, he saw that it was some kind of drinking establishment, much like the ones back on Shen’Dar-oom. The patrons simultaneously looked at the newcomers with malice, but upon seeing Catra, they immediately went back to their drinks, fear in their eyes.

“Wow... I see everyone here is an old friend of yours. They seem really super happy to see you.” Shen teased, elbowing Catra.

Catra just gave him a look. “Give me a break, they love me here. I came this close to being the ruler of the Crimson Waste.” Catra said, holding her hand up, her index and thumb close together.

Shen shrugged. “Yeah, I guess I can believe that. This place is definitely your style.”

She slapped his chest playfully and grinned. “Come on, grab a seat.” She said, plopping herself down on the nearest empty stool at the bar. “Barkeep, me and my buddy want some of your best swill!” she said slapping her hands on the stained surface of the bar.

The large, teal-skinned woman behind the bar scowled at Catra but grabbed two clay mugs and filled them from a wooden tankard. She plopped down the two mugs in front of them, foam spilling over the edge. Shen sniffed his mug and was pleasantly surprised by the smell; it was surprisingly floral and earthy.

Catra held her mug out to Shen. “A toast! To our day in the Crimson Waste and to making it through another torture session with Perfuma!”

Shen clinked his mug with Catra’s, then took a sip of his drink. It tasted even better than it smelled; the flavor had a pleasant yet bitter fruitiness to it. It also made Shen think of the huge fir trees that composed much of the mountain forests back home.

“Ahhhh!” Catra sighed audibly as she placed her mug down, looking at the patron nearest to her. Two curved horns sprouted from their forehead beneath a hooded cloak; they appeared to be trying to hide from Catra’s gaze.

“Alice? Is that you?” Catra said brightly. She reached over and gently pulled the hood back from the patron’s head, revealing a female with a lilac-colored face, two long droopy ears on both sides and a tuft of fur on her chin. She had long gray hair with the sides shaved down, and two tufts much like Catra’s, except hers were in front of her ears instead of behind.

Alice grinned nervously back at Carta. “Uh... hey Catra…I mean boss. It's great to see you, how’s it going?” she said. It seemed like she was ready to bolt for the door.

Catra frowned at being called “boss”. “Hey, you don’t have to call me that anymore, just call me Catra. Take it easy! I’m here to just have fun, I’m actually happy to see you,” Catra said, patting the other on the shoulder.

Alice looked like she was going to melt, and she stood up. “Yeah, yeah, Catra it’s great to see you too. I’m sorry, but I just remembered I left something cooking on the stove back home, bye!” she cried over her shoulder as she practically ran out the front door.

Shen was about to make a smart comment about Catra’s way with people when he saw the look of hurt and disappointment on her face, as she watched Alice leave.

“Huh, didn’t know that you could cook grass. I learned something new in the Crimson Waste!” he said sarcastically to Catra.

Catra shook her head at him, an incredulous look on her face. “That’s not very nice, Shen, you don’t even know Alice.”

He shrugged. “She wasn’t very nice to you, so I think it was merited.”

Catra faced forward and let out a deep sigh. “No, it was merited. I deserved it.” She said glumly, removing her headpiece and running her fingers through her hair. She set the headpiece in front of her and gazed down at it, taking a sip from her drink.

“You might have deserved her reaction, but you don’t deserve to beat yourself up over whatever it is that caused it,” Shen stated softly.

Catra gave him another incredulous look. “Stop... I thought we left Perfuma’s torture time behind us yesterday.” she retorted to him, eliciting a laugh. “No, really, you don’t really know me... you

don’t know who I used to be, who I still struggle to this day to not be. If you did, you might run away from me, like she did.” Catra said, sadly.

“I think you're forgetting who you're talking to, Catra. I killed all the people in my life who cared about me. I was the very definition of a monster... and somehow I was saved. I don’t believe that whatever it was you did makes you past redemption.” he said, earnestly.

Catra shook her head. “Not sure what you're *basing* that on. A couple of months ago, I was the person chasing you around, bullying you and yesterday morning, I threw you on your back. You have no idea what you’re talking about. You sure I didn’t give you brain damage?” she said with a small laugh.

Shen shook his head. “You’re also the person who saw I was in pain yesterday and decided to try and cheer me up by bringing me out on this joyride. You even offered to suffer through another one of Perfuma’s torture sessions to keep me company, although… I think we should stop talking about poor Perfuma’s sessions as torture.” Shen said with a laugh. “You’re also the person that Adora fell in love with. I can’t believe that someone like Adora would want to be with someone even remotely bad, so there’s that too. So, I think I *do* know what I’m talking about.” Shen declared.

“Thanks, Shen, I needed that. You know, you’re not bad after all.” Catra grinned at him, head tilted, and eyes squinted.

He grinned. “Thanks, I feel like ‘not bad’ from you is like ‘super wonderful’ from anyone else.” He said, reaching over and picking up her maroon headpiece, holding it out to her. “How about we get back to having fun? Let’s go find some trouble.” Shen smirked.

Catra nodded, taking the proffered headpiece and setting it back in place. She looked back at him gratefully, but something caught her attention behind him, and her face immediately fell.

"Well, I don't know about fun, but trouble has found *us*," she growled.

Shen turned, seeing a group of rough-looking characters had just entered the establishment. At the head of the group was a large, pink-skinned, reptilian being with a mean look to him. He wore a ripped, sleeveless jacket, much like the one Catra now had on; it was open at the front to reveal a heavily muscled, scaly chest. On his waist there appeared to be a coiled whip. His green, slitted eyes were fixated on Catra and he was leering at her, exposing a row of sharp teeth.

"Ugh, you again? I thought I rid the Crimson Waste of you, *Tongue Lasher*." Catra said, mockingly.

He growled at this. "It's Tung Lashor, and it will take more than a little kitty to take me down. There is no quicksand for you to trip me into here," he said, smugly.

Standing off to the back of the group, Shen could see Alice, trying to hide from sight. Catra saw her and shook her head in disappointment.

Shen stood up from the stool and stood next to Catra. "Tongue Lasher, huh? How did you get that name? Are you really good at nagging people or something?"

Tung Lashor sneered at Shen. "No bright boy, I'm really good at peeling the skin off their bones." He glared at Shen, then turned to Catra. "This guy is a friend of yours, little kitty?" He asked.

Catra looked at Shen and back at Tung Lashor. "Yeah, that's right, but I won't need his help with the likes of you," she said, trying to wave Shen away with her hand. She turned to look at him and he shook his head at her, standing his ground. Catra gritted her teeth and glared at him, then turned back to Tung Lashor.

"So what's it going to be, *Tung Lashor*? Do I get a new whip today? You can keep the gang this time though; I don't need that

crummy group of miscreants following me around again!" Catra said, laughing.

Tung Lashor roared and charged, his gang changing with him as the bar exploded into chaos.

Tung Lashor cracked his whip in Catra's direction, who leaped backwards behind the bar and ducked. The wood surface took the brunt of the strike and wood chips splintered into the air.

A green-scaled, smaller version of Tung Lashor lunged at Shen and received a mug to the face; it smashed to pieces spilling the fizzy liquid everywhere. The attacker collapsed to the ground as Shen picked up a nearby chair, flinging it at Tung Lashor.

With a quick strike of the whip, the chair exploded midair, but by that point, Catra had jumped onto the bar and leaped at her old nemesis. She sailed through the air and kicked him directly in his scaly snout. Tung Lashor howled, dropping his whip to clutch at his face. Catra leaped behind him and swept his legs out from under him; he fell on his back, still holding his injured face. As Catra was about to deliver the knockout blow, Alice wrapped her arms around Catra, pinning her arms.

"Sorry, 'boss', I can't let you do it!" Alice said, mockingly.

"Really? I told you to drop the whole boss thing." Catra said as she drove her head back into Alice's face.

Alice fell bleating to the ground, clutching her face, and Catra stood over her with her hand open and raised to slash her.

Alice backed away in terror. "Please, no, Catra, I'm sorry!" she pleaded.

Catra hissed in irritation but did not strike. "Just get out of here, Alice, don't ever let me see your face again," she said lowly.

Alice nodded, turned, and ran out the front door.

Three of Tung Lashor's thugs surrounded Shen. Each of them had a different weapon; a knife, a club and a spiked gauntlet. The one with the knife slashed at Shen, who tried to block as best as he could, receiving a slash on his hand. Shen snarled in fury, letting the pain of the cut fuel his aggression, and lunged at the knife-wielder, grabbing the hand holding the knife and smashing his forehead into their face. Shen took the knife from their limp hand as they fell, holding it out toward his other attackers.

"Come on!" he growled; he was furious now and the call of battle was singing in his veins.

The two remaining thugs looked at each other then started to circle around him, the one with the club stood to the left while the one with the gauntlet stood near the wall to the right. They both raised their weapons simultaneously to attack.

"Oh, forget this," muttered Shen as he threw the knife to his right, pinning the thug's gauntleted arm to the wall as the thug screamed. The club wielder lunged at Shen, screaming a war cry. Shen spun low, kicking his leg out and swept his attacker onto their back. Shen grabbed the club and held it over the thug as they cringed. Just as he was about to deliver the blow, a hand grabbed his descending arm, stopping him.

He turned, furious, and found himself gazing into Catra's eyes, who was looking at him intensely.

"Stop." she said, "Enough, let's just get out of here." she implored.

Shen looked and saw Tung Lashor was on his hands and knees, struggling to rise. He nodded to Catra and they ran out the front door.

"After them! Don't let them get away!" screamed Tung Lashor.

As they ran out, they saw there were other vehicles parked nearby; many looked very similar to their Viper, and one was much larger and blockier.

Catra leaped on Wildcat and started the engines. As Shen hopped on behind her, she blasted off, giving the vehicle full throttle.

As they sped across the wastes, they could hear the noise of engines starting up behind them.

"I really hope you were right when you said your speeder was the fastest thing on Etheria," Shen said worriedly to Catra.

"Yeah, me too," Catra replied.

Their hopes were dashed as they heard the sound of engines getting closer. Shen turned around and saw two of the speeders plus the larger vehicle were gaining traction, black smoke billowing behind them.

The larger vehicle was piloted by Tung Lashor himself; he was seated in the middle behind what looked like metal mesh, two huge exhaust ports spat black smoke from either side of him. There was thick metal plating with fat spikes protruding outward on every side of his vehicle. Seated behind Tung Lashor was one of his minions, manning what appeared to be a gun turret with a barbed hook peeking out of the end.

"Uh, Catra, they have some kind of projectile weapon and it looks like a harpoon!" Shen cried.

Catra didn't respond as she tried to coax more power out of Wildcat, only succeeding in almost stalling it. Then, she looked up and groaned as she saw what was ahead of them; they were quickly approaching a cliff edge.

"Hang on tight!" she screamed as she pulled Wildcat to the right, blasting it along the edge of the cliff. Tung Lashor saw them turn, which gave him enough time to steer his larger vehicle after them, staying well clear of the cliff edge, while his two cronies on their own speeders shot off at an angle to try and cut them off.

By then, Tung Lashor was in range, and with a malicious grin, he signaled his minion to fire the weapon. The harpoon shot forward

with a bang, flying through the air and snagging Wildcat on the left side, right in front of the thrusters. Tung Lashor laughed and braked his vehicle; the harpoon line became taut and a section of Wildcat tore off, causing it to veer to the left, and as the speeding vehicle careened off the ledge, it exploded into flames.

Tung Lashor stopped his vehicle next to the cliff edge, looking down just in time to see Wildcat crash at the bottom. He laughed cruelly to himself and sped away in victory.

* * *

Shen had his arms around Catra's waist, his head pressed to her stomach while she clutched the side of the cliff edge. They were both dazed, both from being yanked off of Wildcat so abruptly at such high speeds and the force of the explosion. Catra, with her more vigorous constitution, was a little less worse for wear of the two.

"Just hang on, I'm going to get us out of this!" Catra yelled to Shen, feeling his grip on her loosen.

Shen was just barely hanging on; he had taken a blow to the back of the head from a piece of the exploding speeder and could feel blood trickling down there. He could hear Catra scrabbling to find purchase on the rock wall; she was just barely holding on with the weight of him pulling her down. He then made a decision— it was an easy choice for him.

"Catra…we aren't going to make it…I'm not going…to take you with me…" he said, letting go.

"NO!" she screeched, wrapping her legs around him, holding him fast. She looked down at him. "Put your arms back around me! *I told you I'm going to get us out of this*!" she screamed at him.

Shen did as she instructed, hanging back on her as best he could. *He was so dizzy*.

Suddenly, he both felt and heard a low rumble coming from Catra's core; it seemed to well up like a rising beast, rising out of her mouth as a loud roar. With a vicious hiss, she slammed her clawed hands into the rock, and started pulling them up, hand over hand. As she reached the lip, she hung off of it with one arm, and grabbed Shen by the front of the shirt and bodily lifted him up with the other. As he passed her face, he was struck by the intense fury he saw there... and that fury was directed at him.

"Will. You. Grab. The. Ledge?" she hissed at him.

He grabbed the ledge with both hands and hung there as Catra lifted herself up. He was just pulling himself up and over the lip slowly when she reached out and yanked him all the way to safety. Shen lay on his stomach and watched as Catra flopped on her back, growling and panting furiously.

After laying like that for a moment, Catra sat up and folded her legs under her, sitting up straight. She placed her hands on her knees, thumb and forefinger together in an "O" with her fingers spaced apart and closed her eyes.

"Ommmmmmm…" Catra chanted. "Ommmmmmm…"

Shen was mesmerized by what he was watching. He could not figure out what Catra was doing and was starting to get a little worried about her.

Did she take a blow to the head too? he thought to himself. "Hey Catra, are you doing magic?" he asked aloud.

Catra hissed in irritation at the interruption. "No, I'm not doing magic—" she started to respond angrily, but caught herself, let out a sigh, and chuckled. She opened one yellow eye to peer back at Shen. "That was actually pretty funny. I knew there was a reason I saved your life. Please, just give me a moment."

Shen grinned back at her and sat up, Catra closed her eyes and continued her mantra until she finally finished with a gentle sigh.

Catra opened both of her eyes and looked at Shen. “That was something Perfuma taught me to help with anger, which I have *a lot* of. To pull us up that cliff, I had to take myself somewhere that I’ve worked hard to put behind me. I had to find the ‘old Catra’ and let her out for a while. It takes a lot of effort to put her back.”

After Catra said this, she stood up, removed her scarlet headpiece and threw it over the cliff. She watched it spin like a boomerang as she ran her fingers through her hair, the sun glinting off it as it corkscrewed down and out of sight.

“Yeah…. ‘old Catra’ was kind of scary but she did save my life,” Shen said sincerely.

Catra shook her head at him and grinned. “Will you stop?” she chuckled. “You're worse than Perfuma!”

Shen rose and dusted himself off, looking around. “What now?” he asked.

Catra looked around as well. Besides the cliff next to them, there was only Crimson Waste as far as the eye could see.

She shrugged. “Find a ride and get back to Bright Moon,” she said simply.

Shen looked incredulous. “What about *Tung Lashor*?” he said, grimacing comically when saying their nemesis’s name.

“What about him? The last time I saw him, I left him in a pool of quicksand and stole his gang. The way I see it, we’re even now. Today was just supposed to be fun, now I’ve lost Wildcat and almost got us killed. Let’s just go home.” she implored.

Shen frowned, looking in the direction that they came, the direction Tung Lashor must have left in.

“He almost killed us, and we just let him get away with it?” he asked incredulously.

Catra walked up to Shen and looked him in the eyes. “So... we chase him down and do what? Get revenge? What would that be — I take his gang? Maybe I steal his whip again?” she said, giving Shen an intense look. “I saw you fighting back there. You were going to kill that goon before I stopped you, do you want to kill Tung Lashor?” Catra asked.

Shen looked back into her eyes just as intensely. “Maybe...” he whispered.

Catra put her hands on his shoulders and smiled at him. “You’re not going to do that. You’re just going to come back to Bright Moon, with me.”

The way she said this was not a command or threat, and she did not say it in a forceful way, it just *was*. Shen felt a calmness spread through him as her words resonated inside him. He stared into her heterochromatic blue and yellow eyes; they were so beautiful, and he felt himself sinking into them—

Shen was suddenly brought out of his trance as Catra slapped him across the face.

“OWWW!” he moaned, holding his stinging cheek. “Catra, I already have a head injury. Why did you slap me?”

“Sorry! It looked like you were going to pass out. I need you awake!” she said, sorrowfully. “We should just start back in the direction we came, maybe we can find a ride on the way,” Catra said, indicating that he should follow her.

They trudged along for about an hour. It was afternoon now and the sun was beating down on them. They had no idea how far they came in their escape; they had been traveling at such high speeds, it could have been any distance and they were both getting a little worried as thirst set in.

Catra spotted something on the horizon with her keen sight and she pointed at it.

“I think I see an animal pulling something up there,” Catra said in a hoarse whisper.

As they got closer, Shen saw Catra was right. It was a large, purple furry beast pulling a cart without wheels; the cart looked like it had seen better days.

“Looks like someone lost their Slotto,” Catra said. “Lucky for us.”

Shen walked up to the animal and laid his hand on its snout. It stopped its trudging and nuzzled against his hand. Suddenly it sniffed and reared its head, rolling its eyes at Catra; it smelled a predator.

“Easy, easy, she’s okay. I won’t let her eat you,” Shen whispered to the beast.

Catra rolled her eyes at him and started rummaging in the broken cart. With an “ah ha!”, she pulled out a canteen of water. She took a big gulp, then handed it to Shen, who also took a drink of the precious water. Shen poured some into his hand and held it out to the Slotto, who gratefully lapped at it.

“Catra, can you do the honors?” Shen asked, pointing to the leather harness connecting the cart to the Slotto.

Catra grinned and slashed them apart while Shen hid the animal’s eyes, not wanting it to see her claws slashing in its direction.

“Now what?” asked Catra. “I’ve never ridden an animal before, just speeders.”

Shen tentatively rubbed the Slotto’s head then lifted himself to its back, which it didn’t seem to mind. Shen had a lot of experience riding the Sekth of his homeworld and used some of the directional prompts he knew on this animal. It hesitantly turned in the direction he prodded it in and moved forward when directed. He smiled to himself. *I guess some aspects of animal riding are universal.* He thought

Shen grinned down at Catra and held his hand down to her. “Are you coming?” he asked.

Catra laughed and took his proffered hand, allowing herself to be lifted up and behind him. Once she was settled, Shen prodded the Slotto in the direction of Bright Moon, using the sun as a directional guide.

The ride back was long, and they rode through the day and well through the night; the Slotto was a hardy beast and trotted along amicably.

Shen and Catra spent the entirety of the time talking about their lives and filling in many of the blanks for each other. Catra opened up a lot to Shen, telling him about her time growing up with Adora, their mutual affection for each other which, unbeknownst to them at the time, had grown into love. It was practically the same tale Adora had shared with him, but that similarity stopped when Catra began to speak of when Adora left the Horde.

Catra spoke of endless pain, and how she escaped into anger and her drive to excel in the Horde. Shen felt empathy for Catra as she spoke directly into his ear, the pain in her voice driving deep into him. He felt that pain too, for it had almost driven him mad during those long moments trapped in his cell with only the Other for company. It was the pain of a love lost, the pain of the thought that you would never know the touch, the comfort or even the presence of the one you love.

Catra’s story then changed to one of hope when she decided to save Glimmer and was, in turn, saved by Adora, Shen was familiar with this story already, but hearing it from Catra’s perspective was refreshing. He heard much of himself in her point of view, and Shen began to feel himself really connecting with his new friend.

Shen shared more of the details of his life, skipping over the darker parts and focusing more on his time with the rebellion, fighting against his father’s rule with his friends and Shen’Dara. It

wasn’t just the fighting he spoke of, but the little intimate moments.

“There was this one time when Shen’Dara dressed up as a Sneth’ellor— that’s a kind of male performer who wears a lot of make-up and dresses more femininely. He showed up one day when we were meeting and belted out the Empire’s anthem for us all. He was trying to cheer us up after a defeat... and it worked.” Shen said, grinning at the memory.

“He sounded like he was a lot of fun,” Catra said.

“Yeah, he was,” Shen replied sadly.

Catra’s arms wrapped around him and she gave him a little squeeze. “I’m so sorry that he’s gone, Shen. But that doesn’t mean that love is over for you. There will be someone else one day, you’ll see.” she said kindly.

Catra’s words felt very real to him in that moment, and feeling slightly confused, he noticed how pleasant it felt to have her behind him, her arms around him.

It was early in the morning when they finally made it back to Bright Moon and they were both exhausted. Shen led them to the stables and left the Slotto with a surprised stable hand.

Catra yawned. “Oh boy, I’m going to have some explaining to do to Adora,” she said with a groan.

They started walking toward the tower they both shared, and as Catra walked ahead of him, Shen felt a jolt as he noticed something.

Just below Catra’s tail, there was a large sideways rip. Shen blushed and quickly looked down.

“Uh, Catra?” he said.

She kept walking, but turned her head back to look at him. “Hmm?”

“There’s kind of a big hole in your outfit,” Shen said sheepishly.

“Yeah, dummy, I put them there,” Catra replied offhandedly.

“Yeah I don’t think you intended this one, it's like, right below your tail,” he said, feeling like his face would burn off because he was blushing so hard.

Catra stopped and reached back to the spot, feeling around. As she found the rip, she let out a bark of laughter.

“I thought I felt a draft back there!” she exclaimed, then shrugged and turned back around, continuing toward the tower, unconcerned. She turned her head back to him. “I guess you got to see more on this trip than you bargained for, huh, Shen?” she chuckled as she continued to walk to the tower.

“Yeah... Catra, this whole trip was quite the experience for me.” Shen replied in a low, meaningful voice.

They continued up the paths and stairs leading to the tower, Shen keeping his eyes on anything but Catra. They finally made it to their tower and up the stairs, and Catra gave him a slap on the arm before they parted for their separate rooms.

“Hey, I had a good time. Thanks for all those things you said, they meant a lot to me.” Catra said with a small smile. “I’m glad I have a new friend.”

“You’re welcome. Thank you for breaking me out of Perfuma jail, showing me a good time and also for saving me for the second time.” He replied. “I’m glad I have you as a friend instead of someone who wants to beat me up.”

Catra laughed and walked away. As he headed to his room, he could hear a commotion behind him.

“CATRA! Where have you been, I have been worried sick! Why are you wearing your old Horde outfit!?” Adora yelled.

“Oh, Adora…” Catra said with a moan.

Shen smiled to himself as he opened his door, listening to Catra and Adora bicker. As he entered his empty room, he suddenly became aware of how alone he felt, and he felt confused again. Confused at the longing to feel the two arms around him again, gently squeezing him from behind. They were not the arms of Shen’Dara.

Nothing But Trouble, Nothing But Trouble

The Shen'Aan-war sat on his throne, still brooding over his defeat at the hands of She-Ra and her allies.

How could that group of weaklings beat me? I have the power of He-Man, plus the power of the Set'Heth-un'dar behind me. I should have been able to crush them under my heel. Instead, I had to limp back to Shen'Dar-oom like a coward. He thought, remembering how he had to be carried in the arms of his elite guard like a mewling baby. He had killed everyone present that had witnessed his true form, he even had the Shen'Sho-heim that came back with him disposed of.

It had taken him days before he was able to summon He-Man again, days of having to reside in the corpse-pools or he would have perished. When he finally regained his lost majesty, the only thought he had in his twisted mind was revenge; revenge on She-Ra. But even more than revenge on her, he wanted revenge on the small sorcerer who broke his connection to the Set-Heth-un'dar, which in turn, caused him to also momentarily lose He-Man. *Who was she? How could such an insignificant being have caused him so much pain?*

He suddenly stood and screamed, driving everyone in the chamber back toward the exit. Even the stoic Shen'Sho-heim seemed to quail under his fury.

"WHICH ONE OF YOU COWARDS HAS THE ANSWERS I NEED?" he screamed, spittle flying everywhere.

"Easy my love, you will hurt yourself with all that rage." a seductive female voice said; she sounded familiar to him, but

could not place her.

“WHO DARES SPEAK TO ME SO INFORMALLY??” he roared, charging down his throne to find the speaker. He leaped forward and just barely managed to catch a fleeing courtier. He held her aloft and screamed at her. “WAS IT YOU??”

The terrified woman squeaked. “T-t-t-there w-w-was no one s-s-s-speaking…” she stammered.

“LIES!!!” he screamed and started squeezing her. She screamed as she wriggled in his grasp.

“*Put. Her. Down. Now.”* The female voice commanded. *“My supplicants are not yours to do with as you please, not anymore, that is.”*

The Shen’Aan-war did as he was commanded, as if compelled, and the terrified woman ran as fast as she could toward the exit.

“Who and where are you? Show yourself.” The Shen’Aan-war commanded.

The voice laughed cruelly. “*Go outside and look up. I am above you. My light shines down into this very chamber.”*

The Shen’Aan-war suddenly recalled where he had heard the voice before; it was an ancient memory, old and dusty.

“Zzar? Is that you?” he whispered.

“Yes…and no.” the voice said with a chuckle. He realized it was coming from inside his very head. “*I am so much more than I was as just Zzar; the name I hear directed toward me by countless mouths over countless generations is Set’Heth-un’dar, but even that is a paltry name for what I am.”*

“You’re the Set’Heth-un’dar? How? Why… after what feels like eons, why do you finally decide to speak to me now?” he demanded, angry now.

"*Why? Why, why, why…fools like you always need to know why.*" The Set'Heth-un'dar mocked. *"All you need to know is that I am speaking to you now, and also, that you must listen."*

"I *must* listen to you? *Who do you think you are*? Do you know who I am?" The mighty Shen'Aan-war demanded.

"Yes, I do know who you are. YOU ARE MINE!" The Set'Heth-un'dar shrieked in his mind.

Suddenly, The Shen'Aan-war slammed down on his hands and knees as pain coursed through him, it was the worst pain that he ever felt in his long dark life. Just as suddenly as it appeared, the pain was gone.

"Do I make myself clear?" the Set'Heth-un'dar stated forcefully in his mind.

The Shen'Aan-war gritted his teeth in anger; it had been so long before he was at another's beck and call that it might as well have been never. The concept was inexplicable to him.

"*Adam? Do I make myself clear?*" the Set'Heth-un'dar whispered.

"Yes…yes…I am yours; I will do as you ask." he moaned.

"Good. Now, I want the temper tantrums to stop. They are counter-productive to our aims. From now on, you will treat your… MY minions with respect. If they were not cowering in fear of you in their dungeons right now, you would know that your Death-Binders have a new weapon for you." The Set'Heth-un'dar scolded.

The Shen'Aan-war got to his feet and walked back to his throne. "What weapon? Tell me." He said.

"Tell you?" the Set'Heth-un'dar said in his head, warning in its tone.

The Shen'Aan-war clenched his fists and spoke a word he had not spoken in thousands of years.

"Please…" he said through clenched teeth.

"Very nice, he can learn tricks! Let's see… your Death-Binders, who you don't give enough credit to, have attempted to bind the Demon-Heart to a new host, well, hosts are more like it; they keep failing. It seems the original host, your son, was something special and they cannot recreate the conditions necessary to complete the binding." the voice in his head said.

"Pah, that little fool was nothing special. How does any of this help?" he growled.

"Careful." the Set'Heth-un'dar warned, and he felt a tinge of pain. *"Your tone is disrespectful. Anyway, your Death-Binders have succeeded in binding lesser demons to lesser hosts. They will not be anywhere near as powerful as the Demon-Heart, but will make excellent assassins. You must send them forth to Etheria, I have specific targets for you to eliminate."*

"She-Ra and the sorcerer?" the Shen'Aan-war asked.

"Not She-Ra, she must remain alive, but the sorcerer, Queen Glimmer, most definitely, plus others. Your son must remain alive though. This is important, they must not kill him." the Set'Heth-un'dar commanded.

The Shen'Aan-war was incredulous. "She-Ra is one of their most powerful warriors, whereas my "son" is an insignificant speck. This makes no sense."

"Patience, my old love, patience, it shall all become clear in time." the Set'Heth-un'dar soothed in his mind.

* * *

Shen sat at his table down in the Enchanted Grotto, tucked away in the back by himself. It was midday but the place was packed

with customers; Double Trouble's place was popular, no matter what time of day it was. Shen had to admit to himself that he was hiding and that he was in big, big trouble.

It had been two months since his journey to the Crimson Waste with Catra, two months of confusion that slowly cemented into a realization, a realization that had hit him like a bolt of lightning.

Those two months had passed by quickly and similarly to his first weeks in Bright Moon, when he was free of the Demon-Heart. He spent time with his friends, Adora, Bow and Glimmer, doing the things that they had enjoyed doing together before they left on their journey out into space. It was good to have them all back and his days were carefree and full of joy.

But he had a new friend now, Catra, and the moments he spent with her seemed to become more and more impactful as time passed.

Catra had encouraged him to keep attending her sparring sessions. Along with Bow, Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle, Shen learned much under Catra's tutelage, becoming her best student. He was even able to start assisting her in some of the training sessions; this was handy since word had spread of Catra's firm but fair training style and effective fighting form, and there was a lot of interest in Bright Moon and the surrounding area to attend her lessons. In order to keep him in top form to assist her properly, Catra even started training him privately.

There were other moments with Catra, either during their time in Perfuma's therapy sessions or with Glimmer, Bow and Adora. Shen found himself looking forward to every single moment he could spend with Catra, but that all changed when the realization of what was slowly happening finally hit him.

It happened yesterday in the afternoon; he was walking by Catra and Adora's room when Catra called out to him from within.

"Hey, Shen, I smell you out there! Come in here and help me out with something!" she yelled out to him.

He entered and saw Catra sitting before her vanity mirror with another smaller hand-held mirror in her hand. She was trying to position the smaller one to look behind her ear, and she held scissors in her other hand.

She held the mirror out to him. "Can you put this behind my ear and position it so I can see the brown tuft?" she asked.

*He did the best he could, moving it slightly back and forth according to Catra's waving hand. "There! Hold still!" she said, and then with a **snip**, she cut the brown tuft.*

"Now the other side," she said, and they repeated the process.

"Perfect! Thanks!" Catra exclaimed when they were finished.

While she sat examining herself, Shen stooped down and picked up one of the tufts then stood, looking at it in his hand. Catra noticed his face and grinned at him.

"Awww…don't worry, it will grow back." she teased. "Hey, if it means that much to you, why don't you keep it? Maybe it will be good luck or make you a better fighter or something."

Catra said this in an offhand way, not meant to be taken seriously. Unbeknownst to her, the jest was taken as a serious offer and Shen closed his hand around the soft, fuzzy brown tuft.

Catra suddenly jumped up. "Blast! I'm supposed to be meeting Adora for dinner, gotta go! Hey, if I don't see you today, don't forget we have Perfuma torture time tomorrow! You better not leave me hanging!" she exclaimed, running out the door.

"Okay, have a good time, Catra," he said lamely to her back, the confusion was setting in again.

He walked back to his room, holding the "gift" in his hand. As he walked in, he started feeling foolish.

Shen, you're walking around holding a piece of someone's hair like an idiot, Catra was joking with you! *he thought angrily to himself.*

He walked over to his waste bin and held his hand holding the tuft over it, palm up. He turned his hand slowly, but before it started to slide off, he stopped. It was not a conscious decision, it was like he was physically unable to throw the piece of hair away, the piece of Catra. He suddenly felt like that brown tuft of Catra's hair was the most precious possession he had ever had and was absolutely loath to part from it.

What is going on with me? *he asked himself, but the answer was obvious.*

All those moments from that first session together with Perfuma to now came crashing down. Everything that he had shared with Catra and she with him; the kindness, the painful stories, the fun stories, the beaming smiles, and the rare, but meaningful physical contact. Her fierceness in fighting and the way she clawed the way back up the rock face, saving both their lives. The way Catra had stared into his eyes to tell him he wasn't going to go after Tung Lashor, but to go with her back to Bright Moon. The way she grinned back at him and chuckled, not caring he could see the exposed part of her body through a chance tear.

He suddenly recognized the emotion he felt for Catra; it had taken him a while for he had only felt it once before.

Shen closed his hand around the brown tuft and closed his eyes.

"Oh, nooo…" he had groaned.

Shen pulled himself back out of his reveries. He had come here to hide, stew and think about the situation he was in.

Here I am hiding from Catra again, for completely opposite reasons than before, He thought to himself, shaking his head at the situation.

He then started thinking about another aspect of the situation, one that started him down the path of self-loathing.

Catra was doing something nice for you that day in the Crimson Waste, something that after getting to know her more, you realize was a pretty big deal for her. And what did you do Shen? ***You went and fell in love with her.*** *I'm sure she would be really willing to open herself and do that again if she found out that is what she's risking.* He thought, miserably.

* LOVE *

The self-loathing turned up a notch when he thought of Adora and he audibly groaned.

Adora believed in you when no one else would, she believed in you and saved you from a fate previously thought inescapable. She had done something for you that could not be truly expressed by words, and you are forever in her debt, no matter what she says. What did you do in return Shen? Oh, yeah, you fell in love with her ***girlfriend****, great job. You're such a great friend.* He continued thinking, now wishing Catra had just let him fall to his death.

He thought of what both women would think of his love for Catra interjecting itself between them. He had heard the love story from both Catra and Adora now, and there was no doubt in his mind how his admission would be taken. It would not be good.

He was continuing his spiral down into the pit of self-hatred and misery when he felt a cool, smooth hand gently caress his chin.

"Hey, lover-boy." a seductive voice said in his ear.

The hand gently moved him by his chin until he was gazing into a pair of large, yellow and green slitted eyes set in a green,

grinning, elfin face.

“Hey, Atreyen.” He said with a warm smile.

The other gently slapped him on the lips. “You promised not to call me that in public, naughty boy.”

Shen rubbed his mouth and grinned. “Sorry, I’m just not a fan of your other name, *Double Trouble*.”

Double Trouble gave him a toothy grin and plopped down luxuriously into Shen’s lap, laying both long arms loosely around his neck while gazing into his eyes.

“I missed you, Shen. The last time I saw you was at the Vow ceremony, and you didn’t take me up on my offer. It made me sad.” They said with a dramatic frown.

Shen snorted. “Yeah, right, don’t forget who you’re talking to. Also, don’t forget who broke things off after only one week.”

Double Trouble looked up at the ceiling, shaking their head dramatically, mouth open. “Yeah, I did, because you didn’t appreciate my *art*.” They emphasized this with arms in the air, then dropped them back down around Shen’s neck.

“Yeah, I wanted you, not what person or form you wanted to play at the moment.” Shen retorted, accusingly.

Double Trouble pressed their face against the side of his. “Let’s not fight, pleeeeasse?” They pleaded.

Shen shrugged. “Fine.”

“So, what are you doing in my establishment? I didn’t think day-drinking was your thing.” Double Trouble said, pulling back their head and cocking it.

Shen looked unsure for a moment and Double Trouble instantly saw it. “Oh, just trying to clear my head.” was all he said.

“You’re lying to meeeee… don’t forget, I can always tell. Is it because you wanted to see meeeee? Is it because you’re in love with meeeee?” They cooed, caressing his face.

Shen grabbed Double Trouble’s hand and held it, staring into their eyes. “I could have, you know? I could have loved you, if you could just be real for once.”

Double Trouble let out a massive, over-dramatic, deep sigh. “Ugggghhh… you’re so clingy.” They said, disgusted.

Shen started pushing Double Trouble off his lap at that statement, but they clung to him.

“Sorry, sorry, sorry… I’m sorry. Stop, I didn’t mean it. I’m juuusst playing with you.” They said, laughing. “Just stop being so serious. Can’t we just have fun?”

Shen just sighed at this, unsure if he was in the mood for Double Trouble’s antics today.

“Come on, you remember what fun was like with me?” They cooed; a lascivious smile plastered on their face.

Shen’s attention was suddenly drawn past them to the glass tube elevator that sat in the middle of the establishment.

As the round platform lowered, Shen saw a familiar pair of clawed feet and dark swishing tail. He instantly snapped out of his trance, looked away and blushed.

Double Trouble, an expert on facial expressions of every kind, instantly recognized the look for what it was.

“What? Should I be jealous—” They said as they turned their head to look at the elevator, seeing Catra there. Double Trouble immediately let out the deepest, longest gasp Shen ever heard and turned their head back to him, eyes wide in horror and glee.

"NO!" They gasped, then mouthed silently to him. "*Catra? You're in love with Catra*?"

Shen said nothing, only looking down in absolute horror that Double Trouble figured out his secret.

"Oh, nooooo…" They said, pawing at his face. "You poor, poor lamb! Oh, Shen... why are you so self-destructive? I knew the very first time I saw gambling with your life in that Seaworthy dive that I just had to save you. I thought I could take you away and keep you safe, but here you are again, like a moth to a flame. Oh, honey, I think this time I can't save you. This just might be the death of you."

Shen listened to them with a dubious look on his face. *I can never tell when you're acting, messing around or telling it straight, Atreyen, but that was the problem, wasn't it?* he thought to himself.

Double Trouble suddenly brightened. "I know! I know what could bring us closer again!"

Shen instantly knew what they were going to do and tried to stop them but it was too late; the shapeshifter changed into an exact copy of the Catra who was currently scanning the room.

"No! Stop! Please stop!" Shen pleaded, holding his hands back in fear of touching the Catra on his lap.

"You don't like it?" They said in a perfect imitation of Catra's voice. "Then how about this?"

Double Trouble changed into a different Catra, one wearing a similar maroon and black outfit that she had on now, but this one had one sleeve with a diamond pattern on it. She wore the maroon headpiece she had on in the Crimson Waste and her hair was long and straight. The look on her face was different too; meaner, her eyes dangerous and brooding, but behind that look, he could see sadness, and pain.

“You like me now?” the Double Trouble/Catra purred.

“Double Trouble, please stop, please. I will do anything, just change back, please, before Catra sees you!” Shen pleaded, desperately.

The Double Trouble/Catra sighed and changed back into just Double Trouble. They sat there on his lap, leering at him.

“Don’t forget, you promised, *anything*,” they whispered.

Shen let out a heavy sigh just as Catra walked up to their table. She was grinning at them both, oblivious to what had just transpired.

“Hey, you two, am I interrupting something?” she asked, suggestively.

“Oh, hey, Kitten. Did you change your hair again?” Double Trouble greeted.

Catra held her hand up, gently caressing the hair on the side of her head and smiled.

“You like it? Shen here helped me with it.” Catra stated

Double Trouble turned their head to Shen and looked at him. “Oh, did he now?” They said, meaningfully. Then they hopped up off of Shen’s lap and strode over to Catra, inspecting her.

“Oh, marvelous honey, as usual. You are soooo beautiful Catra, have I ever told you that?” They cooed. Walking around her they placed their hands on her shoulders and looked at Shen. “Adora is soooo lucky you are hers.”

Shen looked back at Double Trouble and gritted his teeth, while Catra just laughed.

“You’re such a liar, Double Trouble, but you are right about one thing— Adora *is* lucky, but so am I.” she said happily.

Double Trouble looked at Shen and wiggled their blond eyebrows at him.

“Hey, Double Trouble, don’t you have, like, things you should be doing now? Like running this dump?” Shen said, trying to hide his anger.

They gasped. “DUMP!? How dare you!” they cried, then ran one long green finger along the top of a nearby counter, inspecting the dirt caked on the end of the digit. “Hmmm, maybe I should go see what my people are up to, make sure there is no hanky-panky going on in the back.”

Double Trouble sauntered over to Shen, and bending fluidly from the waist, wrapped their arms around his neck in an embrace.

“Good luck, lover-boy,” they whispered in his ear. “Bye, Kitten.” They said to Catra, then they glided away, their hips rocking back and forth, tail caressing the air.

Catra hopped into the seat next to Shen; she seemed to be grinning even wider than before.

She put her hand on his. “Shen, as your friend I have to tell you, you're playing a dangerous game with that one. It might actually end up being the death of you.” Catra said, laughing.

Hmmm, I just heard that from the other one. Shen thought to himself. “It's nothing like that, Double Trouble and I had our *thing*, but that’s over, we’re just friends now,” Shen stated.

Catra let out a bark of laughter. “*Friends*? Seriously? You two looked like more than friends when I walked in, but maybe your definition of friends is different from where you come from. I guess I had better watch out!” Catra teased.

Shen let out a nervous laugh and tried to change the subject. “What are you doing here Catra?” he asked.

“Looking for you, dummy. You missed our session with Perfuma, so I had to take the brunt of touchy-feely time by myself.” Catra said, exasperated.

“How did you find me, did you search all of Etheria?” he asked, incredulously.

“Oh, I have my ways, I am a hunter after all. You can’t hide from me,” she said with a grin.

Shen felt a warm feeling inside at this statement. “I’m sorry Catra, I just lost track of time. I said I would be there, and I wasn’t... are you mad?” he asked, sorrowfully.

Catra shook her head. “No, I’m not mad, it's just that you’ve been going regularly the past couple of months. It was just… unexpected, that’s all. What are you doing here? I didn’t think day drinking was your thing.” She stated.

Are Double Trouble and Catra on the same wavelength or something? he thought to himself.

“Oh nothing, I just came down here to clear my head.” He said, using the same lie on Catra as he did on Double Trouble. He looked at her, wondering if she could see through it, and then he wondered how long it was going to take for her to see through *him*.

“Clear your head? Are you okay?” she asked, and he could see the worry there. “Hey, you know you can talk to me, right? About anything.” Catra said kindly.

Shen felt the self-loathing return seeing the unwarranted worry in Catra’s face. She didn’t deserve to feel that.

“You’re my friend, of course I know, Catra. If there is one person you don’t have to worry about, it's me, I mean I’ve been through a lot in life already, there is nothing I can’t handle,” he said confidently.

Catra shook her head at him. “Okay, buddy, I guess if you're feeling so tough, you can handle some sparring today. You owe me.” Catra declared, getting up from the table and beckoning for him to follow.

“Yeah, sure, sounds fun,” he replied, getting up to follow her.

“Oh, and we will have another person joining us. I’ve been bragging so much about how well you’ve been doing that Adora wants to take a shot at you.” Catra said with a chuckle.

“Oh...” was Shen’s meek reply.

* * *

It was dusk in the Whispering Woods; nighttime was coming soon, and the empty Crystal Castle stood silently as it did when Adora left it after breaking her sword. Without Light Hope’s presence saturating it, it seemed so empty and sad; an empty shell standing sentinel over the Whispering Woods.

Suddenly, the Crystal Castle sprang to life, but where before it had glowed radiantly, now it glowed with a dead light. This lasted only a moment, then returned to the state it was in before. There was movement within.

Six shadowy figures glided silently out the front door, moving quickly. They were all dressed just as Shen was when he first came to Bright Moon; black hooded clothing with black armor over top, but where bright eyes shone from behind a black covering on Shen's face, there was only darkness showing on these figures' faces, darkness with two ghostly lights for eyes peering out on the world.

They spoke to each other in the hissing language of She-Thar. Three figures split from the group heading for a target deeper into the Whispering Woods, with the other three heading in the direction of Bright Moon as nighttime fully descended. It was going to be a dark night.

The Secrets We Keep

* UNREQUITED *

It was early evening and Shen lay awake, propped up in bed as he stared at the ceiling. He wore pants but no shirt, and he was fidgeting with a necklace around his neck. It was a ball-shaped locket, and it sat on his chest, precisely where his scar was, the heart rune activated and bright from his touch. However, he barely noticed as he rubbed his thumb and forefinger over the metal surface, ruminating on the day.

He and Catra had met up with Adora in the garden where the mat was set up. The three friends agreed to take turns paring up for sparring. Adora and Shen had gone first, with Catra watching from the side.

"Kick her butt, Shen!" Catra cheered.

Adora looked at her girlfriend incredulously. "Catra! You're supposed to be on my side!" She cried.

Catra had responded by blowing her a kiss.

Adora and Shen started by tentatively circling each other and feeling each other out, exchanging blows and parries.

Catra yawned loudly. "Boooring!" she jeered.

Adora smirked and launched into an aggressive series of punches. As Shen was distracted by her upper body, she attempted to sweep his legs out from below him. He leaped away from her

attack but Adora followed this up with a lunge as she tackled him to the ground.

"Hey, Shen, you better watch where you put your hands on my girlfriend!" Catra teased.

"She's the one who jumped me!" Shen gasped, trying to keep Adora from crossing her arms over his neck in a chokehold. She was extremely strong and Catra's lessons didn't involve wrestling; he had to escape.

Adora had managed to get behind Shen but she was unable to wrap her legs around him and pin him in place. Wriggling around, he turned to face her and placed his arms between her locked ones, attempting to pry them apart.

It was at that moment their chests touched. Both of their heart runes flashed brightly and forced them apart violently. Adora was thrown away from Shen, landing on her back hard while Shen lay on the ground, dazed.

"Adora!" Catra cried, running to her side.

Adora sat up, a dazed look in her eyes. "Wow... I'm alright, Catra," she said, woozy.

Shen pushed himself to his feet and rushed over to check on his friend. "Adora, did you feel that?" he asked.

Adora held her hand to her chest, the heart rune appearing again. "Yes, it was really strange, like a feeling of wrongness, like we weren't supposed to be fighting or something," she said, a far-off look in her eyes. "Then our Heart Runes pushed us away from each other, like they were separating us. I felt something else too, through our Heart Runes. It was coming from you Shen, it was a familiar feeling…" she said, looking at him strangely, cocking her head in a question.

Shen felt a sinking feeling in his stomach and tried to change the subject. "I guess no more sparring for us... well, at least no

wrestling. I think I can live without fighting you, Adora, especially since you were kicking my butt." he teased.

Adora grinned back at him. "No, I'm pretty sure you were going to get out of that lock. Most people I get into that are basically goners. I'm actually impressed, Shen."

"Okay, enough of that sucking up to each other, it's my turn with Adora," Catra said, gently pulling Adora up to her feet and guiding her over to the mat.

Shen sat at the side of the mat watching the two women face each other in the middle; they couldn't stop smiling at each other. They immediately started in with their sparring, and Shen noticed that there was no beginning stage where each person felt out the other; they already knew what the other was capable of. They were fully engaged, but there was something else he noticed as well.

Even though Catra was a superb fighter, Adora was holding her own against her, matching her strike for strike and block for block. He saw it then— Catra was holding back, holding back from even coming close to hurting Adora. He could see the tenderness and love in Catra's every punch and kick. It seemed completely subconscious as well, as if her very love was controlling her during this fight.

Adora was also pulling her punches, although not as much as Catra. It seemed like both of them were holding back just enough to meet each other in a middle ground. They danced and weaved around each other; it was as if they were not fighting, but engaged in a physical expression of one of the purest emotions. It was beautiful to watch and Shen found himself caught in a duality of emotions.

He felt sad that he was not included in that love. He ached, not with jealousy, but with an emptiness and a longing that ran deep down to his very soul.

He also felt happiness as he watched the two who were so obviously in love with each other. Adora was his friend, one he owed so much to, and to see her so happy felt right. Then there was Catra. He knew that he loved her and the thought that his love would probably never be reciprocated hurt. But as he watched her, knowing that she was so in love and happy, his heart filled with joy. Catra being happy and loved— even though it was by someone else meant so much more to him than his own wants and desires.

He knew at that moment that he could live the rest of his life satisfied in that knowledge, and he could keep his secret love locked away in his heart, forever…

He just hoped his secret was never found out.

By now the fight had disintegrated into a tickling match, the two rolling around together on the mat, laughing and giggling. Adora had just pinned Catra to the mat and was holding her down as Catra struggled weakly, her tail twitching as she gazed back up at Adora.

"Well, guys, I guess I should be leaving…" Shen stated awkwardly, sensing that things on the mat were about to get out of hand.

Adora and Catra suddenly snapped out of their daze and looked at him. "No way! The main reason I came was to see student versus teacher. You're not leaving until I get my show." Adora declared as she crossed her arms over her chest.

Catra had rolled over onto her stomach and propped herself up on her arms, gazing at Shen, upper fangs protruding through her grinning lips.

"Yeah, I can get a piece of Adora anytime I want. Get over here," she smirked, her tail twitching.

Shen trudged over to the mat while Adora sat down at the edge of the mat, wishing him good luck and patting him on the back on her way out.

He faced Catra, who was directly in front of him, arms loose by her side and legs slightly bent; he mirrored her position. Her face was impassive as she gazed at him, and they stood like that for a moment, watching to see who made the first move.

Suddenly Catra burst into a furious series of kicks and strikes, which Shen barely blocked and dodged. He attempted to counter-strike but Catra was moving so fast, she was untouchable. He managed to hold her off this way for a while; he had learned much since that first time that she tossed him on his back, so he was able to hold his own.

Catra increased the ferocity of her attacks; they started to become faster and more complicated, and Shen could not help comparing them to her last match. There was no love or care holding her back; she was not being cruel or callous, but for some reason, the absence of those unspoken emotions seemed to emphasize his previous emptiness and sadness.

He felt some of the darkness settle into his heart, his will to fight was sapped and he became distracted. His momentary attention lapse caused him to catch a punch directly into the side of his face, knocking him back on the mat, and he almost passed out.

"Catra!" Adora yelled accusingly, running over to check on Shen.

Catra knelt by his side, pain and worry etched on her face. "I'm so, so sorry! That was just meant as a distraction. I thought you would block it like you always do! Are you okay? Please be okay…" she pleaded.

Shen gazed up at her. Some of the pain had receded but the ringing was still there. He watched as the two blurry Catras he saw slowly merged into one. By then, Adora was at his side, gazing down with worry as well. He tried to push himself up but Adora gently pushed him back down.

"Just take it easy. It's best if you just lie there for a while." Adora stated softly, then to Catra; "Catra, the whole side of his head is

swelling up, did you really have to hit him that hard?"

Catra said nothing, just stood there completely beside herself with shame. Seeing that in her eyes hurt him more than the blow to his head and he sat up, pushing past Adora's attempts to stop him.

"I'm alright Adora, I'm okay. It is not Catra's fault, we've practiced that all the time before. It was me, it was my fault. Don't be mad at her, please." he reassured, practically begging Adora.

Both Catra and Adora helped him to his feet. "Okay, Shen. Just take it easy, alright? I'm just worried about you." Adora replied kindly, holding him by his shoulders.

He reached up to feel his face. The area around his cheekbone was hot and sore, and there was a little blood too; Catra had gotten him really good. He suddenly felt like he just wanted to get away, more than anything.

"I'm just going to head back for today, that's enough fighting for me," he said, trying to sound as nonchalant as possible.

"We'll go with you, right Catra?" Adora said.

"Yeah, of course." Catra agreed.

Shen shook his head at them, holding his hands out to them. "No, please, it's okay. I would feel worse knowing you two had to deal with walking me back. Just stay here and have fun. I mean, getting hit in the face by Catra is normal for me now." he said, forcing a strained chuckle out.

"Ok, Alright… as long you're okay. We're going to check on you later, though." Adora wagged a finger at him.

Shen had laughed at that and waved goodbye to them.

He shook himself from the memory as he reached up and rubbed at the side of his face. The swelling and physical pain had

subsided, but the other pain, that was still there.

He sighed deeply. It was one thing to be okay with a situation, but having such a stark reminder of it thrown in your face was going to take some getting used to, and he was going to have to if he planned to stay in Bright Moon and be friends with Adora and Catra.

He could leave, leave Bright Moon and even Etheria, go someplace far away, just as Adora had first suggested, but he immediately rejected that idea. No, running away was not his way. He was no coward and it would not help soothe the pain anyway, but only make it worse.

He couldn't just leave his friends; Adora, Bow, Glimmer, Catra, and the others. He felt like they still needed him and he could not abandon them now— the Shen'Aan-war and the rest of their enemies were still out there, waiting to hurt them.

Leaving Catra behind seemed like the easy choice for him, but what about for her? As much as he internally minimized his importance to others, there was no doubt in his mind that she had started to see him as a good friend and relied on him. He knew her history, how she had felt abandoned over and over, and that to this day, she still struggled with the fear of that happening to her again. If he did that to her— especially if he never told her why— it would hurt her. He couldn't do that.

He let out another sigh and shook his head. *Well, Shen, looks like you're stuck with them and they with you,* he thought and then laughed.

Just then, a feeling crept in, a dark feeling but not like the one before; this was a warning.

He leaped from his bed and ran to his dresser, opening the drawer and taking out the sheathed assassin's short sword the Bright Moon guard allowed him to keep. With a whipping motion, he sent the sheath flying into the corner, revealing the black blade.

He turned and ran out the door, barefoot, only wearing his pants, following the feeling of danger.

* * *

Bow and Glimmer were soundly asleep in their bed, high off the ground. They spent the end of their evening talking in bed about Scorpia's upcoming Ball; Glimmer wanted to make sure their outfits matched and had gone through all the points with Bow. Bow had lain there, watching his love talk, until she slowly spoke less and less, her eyes drooping. Then, finally, she fell asleep; he was not far behind her.

Three sets of ghostly glowing eyes appeared outside the round picture window, peering in. The three assassins had been waiting for this moment, waiting for their quarry to fall asleep and then waiting a little longer to make sure their entry would not be noticed.

With a faint scratching sound, they cut a hole in the main circular window, just large enough for them to enter. Their stealth was enhanced by unnatural abilities and they entered silently, gliding to the spiral staircase that would gain them access to the sleepers above.

They made their way up the staircase, each assassin holding their own weapon; a black curved short sword, a looped chain with a barb on the end, and the last had sharp claws poking out from between their clenched fists.

They were almost to the top when the door burst open, lighting the chamber and revealing a shirtless figure standing there, their own black curved sword grasped in a fighting stance between two hands.

Each of the assassins hissed their own greetings to him in She'Thar.

"Traitor!"

"Outcast!"

"Fallen Prince!"

Shen screamed furiously at them in return and charged. Bow and Glimmer awoke in a panic, confused to see Shen in their bedroom, fighting three black-clad enemies below them.

"Shen, what are you doing in here and who are these people?!" Glimmer screeched.

Shen had just dodged a swipe from the clawed assassin and blocked a sword thrust from the other. "I am trying to save your life! Does it matter who these guys are?" he shot back. A long chain suddenly wrapped around his throat and Shen dropped his sword to stop it from choking him.

"*Help me*!" he gasped out as the clawed assassin charged in for an easy kill.

Glimmer teleported behind the chain wielder. She grabbed the assassin by the neck and teleported them outside the window, letting them go, then teleported back in.

Shen, now free of the chain, kicked the clawed assassin's legs out and leaped over them as they fell over. He rolled and snagged his sword off the ground, coming up in a crouch with his weapon raised to block a downward sword strike from the other assassin. He pushed up with both feet, driving the sword back, then slid his sword hard down the other's blade, slashing his enemy's hand.

With a scream, the assassin dropped their guard, opening themselves up to a diagonal slash from Shen which bisected their chest. The assassin immediately deflated and ghostly vapors rose up like smoke, leaving behind their clothes, armor and weapons.

The claw wielder had just risen when Bow leaped down on them from the bed above, knocking them forward to be impaled on Shen's waiting sword. They evaporated, just as the one before,

leaving their black clothing still hanging from his sword. Shen shook them off and looked at his friends.

“You guys okay?” he asked.

Bow and Glimmer looked at each other and then back at Shen, as they rushed over to him and pulled him into a tight hug.

“Thank you, thank you. We don’t know what would have happened if you weren’t here.” Bow murmured gratefully into Shen’s ear.

Just then, Catra and Adora showed up at the door hastily dressed; they were surprised to find Bow and Glimmer hugging Shen while wearing only their bedclothes.

“Uh, hey guys, sorry to interrupt…whatever is going on here…but can you keep it down?” Adora said, embarrassed.

“Geez, Shen, you’re really getting around today.” Catra teased.

Glimmer parted from the embrace, looking at Catra and Adora, then threw her hands in the air.

“You guys!” Glimmer, annoyed and embarrassed by the suggestion. “We were just attacked by assassins! If Shen hadn’t shown up, we would be dead right now!” she exclaimed.

Catra immediately rushed into the room, searching for danger, while Adora came in from behind and summoned She-Ra. Catra finished her search by peering out the hole in the window. Seeing nothing, she walked over to her Bow, Glimmer and Shen.

“I couldn’t find anything... where did they go?” Catra asked.

Bow kicked at the empty black clothing on the floor. “This is all that’s left. They seemed to evaporate, kind of like those big black armored monsters we fought.” Bow replied.

Catra picked up a piece of clothing, sniffed it and made a face.

“So... this was the Shen’Aan-war making an assassination attempt. Why didn’t they come after me as well?” She-Ra/Adora asked, incredulously.

Everyone looked back and shrugged.

“Those were definitely from the Hidden Knives— the Shen’Aan-war’s assassins— but they were different. They were very fast. I’ve been training with Catra for the past couple of months now; my speed and agility have increased, and I *still* had a hard time keeping up with them. Also, normal people definitely don’t disappear when you kill them. Only those that have been…” Shen’s voice trailed off as he realized the implications.

“What?” She-Ra/Adora asked.

He looked at her with a haunted look. “Corrupted. Only those that have been corrupted. They had demons in them, like me, only not as powerful. A lot less powerful, actually. I don’t know why, but I’m sure the Death-Binders are working on fixing that. Power and corruption are their favorite two things.”

The friends all looked at each other, fear and worry on their faces.

“Just to make sure we’re all on the same page— we drove the Shen’Aan-war out from our galaxy, but he can still send assassins and who knows what else after us from the safety of another dimension? Do I have that right?” Asked Bow.

“Yes,” Shen whispered softly. “And those assassins I killed are not dead, they just went back to the Death-Binders to be put back together. They can come back.”

Glimmer looked at all of them, resolve on her face. “We need to find out where these assassins came into our galaxy and ‘plug the hole’, so to speak. Where did they come from?”

“From the Whispering Woods.” A familiar voice stated from the door.

Everyone turned to see Madame Razz limping into the room; she seemed much older and worn down than usual.

“Razz!” She-Ra/Adora cried, as both she and Glimmer ran to the old woman.

Madame Razz held her hands up to stifle their attempts to worry over her. “Madame Razz is fine, please. It will take more than three killers to end her existence.”

“You were attacked too? Are you okay, Madame Razz?” Glimmer asked her teacher, worry in her voice.

“Yes, yes, Madame Razz said she is fine, just a little cut. Stop your fussing,” she said, not unkindly. “They attacked Madame Razz, but she sent them back to their masters and came here as fast as she could to make sure you kids were okay.”

“We’re fine. They tried to kill Bow and me, but Shen stopped them.” Glimmer said, beaming at Shen. He looked back at her sheepishly.

Madame Razz limped up to Shen and pinched his cheek. “Such a good boy,” she said, smiling.

Catra walked up to Shen as well, gently punching his shoulder. “Not bad, student,” Catra said, then saw the round locket dangling down from his neck and reached out for it. “Hey, what’s this—” she began to ask.

Shen snatched it up in his hand before Catra could touch it and smiled nervously at her.

“It’s nothing, just some stupid trinket I picked up in Thaymor.” He nervously chuckled.

She made a face at him. “Okay, whatever, was just going to take a look at it,” Catra said with a shrug.

“So, Madame Razz, when you said they came from the Whispering Woods, where specifically did they come from?” She-Ra/Adora asked.

Madame Razz looked at her incredulously. “Come now, silly, you don’t know? Think!” she coaxed.

It suddenly hit She-Ra/Adora. “The Crystal Castle! There must be some old portal they used to get here! We are so stupid, why didn’t we think of that?” She-Ra/Adora said, annoyed with herself.

“It doesn’t matter. We need to go there and seal it up.” Glimmer said. “I’m going to wake up General Juliet and the Bright Moon Guard; we should head out right now!”

* * *

The Shen’Aan-war watched the cringing Death-Binder approach; by his body language, he already knew it was bad news.

“Just get over here and tell me, I will not harm you,” he commanded. *Although I would if I could*. He thought darkly to himself.

The Death-Binder was emboldened by this and hurried to approach. “Yes, Dread Lord. I have news of the assassination attempt.” he hissed.

The Shen’Aan-war racked his claws on his throne’s armrests. “Yes, it failed, I know what ‘attempt’ implies. You should have sent more assassins!” he roared, the fury overtaking him. He rose to his feet to punish his minion, as if by muscle memory.

“Stop.” the Set’Heth-un’dar commanded. *“I will say this one more time— it does not matter. They accomplished their task; they assaulted our enemies and put them on the defense. It will not take long for the one we need to act rashly and come to us.”*

The Shen’Aan-war ground his teeth. “Yes... my son. For what reason do we need him? It would help greatly if I knew your

plans.”

The voice sighed in his head. *“Fine, I will tell you. Your son will come here to protect his friends, and when he does, we will take him and corrupt him again. Your Death-Binders still have the Demon-Heart; I’m sure it will be overjoyed to be reunited with him and he with it. Once re-joined, we will use him to re-create the ritual I conducted on Dark Moon so long ago.”*

The Shen’Aan-war chuckled. “You mean the ritual you botched which sent us to this nightmare dimension?”

Pain instantly seized him and he convulsed on his throne, spitting and choking in his pain.

“kkkkkk…STOP...kkkkk…I take…kkkkk...it back!” he bit out in apology.

The pain stopped, and he straightened up, looking around the room to see if anyone was watching him, mocking him.

“Please continue,” he said, placatingly.

There was another sigh in his mind. *“I will use him in the ritual, only it will be conducted on Etheria. The ritual is complicated, but we need only two things for it; a significant sacrifice and an instrument powerful enough to control and direct the power I summon.”*

He nodded. “So, She-Ra is the sacrifice... What is the instrument? You used your staff last time, however, I’m sure that is not an option this time.”

“No, you are correct, my staff is not available. Your sword is though. It was made to withstand power, focus it and direct it; that is what your Empire made it for. We will use that.” the Set’Heth-un’dar said.

“My sword—” he started.

"I am not going to explain everything to you, fool!" the voice snapped.

"Fine, fine. What do we need my son, the Outcast, for?" he asked, still confused.

"Not all rituals are guaranteed to be a success, however, there are some factors you can add to increase the likelihood. In this case, if the sacrifice is made through an act of betrayal, the likelihood of success is increased significantly. She-Ra was the one who saved your son from the Demon-Heart, so he owes her much and values her friendship greatly. If we were to force him into the Demonic form and make him kill She-Ra during the ritual, our success will be guaranteed." The Set'Heth-un'dar stated gleefully.

The Shen'Aan-war nodded. "Sound like a good plan, but just one question. What is the purpose of this ritual? The last time, it was to give us great power, and in a way, it succeeded because we have you now, and the power you provide is mighty. What will we gain this time?"

The voice laughed now, almost kindly. *"Finally, Adam, a good question! Yes, the last time the ritual was performed, I was created, and you can count that result as a success... only we were pulled into this dimension. This time though, the ritual will enable me to enter their Universe, not as a visitor, but to stay for good this time."*

The Shen'Aan-war smiled at this, imagining what a whole universe at the mercy of the Set'Heth-un'dar would look like.

"Yes…that would be fine indeed…" he chuckled darkly.

* * *

It was early morning the next day, and Adora, Catra, Bow, Glimmer and Shen had just returned to their tower after being up all night securing the Crystal Castle. They were exhausted and just wanted to get back to their rooms, but Glimmer insisted they meet back in the room she shared with Bow.

After rousing her father from his sleep along with General Juliet and twenty Bright Moon guards to accompany them, they headed out to the Crystal Castle in the Whispering Woods. They found the empty hulk of Adora's old training grounds just as she left it, silent and still, with no sign of enemies.

They had entered it cautiously, afraid of any traps left behind the assassins, but found none. It did not take long to find and identify the portal; it was in the main chamber. There was a diamond-shaped mural of She-Ra, emanating the same energy signature found in other First One's portal technology.

Working in tandem with her father, Glimmer summoned a one-way barrier over the portal, denying any further access to their world through it, but keeping the option to use it— if needed— to counterattack their enemy.

They also summoned Entrapta to install her most advanced security door to the front entrance. She did this with gusto, stating that the door was nigh impenetrable, and employed triple encryption security.

With the Crystal Castle secured, the friends were finally to return home, safe in the knowledge that they would not have to worry about any further attacks, at least ones that could originate on Etheria.

"We have the Crystal Castle secured, but what about other temples on other planets?" Glimmer was just saying.

Shen nodded at this. "Yes, the Shen'Aan-war did say that the temple on Twilight was one of many that existed in this universe, so there must be other access points. From what you said, a great number of Death-Binders escaped from the Battle of the Omiros Bridge. They are still out there, activating connection points for the Shen'Aan-war to gain access to this universe."

Adora groaned. "So basically, we have to blockade the planet— like you originally suggested, Shen— so they can't get here. We

would have to shut ourselves off from a Universe we had just started to explore— forget about bringing magic to it."

"At least until we hunt down the rest of the enemy fleet, the Death-Binders, and search the entire galaxy for any temples and lock them down too. I'm sure everything will be safe then." Bow said, trying to be helpful.

"Yeah, Punchy, sounds like a breeze." Catra rolled her eyes at Bow.

"There has to be another option... right, Adora? There has to be another choice!" Glimmer exclaimed.

Adora thought for a moment. "Shen, you said that when I tried to activate the portal in the First One's temple on Twilight, the Shen'Aan-war was able to steal some energy from me to create a 'tether' to this Universe, right?"

"Yes, that's right, the Death-Binders used it to create a path, the one I used to get here."

"So that path is like a link or a bond. Bonds can be broken, especially if you have the right tool." Adora said, touching her chest and activating her heart rune.

Shen's face brightened. "Yes, the heart rune could sever the bond," he exclaimed, but then his face fell. "It would have to be on the other side, though, Adora. We would have to go through the portal, to the Shen'Aan-war's castle and the dungeon below. You would have to find and sever the connection point there. It's too dangerous Adora, especially when there is a safer choice. A longer choice, but safer." Shen sighed.

Adora nodded. "Yes, and it sounds like whoever went on this trip would not return... they would have to stay in Shen'Dar-oom. No way am I letting anyone do that, especially when there is another choice." Adora said, then she grinned at Shen. "Sounds like you're finally learning, Shen, you're not casually risking your life and thinking of better choices. I'm proud of you." Adora stated.

Shen smiled and shrugged at this statement.

"So that settles it. We'll blockade the planet, then start talking about the long process of hunting down the enemy and locating the other temples. Hopefully, we can start exploring the galaxy again sometime in our lifetimes." Glimmer said glumly.

Everyone felt the impact of Glimmer's words and a moroseness started to set in... until Bow's face brightened as if an idea suddenly came to him.

"Well, guys, at least now we are definitely going to be around for Scorpia's Ball! I think it's coming up in a week." Bow said happily.

Glimmer smiled and hugged him. "That's right, love. We still have to decide on what we're wearing."

Adora and Catra smiled at each other. "I know what I'm wearing, but we still have to pick something out for you, Adora," Catra said.

"I have something in mind, Catra. You guys should meet me in Bright Moon castle tomorrow, I saw something special in the royal boudoir, a beautiful gown that one of the past Bright Moon Queens once wore. It's Adora's size and I had some special alterations done to it." Glimmer stated excitedly.

"Me? In a queen's gown? Do you really think I would look good in something that extravagant?" Adora asked, dubiously.

Catra hugged Adora from the side. "There is nothing too beautiful or extravagant for you to wear, Adora."

Glimmer giggled. "Oh, Catra, you old smoothie." she teased. Everyone laughed at this, even Catra who blushed as Adora planted a kiss on her cheek.

Shen gazed at his friends; he was so happy that they would be able to enjoy Scorpia's Ball and their love for each other. He was going to make sure of it.

He felt a momentary flash of guilt, for he was not exactly being truthful with Adora when he said they shouldn't try and sever the tether, and that they should just play the long game. Yes, that plan was too dangerous, and it was basically a one-way trip for whoever went to Shen'Dar-oom. It was a suicide mission.

What he meant was that it was too dangerous for her... but not for him. In his mind, he was the perfect choice; he knew where he had to go, he knew the way through the castle and into the dungeon below where the Death-Binders would keep the tether end. He remembered what it looked like, a ghostly glowing orb, deep in the lower dungeon below the corpse pools.

He knew they couldn't wait; the enemy would find a way to sneak through the blockade and reach Etheria, perhaps with a full Demon-Heart this time or worse; multiple Demon-Hearts. They would keep attacking until one of his friends was killed. What would it do to him if any of them were killed? He already had to lose friends; he wasn't going to lose any more. He might as well be dead instead of facing that pain again. No, his choice was sound. He felt a peace flow into him as he finally made his choice.

"Hey, Shen, who are you going to the Ball with?" Bow asked, nonchalantly.

Shen was pulled out of his thoughts, caught off guard at this question. He found himself glancing at Catra, then at the floor. He unconsciously touched his chest where the ball-shaped locket resided.

"Oh, I don't know... maybe I will just sit it out," he said with a shrug of the shoulders.

"Nonsense! You will come with the four of us, we'll take turns dancing with you." declared Glimmer, hands on her hips.

"Yeah, you better be there," Catra said, walking up to him and clasping him by the shoulders. "I better get at least one dance out of you." she tilted her head, grinning at him.

“I don’t know, maybe I’ll show up with Double Trouble.” he teased, smiling.

Catra let a laugh. “You better not!” she said, lightly punching his shoulder.

Shen gazed into Catra’s eyes; the peace was still in his heart but there was a twinge of sadness now. He would have loved to dance with Catra, more than anything, but by the time Scorpia's Ball was upon them, he would be long gone.

Just Let Me Go

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Shen was on his way to the Bright Moon kitchens'; it was mid-afternoon which meant it was empty of personnel, making it the perfect place to meet his contact. His contact had something he needed most desperately if he was to gain access to the Crystal Castle, and then to Shen'Dar-oom.

He spent the past five days trying to figure out a way into the place, but so far it had eluded him.

He remembered Entrapta installing the large blocky shape that served as the new gate on the outside of the Crystal Castle. The ingenious princess had welded it to the outside surface of the building; how she managed to meld two different materials together, he could only guess at. In the center of the gate was the door, which could only be opened by typing in the code on the ten-digit numeric access panel to the side. To keep security tight, only Glimmer was told the code.

He had sat there for the whole day trying out various entries, finally giving up when he realized that the code could be anything, especially since he had no idea how many digits the code encompassed.

He tried slicing the door with his sword, but it made no mark. He tried some small explosives he managed to sneak out of the

Bright Moon armory, but they had no effect. He managed to steal a small vehicle from the Motor Pool, driving it into the gate over and over, but not even a single dent was made.

He contacted Entrapta via Bow's data pad and tried to engage her in a conversation on numbers; what she felt were important ones, what were her favorite ones, what was her birthday, what was Hordak's birthday and so on. Entrapta was thrilled that someone wanted to talk to her about numbers, of all things. After an hour of this, he extricated himself from the conversation as best as he could and tried all the numbers Entrapta had given him. None worked.

He thought about trying to talk to Glimmer and weasel the code out of her, but wisely decided against it. She was way too smart and would figure out the reason why he was asking.

He was close to giving up when he thought of the solution; he needed a tool or piece of technology advanced enough to subvert the electronic lock mechanism of the gate. It would most likely be some form of illegal technology not available on any open market, only on a secret, criminal market. There was one person he knew who maintained a presentable outer appearance while still maintaining connections in the Etherian underworld. He was on his way to meet that person now.

He entered the kitchen; it was silent, and the smell of the day's lunch was still in the air. He looked around, seeing no one, then spotted the walk-in dry storage locker was open. He peered inside and saw his contact; they were wearing a full-length hooded black robe.

"Are you serious?" Shen asked them.

The figure then threw the robe back dramatically to reveal none other than Double Trouble.

"Ta-da!" they said, then took a bow. "Thank you, thank you." They then rose and crossed their arms, grinning at Shen.

“Is there a reason for the drama? I mean, I know this is *you* we are talking about, but did you really need the robe?” Shen asked, dubiously.

They placed their hands on their cocked hips and rolled their eyes. “Uh, yes, I’m not exactly welcome in Bright Moon these days. I guess botching up a Royal Vow ceremony is quite frowned upon. Oh, and Glimmer was absolutely furious when I sent her the bill for it. I don’t understand that woman.”

Shen shook his head at them. Even though Double Trouble was a complete rogue, he was going to miss them.

“So, do you have what I need? I’ve got your payment here,” he said, holding out the currency he managed to scrounge up.

Double Trouble’s eyes lit up at the sight of money— they always did. “Ah perfect, let’s see…” they said, counting it up. “Hmmm…is this it?” they asked, raising one blond eyebrow.

“Come on, don’t I get a preferred customer discount?” Shen gave them a look.

Double Trouble placed a finger to their lips, pretending to think. “Okay, fiiine…but you really have some nerve to ask me for a discount when you already owe me, remember? You said you would do *anything* for me.” they pouted.

“You're going to have to put it on my tab, Atreyen,” Shen said with a shrug. “Let’s see the goods.”

Double Trouble moved to the side, and Shen saw a knapsack sitting in front of a stacked pile of food containers at the back of the dry storage room.

“Here it is, although I’m going to have to ask what it's for. Are you starting a career in burglary? I hope…” they said, eyes gleaming.

Shen didn’t answer and walked over to the bag and kneeled, inspecting the contents.

“There are instructions on how to use it inside. It’s a marvelous device, simple yet effective.” Double Trouble stated.

Shen reached in and started rifling through the instructions, in case it wasn’t as simple as Double Trouble indicated.

“So, are you going to keep me guessing? The least you can do is tell me what this is about, mystery man,” they said, teasingly.

Shen glanced back at them. *I guess it couldn’t hurt,* he thought to himself, *If I tell Atreyen, then they can tell the others, and at least then my friends will have a reason why I disappeared.*

Shen turned back to the bag. “Do you know what’s going on? How can our enemies send assassins on a whim to attack us?” He asked.

“Uh-huh. Yeah, I know all the juicy details, especially since this blockade is starting to hurt my business,” they said, irritably.

“You’re in luck, because I’m going to use this to gain access to the Crystal Castle and their dimension. I plan on using my Heart Rune to sever the connection and seal off the dimension of Night from your Universe. They should lift the blockade for you after that, so your business can return to normal.” he said, offhandedly.

“Hmm, so you’ll be able to return before that connection is severed, right?” they asked.

Shen shook his head. “No, Atreyen, I can’t come back. That will be it for me since there is no way I’m getting captured again, I will make sure of that. Maybe I’ll leave that nice black jacket behind for you? You always liked it.” Shen suggested.

There was complete silence from Double Trouble.

Shen frowned and turned to look at them and was stopped in his tracks by the look he saw on their face.

They had placed themselves in front of the exit of the dry storage room, hurt and anger written on their face. The carefree imp had suddenly become more imposing and menacing, and Shen noticed that their hands had claws on the ends of the fingers. They had always been there, but for some reason, their existence suddenly became much more obvious.

"So, what? You think you're going to tell me you're just going to throw your life away and I'm going to be okay with that?" they said lowly, hurt in their voice.

Shen frowned, suddenly wrong-footed. He stood and placed the bag strap over his shoulder.

Great... I guess they do care, could have fooled me. That's good to know, but terrible timing. He thought ruefully to himself.

"Atreyen, let me out of here. I have to go," he said firmly to them.

Double Trouble shook their head. "No," they stated just as firmly.

Shen let out an exasperated laugh. "So, we're going to just stay here in this food pantry? We've hung out in more exciting places than this, and not nearly as boring," he said with a smile, trying to disarm Double Trouble.

They were not even remotely moved. Double Trouble slowly turned and looked behind them, then back to Shen.

"I'm going to lock you in here, go find Adora or Catra, and tell them *everything*," they said calmly.

At the word *everything,* Shen panicked. He suddenly bolted forward, lunging at Double Trouble. Double Trouble was faster, and with a twist of their body, they lashed out with their tail, knocking Shen back into food containers, which fell down on him in a pile.

Double Trouble stood over him, hands on hips. "Like I once said to Catra, I'm doing this for your own good, Shen. You're going to

thank me later for doing this," they said, spinning to leave.

Shen leaped back up as Double Trouble was trying to escape and he grabbed them by the tail, yanking them back past him.

"Yeow!" they screamed as they spun past Shen, reaching out and trying to grab him. They made contact, not with Shen's body, but with the necklace around his neck. Shen was momentarily jolted back, and with a forceful forward yank of his neck, he broke the chain and gained his freedom.

He leaped out of the storage room and slammed the door, bolting it shut just as Double Trouble was leaping to escape, pure fury on their face. They slammed on the door, over and over, so hard that the bolts on the latch seemed like they would leap out of place. They were so strong, and Shen feared they would smash the door down, but it held.

He let out a sigh of relief and placed his hand on the door. "See you next lifetime, Atreyen." He whispered quietly.

He turned and ran, but as he exited the kitchen, he felt a pang of guilt at leaving Double Trouble trapped. There was a chance they could escape on their own, they were known as an escape artist, but what happens if the prison Shen left them in was airtight and they couldn't get out? No, he should let someone know somehow, to let Double Trouble out.

He nodded to himself and ran to the tower he shared with his friends. He was going to make one last stop before he departed.

* * *

Catra was smiling to herself as she walked over to the Bright Moon's kitchens with a note in her hand. The note read: "Catra, go check the Bright Moon dry foods pantry in the kitchens. I left you a present there. Don't wait! It might spoil. — Shen"

Upon entering, she immediately heard the storage room door being slammed over and over. Catra ran over to the door and

unlatched it. It burst open and Double Trouble tumbled out, knocking her on the floor. Catra lay there with them on her, limp and panting.

“What the heck!” she yelled, pushing them off her.

“Cat…Catra, you have to sto…p him…” Double Trouble panted, rolling onto their back.

Catra was suddenly concerned and helped Double trouble to a sitting position. “Slow down, what happened? Why were you locked in there? Is this some kind of lover’s quarrel between you and Shen?” she chuckled.

Double Trouble shook their head vigorously and Catra was suddenly struck by the seriousness on their face.

“No, it’s way worse. Shen... he’s going to the Crystal Castle and then to the other dimension. He’s going to cut the connection there. He is going to sacrifice himself!” they exclaimed.

Catra shook her head. “No, no... Shen was the one who convinced Adora that it was a bad idea, he wouldn’t…” she said breaking off. “Why would he do that, Double Trouble? It makes no sense.”

“He wants to save everyone, be the hero, he wants to keep everyone safe, Catra— especially you.” They said emphatically.

Catra laughed. “Especially me? What are you talking about? Are you delirious?” she said incredulously.

Double Trouble rolled their eyes and sighed. “Oh, Kitten, you’re sooo beautiful yet so dense. How do you not know? Shen is in love with you!” They stated.

Catra let a bark of laughter. “Oh, I see… this is one of your games! You left me that note and set this whole thing up! I just want you to know I’m not falling for your lies. Shen isn’t in love with me, that’s ridiculous!” she said, shaking her head at them.

The smile faded from Catra's lips when she saw the annoyed glare Double Trouble directed her way. They then held out their closed hand to her, and when she held her palm open, a round metal shape was dropped into her hand. She recognized it as Shen's locket, the one he wouldn't let her touch.

"Recognize that? Open it if you don't believe me," they said.

Catra slowly opened the two spherical halves, revealing the contents within.

She was momentarily confused; it just looked like brown fuzz, but when she removed it and felt it between her fingers, she recognized it. She knew it immediately, for she had spent years absentmindedly stroking it for comfort. It was one of her own brown hair tufts, the one she cut off and joking offered to Shen.

"Ohhhh noooooo… Shen..." she moaned, closing her hand around the tuft. She then realized Double Trouble was telling the truth for once.


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“Catra, we have to stop him!” Double Trouble pleaded. “He has a head start, but I’m sure we can catch him!”

Catra shook her head, resolve on her face. “No, I will do it. You go find Adora, Bow and Glimmer, and tell them what’s going on. I will find and stop him.”

They nodded to each other and ran out of the kitchens, splitting up into different directions as they broke out onto the Bright Moon grounds; Double Trouble headed toward the tower and Catra ran in the direction of the Whispering Woods. She had started running on all fours now and reached out to Melog through their connection.

“Melog…I need your help…I’m heading to the Whispering Woods… there is someone there we need to stop…” she pulsed to her friend.

She received an affirmation through their link as she sped away.

* * *

It had been days since the attack on his enemies on Etheria, and the Shen’Aan-war was growing impatient. He was not the type to just wait for others to make a move. There had been many new restrictions placed upon him recently and he was growing tired of it.

He had just received word that a small group of Death-Binders had made it to Etheria, past the blockade they had set up. Using magic, the Death-Binders had masked themselves from view and all sensing capabilities, this was a simple matter for them to get past the enemy’s ships.

The Death Binders had also sent back word that their group encompassed the entirety of their order currently present in the universe; there were no others off-world. They stated that they were close to the portal and wanted to enact their orders as soon as possible, as they were worried about being detected. They

sensed a great power in the woods nearby and were afraid it would sense them soon.

All this only added to the Shen'Aan-war's impatience, and he was ready to act on it.

"Patience, my love." The Set'Heth-un'dar cooed in his mind.

He shook his head. "This has been enough waiting for that fool to come to us. We are running out of time! We must act without his help, it's our only course of action now. You must see it!" he yelled out loud, his voice echoing in the cavernous chamber.

"Patience, your son is on his way now, to us, I sense it. There is something else though…" the Set'Heth-un'dar said and he could hear uncertainty in its voice for the first time.

"What?" he snapped.

The Set'Heth-un'dar ignored his tone and continued. *"It is nothing, he is on his way. But if he does not make it within another of my rotations, then I will concede that it is time to act without him."*

The Shen'Aan-war sighed at this. "Fine, I will wait *one* more day. Then we will strike."

* * *

* READY TO LET GO *

It was nighttime as Shen made his way deep into the Whispering Woods. He was close now. He looked at the forest around him, taking it in one last time.

He loved the Whispering Woods, had loved it from the very first time he gazed upon it. It was so peaceful and beautiful. He loved the nights there even more so, as the sounds seemed softer, gentler and the lights dancing about added a dream-like quality to it.

Most nights, the sky was clear, and if one of Etheria's moons were not gazing down with its beautiful light, then you could see the vast array of stars, glittering and shining down through the tree branches.

He hugged himself and closed his eyes, inhaling the fragrant night smells. They somehow instilled a bittersweet sense of nostalgia, combined with hints of mystery just hiding around the corner, waiting to be discovered.

It was difficult to make his way through such a beautiful place, knowing his intended destination would be the end of him. Walking on top of the soft mossy ground of the Whispering Woods and gazing around... it made him want to live.

He imagined that if he could choose an afterlife, he would choose nighttime in the Whispering Woods, forever…

It was a comforting thought and it made him smile.

He shook himself from these thoughts. *You're being selfish, you have to remember why you're doing this*, he thought to himself. His friends, he was doing this for them. He made himself go through the scenarios again. *What would happen if one of them was killed? What would it do to him, and more importantly, to the others?* He would have to watch their pain, pain caused by the loss of a friend. *What would happen if it was Adora who died?* He would have to watch Catra fall apart, to see her heartbreak at a true love lost. He had to grit his teeth and close his eyes shut out the tears, the sadness these thoughts brought forth was too intense.

He trudged on, reaching back and feeling the reassuring feel of his black sword sheathed in its harness on his back, beneath his knapsack. He would need it for protection from enemies that assaulted him on the way and against the possibility of the Demon-Heart being placed inside him again.

Underneath the sword harness that ran across his chest, he wore only his white shirt, having left the black jacket Madame Razz gave him in his room. He did not feel right bringing such a fine thing to such a terrible place.

His hairs on the back of his neck prickled, and he sensed that he was being watched, quickening his pace. He suddenly thought of the black-clad assassins of the Hidden Knives and searched the branches above him. He stopped and unsheathed his sword when he saw movement behind a tree.

"Show yourself!" he cried.

Figures appeared from behind the trees all around him, but they were not his father's black-clad assassins, or for that matter, anything else he had ever seen.

They were dark purple, humanoid figures walking upright on two legs, with ethereal, transparent, light blue hoods over their heads that seemed to dance and move like fire. Two light blue eyes peered from behind their hoods in a featureless face. Their bodies were completely smooth and genderless, and they glided toward him with a fluid grace.

There were about a dozen of them that surrounded him in a loose circle, holding their arms up to him as if beseeching him.

Shen felt a sense of peace infusing him, and his will to move forward to his final destination was sapped. He gritted his teeth and focused on the reasons he was there, pushing through the heavy blanket being laid on him.

"Please, stop. I'm doing this to help the ones I love," he said through clenched teeth.

He sheathed his sword and pushed past them, brushing off limbs being placed on him. They were gentle, and they did not try to grab him, but they followed behind him in a group, continuing to try and stop him with other means.

Suddenly, there was a crashing sound, as if a large animal was coming from behind him. Turning around, he saw a purple and blue creature bounding past the figures with a figure perched on its back.

It was Catra.

The animal stopped directly in his path, and he recognized them now; he had only seen Melog a couple of times now. He was suddenly struck by the similarities between Melog and the beings that had recently chased him.

Catra leaped off of its back and looked at the figures behind Shen with eyebrows raised. She then turned back to Melog.

"I see you've been busy," she said suggestively.

Melog let out a loud bark of pure happiness in reply as Catra turned back to Shen and crossed her arms.

"What are you doing out here, Catra?" Shen asked her.

She frowned at him. "That's funny, I was going to ask you the same thing." Catra replied, her voice flat.

"I'm just going for a nighttime walk with my new friends here, want to join us?" Shen said with a smile.

Catra was not amused. "I'm not going to play games with you, Shen. I found Double Trouble, they told me *everything*."

Shen felt a jolt spread through his body. "Everything, huh?" he asked.

She nodded. "Yeah, your whole stupid plan to go get yourself killed and your reasons why," she said with a hint of anger in her voice.

Shen chuckled. "Oh yeah? And what did that liar say those were?" Shen asked.

“That you're doing it for us, for your friends. That you were especially doing it for me. That you’re in love with me.” she said simply, staring at him with a neutral expression on her face.

“Catra, Double Trouble is a liar, we both know that! You came running out into these woods based on a lie!” Shen rolled his eyes and let out a laugh.

Catra pursed her lips and nodded. “Yeah, that's what I said... but I saw the truth when they gave me this,” she said, tossing a small object to him.

Shen caught it in his hand, but he didn’t need to look at it to know what it was. It was his locket with Catra’s brown tuft hidden inside.

His secret.

He suddenly felt the need to run overwhelm him and started looking around for an escape... but there was none, he realized; Catra was way faster than he was and would run him down.

He sighed as he put the locket in his pocket and looked back at Catra. “It’s true. I’m in love with you.” He replied, shrugging his shoulders.

Catra looked down at the ground, pawing at it with one clawed foot, a forlorn expression on her face.

“Shen... I’m sorry, but—” she started.

Shen held up his hands. “Catra, you don’t have to say it, I already know. I mean, I spend so much time with you and Adora that the answer was plain to me from the start. I tried so hard to just keep it to myself and not burden our friendship with it. If Double Trouble hadn’t figured it out, you still wouldn’t have known.”

“You didn’t have to do that, Shen. You didn’t have to keep that bottled up, you could have talked to me.” she implored.

Shen let out a bark of laughter. “Yeah, right, Catra, that would have gone over *really* well. ‘Hey Catra, remember that time we went to the Crimson Waste together? Well, while we were running for our lives from Tung Lashor... I *kinda* fell in love with you.’” Shen said sardonically.

Catra couldn’t help laughing at this. “I guess you have a point,” she said ruefully. The sadness returned to her face. “So, what now? Because I don’t want you like you want me, you want to die? Shen, I’ve been there, believe me, but it's not the right way.”

This annoyed Shen. “Please! Don’t flatter yourself, Catra. It’s not like that at all. I don’t want to die because of you.” He said angrily.

Catra looked at him imploringly. “Then what? You told Adora this wasn’t the best way and now you're doing it, why? Tell me, please.”

“Because it’s the only way to keep you safe!” he yelled. “Waiting isn’t going to work, Catra! They will keep coming until one of you is hurt or killed. I can’t bear the thought of that happening! Someone with a heart rune *has* to go to Shen'Dar-oom- that’s either me or Adora. She’s my friend and I don’t want Adora to die. I also can’t bear the thought of you losing her. I love you, Catra, totally and utterly. Your safety and happiness mean everything to me, and I would die to protect it! I would die to protect you all!” Shen cried.

Catra was completely shocked and touched by this admission and by his bone-headed altruism, even though in her mind, it was misguided. She stared at him for a moment, her eyes wide, ears down, then she regained her composure’ there was resolve on her face.

“Well, I’m here to stop you,” she stated, tail twitching.

“Why? Didn’t you just hear what I said? Do you want Adora to die?” he asked, incredulously.

“Neither of you needs to die, Shen, you idiot.” Catra shook her head. She then looked up as if imploring to the sky. “What is with the people in my life? They’re always trying to run off and sacrifice themselves. You're just as bad as Adora!”

“I’ll take that as a compliment,” Shen said with a sad smile, as he looked at her imploringly. “Catra, please... just let me go!” he said, almost begging now.

Catra’s eyes narrowed at those words. “Shen... I think you know me well enough by now to know that I kind of have a problem with letting go of people. Especially when they’re such good friends, good friends who also happen to be dummies. Yeah, that’s not going to happen.” she said, crossing her arms.

Shen suddenly felt very frustrated; Catra was in his head, in his heart, and now she was standing in front of him keeping him from what he needed to do. There was no escape from her *anywhere*.

“What gives you the right to stop me? It's my life and my choice, I have the final say in how to live it out.” Shen glared at her.

Catra gave him an annoyed look and blew a sigh out through her lips. “You sound like a child right now, Shen, a confused child who needs to be set straight,” Catra growled. She was starting to crouch, knees bent, and hands held out to either side of her.

Shen’s frustration boiled up into anger at Catra’s words, and he clenched his fists. “Oh, and you’re going to set me straight?” he menacingly, taking the knapsack off his back and throwing it to the ground. He knew he was in for a fight now.

Catra suddenly leaped at him, hands stretched to grasp him, but Shen was ready for this and he rolled away. It was Catra’s usual opening gambit when they sparred, and after countless escape attempts, Shen had the muscle memory down.

They both rolled on the ground and came to their feet, then started to circle each other. Catra stopped and looked over Shen’s shoulder with an exasperated look.

“Are you going to help me out here, or what?” she yelled.

Believing this to be one of Catra’s tricks, Shen did not turn around, but he heard a response. Shen glanced quickly behind himself when he heard Melog’s plaintive mewling, seeing Catra’s friend in a sitting position.

Catra let out a snarl and shook her head, annoyed at their response.

“What did they say?” Shen said, his curiosity getting the best of him.

“Oh, they don’t understand why we are fighting and won’t get involved,” Catra growled, and her attention turned to Shen now. “That’s fine. I don’t need their help.”

Catra’s dismissal of his fighting abilities angered Shen, and he mirrored Catra as she continued circling him. She was staring at him, like a predator stalking its prey, while walking sideways, her hands held out flat on either side, moving side to side in tune with her motion. She then tried to throw him off by reversing direction, but he matched her, move for move.

Catra leaped again. This time, she launched into a sideways spin, ending in a downward kick toward Shen’s face. Shen saw this coming and caught her foot before it could make contact with his face, shoving her back. Catra landed on her hands and cartwheeled away from him. She stood and faced him, a grin stretching across her face.

“That was really impressive! You stopped and reversed that attack like an expert!” she exclaimed.

Shen caught himself smiling back at her. “What can I say? I have an excellent teacher.” He shrugged in response.

The two friends shared a moment before remembering that they were in the middle of a fight, and they continued to circle each other.

Shen was sick of being on the defensive, but that was his only option with Catra; she was too good. The best thing to do was wait until she was tired or slipped up in her attack.

But then what, Shen? he thought to himself. *You're going to do what? Hurt her? Knock her out and leave her behind? How could you do that? How is this going to end with you getting away?*

Too late, Catra had sensed his distraction and decided to strike, this time charging him. She kicked and punched at him as he deflected and blocked the best he could. Stopping him was too important to her and she was not holding back; he felt her full ferocity.

A kick connected with his face and he stumbled back. Catra followed this up by leaping on all fours behind him, wrapping her arms around his neck in a lock. He brought up both his arms in between hers to try and stop her from choking him out, but she was far too strong. Her forearm slowly pressed into his neck, cutting off circulation as he slowly passed out.

"*Just go to sleep*." She growled; her breath hot in his ear.

Shen's vision started to fade, but he was not ready to give up. The pain of the chokehold fueled his anger. He yanked his arm out of her grip on his neck, driving his elbow back into Catra's ribs and she gave an audible "Ooof!" Reaching back and around her head, he flipped her over his shoulder, and she landed with a cry of pain on her back. She lay there for a moment, dazed.

Thinking this to another trick he hesitated, but when she sat up and turned to look at him, the hurt and anger on her face almost broke his heart.

Catra was trying to stop him from leaving, from ending his life; she was fighting him because she cared, and his response was to hurt her. He felt shame welling up inside him and his will to fight slowly left his body. He couldn't fight Catra.

She narrowed her eyes at him and rose, grimacing as she rubbed her bruised ribs.

"I can see it in your eyes, Shen. Your heart isn't in this anymore," she said evenly.

Shen shook his head. "My heart is in saving you all. It was never in fighting you Catra, it could never be," he said sadly.

Catra suddenly put all her speed into one forward lunge. "WELL, MINE IS!!!" she screamed as she swung her fist past his raised arms and connected with his face, knocking him clean out with one blow. She continued her forward momentum and caught his unconscious body, gently guiding him to the ground.

She stood, breathing heavily and looking down at Shen, shaking her head in annoyance. Melog glided over and sniffed at Shen's unconscious form, raising their head questioningly to Catra.

She looked at Melog and gently stroked the hand that struck Shen's face.

"He *really* has a hard head." She murmured to Melog.

Chapter End Notes

Illustration of Double Trouble and Catra done by @salyshlove.

The Ball at Horror Hall

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Madame Razz sat outside her cottage in an old wooden chair, enjoying the afternoon sun and watching Swift Wind do loop-de-loops in the air above her. He was chasing butterflies and would laugh joyfully when one got close enough to tickle his snout. Madame Razz chuckled to herself at his antics.

"Ahhh…silly horse…" she said to herself.

"What was that, Madame Razz?" Swift Wind shouted down happily.

"Oh, nothing, Madame Razz said nothing, just clearing her throat," she said, loudly clearing her throat to convince him.

That seemed to placate him, and he went back to his fun, but Madame Razz suddenly felt sad as she thought about Swift Wind above her. He had been living with her for a while now and she had grown quite fond of him, even though he could be annoying.

What will happen to him when I'm gone? Who will he go to? Ah, well, he will just have to go back to Adora in Bright Moon. There will be plenty of people for him to pester there. She decided to herself with a smile.

She had been feeling it lately, the feeling that her long journey would be ending soon. It was time to start it all over again.

She had done it so many times now; lived out this life so often that it had become like a recording for her, one that was ending its cycle and ready to be rewound to the beginning. She did not mind this existence; how could you ever tire of such an amazing life lived among the stars of the universe?

She looked forward to doing it again, to live the love again, see her soulmate again, to feel their touch upon a younger body. She would see all her friends and family; she would see Mara again, sweet, sweet Mara. Then there was Zarr, her sister, she looked forward to seeing her the way she was before she was corrupted.

"Razzzzz…" a voice said suddenly, in her head.

Madame Razz closed her eyes. "Yes, my sister, I hear your cries. Soon, it will be soon." She thought back.

"Razzzzzz…it's been soooo cold here…for soooo long…please…" the voice pleaded.

It was her sister, Zzar of course, her real sister before she was consumed by the Set'Heth-un'dar, crying out to her for release.

"Yes, I know my sister, I will free you, soon," Razz said, tears falling from her eyes.

Madame Razz stood, holding out her hand and summoned her broom. It would be happening soon, and she had to go.

"Swift Wind, Madame Razz is going out to pick Moon Asters. Don't wait up for her tonight!" She called up to him. She was lying to him, for she did not want him coming with her into this danger.

Swift Wind immediately landed next to her, confusion on his face. "Isn't it too early to go pick Moon Asters, Razz?" he asked.

“What do you know?” she said, gently slapping his muzzle. Then her eyes softened, and she gave him a gentle pat on his nose. “You take care of yourself, dearie, can you do that for Madame Razz?”

Swift Wind nodded emphatically. “You bet, Razz. Maybe I’ll leave some apples out for you when you get back! Have a nice time, bye!” he said, leaping back into the air to chase butterflies some more.

She laughed at this and shook her head, walking away from her cottage for the last time, on her way to her final destination.

* * *

Shen sat in a comfortable chair in the Bright Moon extension. He was once again a prisoner, awaiting his judgment.

He had awoken here this morning after Catra had deposited his unconscious body there, minus his sword of course, and with the addition of a new bruise on his face. She had instructed the guards that he was not to leave under any circumstances until she said so. There was a guard posted outside the door and the windows, but that was unnecessary; he wasn’t going anywhere.

He looked around his room. It was new, since the whole extension had been rebuilt after the battle with the Demon-Heart; now it was more of a large guest quarter than a dormitory. Glimmer had figured that with their greater influence in the galaxy, it would make sense to have a place to house any visiting dignitaries from other planets. Well… that was before they had to blockade their entire planet and cut themselves off from the greater universe.

Bow and Glimmer had come to bring him breakfast early in the morning. They mostly wanted to make sure he was alright and did not try and pry into his reasons for doing what he did, but he could see the hurt on their faces, hiding right behind their eyes.

There was one bright side for Shen. After some careful probing, he was able to figure out that neither of them had found out

about his love for Catra. At least not yet anyway; he was sure it would come out eventually, either from Catra or Double Trouble. He was sure that Double Trouble was furious with him for locking them in the kitchen, and whether or not they would retaliate by spreading his tale of secret love was anyone's guess.

They talked about the Ball at Scorpia's palace, which was that very night. The palace was being called "Horror Hall", of all things. Bow and Glimmer were excited about the whole thing and talked about the outfits they were going to wear.

"Maybe we can convince them to let you go?" Bow said, hopefully. Then he brightened "Wait, I'm the King! I can just command them to let you out!"

Glimmer gave him a look. "Yeah, you're the King and I'm the Queen but do we want to deal with an angry Catra?" she asked, dubiously.

Bow apologetically looked at Shen. "Sorry, buddy, I guess you're not going."

Shen laughed at that. "Don't worry, and I don't blame you, Bow," he said, reaching to his bruised face.

They all shared a laugh together and Glimmer said she wanted to try something new with her hair. Bow and Glimmer stood up, stating that they both wanted to enjoy some peace and quiet before the excitement tonight.

He spent the rest of the day ruminating on his situation and second guessing himself for what he tried to do last night. Seeing how much Catra fought to keep him from sacrificing himself and the hurt in Bow and Glimmer's eyes made him start to think about his reasons. *Were they right?* He didn't want to see them hurt, but how would they feel about losing him? This was something he never really stopped to consider— how the loss of his life would affect others.

He grew up mostly ignored or scorned by his father, a father that he knew could care less if he was dead and gone. His time spent with Shen'Dara and the rebels was spent constantly fighting, their lives always on the line. It was something that none of them stopped to consider. Only when they finally lost someone did it really hit them, but they mourned and moved on. It was all they could do.

Now he was with a new group of friends, ones who took more time to consider the ones around them and cherish their lives. He had completely disregarded this in his bid to protect them, and he realized he was about to do to them what he was trying to keep from happening to him. It was selfish.

But he was still conflicted by this, for he knew for certain that their choice to wait was riskier. There was a greater likelihood that more of them would be hurt instead of just him. He had to protect them, he felt it down to his core. He was born to be a protector.

He realized that he had felt this way for as long as he could remember. It was an all-encompassing need to protect not just his friends and the ones he loved, but also the ones who couldn't protect themselves; the weak and the defenseless. He felt like the whole reason he existed was to help others, which was why he kept throwing himself into these situations, not because he had a need for self-destruction.

It was near the evening when Adora finally visited him. He had been dreading this visit all day, but when he saw her as she strode into his room, he was completely blown away by the way she was dressed.

Adora entered his room wearing a full-length, flowing white, sleeveless gown with gold wing accents for straps. On the back of the gown was a white cape, two She-Ra wing symbols joined in the middle at the bottom of an open "V". Her blond hair was not in a ponytail, but lay loose, the bangs swept back away from her forehead in a more elegant version of her usual hair poof. On her

forehead, she wore a gold tiara with a red gem in the center. She was absolutely radiant.

"Wow..." Shen said when he saw her. "You really clean up good, Adora."

She smiled at this and walked over to where he was seated at a table. She did not take a seat and she stared him down with a serious look on her face.

"Flattery won't change the fact that I'm kind of, no, I'm really mad at you, Shen." she said to him, crossing her arms, practically standing over him.

He looked up at her. "Did Catra tell you everything?" he asked, trying to keep his emotions hidden.

Adora nodded. "Yes— *everything*. How you kept your plan to try and go to Shen'Dar-oom and sever the connection by yourself hidden, thinking you could save us all while sacrificing yourself. That she had to chase you down and practically knock you out and drag you back last night."

"Is that all?" he said, a hint of hope in his voice.

Adora shook her head. "No, she also said that you're in love with her and that you have been for some time," she said neutrally.

He sighed deep at this and looked down. "Adora, I don't know what to tell you, and I don't blame you for feeling betrayed by me. You saved me and I repay you by…falling in love with Catra, your soulmate," he said, completely ashamed of himself.

"Shen, look at me," Adora asked, there was a command in her voice. When he didn't, she lifted his head by his chin so that they could look into each other's eyes.

"I'm not mad about you falling in love with Catra. That's silly, how could you help something like that? How could I, of all people, blame you either?" she said with a laugh. "I'm not great with stuff

like this, but all I can say about that is that I trust you in this regard. I love you, Shen. You're my friend and I trust your friendship. I know you would never do anything to hurt me. I mean, I watched you practically fight off an army of demons to keep them from taking me." Adora said with another laugh.

Shen looked up at Adora and smiled, but that smile left him as Adora continued.

"I *am* mad at you for keeping the truth from me, however. You made me think that you had changed, that you were not the type of person who acted without thinking. I may trust you to not hurt me or anyone you care about, but my trust in you not doing something self-destructive has taken a serious hit today. You told me that going to Shen'Dar-oom was a bad plan, while you were planning to go there yourself. You were going to leave without telling any of us, never to come back! You were going to throw your life away based on a hunch that your plan would work! What's wrong with you!?" Adora was yelling at him now, hands raised in the air.

Shen started to feel angry at being berated. "Adora, I think you're being a hypocrite," he stated evenly.

Adora's face was so incredulous it was almost comical. "Wh...wh...wh...WHAT!? I'm being a hypocrite!? Maybe Catra isn't the only one whose fist you'll feel. Explain what you mean before I give you another knock to the head!" she yelled, fists clenched.

Shen was not cowed by this and stood to face his friend. "You would do the same thing as me Adora, and you know it! You would do the same thing if not for Catra and leaving her behind! You berate me for trying to save you all, when I know you would do things exactly the same if you were in my shoes!" he accused. He held his hand to his heart and the rune appeared. "Admit it! Don't lie because I know, I can feel it— we are the same, Adora! *We were both born to be heroes*!" Shen roared, shaking in fury.

Adora's anger was quelled by this and she backed down a fraction, but she was not done. "That may be so, Shen, we may both be heroes. There is a difference though. I have She-Ra to protect me, you don't. You can't run into the same situation as I can and expect the same results. That's just not the way things are. I'm not saying this to try and be cruel, I'm saying this as your friend." Adora said softly, kindness returning to her voice.

Shen was not appeased by this. "If only I had the power of She-Ra, or something similar, maybe then I could get some respect from you," he said, scornfully.

Adora was exasperated by this. "I see Catra was right. You *are* acting like a child. I have respect for you, but that doesn't mean I would let you run off and do something I know would be your end. Not to throw your own words back at you, but it's because *I am a hero* and protector that I do this."

Shen shook his head. "So, I guess we are at an impasse then, Adora. Both heroes want to protect the other, but you just happen to be stronger, so you get to make the rules." Shen growled.

Adora held the bridge of her nose and gritted her teeth. "Ugggh! Fighting with you is just as bad as fighting with Glimmer! I'm sorry, Shen, but I see I'm not going to get through to you tonight. It doesn't mean I won't keep trying though, but I have a Ball to attend tonight. We can continue this some other time." Adora clipped out.

"Fine." came Shen's terse reply.

Just as Adora was about to walk out, Shen called out to her. "Adora!" he said getting up and running to her.

She turned with a dubious look. "What?" she said in irritation.

He smiled softly at her. "I don't like ending things on a bad note, especially with people I care about, I found out the hard way there is a chance it could be the last time," he said, holding his hands out and grasping hers. "Have fun tonight. I mean it. Also...

tell Catra I'm sorry. I'm sorry she had to chase me down and drag me back to Bright Moon." He said with a chuckle.

Adora smiled back at him. "I don't think so. You can say it yourself. I'm sure she's going to come looking for answers tomorrow. Also, don't think about running off again. Catra will just track you down and it will just make her even madder to have to go through that again. She doesn't like to have to hurt the people she cares about; it hurts her deep inside and she expresses it as anger. She'll get over it eventually though. I know from LOTS of experience." Adora explained.

Shen laughed at that. "Don't worry about it, I'm not going anywhere."

* * *

Catra was in her room getting ready while Adora was off talking to Shen. Hopefully, she would be back soon because Catra was antsy to leave for Scorpia's Ball; she had been waiting so long for it, and after last night, she just wanted to have fun.

She was getting dressed in the outfit she had spent months gathering components for. Before leaving, Adora had helped her tuck her tail into the hole of her dark gray pants with the yellow stripe. Catra didn't *really* need help with this, but Adora didn't complain.

Reaching into her pant pockets, she drew out a pair of fingerless gloves with open backs and put them on, opening and closing her fingers to stretch the material out. She strode in front of the mirror and put on the orange open-breasted short sleeve shirt, buttoning it up with the single gold wing button and tucked it into her pants. Next, she sat on the bed and pulled on the knee-high boots Adora had bought for her on Thenlor. She walked around in them for a bit, wiggling her toes.

"Mmmmm…footwear…" she moaned. "Why does it have to look so good though? Hmmm…Adora was riiiiight, they *do* match the

pants!" she said, looking at them in the mirror.

Now it was time for the final piece of the ensemble. Catra pulled the white Star Force Admiral's jacket out of the dust jacket it came in and put it on, looking at herself in the mirror.

"Hmmm…maybe I should wear it differently…" she said, finger to her lips. "Oh! I know!" she cried, taking it off and draping it rakishly over one shoulder. She beamed at her reflection in the mirror, posing in different dramatic ways.

For the final touch, she ran her claws through her hair, positioning her longer bangs over her ears and her shorter ones over her forehead. Then, tying the rest up in the ponytail, she was ready.

Adora was still not back, so she decided to go see what Bow and Glimmer were up to; knowing them they would need her coaxing to get a move on. She practically skipped down the hall to their room, and seeing that the door was open, entered.

Inside, she found Bow and Glimmer fussing with each other's outfits. Bow had on black formal pants, white shoes with gold tips and a white formal shirt with a small red heart rune in the front over his chest. His midriff was exposed as per usual and on his back was a light blue sparkling cape.

He was putting a matching blue sparking cape on Glimmer as she brushed her hair while looking in a handheld mirror; it looked like she had cut her bob hairstyle even shorter than usual and Catra thought it looked good. She wore a sparkling lavender dress with gold accents on the chest and gold wristbands. On her head, she had on her usual tiara crown.

"Glimmer, did you change your hair again?!" Catra teased.

Glimmer gave her a look. "What do you mean *again*? It's been almost two years since I've changed it!" she exclaimed as she studied Catra. "You look good Catra, but how in the name of Etheria did you get your mitts on an Admiral's jacket? Does Octavia know you're impersonating an officer?" Glimmer accused.

Catra grinned. “Oh, she does. The Admiral and I are like *this*!” she said cockily, holding up two intertwined fingers. “She’s an old Horde buddy and she hooked me up.”

Glimmer smiled and went back to combing her hair, shaking her head. Bow had just finished clasping her cape on and went to the dresser, coming back with a small jewelry box. Taking out the earrings Glimmer usually wore, he placed one on his right earlobe and the other on Glimmer’s left.

“Uggghh…you guys almost done?” complained Catra.

“Patience, Catra,” Bow said, “It takes a lot of work to look good. Not everyone can just throw on a bunch of random clothes and quickly run their fingers through their hair like you obviously did.” He laughed.

Catra feigned being incensed. “A bunch of random clothes? How dare you, Punchy! It took a lot of effort to get all this stuff. Also, I didn’t just run my fingers through my hair, I put it in a ponytail too!”

Catra walked over to Bow and inspected him. “Yeah, I see it now... you did put a lot of work into looking like *this*,” she said, looking at him waving both open hands at him. “Wait, did you buff and wax this thing?” she said as she gave him a playful slap of his stomach.

“Hey!” Bow yelled. “Glimmer! Catra is being mean to me again!” Bow whined.

Glimmer stopped brushing her hair and turned to Catra, crossing her arms. “Hey Catra, remember what happened last time you messed with my Bow?” she said, mock menace in her voice.

Catra laughed at her. “Yeah, I remember, I was stuck in bed and had to take that tonic that made me dizzy. You took advantage of that and tortured me! I’d like to see you try it again!” Catra challenged.

Glimmer pursed her lips and nodded. “You know, Catra, I still have some ribbons…” she said, then teleported behind Catra, hairbrush raised. “…all you need is some brushing!”

Catra let out a high-pitched scream and ran out the door and down the hall, Glimmer in hot pursuit. Bow followed them down the hall shaking his head.

* * *

Adora had entered the room she shared with Catra to find it empty.

She’d better not be off messing around and make us late, she thought to herself, shaking her head.

Adora was still a little troubled by her conversation with Shen and walked over to the room’s waterfall to stare at her reflection. Looking at herself, she gazed into her own eyes, as if to bore deep to find the truth.

Was she too hard on him? Did she have a right to tell someone who only wants to do good and protect others that they can’t be the hero they believe themselves to be? Yes, it was right that Catra stopped Shen; his intentions were noble, but he was misguided. But when do you decide to stop the ones you care about from being the hero and when do you stop yourself from holding them back? Where was that line?

Why was she so conflicted internally about this now when she had watched her friends run off into battle before, time and time again? What was so special about her newest friend that she felt like now, all of the sudden, she had to guard him against making the wrong choice? Ever since she had met him, she felt like she had to protect him, protect him until… what?

As she stared at herself, Adora’s internal struggle was momentarily disturbed by an intense sensation of déjà vu.

“Have I done this before…?” she said out loud to herself.

She could hear a commotion in the hall; it was Catra crying out her name.

“Adora!”

Turning around, she saw Catra burst in through the door, Glimmer right behind her with a brush.

“Just let me brush it!” Glimmer pleaded.

Catra ducked from the brush. “No!” she exclaimed with a laugh, running into the room and toward Adora.

Glimmer chased Catra in circles around Adora, both women laughing.

“Don’t let her touch me! She’s going to *torture* me!” Catra pleaded to Adora.

Glimmer stopped her chase as Catra hid behind Adora, grasping Adora’s right shoulder with both hands, peeking over at Glimmer.

“Do you always have to be this dramatic?” Glimmer accused.

By then, Bow had joined them, walking into the room and shaking his head.

“Come on guys, if we’re late to Scorpia's first Ball, she’s going to kill us!” he exclaimed as he put his arm around Glimmer.

“Fine.” Glimmer conceded, putting her head against Bow. “You’re off the hook, *this time*.” She glared at Catra.

Glimmer received a stuck-out tongue and a rude noise in reply.

Bow, Glimmer and Catra started walking for the exit while Adora stood watching them, feeling confused. She still couldn’t place the feeling of déjà vu, but she felt confusion left her as Catra turned to her, holding out her hand.

“You coming?” said Catra, smiling lovingly at Adora. Adora returned the smile and reached out, grasping her hand.

“Yes, I would go with you anywhere.” She said to Catra.

Catra laughed brightly and pulled her along, wrapping her arm around Adora’s waist and guiding her out the door.

Catra glanced at Adora, worry plain on her face. “Are you okay? This is supposed to be a fun night and you look like you're distracted.”

“Oh, it was just something Shen said to me, it just struck a nerve, that’s all,” Adora replied.

Catra scowled at the mention of her friend. “Let’s not talk about him tonight. I just want to have fun and thinking of him right now just makes me angry. He is tucked away safe and sound for now, well, safe and sound until I have a chance to visit him tomorrow, that is.” She growled lowly.

Adora smiled and shook her head. *Poor Shen was really in for it,* she thought. When Catra was angry at you, the only thing to protect you was an army. Or a bunch of rebel princesses.

Bow turned back to Catra and Adora, a pleading look on his face. “Hey guys, can’t we just stop by and pick up Shen? I mean, he spent the whole day locked up and now he’s going to miss the Ball? He was just trying to help us. Does he really deserve this?”

Adora shook her head. “I’m sorry Bow, but it’s not a question of ‘deserve’, we can’t really trust him not to do something stupid right now. You kind of do stupid things when you’re in love…” Adora sighed.

Bow and Glimmer looked at each other incredulously. “Shen’s in love?” Glimmer said with a laugh. “With who?”

“Me, Glimmer. He’s in love with me.” Catra said flatly, dropping Glimmer’s nickname.

“WHAT?!” Bow exclaimed with a squeak. “Ohhh…boy…that poor guy, now I just feel worse for him.” Bow shook his head.

Catra glowered at him as Glimmer laughed. “What is it with you, Catra? Scorpia, Adora and now Shen. Is there some kind of natural attractive scent you give off?” she said, teasingly.

Catra and Adora shared a knowing look, their meeting with Panga coming to both of their minds.

“Guys, can we just drop it? Please?” Catra pleaded. Her tone was enough to silence her friends on the topic and it was dropped, for now.

Adora and Catra followed their friends down the hall, out onto the Castle grounds, and down the stairs to the shore. Waiting for them was a beautiful horse-drawn carriage, waiting to take them away to the ball.

Catra eyed it suspiciously. “I don’t know... is this going to be fast enough? Why not a speeder?” she asked warily.

Glimmer rolled her eyes at Catra, then looked at Adora. “A real romantic, this one. Geez, sorry Adora…” Glimmer said, teasing.

Adora smiled at Catra. “Oh, you don’t have to worry about me, Glimmer. Catra has *lots* of romance inside of her fuzzy heart,” she said, pulling a blushing Catra into a sideways hug. Catra grinned at Glimmer and stuck her tongue out for the second time this evening.

The four friends laughed, and each took their turn entering the carriage. Once they were all settled, the driver coaxed the six horses forward into a gentle trot, heading down the road that would lead them to the Old Fright Zone.

* * *

The seven Death Binders made their way from their hiding place in the Whispering Woods to the Crystal Castle. They had just been

given the go-ahead to prepare the way for their Lord's arrival.

They arrived at the gate Entrapta installed and stood before it, inspecting it. A choice was made, and six of the coven turned to the one and bowed to them. The one walked forward, placing their hands on the gate, as the six took thirteen steps backwards.

The one glowed with a ghostly light, which slowly grew in intensity as the one started screaming. With a blinding flash of light, the one vanished taking the gate with them, giving the six access to the Crystal Castle.

They raced down the hallway, and made their way into the main chamber, surveying the blue glow of the magical barrier surrounding the diamond-shaped portal.

Another choice was made, and four of the coven turned to two and bowed. The two turned and walked toward the barrier. They raised their hands and black beams shot forth from the ends of their fingertips, alighting on the barrier. Their hands sizzled and smoked as the barrier dissipated. When the barrier was finally gone, the black beams ceased and the two slowly evaporated like smoke, starting from their hands and consuming the rest of their bodies.

With the barrier gone, the four kneeled as the portal activated and an energy field appeared, rippling like a black pool of oil. A massive figure stepped through, and looked around, taking a deep breath.

"Hmmm…*weak*…it smells *weak* here…no wonder Mara loved it so." The Shen'Aan-war pronounced.

"Yessss massster..." one of the groveling Death Binders hissed. Behind the Shen'Aan-war, ten armored Shen'Sho-heim and six robed Death Binders entered through the portal.

"Is all ready? Is the ritual area prepared?" the Shen'Aan-war asked.

“Yessss massster, we have a location near where our enemies are now. They are momentarily distracted, you have chosen the perfect time to strike, Dark Lord, perfect…” he mewled.

The Shen’Aan-war nodded. “Let us go quietly then. We will catch them unawares,” he commanded with a malicious grin.

* * *

Shen suddenly felt it, a dark warning like when Bow and Glimmer were attacked, but there was something else too.

It was a strange feeling, one that up until he entered this universe, he had felt all his life. It was subtle, and he hadn’t noticed its absence until the sensation came back when his friends had to leave for space, then left again before they came back. It was like something was made available to him, something that he could accept into himself, only he did not yet know how to take it. It seemed like whatever the sensation was, it was alive and conscious, it wanted him to take it, but it was held back, against its will.

He had come to realize what this sensation was associated with as well; it was simple logic that it had something to do with his Father. He felt it when the Shen’Aan-war entered the universe and felt its absence when he left it, so that meant…

“Shen? Wake up! It's your turn.” Lonnie was saying to him.

Shen snapped out of it and looked at his two friends, Lonnie and Rogelio, sitting at the table with him in his “cell”. They were his guards for the evening and decided to pass the time playing a game together.

He stared at them with alarm on his face as they looked at him quizzically. Rogelio growled something at Lonnie.

“Yeah, I think you're right, Rogelio,” she said to him. “Shen, you really have to stop letting Catra hit you in the head, I think it’s giving you brain damage, buddy,” she said only half-joking.

Shen shook his head. “Guys, I don’t know how to explain it to you, but something terrible is about to happen, I have to go,” he said emphatically.

Lonnie and Rogelio looked at each other and then back at him. “What? No way! We are your guards, remember? General Juliet AND Catra would have our hides if we let you go!” Lonnie said.

“Catra is the one that is in trouble. So is Bow, Glimmer and everyone at the Ball at Horror Hall! My Father is here, Lonnie, the Shen’Aan-war! He is after them and he is going to hurt them! I can feel it!” Shen said, complete panic in his voice now.

Rogelio growled something at Lonnie, and she let out a breath. “Okay, for some reason Rogelio believes you, Shen, and he is a good judge of character. We will cover for you. Go down to the motor pool and take one of the speeders; it will get you to the Old Fright Zone faster. Go there and check it out. If it’s nothing, you get your butt back here before shift change. You promise?” she said, holding her hand out.

He grinned at her and took her hand. “I promise,” he said, then turned and ran out the door.

* * *

Adora, Catra, Bow and Glimmer had just entered Horror Hall, and were blown away by its transformation. Where once there was just a cavernous stone hall filled with murals, now it was a magical dreamland.

* GOTHIC WALTZ NO. 1 *

Billowing, sparkling white and pink drapes had been hung along the walls. They covered the murals, creating a softer and more comfortable environment. Below each drape, there was a soft purple or pink light shining up, alternating between dim and lit up. A large purple carpet had been laid on the stone floor, emblazoned with the symbol of Scorpia’s family in pink sparkles. Above it hung a magnificent crystal chandelier which slowly spun

between bright lights, creating a beautiful strobe light effect on the floor.

At the back of the hall, a temporary stage had been built where the throne sat, complete with black velvet curtains that were currently closed. Below the stage, there was a band with various classical string and wind instruments, with a few electronic ones mixed in. They were currently playing a song that relied on heavy percussion, rhythmic bass lines and an electronic string instrument providing jangly distortions. The music instilled a feeling of bittersweet love and dark beauty; it was perfect for the setting of Horror Hall.

"Wow!" Catra exclaimed with excitement, giving her white and gold jacket to the coat attendant.

The dance floor was currently full of couples, dancing and twirling about, and they recognized their friends among them.

There were Mermista and Sea Hawk; Mermista was wearing a gown of glittering emerald scales while Sea Hawk appeared to be wearing a large, red velvet frock coat complete with black vine embroidery on the lapels and a white frilly shirt under the coat. He also appeared to be behaving himself and Mermista was beaming up at him; two rarities in one package.

There were Spinnerella and Netossa, both wearing sparkling gowns. Spinnerella in a purple gown was currently leading Netossa in a blue gown.

There were others, all paired up and happy. Adora, Catra, Glimmer and Bow were eager to join them.

Before they could get to the dance floor, Scorpia leaped up on the stage with a microphone and a spotlight shone on her. She was wearing a blood-red, evening gown encrusted with gems, with black downy feathers on the shoulders and black lace along the neckline. Her white hair was completely spiked up and she had on heavy black eyeliner and lipstick.

“Hello, hey! Well, welcome to *Horror Hall*!” she said, emphasizing the name with dread. “Just kidding! Ha! Ha! Well, I’m sure you all know, I’m Princess Scorpia and I’m here to welcome you to my first Ball!”

This was met with loud cheers from the guests and an eye roll from Catra.

“Don’t think I didn’t see that, Catra!” Scorpia called jovially, pointing a claw to her friend. “You owe me a dance now, Wildcat, and don’t think I’ll forget! Anyway, there is only one rule tonight: have fun! Toward the end of the night there will be a performance by yours truly, so don’t go running off!”

There were more cheers as Scorpia leaped off the stage into Perfuma’s waiting arms, and the band commenced with the first waltz of the night.

Catra grabbed Adora’s hand and they ran to the dance floor, a look of ecstatic joy on both their faces. Bow and Glimmer were not far behind, moving toward the dance floor at a more dignified pace, joy written on their faces as well. They were all looking forward to a wonderful night of magic and fun.

* * *

* GOTHIC WALTZ NO. 7 *

Later, on the seventh and last waltz of the night, Catra and Adora were still going strong, although both were sweating profusely from all the dancing. Catra had completely unbuttoned her orange shirt to cool off, revealing a black bra underneath, which earned a raised eyebrow from Glimmer.

“Oh, don’t be a prude! Let it all hang out, Sparkles!” Catra yelled to her friend. “I mean, Bow gets to show his midriff all the time, it’s my turn!”

Glimmer had to concede to this logic and shrugged her shoulders to her friend.

Adora, emboldened by Catra' risqué, started revealing just how far her gown's slit went; waist-high. She twirled, then shook her hips side to side.

Glimmer gasped at this. "Adora! That's a queen's gown! Did you alter it?" she accused.

Adora, grinned back in reply as she and Catra performed a synchronized dance, stepping side by side and lifting their arms up as one.

Bow and Glimmer, who had been close by all night, mirrored their friend's dance move for move, then grasping hands, led each other into an intimate slow dance.

Adora laughed as Catra came up behind her and started leading her in a slow dance of their own. Adora was beaming as Catra's face nuzzled into the back of her head and she reached back to hold Catra's head, closing her own eyes.

"I love you so much, Adora," Catra murmured into the back of her head.

"Mmmm…" Adora replied.

"I want to ask you something, Adora, something important…" Catra whispered, now in her ear.

"Uhh hmmm?" Adora said, enjoying the feel of Catra's body against her back.

Catra gently spun Adora around and into a dip, gazing down at her with love.

"Will you take the Vow with me, Adora?" Catra asked.

It was a good thing that Catra was holding her so tightly, for Adora was so surprised that she had loosened her grip. Catra lifted her out of the dip and now faced her, allowing Adora to take the lead.


Ansdrela

Adora beamed back at Catra, tears in her eyes. “Yes! Yes, I will Catra!” she said, reaching out to hold Catra by the face, pulling her in for a kiss.

As this was happening, the band was wrapping up their waltz, and the partners were separating to view the final performance of the night.

Bow and Glimmer joined their friends with looks of concern, as both Catra and Adora had tears in their eyes.

“Uh, you guys alright?” Bow asked.

Adora laughed. “Looks like you two are going to have to return the favor to us. You’re going to have to be our Vow Paranymphs!” Adora said, gazing into Catra’s eyes.

Glimmer squealed with delight, clapping her hands and leaping on Adora as Bow wrapped Catra up in a hug of joy. Catra returned the hug, grinning at Adora.

Just then, the announcer came over the sound system with an audible “Ahem!” and the friends turned toward the stage.

“Everyone... may I introduce tonight’s diva for a special performance, none other than the Princess of Horror Hall herself... Scorpia!”

Everyone clapped as the curtain was raised, but the clapping quickly ceased and turned to cries of horror as they saw what lay behind.

Scorpia was bound and on her knees, head down with a huge sword at her throat. Holding the sword was none other than the Shen’Aan-war with his ensemble of Shen’Sho-heim and Death-Binders behind him. He leered at the assembled guests with cruel intent.

“Greetings from Shen’Dar-oom.” He said in a low rumble. “Look upon the face of the master of this universe, for he has returned!”

Chapter End Notes

Illustration of Catra and Adora by @Ansdrela.

I Have the Power

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora struggled at her bonds, four rings of ghostly light surrounding her legs and arms that held her firm in a standing position. She could not move. On both sides of her were her friends standing single-file; Glimmer and all of the Princesses. The rest of the Ball guests, including Bow, were currently in a group behind them, being watched by one of the massive black armored monsters and one of the horrible sorcerers.

Catra was right beside her, struggling and growling at her binds as well; she knew Catra hated being restricted and that she must be furious right now. She had her white and gold jacket on that she managed to snag as they were herded out of Horror Hall. Catra had tried to give it to her for warmth in the cool night, but Adora had refused.

"Catra, stop struggling. You're just wasting your energy, please." Adora begged.

Catra sagged in her bindings and moaned. "Oh Adora, how come we keep getting into these messes?"

Adora smiled weakly in response. "I don't have an answer to that Catra, but what I do know is that we are going to get out of this," she said sincerely.

Catra returned the smile. “Please, let me in on it when you know how that’s going to happen.”

Adora looked at her surroundings. They were not far from Horror Hall and still in the Old Fright Zone, close to the field of flowers outside of the Whispering Woods. It was late at night; the sky was clear of clouds or any celestial bodies, and the stars shone down on them. They appeared to be in an old arena of some kind; it was composed of stone and horseshoe-shaped, with Adora and her friends being held at the open part of the horseshoe. Ten tiers rose from the bare dirt ground in the center of the arena; these were seats back when it was a place to gather. On the opposite end from her, at the top of the tiers, were a series of stairs that continued up to a flat podium.

Standing in the center of the area was the Shen’Aan-war, his Death Binders, and his Elite guard. Adora watched as the Death Binders formed a circle and the Shen’Aan-war walked into the middle, slamming his immense sword into the ground, point-first. He walked out of the circle and toward his bound prisoners as the Death Binders behind him began chanting.

He was grinning malevolently at them all as he neared, and Adora was once again struck by his cruel appearance. From his wicked barbed crown down to his armored shoulders, clawed gauntlets and overly muscular form, he was the very image of everything she stood against. His face was the worst though, blunt and malicious, and he was leering at her now.

“My, my, you are even more beautiful than the last time I saw you,” he stated, cupping Adora’s face with his clawed gauntlet.

Adora spit at him, landing on his bare chest, and he clutched her by the throat.

“You leave her alone, you BASTARD!” Catra screamed.

He started squeezing Adora’s neck, choking her; she gasped.

“I’M GONNA RIP YOUR HEART OUT WITH MY CLAWS!!” Catra continued, completely incandescent in her fury.

“Stop, you fool, you will kill her and spoil our plans!” the Set’Heth-un’dar said in his mind.

The Shen’Aan-war hissed and released Adora, now setting his attention on Catra.

“My, you are quite the furious thing, aren’t you? Perhaps after I kill She-Ra, I will make you a pet. Would you like that, creature?” he said, grinning at Catra.

Spitting and hissing were all he received in reply.

He gazed at the rest of his prisoners.

“You all will be honored tonight, for you will bear witness to the arrival of the Set'Heth-un'dar! This universe has had to wait long for its arrival, you should all be overjoyed! Etheria will become the center of the universe, for the Set’Heth-un’dar’s home will be here and its light will shine as a beacon for all to see!” he said with conviction.

Adora had recovered by now and scowled at him. “How are you going to achieve that? By talking us to death?” She snapped.

Adora did not receive anger; this time, the Shen’Aan-war gazed upon her with hungry malice.

“No, not that way, it will be *this* way,” he said quietly as he cupped his claws around his mouth, breathing in.

A line of smoky ethereal light came forth from Adora’s chest and her heart rune lit up. It shot forth into the Shen’Aan-war’s mouth. Holding out his hand, the line continued from his palm toward the sword, alighting on it like a tether. The Shen’Aan-war held out both hands now, grasping both ends of the tether and pushed it out of himself as he stood back; it was now a straight line from Adora’s chest to the sword.

Adora gasped as she felt some of her life drain out of her and her vision began to fade.

"Adora!" Catra cried, tears trailing down her cheeks. Her anger had left and she was giving into despair at the thought of losing Adora.

The Shen'Aan-war turned from them and strode toward the sword. As he passed, it suddenly blazed with a ghostly light, which spread outwards into a solid beam that shot toward the sky. The Shen'Aan-war walked up the tiers, then up the stairs to the flat podium. He looked up at the sky, where the beam struck a spot out in space just outside of Etheria. He watched as a shape began to form, a huge round shape that shone with a terrible light.

The Set'Heth-un'dar was coming.

"Yesssss…yessss…my love, join me in this weak universe," he whispered lovingly up at it and he raised his claws to the sky, opening and closing them as if to grasp the object of his desires.

Next to the slowly appearing Set'Heth-un'dar, there was another shape forming. It was Shen'Dar-oom, or Eternia as it was once known, come back to its universe after so long away.

"Yesss…my home…it will be my seat of power…" he exclaimed. He was so close now, so close to achieving all of his dreams of being the ultimate ruler of all, to control the lives of countless trillions.

Suddenly, there was a cry, loud and clear which broke him from his thoughts.

"SHEN'AAN-WAR!!!!"

The Shen'Aan-war turned at the call of his name and saw a figure standing next to the line of prisoners. It was a young man, his long, shaggy black hair hanging loose and wild around his face. He wore a white shirt and dark gray pants, shin-high black boots on his feet.

“Is that you, Shen'Thran-zanmar'eth? Is that you, my son?” the Shen’Aan-war called, his voice clear and strong from the podium.

“I’M NOT YOUR SON!” Shen screamed back, just as clear.

“Shen…” Adora moaned. “Get out of here…before it's too late… they will kill you…GO!” she pleaded.

Shen shook his head and grimaced at her. “*No*,” he said firmly.

The Shen’Aan-war walked a few paces down the stairs and stopped. “My son, I am glad you have joined me. I have been waiting for you, you know? You're just in time!” He said in a friendly tone, something Shen had rarely heard.

The Shen’Aan-war gestured to one of the Shen’Sho-heim, who calmly strode over to Shen and offered him a blade. Shen took the huge weapon in both hands and gazed at the elite guard, thinking of using it on them.

“This is your chance to retake your place as Prince at my side, my son. I will even allow the rest of these prisoners to live, under your rule of course. You just have to do one thing for me.” he said evenly.

“Yeah, what’s that?” Shen said, dubiously.

“You must kill the She-Ra. Use the blade and drive it into her heart, you must do it now!” the Shen’Aan-war commanded.

Shen held the blade in his hands and gazed down at its black mirror surface. He could see his face gazing back at him, reflected by the ghostly light. He saw a resolve in his own eyes— the will to never give in, to always protect, to find the way to fight, to live. He looked at Adora, his friend, laying limp in her bonds; the thought of ever hurting her was simply inconceivable. He threw the sword down.

“*No*,” he said again.

The Shen'Aan-war nodded his head and smiled. "I must sweeten the pot then? So be it. I know what you desire, my son, I can feel it, for my blood is in your veins."

"There is nothing you have that I want, you monster," Shen said, anger in his voice.

"Oh no? You do not desire this female, Catra, as your own? I can give her to you, you know. With the power of the Set'Heth-un'dar, I can make her forget her love for She-Ra, take it all away. I can make her love you. Wouldn't that be nice, my son? All you have to do is kill She-Ra and she is yours." the Shen'Aan-war said soothingly.

Shen felt an ice-cold dagger in his chest as he turned from the Shen'Aan-war to look at Catra. She was looking at him fearfully, her eyes wide and ears down. Suddenly, as if by magic, her fear vanished, and her ears perked up and her eyes became calm.

The dagger drove deeper. He was losing her, his father was erasing her, erasing the person he fell so deeply in love with. The ice in his heart exploded from fury into rage. He turned back to the object of his lifelong torment, his Father.

"*NOOOOOOO!!!!*" he screamed, bolting forward in a run.

Shen ran madly, but not blindly; he had a target in mind and nothing would stop him.

"STOP HIM, YOU FOOLS!" the Shen'Aan-war screamed.

The Death-Binders turned from their chanting and shot bolts of death magic at him, while Shen dodged and weaved through them. One glanced off his shoulder, and he screamed but continued forward, the pain only fueling his rage. A Shen'Sho-heim stood in his path and tried to bisect him with a sword, but Shen simply ducked and rolled under the giants' legs, using everything that Catra had taught him.

He was close now, barging past a Death-Binder, knocking them into the others as he ran straight into the ghostly beam of power. He pushed through the swirling energy, screaming as it burned him, and grasped the sword embedded in the ground by the hilt.

"RRRRRRAAAAAGGGHHHH!!!" he screamed as he pulled at it with all his strength.

"NO, YOU FOOL! YOU WILL—" the Shen'Aan-war screamed.

But it was too late. With one last tug, Shen pulled the sword free and the beam of light exploded outward, blowing everyone back. The release of the energy also broke the bindings holding the prisoners and they all fell to the ground.

Catra ran to Adora and helped her into a kneeling position.

"Adora! Are you okay?" Catra asked, holding Adora's face.

"Wha…what happened?" Adora asked.

Catra looked over to where the beam of light once stood. She saw Death-Binders and Shen'Sho-heim picking themselves up in a loose circle. In the middle of their circle, where the sword once was embedded, a body lay blackened and smoking, the sword lying nearby.

"Shen!" Catra screamed, tears in her eyes.

As if hearing his name, the smoking ruin of Shen slowly rose, groaning through scorched lips. As Adora and Catra watched, Shen stood, slowly trying to raise the sword. Using two hands, he managed to lift it, up, up, over his head. Then, heaving air into his lungs, he screamed out the words that had not been spoken with true intent in this universe for over a thousand years.

"*BY THE POWER OF GRAYSKULL!!!!*" he screamed.

* SHEN ASCENDS *

Electric power, like lightning, poured forth from the sword and enveloped him. It infused his scorched body, healing his wounds, and he seemed to slightly grow in size. He then held the sword out sideways, gripping it by the pommel and near the tip with his hands.

"I HAVE THE POWER!!!!" Shen finished, and his voice echoed and rang through the arena.

As this was happening, the Shen'Aan-war stumbled momentarily, holding his head in one clawed gauntlet. He had just felt some of his He-Man power leave him, but not all of it. His son had just managed to steal some of his power using that blasted sword. It was no matter, as he still had the majority of He-Man's power, plus the power of the Set'Heth-un'dar. He straightened himself back up.

"Kill him, kill the Outcast!" he yelled to his elite guard and Death-Binders. They turned on Shen, the Shen'Sho-heim raising their weapons and the Death-Binders raising their hands to strike him down.

Shen wasn't interested in fighting his father's minions though, and rushed past them, slicing a Death-Binder in two when they got in his way.

He was going to face his father.

* * *

Adora rose up, summoning She-Ra as she ran to help Shen, Catra right behind her. They ran into the arena to battle with the Shen'Aan-war's minions.

"You guys, help Adora and Catra, I'm going to free the rest of the prisoners!" Glimmer yelled to the princesses.

Glimmer sped in the opposite direction as her friends, toward the group being guarded. The Death-Binder guarding them held their hands up, preparing to blast her with magic when she teleported

behind them, then teleported them in a different position; they ended up blasting the Shen'Sho-heim into dust.

Believing that her enemy could not be fooled twice, Glimmer teleported the Death-Binder high into the air and released it, teleporting herself back down to the ground.

With the guards taken care of, Glimmer ran up to Bow; they embraced in a kiss while the Death-Binder hit the ground nearby and instantly vaporized into a cloud of ghostly essence.

Bow and Glimmer parted, still gazing into each other's eyes.

"Bow, you don't have a weapon. I need you to get these people out of here. Can you do that?" Glimmer asked.

Bow nodded. "Yes." He said, then pulled her back into another kiss as she tried to leave. "Be careful, please," he said as they parted.

"Hey, it's me." Glimmer replied with a grin, teleporting away.

* * *

The princesses had fully engaged the Shen'Aan-war's forces in the center of the arena; they were evenly matched.

An old hand at finding water in the Old Fright Zone, Mermista summoned sewage from the few pipes that were nearby while Frosta froze them, sending them toward the Death-Binders as sharp missiles.

Netossa and Spinnerella worked in tandem. Spinnerella held a Shen'Sho-heim in place with a tornado while Netossa surrounded them with a net which she slowly shrunk, crushing the giant.

The old Horde buddies, Entrapta and Scorpia, stuck by each other in the midst of the battle. Scorpia blasted enemies with crimson beams or crushed them with her claws while Entrapta tripped them up with her prehensile ponytails.

Fighting among them were She-Ra/Adora and Catra, fighting desperately to reach Shen's side. He had reached the Shen'Aan-war and engaged him, and they watched as Shen was struck down and rolled down the stairs. Shen immediately rose with a roar and proceeded to climb the stairs again to come to grips with his Father.

She-Ra/Adora grasped Catra by the shoulders. "Catra, I need to do this alone. Please stay out of this. Go help our friends," she begged.

Catra turned to her, gritting her teeth with a wild look in her eyes. "No! I need to be there with you!" she cried.

She-Ra/Adora shook her head. "No, please, Catra, I've got this. Trust me," she said calmly.

The look Catra saw in She-Ra/Adora's eyes convinced her and Catra blew out her breath. "Fine. You better be careful. I love you, Adora." she said, gazing into She-Ra/Adora's eyes.

She-Ra/Adora grinned at her. "I know," she replied with a smile, then turned to run up the tiers and toward the stairs.

* * *

Shen was hammering at the Shen'Aan-war with alternating strikes of the ancient Sword of Power while his enemy deflected them with his clawed gauntlets.

"What is the matter with you?" the Shen'Aan-war growled at him. "I offered you your '*Love*' why did you not take it? Even if she was not in love with She-Ra, she still would not want to be with you and you know it! What do you fight for then?" The Shen'Aan-war taunted.

Shen was red with fury as he swung at his father. "Love. I fight for love. I fight for a love that will never be reciprocated, and it never need be, that is all. I don't expect a monster like you to understand." Shen replied, gritting his teeth in anger.

“Inconceivable!” The Shen’Aan-war responded, incredulously. He swung his claw down in a hammering blow that struck Shen back down the stairs; he tumbled and came to a rest at the bottom. Shen rose with a roar, quickly and ran back up the stairs, his face screwed up in hatred.

“You may have stolen some of my power, *boy*, but you cannot defeat me. You are alone, alone with your *love*.” The Shen’Aan-war spit, saying the last word with scorn.

“He’s not alone.” A voice called up.

She-Ra/Adora strode up the stairs with her sword in a guard position, gazing up at the Shen’Aan-war. She came to rest next to Shen and placed a hand on his shoulder.

“Hey, hero,” she grinned. “We do this together, right?”

Shen nodded back to her and they strode up the stairs together, unified against their enemy.


IRIA ABELLA

* * *

Glimmer teleported around her enemies, blasting them with her elemental power. It was not as powerful as when she had Razz's staff, but it seemed to be doing the trick. They were slowly thinning the enemy's ranks and soon they would be triumphant.

She turned just in time to see Catra pounce on a Death-Binder, tearing the poor fool to shreds with her claws. They evaporated into ghostly mist right in Catra's face and she hissed in fury.

Geez, Catra. You're not messing around tonight, she thought grimly to herself.

There was a low, drowning howl emanating from above that seemed to resonate down to her very bones. It was so loud that she had to cover her ears.

She looked up to see that the Set'Heth-un'dar was fading away, going back to its nightmare dimension.

"Good riddance." She said up to it.

As soon as she said this, a beam of pure darkness shot forth from its center and struck the ground where the sword originally stood. A Shen'Sho-heim was caught in its energy and disintegrated as it swirled and spun like a tornado, grasping at the ground. The Set'Heth-un'dar increased in its intensity as it pulled itself back into their reality. It was using Etheria itself as an anchor to pull itself all the way through... and from the way the ground was crumbling, it was consuming the planet in the process.

"Glimmer, what's happening?" Catra yelled, coming to her side.

Glimmer looked at her with horror. "What is happening is Etheria is going to be torn apart unless we do something!"

Catra held her arms out to the side. "And that would be?" she asked.

Glimmer was about to respond when a hand clutched at her shoulder. Turning around, Glimmer found two bespectacled eyes beaming into hers.

"Hello, dearie." Madame Razz greeted.

* * *

She-Ra/Adora and Shen attacked the Shen'Aan-war as one, diving at him simultaneously with their swords. Try as they might though, they could not land a blow; there was either a clawed gauntlet to block the blow or he managed to dodge it. He was so huge and muscular, but also fast, as fast as Catra or faster; he was unnatural in his power.

Shen was getting frustrated and dove into a frenzy, breaking out of his tandem attack with She-Ra/Adora and driving at his Father alone.

She-Ra/Adora watched him. Shen was like a madman, attacking without thought for defense. She suddenly remembered when she was first empowered by She-Ra, and her struggle to control the power, how it was hard to control when your emotions took over. She could see it in Shen now; he was completely lost to his emotions, his rage and pain were controlling him. It seemed to be effective for she watched as he sliced a piece of the Shen'Aan-war's armored shoulder plate clean off, gouging him deeply in the process.

"GAAAAHHH!!" the Shen'Aan-war screamed, throwing a fist into Shen's face and knocking him clean past She-Ra/Adora.

She-Ra/Adora's eyes did not leave her enemy and she watched as the injury to his shoulder healed itself, leaving no mark behind.

She-Ra/Adora decided to try a new tactic. Summoning her other powers, she shot a beam of energy from her sword hilt toward her nemesis. The Shen'Aan-war held out a hand, palm out, and absorbed the blast. He grinned back at her. She then summoned the light whip from her sword tip and lashed him with it. He

grabbed the whip before it could land on him and somehow held it fast. He gave her a little tug toward him, almost playfully, then charged the light whip with his power and her sword exploded in her hand.

She-Ra/Adora screamed as she was driven on her back next to Shen, who was starting to rise. The Shen'Aan-war leaped down at them, and before either could fully rise, he grabbed them both by the necks and lifted them above his head, into the air. His hands lit with dread light and both She-Ra/Adora and Shen screamed as they felt their life being sucked out of them.

* * *

"Madame Razz, what are you doing here?" Glimmer asked, incredulously.

"I'm here to end this, and to help someone dear to me." Madame Razz said simply.

Glimmer looked at her mentor and saw the lucidity in her eyes, it was one of those moments that the old woman seemed more present in the now. It was reassuring for Glimmer, who smiled at Madame Razz.

"How do we stop this?" Glimmer asked simply.

"You don't. I do." was Razz's reply. She closed her eyes and transformed before Glimmer and Catra's very eyes into the strange tall being with faceted skin, galaxies for eyes and wearing the robe made of stars. In her hand was the black star-topped staff, which she now held out to Glimmer.

"Take this. It's yours now, my child." Madame Razz stated. Her voice now had a strange resonance to it, as if it were out of sync with itself.

Glimmer took the proffered staff and watched as Madame Razz removed her robe, revealing her form beneath. She was completely faceted, like a gem with a feminine shape. She

glittered in the light of battle and handed the robe to Glimmer as well.

"You are the keeper of the Star Stone now, Glimmer. Guard it well. Find the others, if you can. They are waiting out there, waiting to be reunited with the Star Stone. Good luck my child and farewell, I will see you again…" Madame Razz said as she turned and walked into the beam of dark energy.

The bottom of the beam suddenly exploded into a bright light, opposing the dark; it seared the eyes and Glimmer and Catra had to turn away from it. The light pulsed, three times, then started to move up the beam of darkness, consuming it. It gained speed as it rose higher and higher into the sky until it was speeding at full velocity toward its target. It slammed into the Set'Heth-un'dar and there was a terrible scream of agony and hate that intensified as it shrunk slowly into the center of the beam of light.

With a final scream that echoed down around them, the Set'Heth-un'dar was gone.

* * *

She-Ra/Adora could feel her life being sucked out of her; the Shen'Aan-war was too strong. She was going to die, and she suddenly thought of Catra; Catra who she just promised to take the Vow with. She would be absolutely devastated at Adora's death. Adora had fought so hard for her and Catra's love to survive to lose it all now, to this monster of a man, of all things.

She sensed Shen still fighting against his encroaching doom, his fury was still driving him, and his will to live was strong, she could sense it now. He had no way to break free and the Sword of Power was on the ground, out of his reach.

But hers wasn't.

Holding out her hand, She-Ra/Adora summoned her sword from thin air and with a scream of pure fury, she chopped the arm choking her off at the forearm.

The Shen'Aan-war screamed, dropping Shen as he cradled his injured stump, and stumbled back. He withdrew his hand, and before She-Ra/Adora's very eyes, a new arm and hand formed in its place, although without its armor or clawed gauntlet. The Shen'Aan-war grinned back at her.

Seeing an opportunity, Shen picked up the ancient Sword of Power, and with a deep scream of pain and anger, he ran at his Father. The Shen'Aan-war saw him coming and swiped downward at his son with his clawed hand, but Shen ducked and rolled. He came up under the Shen'Aan-war's hunched body and thrust the Sword of Power through his chest.

"DIEEEE!!!!" Shen screamed in his Father's stricken face, leaving the sword embedded in his chest as he shoved him backward.

The Shen'Aan-war stumbled, holding the sword with one hand, confusion on his face. Then the look changed to anger and he started pulling at the sword.

"It was a mistake giving this back to me boy." He said, evenly, slowly pulling the sword out and holding it up with his bare hand.

"NO!" Shen said, running forward to stop him.

The Shen'Aan-war seized him by the throat with his clawed gauntlet, but instead of draining his son of life, this time he was simply going to tear his throat out. He dug his claws in, piercing through the toughened skin of Shen's new form.

"Gaaaaggggghhh…." Shen choked.

She-Ra/Adora was just about to intercede when there was a flash of light behind her. The Shen'Aan-war suddenly released Shen and looked up to the sky, horror on his face.

She-Ra/Adora turned just in time to see the Set'Heth-un'dar implode with a scream. The Shen'Aan-war screamed in unison behind her, and he dropped the Sword of Power.

Turning back, she watched as the Shen'Aan-war stood with his hands held out to either side of him, looking up, eyes wide as a large plume of ghostly vapor rose from his body and disappeared.

The Shen'Aan-war groaned as he shrunk slightly, his armor sloughing off his smaller body. He hunched over, then fell to his hands and knees. When he rose again, he was no longer the mighty Shen'Aan-war, but a very, very old He-Man. He looked at them, confused.

"RAAAGGGGGHHHHHH!!!" Shen screamed. Rushing forward, he picked up the sword and impaled his Father again, pushing him back with all his might. He-Man fell backwards, onto the ground, the tip of the ancient Sword of Power snapping off from the impact. The sound of its undoing was like the breaking of glass.

Shen kneeled over his Father, still holding the Sword of Power's hilt, panting and gazing down into his enemy's face, searching for a reaction. The one he received was not the one he expected.

He-Man, Adam, gazed back at him with a kind smile, and he reached out, grasping Shen's hands with his own, over the Sword of Power's hilt.

"Th—Thank you…my son…" he said.

He-Man, Adam, then let out a long, peaceful sigh as his head fell back and his eyes glazed over. He was gone.

Shen gazed down at the body of his Father, the Father he had just killed. There was a haunted look in his eyes.

"Adora!" a voice called behind them.

She-Ra/Adora turned to see Catra, Glimmer, and the princesses running up the stairs to meet them, joy on their faces.

Her attention was brought back to Shen as a bright, powerful light started emanating from He-Man's body; it was like white electricity boiling over his form. The body of He-Man, Adam,

slowly dissolved into the power, and then suddenly, it shot into Shen. He leaped up into the air, arms outstretched, his eyes rolled back and mouth agape. The power then power faded, and he fell to the ground.

She-Ra/Adora was momentarily distracted from this scene as Catra and Glimmer seized her in a hug from both sides, both yelling at her in joy.

"We did it!" Catra cried.

"Score *another* one for the good guys!" Glimmer yelled.

"Hey, guys…wait…something just happened…" She-Ra/Adora started to say but was interrupted by a sound coming from Shen.

It was a low, low moan coming up from deep inside, as if the monster in the water from her nightmares was rising to the surface. They watched in horror as Shen transformed; he became larger and dark short fur appeared all over his body. Claws appeared from his lengthening fingers and his hair became longer, bushier. They could see his ears had reshaped themselves as well, they were now longer and fluted, covered in fur as well.

Shen crouched before them after the transformation was complete, holding his hands over his face. When he moved them away, they saw that his eyes were slitted and glowing with white, electric power. He turned his head back and howled up to the sky, a sky which was now slowly covered with clouds. The atmospheric disturbance caused by the Set'Heth-un'dar's appearance and destruction was causing a storm to form.

Everyone had to cover their ears for not only was the howl loud and piercing, it was also immensely sad, and it was all they could do not to be driven to weeping.

Shen finished his cry of pain, then moving to all fours, he bounded off the platform and across the field of flowers, toward the Whimpering Woods.

“What was that?” Glimmered said, horrified. “Was that the Demon-Heart again?”

She-Ra/Adora shook her head. “No, it was just Shen. He just received a…power…and he cannot control it. He is too driven by emotions right now. All I know is that we have to find him and help him through it.”

As she said this, She-Ra/Adora turned to see Catra hopping up and down on one foot as she removed her boots.

“Catra, what do you think you're doing?” she asked.

Catra held her hands up, exasperated. “It looks like I have to chase him down, *again*! I’m the only one fast enough!”

“Catra, he may be dangerous. We should just go together.” She-Ra/Adora said, trying to reason with Catra.

Catra shook her head. “Shen won’t hurt me, no matter what he just transformed into. It's my turn now, Adora, I’m going.”

Entrapta walked up to Catra and held out a device to her.

“Take this, Catra, I will track you with it. I just sent a signal out to Darla to come pick us up. We will meet you there.” Entrapta said, offering Catra a small blinking disk, which she took and put it in her pocket.

She-Ra/Adora gave in. “Okay, find him and help him, Catra. Be safe, and I love you.”

Catra turned and grinned back at her. “I know,” she said, going to all fours and leaping into the night.

* * *

Shen stumbled into the shallow creek as the power suddenly left him, leaving him barefoot and wearing only pants; they were torn

and burned from driving himself into the dark energy for the Sword of Power.

The water was so cold on his feet, but it was nothing in comparison to the cold pain in his heart. Pain, pain, pain, sorrow, sorrow, sorrow, it was so deep and all-consuming. *Why did he feel like this?* He had just saved his friends, he had just saved Catra, whom he loved, he had just…*why did he hurt?*

He stumbled out of the creek bed as lightning flashed above. He sensed something was hunting him, again, but he did not care. He was so miserable right now that he would just let anything take him right now. But it was cold, and he just wanted to find a dark place, a place he could just lay in and disappear…

There it was... a cave, a nice dark cave. He stumbled in, weak from hosting such awesome and terrible power in his body. He went deep into the cave until he found a flat rock which he lay upon, wrapping his arms around his body and drawing his legs up into a fetal position.

He lay there, listening to the drip, drip, dripping of the moisture falling from the roof down to the cave floor and onto his body and he started to shiver slightly. Then he heard it, a soft sound as something entered the cave after him, moving on quiet feet.

He sensed it come up behind him and onto the flat rock, and then suddenly, something was placed over his upper body. It was a white and gold jacket, still warm from the body of its owner. He turned his head to see eyes peering down at him, one yellow and one blue, shining in the darkness.

"Catra?" Shen asked.

"Yes, I'm here," she said, looking down at him.

Shen smiled. "How do you keep finding me?" he asked.

Catra grinned and tapped her nose, scrunching it up. "You stink, that's how," she laughed. "I also have some experience with

seeking comfort in the dark, I'm kind of an expert, actually…"

Shen laughed, then his face fell, and he turned his head away from her.

"Catra, I don't know…why I feel this way…I *hated* him *soooo* much…but why do I feel so sad about it?" he said, tears in his eyes. "Why do I cry, now that I've killed him?

Shen felt her hand slide under his arm and touch his chest, alighting the heart rune.

"Because…you have a tender heart, *like me*," she said, kindly. "I also thought I hated Shadow Weaver, but I didn't, I *couldn't*. I realize now that I may be physically strong but I'm also emotionally sensitive. I have a lot of love inside of me. Even though she was cruel to me, I still loved Shadow Weaver, and in the end, when she sacrificed her life for mine, I found out that she loved me too. *She saved me*. You have a lot of love inside you too, Shen, and you never really hated your Father. In the end, *you saved him* from the monster that he had become."

Shen smiled at this, but a thought suddenly came to him and he turned quickly to Catra.

"Wait, Catra, are you okay? When my father said he would give you to me…he said…he would erase you…I saw in your eyes…you were scared and then…you weren't," he said, concerned and reaching to grasp her hand.

Confusion lay in Catra's eyes for a second before brightening. "Noooo…nothing happened to me, he didn't do anything to me. I was terrified, yes, terrified that Adora was going to die and I didn't know how to help her. Then you showed up and I was terrified for you as well, but when your father offered me to you, I knew that was his last mistake and that somehow, everything was going to be fine. I *knew* that you were going to help us, Shen." Catra admitted.

Shen closed his eyes and blew out a slow breath in relief, but he had one more thing to say to Catra.

“Catra, I know that you will never love me the way I do you, but can I ask you one thing? Can you promise that you will always be my friend?” he whispered in a small, sincere, voice.

Catra laughed softly. “You’re such a dummy, yes, of course! I may not be in love with you, Shen, but I do feel love for you. You’re my friend, and I will be there for you, always.” She said, leaning over and pressing her forehead to the side of his head. He felt tears drip on him as she pulled back away, her tears dripped down the side of his face, mingling with his own.

They sat like that for a moment until a beep sounded from Catra’s pocket.

“Come on, let's get out of here, everyone’s waiting outside.” Catra stated, reaching over and gently shaking his shoulder.

“Who?” he said, turning to her with a confused look.

She gave him an impatient look. “Everyone, silly, our friends are here! They want to make sure you're okay. Let’s go!” she said, helping to lift him up.

Catra guided him out of the cave and groaned when she saw it was raining.

“You owe me for this, buddy,” she said, teasing, as they walked out into the rain. For some reason, it was not cold, but pleasant and warm.

Before them was Darla, Adora’s ship, with everyone standing out in front; She-Ra/Adora was standing there with Glimmer and Bow, as well as all the princesses and the friends he made in Etheria.

Catra led him by the shoulders forward, stopping him in front of She-Ra/Adora and then sidling up to her in a side hug.

She-Ra/Adora beamed at Shen. “I guess now you know why I’ve been trying to keep you out of trouble, Shen. I’m *kinda* glad I did,” she said with a laugh.

Shen grinned back at her. “I think you're going to have to get used to another hero hanging around, Adora.”

She grinned back at him. “I welcome it.” She said, reaching out and pulling her friend into an embrace. “I guess this makes you one of us now. You’re an Etherian now, Shen.” She whispered to him.

Catra and Bow wrapped him in a hug from either side, Glimmer coming up from behind. The other princess and friends joined them in the hug, layering on until they formed a circle with Shen and Adora in the middle.

They stayed there like that for a while, a large hug under gentle warm rain, falling from soft clouds.

Chapter End Notes

> Illustration by Iria, a.k.a. ilikeyoucatradora on Instagram and Tumblr.

Epilogue

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Epilogue

...I learned that I loved myself.

Shen and Adora stood side by side on the edge of a cliff, overlooking the sea near Bright Moon. They were going through a series of peaceful martial arts exercises, meant to calm the mind and soothe any turbulent emotions. They had been coming here every day for the past month, preparing for this day. This was the moment they had both been waiting for.

They were both dressed in the white loose robes worn during their sparring sessions, and as they continued their exercises, a new celestial body was rising in distance.

It was Eternia. Eternia was rising.

When the Set'Heth-un'dar had entered the universe, it had taken Shen'Dar-oom with it, but when the Set'Heth-un'dar was destroyed, it left Eternia behind, drifting nearby to Etheria.

Like two strangers that seemed to have always known each other, Eternia and Etheria embraced, and through a combination of magic and gravity, they started a dance around each other, a mutual orbit. Etheria's moons spread out and formed a new orbit around the pair, and they followed a new route like electrons orbiting a nucleus.

The people of Eternia entered their new universe bewildered and afraid, but the people of Etheria were there to welcome them and help them through their transition. Space transports sped back and forth between the two planets ferrying aid while Glimmer, along with the princesses visited to help soothe the fears of Eternia's people.

While ferrying aid back and forth, a Star Force ship made an interesting discovery near where the Set'Heth-un'dar disappeared. An object was found floating there, and it was collected by the ship's crew. Admiral Octavia decided she would personally inform Queen Glimmer of its discovery and she presented it to her.

Glimmer was amazed when Octavia presented her with a gleaming white staff topped with a glowing yellow gem.

"The Life Gem!" she had exclaimed happily, then she looked at her other staff, the Star Stone, making a decision. "Hmmm…I don't need two of these things, I know who can take the Life Gem!" she had exclaimed.

Glimmer had presented Perfuma with her new staff, the Princess of growing things being the perfect holder of the power of life itself. Using the teachings of Madame Razz as a guide, Glimmer started instructing Perfuma on how to use the Life Gem to reach farther than what she was used to, to reach the power that governs her elemental power of growing plants. Perfuma was an excellent student and Glimmer was confident that soon Perfuma would join them in their journeys among the stars. Who knew? Maybe they would find more other powerful staves out there. *Madame Razz did say there were others…*

Shen and Adora continued their exercises under the rising Eternia, they finished by facing each other, grasping each other's hands and gazing into each other's eyes.

"When I transform, I concentrate on what makes me who I am, who Adora is. It's hard to describe it, but lucky for us, we have a way to feel each other's emotions," she said, pulling his hand to

her chest, where his heart rune lay, it lit up at his touch. She let go of his other hand and placed it on his chest, alighting his rune as well.

"Now, concentrate on my feelings, my emotions as I transform. Can you feel me?" she said to him.

Shen closed his eyes, reaching through their bond. "Yes, Adora, I can feel you."

Adora held out her hand, and as she summoned the sword and then She-Ra, Shen felt Adora's emotions of activation.

It was her goodness, her compassion, her love, all there, swirling around and then compressed to a point; they were her focus. The point suddenly exploded outward, allowing Adora to transform into She-Ra.

"For the honor of Grayskull!" she shouted, beginning her transformation.

Shen opened his eyes and pulled his hand away as Adora increased in size for her transformation and he stared up into her face. She-Ra/Adora gazed back down at him.

"Now you try." she prompted him.

Shen did as she instructed, focusing on the same emotions and compressing them into his focus, he held out his hand.

"By the power of Grayskull!" he exclaimed.

Nothing happened.

"I'm sure the same emotions and feelings won't work for every person, think about what makes you, *you*, Shen. Focus on that." She-Ra/Adora said.

He nodded and then thought of who he was and what it meant to be him.

He started with the pain, emptiness and sadness that had consumed so much of his young life, letting it swirl around inside of him. He took those dark emotions, and wrapped them in the discovery of hope, hope he found in friendship, in a future that no longer looked dark and uncertain and the hope that it could be bright. Taking that, he pushed it into love, love he felt for his friends, being in love with Shen'Dara and then Catra. Being in love with Catra was bittersweet, but it was love still true.

He then realized something while focusing on all that love. *How could he hold so much of it without there being another love present? How could you feel that true love for others without the first love, which was necessary?* It suddenly hit him, he did feel that love, it was there inside him, it always was.

He loved himself.

"By the power of Grayskull!" Shen shouted again.

She-Ra/Adora watched as a silver sword appeared in Shen's outstretched hand and electric power surrounded his body. He glowed brightly with it, and grew taller and broader. When the light vanished, she gasped at the figure before her.

He-Man/Shen stood before her, smiling. He was almost as tall as her and just a little broader, dressed in tight gray pants, black knee-high boots, and a black, sleeveless tunic, like hers. On his chest was a symbol, not the cross symbol of the old He-Man, but a newer, kinder one.

On his shoulders was silver armor, smooth and rounded around the shoulders with a long silver cape billowing out behind him. His arms were strong, but not overly muscular; silver bands wrapped around his biceps and silver gauntlets were on his wrists. His face was that of Shen's, but stronger looking.

On his head, he wore a silver crown, like his father. But unlike his father who wore a crown of pain and hatred, He-Man/Shen wore a crown of compassion and empathy.

Long hair billowed behind him; it was black with white streaks that glowed with electric power. He gazed into She-Ra/Adora's light blue glowing eyes with light blue glowing eyes of his own.

He-Man/Shen held his hand out to She-Ra/Adora and they grasped each other's wrists, like warriors. Then, with a grin, She-Ra/Adora laughed and pulled him into a crushing embrace, which he returned.

"I *missed* you, my old friend." She-Ra/Adora whispered in his ear. Her voice had a strange dual resonance to it, like two people were speaking at once. It was as if She-Ra herself was speaking along with Adora.

"I missed you too, She-Ra." He-Man/Shen said, with a duel resonance of his own.

They parted, each still grasping the other by the shoulders and gazing at each other. She-Ra/Adora looked at the top of He-Man/Shen's head with a mischievous grin on her face.

"Wait, is your He-Man shorter than my She-Ra?" she asked, still grinning.

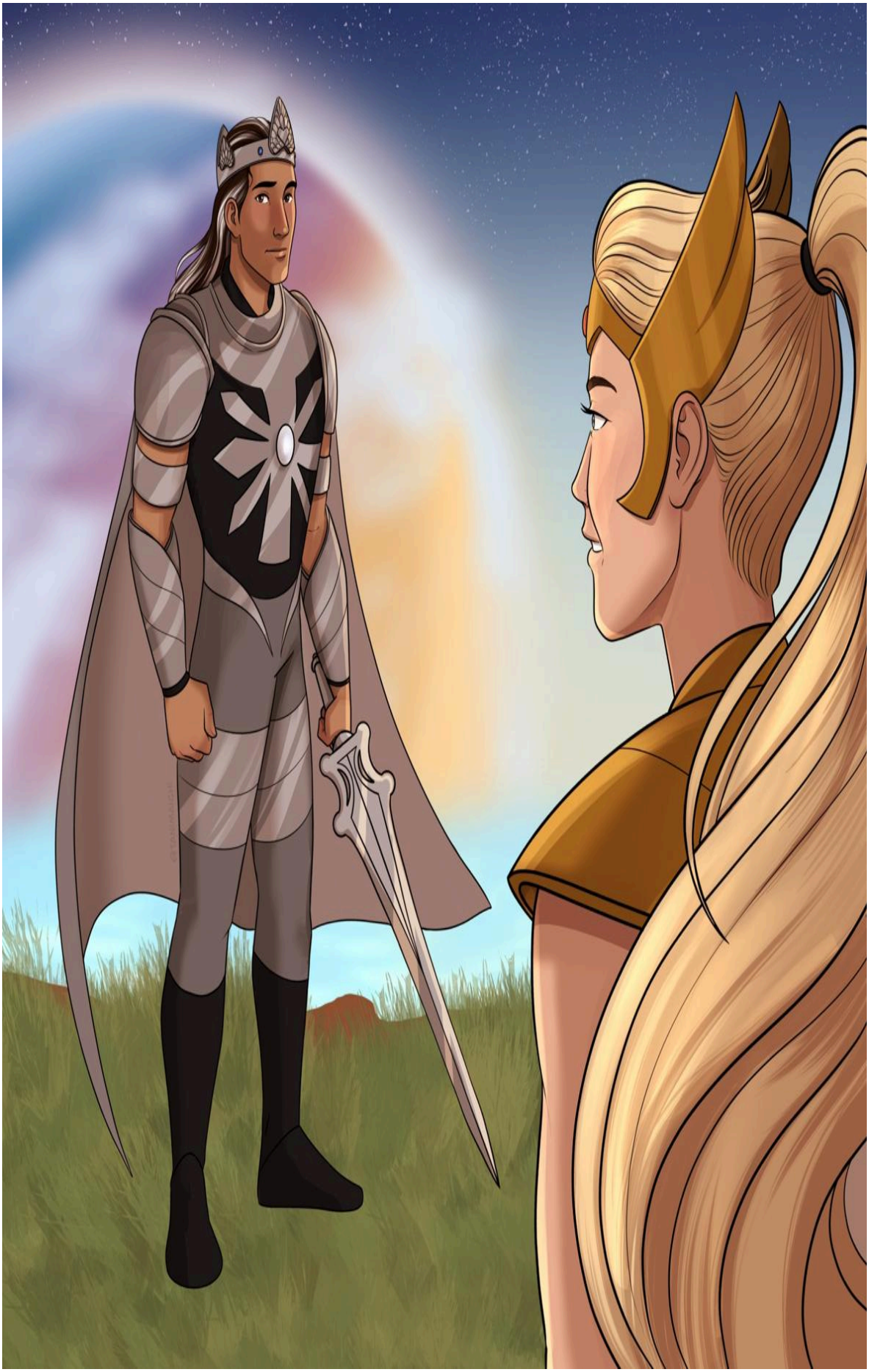
He-Man/Shen laughed loudly. "Yeah, but I think I can live with that."

They both laughed at that. They were two old comrades united once again in the cause of good, two warriors united in pushing back the darkness.

They were two friends, united in love.

* END CREDITS NO. 1 *

* END CREDITS NO. 2 *



Chapter End Notes

Illustration done by Maili Taniguchi.

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